

Hears Gray Birds' Guodian Laozi: A Naïve Visual Translation Experiment, 1st Version

Introduction

The question behind this project is simple: what does the Guodian manuscript look like if we resist the temptation to reconstruct it into the received Laozi? I do not expect this experiment to produce a definitive translation. Rather, I wanted to document what happens when the manuscript's unusual graphs, variants, lexical possibilities, and ambiguities are allowed to remain unusual wherever I could justify doing so.

This project was mostly written after two passes of translation of the Guodian mostly “blind” to later received versions, so themes of the commentary are from the translation process itself. Readings emerged from the translation rather than my coming in with any assumptions or frameworks (at least not knowingly imposed). Chapter commentary was written directly after translating, with some notes taken directly after translating each chapter but the more complete version and synthesis crafted after translating all three bundles (A, B, and C). This commentary was without conscious influence from other specific reading or studying outside of background memory I double-checked, with cited exceptions.

My commentary tends to be more thematic, and reference sections that may have become substantially before or after in the accepted sequence. The commentary is also fairly speculative and may reflect my own beliefs (and potentially opinions). As this project was not a rigorous academic project (or at least did not start with that intention), I did not rigorously “weed” such things out – nevertheless maybe they are helpful or at least interesting. I am presently working on commentary for the entirety of the received Laozi as well, but it is not included here yet. I hope that project will eventually have more thorough, subjective commentary for all chapters of the received (WangBi, potentially Mawangdui, potentially HeShangGong) and, treated separately, the Guodian.

Notes on received translation in the main text and the appendix: I did not consistently add Mawangdui variants in every chapter – I may go through at a later time to more comprehensively address the differences between Mawangdui and WangBi or HeShangGong, but the project is not currently at that stage.

Sources cited and depended on:

- *Kroll, Paul W. (2017) “A Student’s Dictionary of Classical and Medieval Chinese: Revised Edition.” ||| A thorough and very reliable dictionary. Supplementarily, I also used < <https://www.mdbg.net/chinese/dictionary> > as well as Wiktionary (https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/Appendix:Chinese_radical), and zi.tools (<https://zi.tools/>). Zi.tools was especially helpful for translating from Chu bamboo script and character evolution, and often was my source for Shuowen Jiezi entries.
- *Pulleyblank, E. G. (1995) “Outline of Classical Chinese.” ||| Fantastic resource for verifying translations and ensuring that old words were being used appropriately.
- *Barnes, A., Starr, D., Ormerod, G. (2009) “Du’s Handbook of Classical Chinese Grammar.”
- *DaoIsOpen.com/comparisons.html ||| Compares the Wang Bi, Mawangdui, and Guodian characters. The same website also provides photographs of the Guodian slips, which I refer to in addition to those provided by Chinese Text Project, see below.
- *Henricks, R.G (2000). “Tao Te Ching: A translation of the Startling New Documents found at Guodian.” ||| Provides version comparisons with Mawangdui and WangBi
- *Cook, S .(2012) “The Bamboo Texts of Guodian.” || provides original characters for Guodian characters, and explains why the modifications into modern have been made.
- *Chinese Text Project: For both the text of the WangBi, Mawangdui, and Guodian with original annotated pictures of the Guodian slips, so that I can make judgment calls if necessary.
- *郭店楚墓竹簡 (Chu Bamboo Slips from Guodian) (荊門市博物館 , Jingmen City Museum). Has clearer and sharper representations/scans of most of the characters in the Guodian – what this misses by darkened photography or spotty scanning tends to be covered in the version from DaoIsOpen for Laozi A, parts of B, and C, and Chinese Text Project for Laozi A.

For the received/WangBi

- *Dao De Jing- Chinese Text Project < <https://ctext.org/dao-de-jing> >. Warring States (475BC-221BC), English translation by James Legge. ||| Features Chinese Characters as well as translation.
- *Boisen, B. (1996) “Lao Tsu’s Tao-The-Ching: A Parallel Translation Collection.” ||| Fantastic for getting a second opinion on translations, but I did not rely on any of these very deeply.
- *Linnell, Bruce R. (2015). “Dao De Jing by Lao Zi: A Minimalist Translation.” Retrieved from the Gutenberg Project: < <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/49965> >. ||| In-depth look at the history of Daodejing, its editions and translations, with a chapter by chapter transparency about translation decisions and evidence. Very good for the study of nuance in word choice and construction.

Notes On the Methodology of Transcribing and Translating the Guodian

First and foremost, I am not formally trained in Classical Chinese. I speak and write an intermediate level of Modern Chinese. I am not trained in paleography. I have read English translations of the Laozi/Dao De Jing, sure, but I don't have them memorized, and most of what I had read was at least seven years before starting this project. I was taught some of the Old Chen Style Taijiquan sequence, and am trying to learn the rest on my own, but I am not trained in the "inner trainings" of Daoism to any deep degree. I am a hobbyist at best. I have a PhD, but it is in biology, earned by studying the behavior of birds. Perhaps one could say I am an "uncarved block", ignorant. This work may reflect my ignorance, but it is sincere in its intention to understand the Guodian Laozi for what is written on it. In my ignorance, there may be things I misunderstand, or things I just don't know about that would change the way I've written something here – please tell me. I may be particularly weak in my understanding of Classical Chinese Grammar, or established Chu script substitutions or conventions established in other documents, despite my best efforts. I am not pretending this is perfect; it is an attempt. That is all I have to say about my credibility, and, for the most part, myself. I invite you to view this as a "naïve visual readings experiment." I wanted to see how this oldest known version of Laozi would read without trying to fit it with the later versions, to let it speak by itself.

I was inspired to do this project when I was reading Cook's and Henricks' work on the Guodian, and took a look at the differences they noted between the original characters and the ones in the received texts, most often Wang Bi. I was then inspired to resolve inconsistencies between the two by looking up photographs of the actual slips, from Chinese Text Project, DaoIsOpen.com, and "郭店楚墓竹簡 (Chu Bamboo Slips from Guodian) (荊門市博物館 , Jingmen City Museum)". Upon seeing the photographs, I was inspired to try to transcribe and translate from scratch, using Wiktionary, Zi.Tools, the ShuoWen Jiezi, the ShuoWen Xinzheng by Ji Xuesheng, Paul Kroll's "Student's Dictionary of Classical and Medieval Chinese," and finally Cook and Henricks for reference and guidance. This approach was to limit bias from later versions of the text from the Han and forward – I have some familiarity with the Dao De Jing from reading translations most of a decade ago, but I had not translated the Wang Bi before, nor do I have in-depth knowledge and memorization of these later texts. So, I dared myself to do this transcription and translation as "blind" to the WangBi and Mawangdui as possible, unless truly, truly stumped. I only translated the received (WangBi) Daodejing after completing an initial translation and at least one revision of the Guodian first.

This is not an attempt to overturn the received tradition or to replace existing scholarly editions. Rather, it is an attempt to ask what the Guodian manuscript itself appears to say before later interpretive traditions are allowed to shape the translation.

My approach was as follows:

- **Literal Reading:** I assumed that the scribes meant every character they wrote in the most semantic sense, departing from this baseline only when a literal reading produced a grammatical impasse or broke structural coherence within the immediate syntax..
- **Dictionary Synthesis:** If the literal sense did not work, then I would consult the ShuoWen Jiezi and ShuoWen Xinzheng (partially from zi.tools) to understand the connotations of the word, and known historical loans and substitutions. I would also consult Kroll's dictionary for confirmation with translation.
- **Component Deconstruction:** If the character on the slips did not visually match (in my opinion) the characters from either Cook or Henricks, I tried to work out which radicals and components made up the character. I would then try to find a viable alternative supported by zi.tools or Wiktionary based on the character itself or how the components are expressed in characters that are found in those websites (if the one I figured was not already there).
- **Phonetic Loans:** I also investigated viable phonetic loans known from Warring States time period or since, though I never assume a phonetic loan right off the bat. I state that I have used a phonetic loan or component deconstruction in every case I have done it. I do not find rhyming schemes to be convincing evidence in general – I have trouble assuming everything is written to rhyme, and reconstructions, while rigorously researched, may still have error.
- **Scholarly References:** I also state when I cannot get what I see on the slip to agree well with any character I could find – in these cases, I will usually if not always default to what Cook or Henricks has listed.
- **Damage and Loss:** For characters that are faded, damaged, or missing due to broken or damaged slips (or simply unreadable due to the imperfect quality of the photographs and scans I have access to), I consult the same section in case there's a pattern already strongly established. If this is not an obvious or convincing pattern, I will default again to the opinions of Henricks and Cook, but I will note it. I will footnote in every case a character is faded or damaged enough to make me doubt confident identification, and I will mark with a blank box where characters are altogether missing, and default again to Cook and Henricks to estimate how many are missing in each case.
- **Variants:** For any character that looks slightly weird, like an extra or missing stroke, I will note it, unless the variation in whether or not an "extra" mark exists is very well represented in zi.tools entries for the character (and even then, I may note it regardless).

I am also, for now, following the Jingmen City Museum 1998 arrangement and sequence of the bamboo slips in "Guodian Chumu Zhujian (郭店楚墓竹简)", although I recognize it is possible that these may not be the original order. Perhaps one day I will be brave and play with the order; not yet.

A word of warning and a note on format: this translation leans heavily on its footnotes. Where a reading departs from convention, the footnote is where I show my work (e.g., the graph analysis, the sources I weighed, and where I'm genuinely unsure). Reading the body text alone will give my conclusions; reading the footnotes will show you why I got there, and where I could be wrong. Given how contested some of these graphs are, **I'd consider the footnotes essential rather than optional.**

Also worth noting, footnotes recording my reasoning for translation decisions were written alongside the first-pass translation of each bundle, often moved to the meat of the commentary later. The bulk of the commentary itself was written afterward, once all three bundles (A, B, and C) had been translated at least once, which allowed me to write with the whole manuscript in view and to cross-reference related passages and graphs across bundles. As a result, the commentary tends to be more thematic, and reference sections that may have become substantially before or after in the accepted sequence. The commentary is also fairly speculative and may reflect my own beliefs (and potentially opinions). As this project was not a rigorous academic project (or at least did not start with that intention), I did not rigorously “weed” such things out – nevertheless maybe they are helpful or at least interesting.

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A note on the name, and in praise for a certain species of mockingbird, the Gray Catbird, a bird that lives in North America. I've thought more than once that the Gray Catbird is the ultimate Daoist. Dull plumage, stays in the shade, but each one sings their very own individualistic song-- they mimic what they want to in the environment, but have very little if any inclination to copy each other, and each song is lovely and complex and beautiful-- a common bird the uninitiated never notice, some birders devalue for their commonness and drab plumage. The gray, shade-colored plumage is not flashy or displayed; the thicket and shadows of thick vegetation are their preferred spot and if left, never far, not eager for unnecessary danger or recognition; each one singing their own individual, complex song, mimicking their environment but not each other, taking inspiration from nature but not following the cultural, institutional script; common enough to be overlooked by the cloudy-eyed, annoying to those who run in an economy of rarity and spectacle, noticed only by those who watch, and listen, carefully. I have been a student of these birds for seven years. Perhaps, in their own way, they are my own little gray-feathered sages, teaching their ways without words.

--Humble and learning, Hears Gray Birds

Guodian (A:1)

繼¹智(弃²/棄)(𠄎/辨)³,

Continue knowledge/wisdom, abandon (artificial) differentiation/discrimination

Keep true knowledge⁴, but abandon artificial classification,

民⁵(𠄎/利)百(𠄎/倍)⁶。

Common-people sharp/smooth/benefit/abundance/cleverness/swift/profit robust/hundredfold/multiply.

And the people's benefit will increase a hundredfold.

繼(𠄎/攷)⁷ (弃/棄)利,

Continue knock/strike/examine/analyze/research abandon abundance/sharp/benefit

Continue analyzing, but abandon seeking further benefit,

覯(𠄎/惻)⁸亡(又/有)。

Gazing-from-afar sorrow/pain/grief not exist/have.

And gazing from afar in sorrow vanishes.

¹ Originally 𠄎 throughout chapter, more specifically 𠄎. This was an old form of 繼, though zi.tools claims this is also an old form of 絕 (but this could be due to the assumption that the Guodian slips HAD to match the WangBi, and the sampling from projects that made that assumption). Worth noting: 繼 = Left-Facing Skein, means SEVER (絕); 繼 = Right-Facing Skein Means CONTINUE (繼). For my translation of the Guodian, we treat it as 繼. Direct visual analysis of the brush paths rejects the standard filing. The graph displays a strict left-anchored vertical thread spine (𠄎/糸) paired with a rightward hand frame (𠄎), matching the precise orthographic blueprint of 繼 (jì - to continue/inherit). By removing this artificial textual editing, the opening philosophy of the manuscript shifts dramatically: it does not recommend an anti-intellectual destruction of knowledge, but rather a developmental mandate to inherit true wisdom (繼智) while abandoning artificial, institutional debate tactics, or arguing (棄辯).

² 𠄎 Worth noting the etymology of this character is throwing a child into a waste basket, something done to deformed babies or during famine: this is permanent, absolute rejection, illustrated by a visceral cultural horror.

³ 𠄎 Expressed in Cook as 𠄎. (𠄎 over 又). Could be 辨 (discrimination, differentiation, (ultimately artificial classifications), could be 𠄎 → 鞭 (whip) read (because of shared phonetics and a cut/boundary/dispute connotation) as 辯 (Confucian debate tactics, argumentation, (institutional) disputes) or 辨. By Cook, also could be 二 over 支, could be 便. In zi.tools, 鞭 contains 𠄎, but its page leads to 辨.

⁴ This could be translated as “insight”, as this really has the feeling of perception, observing the patterns of the natural world (自然), and thus the Dao; very much NOT the “cleverness”, or accumulated institutional traditions or accepted interpretations. This is not institutional or traditional judgments of right and wrong, or collection of “established” facts and definitions that should be trusted because everyone else / “smart” people do. This “insight” is the un-labeled, direct, observational understanding of the natural world, not conventional “knowledge”.

⁵ 𠄎 A proposed etymology for this character is a needle going into an eye, how early rulers blinded slaves to gain their compliance. Eerie how 民 came to mean the “people” or the “masses”, perhaps by compliance with authority.

⁶ 𠄎: Zi.tools has this under 𠄎. 𠄎 (robust and stout). It has been suggested that 𠄎 was used in place of 倍 in late Chu writing for mathematical increases, though I have not found a primary source confirming this usage. The reading 倍 as hundredfold is found in later versions of the Laozi, and “hundred robust” is not as intelligible.

⁷ 𠄎 Right side is definitely 𠄎 (the old version that looked like 𠄎 over the trident that is hand 又. The left is probably 𠄎. Zi.tools indeed has this as 攷 (knock, strike, examine, analyze, research). 𠄎 refers to the experiential skill of an artisan, craftsmanship. This character *could* be 攷 (with 𠄎 = 支 as it always does), meaning wash, cleanse, sometimes in Chu for 修 (to cultivate, cleanse (especially internally), or let flow naturally). See B:7 (攷)

⁸ With these two characters, my translation is a bit unique. I keep 覯 (technically 見 to the left of 兆, reflected by zi.tools) as “to gaze far away” (perhaps with envy or ambition, also means a lord’s audience), and I keep 惻 (as on zi.tools, but technically 𠄎) as “sorrow, grief, suffering”, or literally, as it is a ding-cauldron above a heart.

繼愚⁹(弃/棄)慮¹⁰,

Continue intentional-action/changing abandon calculated-anxiety/strategic-worry

Continue intentional action and abandon strategic anxiety,

民(复/復)季¹¹子。

Common-people return/revert/cycle-back baby/newborn.

People will go back to being young.

三言以為史¹²不足,

Three statements, [by-means-of use/do]/taken-as through-records/decrees, not enough/sufficient¹³

Three statements used as written decrees are insufficient,

或(命/令)之或(虐/乎)¹⁴ (豆/豆¹⁵/屬)。

In-some-cases commanding, in-some-cases perhaps/“!”/in-containers/bean/[see footnote]

When one sometimes commands it, and sometimes perhaps forces it into containers.

(夔/視) (索/索) 保(夔/僕)¹⁶

Look/view/compare/regard rope/norm/force-to-do/unstrung/unconnected protect servant/attached-to

Look at the ropes, protect the bound dependent.

少(△/私) (夔/須)¹⁷ (夔/欲¹⁸)。

Few/reduce/minimize private/personal-bias/self-interest, need/slow/need-to/wait-for desire.

Reduce your self-interest, limit your cravings to what you need.

⁹ Originally 爲 over 心 → 愚 (which zi.tools agrees with), which may be a phonetic loan word for 化 (change) but I can't find a source for this. It could be 偽 (harmonious accord), or this for 偽 (artificiality, deception, departure from the uncarved wood). But see Cook's "Bamboo Texts of Guodian" page 226: I actually agree with him, that this is 爲 (to do, to act) with the heart radical giving a sense of emotional/mental aspect: intentional action

¹⁰ Could be in the place of 詐 (deception, fakery), 怙 (pride), or 虐 (cruelty, autocratic abuse), but see Cook (page 226). The original 慮 (ponder, anticipate, reflect, infer, probably strategic worry/ calculated anxiety) works well.

¹¹ 季子, newborn, baby son (See the Mawangdui medical manual 脈法 (Mai Fa). 季 itself originally meant young grain, but was extended to mean youngest brother, and generally as a connotation of young.

¹² Originally 史, which is technically 卜 over 日 over 又, how it is rendered in zi.tools, where it is listed under 史 (policy (especially written), scribe, historian, ritualists decrees, employment). However, zi.tools also lists this character to mean 事, which I find less convincing, as this character appears elsewhere in another form. (See A:17)

¹³ 足, in oracle bone, was a marching human leg, toward a destination. That your feet marched all the way to the destination, it became in the Zhou an abstract measurement meaning “full, complete, satisfied, sufficient”. Perhaps more viscerally this can be translated as “do not make it there”, or, more literally “has no legs (so cannot go)”.

¹⁴ 乎 in the Guodian is always 夔, written 虐 usually stands in for 乎. I often translate this as “perhaps.”

¹⁵ 豆 → 豆. This means food container (a shallow round container on stems with a lid, sometimes used in ritual sacrifice) or beans/legumes, so probably a loan. Cook has many suggestions. 屬 (categories, different-but-the-same in the Shuowen Jiezi), used in the Mawangdui and WangBi. 樹 (plant, set upright, of plants; interesting because 豆 was part of its ancient character according to the Shuowen Jiezi, with an impression of straightness; but, a different character in the Guodian already exists for this character.) I favor this reading partially on thematic grounds, risking confirmation bias; fitting people into bean-pods or containers fits themes of the Guodian. The received has 屬.

¹⁶ Originally 夔: either 夔 (thicket, dense uncontrolled wild undergrowth) or 夔 (cluster of grass), over 臣 (minister, slave). May be 僕 → 僕 = servant (unsophisticated, “ignorant”, uncorrupted person, attached to or connected with); this servant reading matches zi.tools better. 《漢語同源詞大典》 claims that 僕 and 僕 mean “attachment” or “dependence”. Zi.tools has under 僕: I don't think it is accurate, should be 夔 over 臣 or similar: there's no man.

¹⁷ 夔 Controversial, usually rendered 寡, sometimes rendered to 須 (beard → need, await, require/ stay for) which is most supported by zi.tools, but may be an abbreviation of 寡. Maybe should be read as 顧. (See A:13)

¹⁸ Chu variant of 欲 listed under zi.tools is 谷 + 次

A:1 Commentary:

The most daring part of this translation is to reject the “rejecting”, and reading the bamboo slips as they are: 𣪠/ 繼— keep.

The Guodian is by no means telling anyone to stop trying to learn or think, but it encourages rejecting the imposed “knowledge” based on theories of what should be, categories that should exist. Nature does not recognize or care about such rigid categories, and while these make convenient communication possible, it is rare that these cut-and-dry classifications are real. Reality is certainly not operating in clean, institutional boxes. When one clings to the artificial labels of things, the sorting imposed by a civilized mind, one actually strays further from the reality in front of them. Things of course differ, but they differ on a spectrum, and hard-fast rules rarely always apply. One is better off observing what is before them than relying on the conventional assumptions or theories from elsewhere, or oneself. The Guodian advocates for direct, local observation over imported theories or conventional assumptions.

Additionally, the Guodian instructs to continue working with intention, researching, analyzing, but stop trying to rig it to make oneself famous, rich or respected. The two characters I take up here are 覩, “to gaze far away,” (a term that also carries the sense of a lord’s audience, and by extension gazing toward power or status) and 惻, “sorrow, grief, suffering” (literally a ding-cauldron over a heart). Read together, abandoning the pressure to gain fame or rank means the gazing-toward-power vanishes, and the grief that comes bundled with it goes with it. Without pressure to find a certain result or make some kind of breakthrough, one can sit, observe, learn without distractions or pressure. The envy or jealousy, or greed, or pride, that powers the striving, the wanting what one does not have, or wanting more of what one does—none of it can bring any happiness; abandon these, and that sorrow and worry will similarly be rejected with it. If one is not trying to gain more than what they need or have, there is no reason to look far away with any emotional discomfort.

Furthermore, the Guodian instructs one to continue acting with intention, putting meaning behind what one does, but discourages letting that turn into vying for power or prestige or wealth.

The anxiety, the scheming, the strategy of “playing the game” wears on one, ages one. Letting that go frees one up to be themselves; the stress that ages them vanishes, youthful energy recovers, and psychologically, there is room to be oneself again, like a child. By lessening or eliminating preoccupation with constantly trying to get ahead or work through the politics of things, one makes the intention behind one’s actions less forced and more meaningful, more sincere, more natural, like the spontaneity of a naïve child or an animal in the natural habitat.

The relief offered from these truths are not attainable by writing them down or reading them out, nor would there be any success in trying to command or force something to fit or be contained a certain way. Writing them does not make them so. The Guodian recognizes that these psychological shifts cannot be achieved through top-down mandates, written laws, or by forcing people into ideological containers. Trying to unilaterally decide where things belong is exactly the artificial classification and worry-triggering strategizing the Guodian just warned about.

Perhaps the most surprising line, provided my translation is accurate, is “Look at the ropes (that bind or do not bind someone), protect the dependent (low servant, the ones attached to you).” I translated this line this way because the graph is 𠂔 over 臣 rather than the wood-radical 𣎵 of the received tradition; this points toward 僕 (servant, dependent, unsophisticated) rather than ‘uncarved block.’ 漢語同源詞大典 connects 僕 and 樸 through a shared sense of ‘attachment/dependence,’ which supports reading the line as being about a bound or dependent person rather than raw material. The character on the slips lacks a wood component, so I do not think this is the “uncarved block” or unworked wood. I think the meaning is perhaps more immediate than this, and far less abstract and mystical. One cannot fully control the actions of others; they cannot really command people to abandon any of their ambitions, nor fit them into pretty categories. No amount of writing or ordering or forcing will change that. Instead, one must turn to their own “ropes”, who depend on them for comfort or survival, who need them.

The games for power and favor and prestige and fame come with tempting gains or catastrophic losses, and the decisions that the head of the house makes often lead to joy or suffering for their wives, their children, their elderly parents, and if applicable, their servants or other dependents. If the head of the house does not consider them, does not protect them, then no one will. Reducing wants to real needs, reducing one’s self-interest and curbing one’s pride and ambition are real defensive steps to secure the fate of the whole house. The life may not be glamorous, or even recorded in history, but at least it will be safe, more relaxed, and perhaps even happy.

Continue to learn, continue to analyze and research, continue to work with intention, but do not heed the temptation to put artificial constructs on nature, or the pressure of climbing ranks, getting rich, or making history, and certainly do not devote one’s life to it – or the lives of the bound.

Received 19 (A:1)

絕聖棄智

Sever/leave-behind/renounce sagacity/virtuousness/mastery, abandon knowledge/wisdom
Leave behind sagacity, abandon wisdom

民利百倍

Common-people benefit hundredfold/[multiply].
The people’s benefit will multiply a hundredfold.

絕仁棄義

Sever/leave-behind/renounce humane/kind/benevolent abandon proper/dutiful/responsible¹⁹
Leave behind benevolence, abandon responsibility,

¹⁹ 義: right-mindedness, proper, appropriate, dutiful and responsible, but all of these with special attention to one’s own clan or social group. Social consciousness.

民復孝慈

Common-people return filial-piety tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence

The people will return to filial devotion and loving care of the young.

絕巧棄利

Sever/leave-behind/renounce skill/craftsmanship, abandon benefit/sharp/profit/smooth

Leave behind skill, abandon benefit,

盜賊無有。

Thievishness/stealing outlaw/villainy/murder not/lack/without have/existing

And there will be no stealing or villainy.

此三²⁰者以為文²¹不足

This/these three, [by-means-of use/act]/serve-as pattern/literature/writing [no-legs]/insufficient

These three things, treated as text, are insufficient.

故令{之}有所屬

Thus/therefore, command/respected/enable have/exist place/that-which attach/connect/follow/category

Therefore, command there to be a place to belong,²²

見素抱樸

See/look plain-silk/plain/blank/innocent embrace/hug/enwrap/surround unworked-wood/simple

Look at the plain silk, embrace the unworked wood,

少私²³寡欲

Few/reduce/minimize private/personal-bias/self-interest, few/scanty/lessen/widow desire

Reduce one's social ego, lessen one's desires.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Comparing this to the received version (Chapter 19),

the Guodian's version, in my opinion, makes a lot more sense and is much more rational.

From future versions of this passage, the reader is encouraged, at the gentlest, to leave sagacity and mastery behind (as my translation is phrased), “renounce sacredness” (as Linnell translates), or, at the more extreme reading, “Exterminate the sages” (Lau). In the received Dao De Jing, *nothing* is kept: it is either renounced, severed away, or some way rejected and left behind or abandoned and discarded. Responsibility and benevolence are added to the pile of values and behaviors to be left to die, skill and wisdom devalued and trashed. From all of this purging, by magic (or most generously, the Dao), children will be more devoted to parents and parents more loving to children, thievery and crime will evaporate, and the people will see great benefit. The logic is much harder, in my opinion, to follow than it is in the Guodian.

The received version of the Dao De Jing was likely edited during the Han Dynasty, a time

²⁰ Both Mawangdui insert 言 here.

²¹ For some reason, it appears that Lindell translates 文 as “civilized society”, and Feng & English, Lin seem to translate this as “external forms”, and Lau, Chan, Waley, and Cleary associate it with “adornments” or “embellishments”. I’m honestly not sure why. Perhaps the next line about plain silk and unworked wood is integrated that way.

²² Alternatively, “Therefore, enable the people to attach themselves to the following”, in the style of Lau, or “Thus, enable the following to be appended [to the three statements],” in the style of Henricks.

²³ Mawangdui B has 而 here.

categorized by imperial centralization and standardization. The emperors, and those who wished to gain imperial favor, may have had incentive to shift the language to become a manual for top-down governmental control. The version in the Guodian appears to be far more personal, a defensive, anti-authoritarian survival guide.

Perhaps, the received version is giving advice to a government rather than a person: crush voices of dissent and wisdom, and the people will know no better than to follow, getting themselves into no trouble with rebellion and the quelling thereof; treat the people harshly and apathetically, and family support and protectiveness will increase out of need; remove skill and quality, de-emphasize benefit, and there will be nothing to steal or kill over, nothing to covet, nothing to envy. The Guodian offers different solutions to these problems, but they seem to operate on the scale of the person, or at least the household: trouble is avoided by leaving strategic anxiety and seeking further gains in benefit, but one is still allowed to be aware, to think, to do things. As for family stability, devotion to parents and love for children, this seems to be addressed in the urge to consider one's "ropes" and "protect the attached/dependent." Is the protection of one's loved ones not among the most important ways to honor and care for them?

The received Dao De Jing, by my translation and Linnell's, addresses the insufficiency of the written word by prescribing commanding or causing there to be a place for people to belong. In other translations, this insufficiency is addressed by enabling people to see (and presumably use) plain silks/ simplicity and embrace (and presumably value) unworked wood/original nature (e.g., Lau, Chan, Waley). In yet others, the insufficiency is addressed by appending the instruction to see plain silks/simplicity and embrace unworked wood/one's true nature, reducing selfishness/ego (and in some translations the self) and reducing (or diminishing entirely) one's desires (e.g., Henricks, Feng & English, Wu). The Guodian does not seem to think "fitting into containers" or issuing orders at all will be effective. Instead of offering plain silks and unworked wood, the Guodian mentions ropes and servants (or at least potentially attached people of relatively low rank). While potentially the Guodian calls of diminishing desires, it is also plausible that it calls to lower desires to comprise only what one really needs.

Guodian (A:2)

江²⁴(𣶒/海)²⁵所以為²⁶百(𣶒/衆/浴²⁷)王

River sea [that-which by-means-of]/mechanism-by-which do hundred bath/purify/stream king

The mechanism by which rivers and seas act as king of the hundred streams,

以其能為百(衆/浴)下,

By-means-of their/its can/able do/act/use/manipulate hundred bath/purify/stream down

Is through their ability to act as below the hundred streams;

是以能為百(衆/浴)王。

This by-means-of able/can act/do/use/manipulate hundred bath/purify/stream king

By means of this, they are able to act as the kings of the hundred streams.

聖人之(才²⁸/才)民(前²⁹/前)²⁹也,

Sage [‘s/this] talent common-people before/front/forward

The sage’s talent is being before the people,

以身(後³⁰/後)³⁰之;

By-means-of body/self after/behind/delay/later this/[‘s].

By putting the self after them.

其才民上也, 以言下之。

Its/their talent common-people above/superior by-means-of speech/words down/below this[‘s]

The sage’s talent is being above the people, by speaking words to be below them.

其才民上也,

It/its talent common-people above/superior,

The sage’s talent being above the people,

民(弗³¹/弗)(厚³¹/厚)³¹也;

Common-people not thick/deep/sincere/authentic/richly/important/lavish/generous

***The common people are not thick.*³²**

²⁴ Possibly specifically the Yangtze River in the south. 江 tend to be thought of as larger, natural rivers.

²⁵ In zi.tools, technically 𣶒 left of 𣶒, under 海.

²⁶ I usually translate 為 as manipulate, use, or do. Here, the meaning of “act as” is the only one that works. See A:5

²⁷ Only in A:2 does this character take this form

²⁸ Everywhere 才 occurs in the Guodian, some put 在, I suppose taking this as an early form of the latter. There is evidence that Chu bamboo script used 才 for both, but either way, there are no connotations of desire or want.

²⁹ Zi.tools has this under 𣶒, which Wiktionary calls an ancient version of 前

³⁰ Zi.tools has 𣶒, accurate. Henricks has 後 over 止. The meaning is unchanged, this is just an ancient form.

³¹ 𣶒. Originally 石 over 毛 according to Cook – Henricks just has 厚. Listed in zi.tools as 石 over 臺 for 厚 (see also A:17 𣶒) see also A:3 (𣶒→heavy), and the mystery character pair in A:18 (𣶒/𣶒).

³² This is the same character as 𣶒 in A:17, translated as “thickly, deeply, fully”, perhaps even heavily. The “thickness” the people lack may be not having to be bogged down with the importance and weight of the sage, not having to trudge through it in all aspects of life like someone wading through mud. It could also be that the people are not sincere or deep if the sage’s talent (or position) is above them, as it does not support and nourish them from below. No matter the approach, there is some interpretive work to be done here. I hesitate to default to the 重 (heavy) of the received, where the burden connotation is perhaps easier to grasp. I keep the main translation ambiguous as a result.

其才民前也,

It/its talent common-people before/front

The sage's talent is before the people;

民弗(𠄎/害/害)³³也。

Common-people not harm/abuse/damaged/blind(?)

The common people are not pained by blindness.³⁴

天下樂(逸/進)而(後/弗)(訥/訥)。

Under-heaven glee/music advance/move-forward/present/improve and/yet/but not talkative/garrulous

The world gleefully moves forward, and yet is not aggravatingly talkative.³⁵

以其不(靜/靜)也,

By-means-of their/its not/no still/quiet/placid

By means of its lack of motionlessness

(古/故)天下³⁶莫能(與/與)³⁷之(靜/靜)。

Old/ancient//therefore/thus under-heaven in-no-case can/able join/give [‘s/this] still/quiet/placid

Therefore, the world can never join motionlessness.

A:2 Commentary:

This chapter is about “leading from behind”, power from below. To have the most influence, the most sway, one goes to the lower, less conspicuous, perhaps even less dignified places.

Flowing into the depths, rivers and seas draw from the streams and baths above and thus are mighty. The sage’s might similarly comes from letting others go first, speaking with humility, positioning so as to not be a burden upon the people below, by being below.

³³ In zi.tools as 𠄎 (but not 害), alone. In Cook (but not Henricks, who has 害), 害 (a form of punishment by tattooing the eyes, by Wiktionary, under 憲). Could be early form of 瞎 (blind). See also C:2 (𠄎) and A:15 (𠄎). All three characters are very different, and for all three I find the graphic etymology linking them back to 害 somewhat weak. Nevertheless, I default to 害 (𠄎) for now. An eye component on the bottom (目 ← 𠄎) (though it may be a net 𠄎) is visible: perhaps this means to obscure their sight, or otherwise harm the ability to see? This is significant, given that the Chu character for 民 is 𠄎; a proposed etymology of this character being a needle going into an eye, how early rulers blinded slaves to gain their compliance. Eerie how 民 came to mean the “people” or the “masses,” potentially illustrating compliance with authority in this way (See A:1). However, this may be as the early form of 憲 (to publish, to promulgate, standard, law, rule, emulate), according to Wikipedia, where 害 is the phonetic part.

³⁴ Or, “the common people do not emulate it,” or “the common people do not take it as standard.”

³⁵ This could also refer to the sage, becoming “The world gleefully advances [the sage] and yet does not become talkative.” The world nor the sage not becoming talkative as the result of promoting one person seems less likely than the whole world moving forward without having to get bogged down with words, in my opinion.

³⁶ These 天下 have marks above them, the ones on the previous slip two lines up did not.

³⁷ 𠄎 Henricks has 与 over 𠄎, zi.tools has 𠄎, which is more accurate. The Shuowen, through zi.tools, insists this is an old form of 與, but then why use both? A:10 also has 𠄎 (join). 𠄎 (rhetorical) from A:12, and from B:3 𠄎 (grant/and?); Also from B:3 𠄎/与 (bestow). See also A:18 (grant)

In this way, the sage needs not blind and torture the people into submission, the sage's talent is occupying the space that makes such coercive, damaging methods unnecessary. The sage has no need to punish or make the world miserable; it moves along with happiness, unbothered, without having to crow and chatter on about achievements or heroes. There is enough, there is plenty: nothing more than peace, safety, and autonomy is needed or longed for, and they are not wanting for either. People are not frustrated, because they are allowed to act in accordance with their will, their nature, but subtly directed in such a way that life still functions smoothly. There is no power struggles or competition, because there is no economy for it when the power comes from below and behind.

There is a complication in translation, depending on how one translates 厚 and 害. I am highly confident that 厚 is 厚 (thick, deep, full, richly, generous, lavish). When the sage's talent (or position) is above the people, the people are not 厚. This could be a good thing, that the people are not obstructed by the thickness or depth the sage creates – the sage does not make life for them like wading through the thick mud of a swamp, or swimming over deep water where one cannot stand on the ground. The does not permeate every part of their world. However, technically that would describe what the people are *in*, not what the people are. If one is stricter about that, then the people themselves are not “thick”, not deep, authentic, rich, generous: the position of the sage above them deprives them of something, makes them “thin”. To continue, when the sage is in front of the people, the people are 害, which Henricks has as 害 (harm, abuse), and Cook and I have as 害, which originally meant “to punish by tattooing the eyes” (see Wiktionary for 憲) or an alternative form of 憲 (standard, rule, law, emulate). The favorable reading would be that the sage's position in the front does not leave the people blinded by injury to their eyes, but the less favorable reading would be that the sage's position in the front leaves the people not emulating the standard (presumably that the sage is setting). This duality of both lines makes this section tricky. One could read these as the benefits of the sage's reaching the position of above and in front by means of being below and behind, or as the deficiency in results of the sage attempts to rule from above and in front rather than below and behind. Given the positive attitude this chapter has toward the sage, and its description of the sage attaining these positions by emulating the low and before nature of water, I lean toward the more positive leaning, but this on the slips is not so unambiguous. Yet, the world still moves, the people still function, everything is still alive and in motion. Even in peace, without advancement or achievement, there is life, movement. There is no risk of becoming stagnant or dead; the rivers and seas will supply the streams through rain, and the natural cycles of life will continue to circulate³⁸. Because the sage, the river, the sea, are

³⁸ Another little note regarding movement and water: personally I have always been confused by the association between water and stillness. Water is always moving. The ocean has endless waves, the rivers endlessly flow, even small ponds have their ripples and swaying of the water in place, and even undisturbed ice creaks and shifts (to say nothing of the unfrozen water often below). The authors of the Guodian certainly did not know this, but water molecules are constantly forming and breaking hydrogen bonds, transient associations based on the uneven spread of their charges. Water is constantly moving, even if it is not going anywhere.

constantly in motion, constantly circling, the world cannot be still and arrested. Even in place, forces are moving.

A quick aside, this valuing of the lack of motionlessness is preserved in at least some practices of Taijiquan: circular, reeling silk movement and spiral energy (纏絲勁). In this practice, the body is never totally static, instead always swirling and moving internally even if outwardly appearing still. This system explicitly recognizes the vitality of constant circulation and movement. To become perfectly still in a frozen, dead sense would be to arrest all of that internal energy, collapse the alignment that is maintained by the elliptical movement of qi (vital energy), and invite damage and death. An organism, especially a warrior, with no internal movement, no capacity to shift, cannot maintain balance or stance against enemies or danger. Internal movement is the baseline requirement just to stay where you are. This suggests that the paradox of moving to not-move is not just literary, as a tradition established centuries later also insists on the same principle as a physical truth beyond poetry.

The Confucian idea of the ruler having the duty to the people to supply them, and the people have the duty to obey in a bidirectional relationship, really is not so incompatible with this thinking. The sage ensures the people have enough without indulging in excess or lording over them in an aggressive manner, and the people in return keep the world moving (or, depending on how one translates, keep promoting the sage). There is mutual respect, and in this way, there is harmony. When the leader works for the people, and the people are successful and honor the ruler, this is in accordance with the Dao. Rather than this practice being maintained by obvious ritual as Confucius would emphasize, those acting in accordance with the Dao just...do it, silently, because that is the favorable arrangement.

Received 66 (A:2)

江海所以能為百谷³⁹王者

River seas [place by-means-of]/mechanism-by-which can/able act/do/use hundred valley king

The mechanism by which the rivers and seas can act as the kings of a hundred valleys,

以其善下之

By-means-of it virtue/goodness/favorable/advantage below/down

Is through lowering its goodness;

故⁴⁰能為百谷王

Thus can/able do/manipulate/act/use hundred valley king

Thus, can act as the kings of a hundred valleys.

是以[聖人之]

This by-means-of [sage]

By means of this [the sage]

³⁹ In every instance in this Chapter, Mawangdui has 浴, like Guodian

⁴⁰ Mawangdui have 是以 here and in the next line both, not 故

欲上民 {也}, 必以 {其} 言下之.

Desire above/superior common-people, certainly/must by-means-of words below/down this

Desiring to be above the people, certainly speaks words to be lower than them.

{其} 欲先民 {也}, 必以 {其} 身後之.

Desire first/front/prior common-people certainly by-means-of self/body behind/after this

Desiring to be first of the people, certainly keeps the self behind them.

是以⁴¹ 聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage,

處上而民不重 {也}

Stays/resides/occupies above and/but/yet common-people not heavy

Stays above, but the people are not heavily burdened,

處前而民不害 {也}

Stays/resides/occupies front/before/forward and/but/yet common-people not harmed/abused

Stays in the lead, yet the people are not abused.

是以天下樂推而不厭⁴² {也}

This by-means-of world music/glee go-forward but not satisfied/tired-of/bored/disgusted,

By means of this, the world gleefully advances him, and do not bore or loathe him,

以其不爭⁴³

By-means-of its/it not disputed/fight/contend/strive/quarrel

By means of his not striving and competing,

故天下莫能與之爭.

Therefore/thus under-heaven in-no-case can/able share/join [‘s] competition/quarrel/dispute.

As a result, no one in the world can join in his competition.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: There are not many differences between the

Guodian A:2 and Chapter 66, but there are some. Instead of the sage’s talent positioning above or below or behind or in front, it is that the sage desires to be in one position and so goes to the opposite. Paradoxically, this word desire implies to a degree that the sage is indeed striving at least to some degree for power or social position. Being talkative/garrulous is replaced also with loathing, being fed up with, or being bored of the sage. The stillness mentioned in the Guodian is replaced by disputing, competing, quarrelling. The argument at the end is that because the sage does not strive or compete, no one in the world can compete against him. This is true to the extent that the sage is not actually striving, but the use of the

⁴¹ Mawangdui have 故 for the entirety of the line here. 居 in place of 處 as well where it occurs

⁴² The Shuowen Jiezi, through zi.tools, offers the meaning of “pressed-down, weighed down, forced down”, Kroll suggests this is a borrowing of 壓, as does zi.tools itself.

⁴³ Both Mawangdui end this line with 與, and start this line with 非 (A) or 不 (B)

word 欲 calls this into question; does the sage actually intend to be below or behind, or is this performative, subversive? Is it a sneakier play for power, but still a play for power? The use of the word 才 in the Guodian does not introduce this complication: the talent is the position; there is no implied desire connected to it, and if this is indeed just 在 where this character occurs, then there is even less –this is just the position, where the sage exists naturally!

Guodian (A:3)

(𠂔/𠂔/罪) 莫 (𠂔/重)⁴⁴ (𠂔/乎) ⁴⁵ (𠂔/甚) (𠂔/欲),

Breaking-the-law/crime no-one/in-no-case heavy/crushing perhaps/than too-much/excess
want/desire

No crime is more crushing than excessive desire.

(𠂔/咎) 莫 (𠂔/會)⁴⁶ (𠂔/乎) (𠂔/谷/欲)⁴⁷ (𠂔/得),

Calamity/disaster/blame no-one/in-no-case universally-welcomed(?) perhaps want gain/obtain

No disaster is more unanimously welcomed than the want of gain.

(𠂔/化)⁴⁸ 莫大 (𠂔/乎) 不智足。

Transform/change/convert no-one/in-no-case greater perhaps not know/wisdom
foot/sufficiency

No conversion is greater than not knowing sufficiency.

智足之 (𠂔/為)⁴⁹ 足, (𠂔/此) (𠂔/𠂔/𠂔)⁵⁰ 足矣。

Knowing sufficiency [consider-as] sufficiency, this/these constantly/persistently sufficient [!]

Knowing sufficiency as sufficiency: this will always be sufficient!

⁴⁴ 𠂔: Cook has 𠂔 to become 重 (but the Guodian has this and it looks nothing like this: 𠂔). Zi.tools lists under 石 over 主, but see also 石 over 臺 for 厚: in A:2 (𠂔) and A:17 (𠂔). Heavy, thick, perhaps the meaning is “serious”? Compare to the mystery characters in A:18 (𠂔/𠂔). Due to the resemblance of the 主 component in 𠂔 (See A:4), this would be stone (石) over pillar (主), two heavy things that give a sense of crushing weight, or at least something very heavy to bear. Based on that, I favor some meaning of “heavy, crushing”, similar in sense to 重.

⁴⁵ 乎 in the Guodian is always 𠂔, written 𠂔. This can mean tiger 虎, but in the Guodian, it often stands in for 乎. (interrogative, rhetorical, exclamation, imperative, speculative). Instead of “perhaps”, 𠂔 is acting as “than”.

⁴⁶ 𠂔 Zi.tools has this as 會 (as 𠂔 over 日/甘), under the page 𠂔. Cook has 井 between 𠂔 and 日, which may be more accurate. May be 𠂔 (as early form of 痛 (Pain) or 甚 (too much/ severe, but see 𠂔)) or 險 (dreadful). Zi.tools suggests 𠂔 (gathering) but a character from the Guodian already exists under this, similar if not for the right part. 𠂔 means all, everybody, together, unanimous. Not for nothing, this character also bears some resemblance to the Zhou dynasty form of 𠂔 → 𠂔 → (𠂔), a musical instrument. If the bottom of this character really is 甘 (𠂔, sweet) or even 昌 (𠂔, sunlight, flourishing, lovely), we have “everyone/unanimous” (𠂔) over these positive things (sweetness of food is pleasurable, sunlight and the songs and shouts of the morning are favorable, perhaps there is a sense of “universally welcomed” here? Something everyone seems to think is favorable or at least in some way auspicious or beneficial? This is speculative for sure.

⁴⁷ 谷 and 欲: both are used in this chapter. Here and throughout, I translate 欲 as desire, craving, an urge to obtain, possess, or consume something. 谷 is expressed as want, an inclination, usually in terms of what to do, or to avoid.

⁴⁸ The slips are unambiguously 化, but others say it could be in place of 禍 (unblessed, divine misfortune)

⁴⁹ Abnormal form of 為: usually 𠂔, 𠂔, or 𠂔, (or in parts of Laozi B, 𠂔) but still within the variation listed by zi.tools that I am not very suspicious. 之為 as a compound means “consider(ed) as”.

⁵⁰ Technically 𠂔, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𠂔 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆, though without support from Shuowen Jiezi for this latter form with 心. This cluster is also related to 恒, which Cook seems convinced this means 恆 in B:1 and here, but 恆 in strips 6, 13, and 18.

A:3 Commentary:

Excessive desire is a transgression for the same reason that want of gain is a disaster: both endanger the self, both serve as a ticket into the world of striving for recognition, power, and wealth. Wanting to gain is socially acceptable, even encouraged, but the results of engaging in trying to obtain gain can be devastating, or, as the Guodian itself may put it through a character composed of a stone over a pillar, heavy to the point of crushing. One enters into this world of competing, attracting attention, making friends and enemies, by ceasing to realize that what is necessary is enough, by losing sight of sufficiency as sufficient. Of course, the only preventative remedy is knowing sufficiency as itself, knowing it is enough not to have fame, recognition, wealth, favor, power, prestige. Living is enough. I translate 咎 as calamity, though Cook has “retribution”, as though this wanting to gain is in itself the punishment. The way this word is used in the Yijing / Zhouyi, perhaps it could be retribution, but normally I see this translated as fault, error, disaster. Nevertheless, I thought it was worth a mention.

Received 46 (A:3)

天下有道

Under-heaven has/exists Dao/way

When the world has the Dao,

卻走馬以糞

Step-back/withdraw/pardon [walk/go horses]/galloping-horses by-means-of defecation/fertilization.

Gallop horses are pardoned to be used to fertilize fields

天下無道

Under-heaven lack/no Dao/way

When the world lacks the Dao,

戎馬生於郊

Warfare/army/military/soldier/assault/assist horses born/live in/at/than suburbs/meadows/outlands

War horses are born in the meadows.

[罪莫大於可欲]⁵¹

Crime/sin/vice in-no-case great/big in/at/than/regarding possible/permissible/can desire/craving

There is no crime greater than the capacity for desire

禍⁵²莫大於不知足

Divine-misfortune in-no-case great/big in/at/than not/no know foot/leg/sufficiency

There is no divine misfortune greater than not knowing sufficiency.

咎莫大⁵³於欲得

Fault/error/calamity/blame in-no-case great/big in/at/than desire gain/obtain/get

There is no blame greater than the desire to obtain more.

故知足之足常足矣

Therefore/thus/as-a-result know foot/sufficiency [‘s] leg/foot/sufficiency always/constant sufficiency!

Therefore, knowing the sufficiency of sufficiency is always sufficient!

⁵¹ From Mawangdui only, Mawangdui B lacks 於.

⁵² Mawangdui A has 禍

⁵³ Mawangdui A has 咎

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Chapter 46 of the received Dao De Jing has a bit more than what is featured in the Guodian. Most prominently, there is imagery of strong galloping horses being used to fertilize fields when the world “has the Dao”, and warhorses being born in the outlands or suburbs when the world “lacks the Dao.” Perhaps having the Dao reveals sufficiency, and thus prevents wars of ambition, wars fueled by want of gain.

Excessive desire is the crime in the Guodian; in the Mawangdui, the very possibility to desire is the crime – quite a bit more extreme, with echoes of the Four Noble Truths of Buddhism, the idea that the root of suffering is desire. The Guodian does not go this far, specifying “excessive.” Certainly one can still want things, but one should limit their wants reasonably, by need. With regards to the Mawangdui, Buddhism only had a significant presence in China centuries after the Mawangdui, though it certainly may color the interpretation of the Mawangdui and the received versions by later readers (myself initially included). It is unlikely the author(s) of the Mawangdui would make this connection to the Four Noble Truths, though it is interesting that there is such harshness toward desire. It is more likely that this antipathy toward desire can be explained by the influence of “*Huang-Lao*” thought, particularly the Guanzi’s *Xinshu* (“techniques of the mind”) material gaining court influence in the early Han. This, too, is an interpretive hypothesis not necessarily demonstrated by textual transmission.

Additionally, later versions consider the not-knowing of sufficiency to be 禍, a divine misfortune, as though a curse from somewhere external. However, the Guodian recognizes it as 化, a transformation, a conversion, a change of the mind. Once one pays attention to and is tempted by the “more”, one loses sight of what was enough, what could still be enough, and as a result, the behavior changes, and the calamities ensure. The lust for gain is not divinely imparted, at least not implicitly, in the Guodian. However, one can convert again by learning sufficiency. While the received makes this not-knowing of sufficiency to be an imposed curse, the Guodian makes this an internal, and potentially reversible, process.

Guodian (A:4)

以(衍⁵⁴/道)(𢇛/差⁵⁵)人(室⁵⁶/主)者,

By-means-of path/Dao, difference/recover/mistake people ruler/host/dominant [person]

Those who, through the path, deviate from the rulers of people,⁵⁷

不(谷/欲)以兵(𠂔/𠂔)⁵⁸於⁵⁹天下。

Not want/desire by-means-of weapons/warfare strong/dominance//firm/rigid in/at/than world

Do not want to use weapons to harden the world.

善⁶⁰者果而已,

Skilled/good people fruit/reality/execution and/yet stops/finishes/already.

Skilled people reap the fruits of their labor and yet are finished there,

不以取𠂔。

Not by-means-of seize/capture/acquire dominate/powerful/rigid/firm.

Not through seizing and rigidifying.

果而(𠂔/弗)(發/發)⁶¹,

Fruition but/yet/and not weeding-with-feet//shoot/emit/broach

They reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not trample further,

果而(𠂔/弗)(喬/驕)⁶²,

Fruition but/yet/and not lofty/high/tall//arrogant/proud

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not become lofty and proud,

果而弗(𠂔/矜)⁶³,

Fruition but/yet/and not flaunt/prag/sympathy/peril/important

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not flaunt them.

⁵⁴ Refers to walking, jogging, or striding (small steps). On slips, look like 衍 to me; but both are old forms of 行

⁵⁵ 𢇛 Originally 來 over 左 according to CRY, but listed in zi.tools under 差 as 來 over 右 as ZLW would (see Cook for both). I can see either being the case. Whether 右 or 左, these are both hands, and the original meaning of this character was “to rub” (put hands to wheat), but came to mean “difference”, “proportion(ate),” “mistake/error,” and also “choose,” “send”, and, in Chu regional dialect, “to recover from illness”, according to Kroll.

⁵⁶ Original is 𠂔, but this is indeed listed under 室 in zi.tools,. According to Duan Yucai through zi.tools, 主 was the ancient form of 室 (ruler or master). The character is constructed as a canopy/roof (人/宀) over a pillar, now represented as 主. See also A:3’s “crushing” pillar and stone.

⁵⁷ Or, alternatively “Those who through the path create a gap between people and rulers.”

⁵⁸ Slips have 𠂔, probably equivalent to 𠂔. Compare to the 𠂔 character in A:11 (𠂔). Zi.tools lists this similarly under 强, having the bottom 力 missing. The two lines may be an abbreviation. Consider, though, 𠂔 (𠂔), a variant of 𠂔 in zi.tools but attached to 剛 (hard interruption, rigid, unyielding, firm, strong). This visual resemblance is stronger to me. A:11 and A:17 would be “rigid” over “power” (力), to mean forceful, “brute forcing”.

⁵⁹ Originally 𠂔 → 𠂔 → 烏 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) ←→ 於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

⁶⁰ In Warring States, 善 means “good at doing”, “excelling at”, “advantageous”.

⁶¹ 𠂔 → 𠂔 The repeated 止止 got reduced to the “footprints” roof 𠂔. A bow 弓 and 𠂔 was added to keep martial meaning. (in zi.tools: 𠂔 | 𠂔 址一址又, under 發). Maybe → 發 (send, shoot, express, launch, announce, broach)

⁶² 𠂔 Listed as 九 over 高 in zi.tools (but only under 喬). High/tall/hook-tipped/upturning (or disguise), but often used in place or as interchangeable of 驕, which means haughty, arrogant, proud

⁶³ 𠂔 listed in zi.tools as 矜. Originally 矛+(命 or 令), flattened over time by abbreviation. Keeps the weapon + order/command/fate – intimidate or boast? By Kroll, sympathy, compassion, uncomfortable, respect, emphasize, cautious, prudent, solemn, grim, but also danger, peril and to hold oneself above or aloof, self-important, flaunt.

是(胃/謂)果而不弭。

These/this stomach//called/speak fruition/fruit but and/not dominate/powerful/rigid/firm

This is what is called reaping fruits of labor without hardness.

其事好[長⁶⁴].

Its/their/it/they business/to-serve good/attractive/excellent/pleasing/to-like [long-lasting/endure].

Its service is excellently enduring⁶⁵.

A:4 Commentary:

This chapter is explicitly about warfare, but can apply for many kinds of affairs, to be honest. This has more of the importance of knowing enough, or “knowing sufficiency” highlighted in A:3, and elaborates on the lack of need to dominate, subjugate, and inflict pain or loss on others in the finding of success. Unlike the rulers of men, who wage wars and measure success by conquest, expansion, and power, those who follow the path have no value in using violence and war to accomplish those aims. They do not need to seize or control anyone else. For those who follow the path, the fact that things are functioning, that one is good at their skill, is enough. There’s no need to act better than anyone else, or show the world their worth, or interfere in the lives of others, especially destructively. The results of their hard work are enough for them.

If we translate 差 not as “deviate” but as “create a gap between rulers and men,” the meaning may shift in interesting ways, almost making it sound like there are those that, by the Dao, drive a wedge between rulers and the people. Instead of making them compliant and harmonious with the commands from authority, there is new distance. Through observing the path of someone who follows the Dao, the values of the people may shift to reluctance to play the games of royals and warlords.

I have chosen to treat 𠂔 as hard, rigid, or firm, based on visual similarities with variants of 剛: this very well could really mean “dominating” in the sense of 强, but if it does not, this follows a greater pattern in the Guodian, and the tradition of Daoism, against rigid, unmoving, stagnant categories and understanding, or power and management. The success comes from staying within one’s matters, not lashing out beyond them. The power comes from not forcing anything to do something or fit something, but by abiding by one’s own nature and skills and letting everything else do its thing. Fruits from trees not watered with the blood of rivals are just as sweet if not sweeter.

It seems that the ruler, however, cannot exist within the boundaries of self-contained utility. The Guodian may be warning that for the ruler, the fruit is meaningless unless it is weaponized to expand boundaries, trample neighbors, and construct a towering, lofty legacy of prestige. They cannot harvest without 'seizing and rigidifying.' Thus, the Guodian warns that lashing out beyond the scope of one's immediate, skilled competence, trying to freeze the world into a conquered shape, destroys the very environment one depends on. True capability is fluid; it reaps the fruit without hardening the branch or tree from which it comes.

A translational note about 矜: I translate this as “to flaunt”. This could be to flaunt might, relating to possible connotations of intimidation or boasting. While sympathy, compassion, and discomfort are other possible readings, other sections of the Guodian suggest that one should very much be uncomfortable about war; see especially C:3.

If, indeed, the only way to reap fruit is through warfare, only just enough should be done and not a step further. War and death should bring no sense of pride – there is nothing to show off, nothing to praise,

⁶⁴ On the slips, this looks like it should be part of the next chapter, A:5, instead, due to section markers. However, context of A:5 convinces me that maybe it is better suited here.

⁶⁵ Or, if I am wrong about the placement of 長, “Its conduct is excellent.”

nothing to capitalize on, just the fruit, and nothing more. The fruit, on its own, is excellent (or perhaps excellently enduring, depending on how one places the 長); it is sufficient.

Received 30 (A:4)

以道佐人主者

By-means-of Dao assist/support/uphold people lord/king/rulers/host [person/phrase-end]

Those who, through the Dao, assist the rulers of people

不以兵強天下

Not/no by-means-of weapons/warfare/military dominate/strong/firm/powerful under-heaven

Do not use warfare to dominate the world.

其事好還

It/its matters/affairs good/excellent/pleasant/to-like come-round/go-back/send-back/redeem

Matters of warfare are good at coming back around.

師之所處荊棘生

Troops/army/learn-from/crowd⁶⁶ [‘s] place stay/reside thorns/difficulty thorny/harsh live/born

In the places where armies reside, thorny plants are born,

焉大軍之後必有凶年

From-it big/great armed-forces/soldiers [‘s] behind/after certainly has/exist ill-omened/deadly year

So, after great armies there are certainly inauspicious, deathly years.

善者果而已

Skilled/good/benevolent people fruit/reality/execution and/yet stops/finishes/already

Good people reap the fruits of their labor and yet are finished there,

不敢以取強

Not dare/bold by-means-of take/acquire/seize/capture dominate/strong/firm/powerful

***Not daring to further dominate by means of capture.*⁶⁷**

果而勿矜

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and not flaunt/prag/sympathy/peril/important

They reap the fruits of their labor yet do not flaunt them,

果而勿伐

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and do-not hack-at/attack/condemn/boast

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not boast of them,

果而勿驕

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and do-not arrogant/haughty

Reap the fruits of their labor, yet do not become arrogant,

果而不得已

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and not-obtaining-way-to-stop/cannot-avoid

Reap the fruits of their labor when it cannot be avoided.

果而勿強

Fruit/reality/execution yet/but/and do-not dominate/powerful/strong/firm

Reap the fruit of their labor, yet not dominating.

⁶⁶ Also master, tutor, counselor, crowd, multitude, learn from, skilled person (craftsman, virtuoso).

⁶⁷ Or, in the style of Cleary, Waley, Henricks, Feng & English, and to a degree Chan, “not daring to take advantage of victory”, or Linnell’s “take using strength”.

物壯則老

Things robust/in-their-prime/mighty/healthy when-then age/old/decay/wane

When things are robust and at their prime, then they age and wane.

是謂不道

This called not Dao

This is called not with the Dao.

不道早已

Not Dao early/ahead-of-time/morning already/stop/finish

What is not with the Dao has an early end.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Comparing to Chapter 30 of the received version, the

Guodian is making distance between those who follow the path (assumed to be the Dao) and rulers.

The received version turns those who follow the path into an advisor to rulers, not someone different from them. The Guodian paints these rulers as those who employ war to further themselves, to take more, to give themselves prestige, behaviors someone following the Dao would never engage in. In the received, those following the Dao are supporting rulers and so urging them, probably, not to frivolously engage in warfare like this.

There are added notes about the inauspicious nature of war, the misfortune that follows armies. It also

adds that fruit is reaped “when it cannot be avoided”, which the Guodian does not mention. The

Guodian in this chapter can almost be interpreted without regard to war, but this line restricts this further in the later versions. Also added is a note about how things at their prime start to wane and age, but that this is against the Dao, and what is against the Dao has an early end – perhaps this is a warning not to peak early? Regardless, these final lines about robustness and aging are absent in the Guodian.

Guodian (A:5)

[長⁶⁸](古/故)⁶⁹之善⁷⁰為士者,

[Long] old ['s]/this skilled act-as/do/use adept/knight/man

As a result, these who are skilled at acting as nobles

必非溺⁷¹玄達,

Certainly not sink/drown/flood translucent/mystery/dim breakthrough/insight/remove-blockage

Were certainly not drowning in mysterious insight

(深)不可⁷²(志)⁷³,

Deep not permitted/possible to-record/remember/intend/aim/aspired-toward.

So deep that it cannot be a target of aspiration.

是以為之(頌):

These/this [by-means-of do/use/act]/regard-as/take-as/make-into ['s/it/this] praise/oracles

This is used as their praise.⁷⁴

夜⁷⁵(唐/乎)(奴/如⁷⁶)(各/冬)⁷⁷涉⁷⁸川,

Night in/at/perhaps/"""" slave/enslave//like winter wade-though/experience/enter-into river/stream

In the night, perhaps as if in winter wading through a river,

⁶⁸ Looking at the strips, this looks like it should be part of this chapter, and not A:4, due to a dash mark. However, the context suggests that maybe it does actually belong to A:4. I discuss both scenarios below.

⁶⁹ I normally translate this as “therefore, thus, as a result”, but in this case it may be “ancient.” I note the inconsistency. Alternatively, this could be “therefore” following A:4’s critique of war and greed. In this case, the last line of A:4 would become “Its conduct is excellently enduring.” A:5 would then start with “Therefore, the skilled noblemen...” However, the 之 (a possessive particle, it/this) suggests to me that 古 is a noun/adjective. If 長 belongs in A:5 and 古 is meant as “ancient” this line becomes: “For a long time these skilled at acting as nobles” or “For a long time the ancient nobleman of talent.” If 長 is in A:5 and 古 is meant as 故 “therefore, thus” (as it normally does), the grammar becomes very awkward: “Long/enduring/maturing, as a result, these skilled at acting as nobles.” If we leave 長 in A:4 despite the mark on the slips, take 之 in the sense of “these”, and have 古 as 故, this line becomes “Therefore, these who are skilled at acting as nobles,” which is the best I can come up with trying to keep everything consistent.

⁷⁰ In Warring States, 善 means “good at doing”, “excelling at”, “advantageous”. The moral benevolence reading came later, with Confucius, Mencius. So think of this as “skilled” or “talented”.

⁷¹ Technically 弱 over 水 (in zi.tools: 𠂔𠂔弓勿水). Could be 弱 (weak and frail)? (See also A:17 and A:19)

⁷² On the strips, has an extra line above it

⁷³ My translation of 志 is a little complex. Its common translation is aspiration, ambition, will. However, this character is also a variant form of 誌 (Wiktionary). The etymology of the character is essentially “What is proceeded to”, by Schuessler, 2007. I was tempted to translate 志 as “recorded as an accomplishment” to capture both the sense of recording and ambition, but both readings work. The mysterious insights are too deep to be the target of ambition or will, because these deep mysteries exist outside of the activities that entail ambition.

⁷⁴ Based on recordable achievements, not any actual deep thing. The deep understanding of the Dao is not recordable, and so does not offer the praise they sought, so that they are not soaked in Dao allows them to collect achievements. It is possible that the scribe meant that the following rather unflattering images (at least by my translation) are taken as praise, but it still stands that the way toward this praise, these hymns, is not the way of the Dao, not the way of closing one’s gates.

⁷⁵ 𠂔 Technically 亦 over 夕 as in zi.tools, but still meaning 夜

⁷⁶ 𠂔 The slips unambiguously read 奴, but this is harder to make sense of than just using 如. It could be a pun, describing the nobles as enslaved by all of these things.

⁷⁷ 𠂔 Original character has a sun under it, reflecting an early form of the character.

⁷⁸ 𠂔 In zi.tools, technically 𠂔止 𠂔 𠂔八少, in the 涉 entry, but without its own page.

(猷/猷/猶) (虐⁷⁹/乎)其(奴/如) (𢇛/懼⁸¹/畏)四(叟/鄰),

Similar-to/like/plan/hesitant/still in/perhaps/“!” its/their/maybe slaves//like afraid four neighbors

Scheming⁸², perhaps maybe as if haunted by fear of neighbors on all sides,

敢⁸³(虐/乎)其(奴/如)客,

Dare/how-dare in/at/perhaps/“!” its/their/maybe slave/enslave guests/clients/stranger

Bold, perhaps maybe as if merely a stranger,

(慄/震)⁸⁴ (虐/乎)其(奴/如) (𢇛/懼⁸⁵/釋),

Looking-with-fear in/at/perhaps/“!” their/maybe slaves//like happiness/joyful//explain/dispel/release

Watching in horror, perhaps maybe as if experiencing true happiness,

屯⁸⁶(虐/乎)其(奴/如)樸⁸⁷,

Difficulty/hardship/gather/guard, perhaps its/maybe slaves//like simple/unworked-wood/unaffected

Struggling, perhaps maybe as if unprocessed wood⁸⁸

(沌⁸⁹) (虐/乎)其(奴/如)(渾/濁)。

Blocked up/ignorant, perhaps its/maybe slaves//like turbid/murky/impure/confused/corrupt/defiled

Obstructed, perhaps maybe as if defiled.

⁷⁹ This particular 虐 is pretty reduced: 𢇛 compared to something more like 𢇛 or 𢇛, so sad I cannot even find it on zi.tools, which makes me wonder if it's not 虐. It is the only one like this out of the entire chapter.

⁸⁰ 其 is usually a third-person possessive, however, it appears to be working in the capacity of an indicator of doubt, incredulity, or speculation (see Kroll).

⁸¹ 心 under 鬼 to mean 畏 (but listed under zi.tools as to mean 愧→懼), but could be read 畏 over 心 (→懼; ashamed, embarrassed). Cook has this as supposed to mean 畏. In C:1, I have this as “induce fear and dread”.

⁸² Elsewhere in my translation of the Guodian, I have taken 猷 as 猶, meaning similar to/like, or “designed/planned”. Here, I actually think that the original character's definition of scheming or planning works better in the pattern. Shuowen Jiezi also lists “hesitant, timid, doubtful and cautious” as meanings of 猶, even relating the “like/similar to” to the act of planning and designing. Inconsistency in my own translation, so I note.

⁸³ 敢 Zi.tools has this under 敢, this is a variant of 敢

⁸⁴ Zi.tools results match more to 遠 (but matches better with 見+袁 all over 止 (from 震). There's not a lot of info on old versions of 渙. May actually be closest to 還, which is also huan, but zi.tools matches most closely with the samples from 震 (which can be pronounced qiong but also huan). Zi.tools lists as 𢇛見袁止.

⁸⁵ 吳 over 心, as listed in zi.tools, leading to 懼. 吳 used to stand in for 澤, but also meant “big white”, but also marsh, pool, pond, moist, brilliance, luster, shine, and grace. Wiktionary lists 釋 as a variant of 懼, which honestly does not make things much clearer. 𢇛 (𢇛), for its part, means “detect”, “observe”, or “use eyes to put someone under arrest” according to the Shuowen Jiezi. Perhaps, this over heart (心) could mean having one's intentions or mind “found out”, if an abbreviated form of 𢇛 is in play. I default to 懼 due to the shared heart component.

⁸⁶ Shuowen Jiezi has this as “hardship”, the sprout breaking out of the ground. Difficulty and hardship.

⁸⁷ 樸 Originally 𣎵 over 臣 over 木. In zi.tools listed under 樸, meaning jujube, or dense or clustered growth, or firm/sturdy. The original form of 樸 was expressed as 𣎵 with 臣, meaning servant or slave. Given the prominence of the 木 radical and that 樸 means jujube, “unworked material” of 樸 probably fits best. (Compare to A:16: 樸)

⁸⁸ The uncarved block is usually positive in Daoism. It may be that the nobles are pretending, seeming raw but just struggling. “Uncarved block” as early as the Guodian may not have acquired its positive connotation yet.

⁸⁹ Hard to find history on this character: It seems to mean “stop, plug, bagged soil and grass to hold back water, ridge between fields” – definitely a sense of obstruction. 沌 is defined by Kroll as “uneducated, unaware, ignorant, and “benighted”, a intellectual, moral, or social deficiency of contemptible degree. So, obstructed or oblivious.

竺⁹⁰能濁以(𦰩/束/刺)者,

Thick/devoted capability/able/harmony/arrive muddied/corrupted by-means-of spike/thorn//to-pierce,
Genuine ability to pierce through the defilement

(廩/將) 舍⁹¹清⁹²。

Hold/support/use/bring/will guest-house/cottage/dwell/save clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent
Brings one to dwell in clarity.

竺能(𦰩/𦰪⁹³/仄)以(𨔵/迂⁹⁴/往)者⁹⁵,

Genuine ability duck-under(?) by-means-of moving-(directionally)

Genuine ability to move through bending and leaning

(廩/將) 舍生。

Brings/will dwell living/nature.

Brings one to dwell in survival.

保此(術/道)者不(谷⁹⁶/欲)(𦰩/黨)⁹⁷ 呈⁹⁸。

Preserve/protect this/those way/path [person] no desire clan/faction/side-with presented/manifest
These who preserve this way do not want to take sides with factions and present themselves.

A:5 Commentary:

The “shi (士)”, or noble, class were celebrated and renowned, their accomplishments remembered and recorded. The ancient talented 士 were not drowning in mysterious insight, because mysterious insight is so deep it cannot be recorded as an accomplishment, or too deep to be compatible with the ascent of ambition. Subtle mysteries of the Dao are too deep and removed from words to record, describe, formally recognize. These mysteries are in the murky depths, and the shi were trying to fly to heaven.

⁹⁰ Kroll’s dictionary has both 竺 and 篤 as “genuine, devoted, honest, single-mindedly, faithful, dedicated, loyal, or to an extreme degree. Zi.tools has these both as “thick” and “heavy”, by 《漢語同源詞大典》.

⁹¹ Listed under 舍 in zi.tools. 舍. Sometimes used in the sense of 捨(to release, relinquish). Second instance 舍.

⁹² Originally, actually 青 over 水

⁹³ Originally 𦰩, which zi.tools renders 𠂔 to the left of 匕 (under its 𠂔 listing, but under both entries, variation is considerable). Cook says 庇 but I don’t see it, unless the 匕 was just not duplicated. There may be evidence for 𦰪 or 𦰫 but visually both are only a little convincing. Li Tianhong argues this is Chu shorthand for 𦰪 (hide, conceal). To me, this looks like 仄 (tilt, lean/ duck under), a man under an overhang/cliff for shelter. Or this could be the Spring and Autumn or Warring states version of 尸 under this overhang, though it would be facing the wrong direction. Undoubtedly this is a backward person under an overhang. Possibly, this means to duck down or duck under something, lean or tilt, in the sense of 仄

⁹⁴ Originally 𨔵 definitely 𨔵 with another component like 𠂔 or 𠂔 (迂? or 行 above 之/止?), these components all give a sense of marching, movement, probably most similar now to 往; Cook calls this 迂→動. This also may look like 迂 (tortuous avoidance). Zi.tools does not have this character under any of these things or anything I’ve searched up – the only safe guess is that it is movement of some kind.

⁹⁵ This is a perhaps creative alternative to how this line is normally rendered. Murkiness, by stillness, is made clear—particles settling out of churning waters. Tilting/leaning/ducking, by movement, makes survival/life, a successfully maneuvering organism traveling through the structures of the environment. This is not a translation totally out of the tradition of Daoism, see commentary.

⁹⁶ Literally means valley, likely a loan or original form of 欲; the Chu variant of 欲 listed under zi.tools is 谷 + 次.

⁹⁷ Cook has this as 尚, but zi.tools has as 堂, meaning 黨

⁹⁸ Technically 口 over 土 by zi.tools, under 呈

The ambition of the shi, their heart set on a direction to be followed, could not be directed that way, nor could the subtle mysteries be bent to further their intentions.

The Shi chased accomplishments that could be spoken of, written, and so earned their praise and hymns that way, but this was not because they were saturated with insight into the murkiness of true nature. The 士 class, whose entire identity was built around recorded achievements, legacies, and social recognition, simply couldn't use 玄達. It didn't fit their economy of merit and recognition. So they remained oblivious to or dismissive of it not because they were wise, but because it offered them nothing claimable. Certainly these men of accomplishments were not the ones making breakthroughs of that nature, not piercing through to the mysterious and endless. Their fame, and regard, are within the social construct. The great kings and famous lords and clever advisors earned their place in history through chasing and attaining tangible gain, obvious power. Insight into the mysterious isn't a prerequisite –perhaps this insight would even halt the clout-chasing.

Guodian A:5 becomes direct takedown of the shi (士) class, the ambitious, striving elite looking to score historical wins and earn a legacy. The Warring States period was full of ambitious men burning themselves out for political fame. In that pursuit of fame, they forced themselves into a life of these things, these sub-optimal descriptions, yet we praise them on their recorded feats, not on their real connection to the subtleties and mysteries of the Dao. Society praises these guys for being hyper-vigilant and perpetually stressed out, but they are actually just suffering. Greed leads to the excessive abundance that leads to the worry over loss. Pride leads to the accumulation of power through favor and dominance that leads to the worry over shame, or being conquered the same way. During the Warring States period, the shi class traveled from kingdom to kingdom trying to sell their strategies to kings. They were under intense pressure to perform, network, and record accomplishments. The Guodian reads as though pointing to the striving old heroes of elite "talent" and saying, "Look at how they are drowning in their own strategic anxieties, and not in the Dao.'

The life of these shi, and those who want to emulate them, is like being in the night, surrounded by dark shadows and unseen threats. It is cold and risky and hard and miserable, like trying to cross a river in the harshest season. Winter is mentioned again, in A:6, where it is associated with danger and caution, and the dangers of winter are many: running low on food, slipping and falling on ice and becoming injured, trying to stay warm, sickness and potentially decreased ability to fight it off. Crossing a river in the winter is even worse than just being in winter: hypothermia from being wet and cold, unpredictable ice collapses, frostbite, equipment loss due to failing ropes, and of course the vulnerability of even an army trying to navigate through all of these dangers. The shi are living their life like crossing a river in winter, a perpetual freezing trauma, not peaceful mindfulness or balanced caution.

Scheming as if in fear of the four directions describes the lack of trust, courtly paranoia, and the cutthroat nature of trying to curry favor and gain influence and prestige. In such an unstable, high-risk-high-reward world, one is constantly strategizing to maximize large gains and minimize massive loss.

The boldness of the traveling shi, comes through being a guest or stranger, someone not attached strongly to where they currently are, who does not have to face those who know them, unaccountable to those around them. They act with impunity because they see themselves as "other". They are not rooted where they may cause disaster, the consequences of what happens to others do not bite so deep. Instead, the terror is from above. The Shi, as warriors and scholars, had impunity before the common people, but were deeply accountable to their reputation, or put otherwise, their name (名) in the network of nobility. They could be bold against the "nobodies", but had to be always on point for players in the game of power. Any failure or blemish on their name could result in exile, poverty, or execution.

Watching in horror, as if experiencing true happiness (if the character is truly 懌): True happiness is contentment, contentment is knowing sufficiency and having acquired it. Someone engrossed in the struggle for more and more has lost the ability to process this, and experiencing true happiness, sufficiency, would, as an outcome, look like abject failure. Fear of loss, obsession with gain, makes this true happiness so alien that the only response is to look upon it with something like confusion, disgust, and terror. Someone who is just content to be alive and be comfortable threatens the validity of all of the risk and all of the strain of the brutal chase for societally defined “success”. If the character is 釋 (released, unburdened), the logic is similar.

If the character is instead 罣 (arrest, detection, being found out) with a heart component added to emphasize mental/emotional state, then the horror of being exposed is what is illustrated. Careful schemes discovered, secret weaknesses made into the talk of the town, falseness crumbling under scrutiny, or “fake it until you make it” hitting an unyielding wall would all be horrific for an ambitious person to endure or watch helplessly unfold.

Struggling, as if unprocessed wood, is trying to carve and mutate something out of its original form. The unprocessed wood, the true nature, is not suitable for the attainment of many achievements and glory, so the shi are forced to try to force it into function. The rest of this paragraph is an extension of the image beyond what the Guodian strictly states. The wood is carved and wrestled with to make a tool, and the shi wrestle and carve into themselves to make a legend. Their original nature, what makes them themselves, is corrupted, twisted, hacked into and pressured, and the end result is someone, they hope, will have the favor of rulers, the respect of people, the fear of enemies, the honor of the subsequent generations. But by the end of the process, is it even the same person who is there? It would make sense that they would look upon the happy, unambitious person with utter horror – that “loser” is intact, pure, and they may never be pure again.

The shi are obstructed, blocked up, not circulating, perhaps losing connection with the Dao, as though they are defiled. This defilement is not necessarily moral sin, but rather the warping of artificiality, the struggling mentioned above, that removes them from their true nature, their purity. The only chance they would have to find contentment is to pierce through that obstruction, shed away the societal, unnatural expectations of success. Those who are content have done this; they see through the falseness of the rat-race for power and fame, they rip through it like a thorn, and they remain unharmed. One who can maneuver through life, bending and being flexible, allowing oneself to be lower to find the path of least resistance, will find less need for permanent modifications or being trapped. Ducking under, leaning around, dodging danger, getting to safety – any animal lives much longer this way than constantly climbing. As for taking sides and presenting themselves, one is much safer when hidden, when not attracting the interest or ire of others. They do not want to get involved in unnecessary affairs that may endanger them and theirs for something abstract.

The word choice of “pierce” may be troubling to those accustomed to later, pacified traditions that value stillness and total tranquility. However there are physical traces of this kind of sharp “piercing” in old Chen Style Taijiquan. This style is characterized by its punctuation with sudden, explosive movements that release great amounts of integrated power (發勁). The concept of a sharp, localized, forceful penetration is not an aberration from the Dao or those that follow it; it is a structural necessity to reach clarity. Similarly, Taijiquan has low stances, withdrawing steps, and torso rotation; to bend and twist and duck and be lower, to dodge incoming attacks or work one’s way through tight passages or obstructions. There is a time for passive yielding, and low-to-the-ground evasion, and there is a time for precise, active striking to puncture a target, cutting swiftly through obstruction. The language of the Guodian reflects and holds both kinds of movement close, refusing to sacrifice active capacity for docile yielding, but also refusing to sacrifice in the reverse.

Before continuing, a translational elephant in the room needs to be addressed: 奴 only occurs in this chapter of the Guodian, other chapters use 女 or 若 (though only in A:20, and the B and C chapters). I genuinely feel bad about translating this as “as if” or “like”, because this must have been a deliberate choice of the scribe. However, I struggle to maintain a consistent translation (i.e. enslaving X or enslaved by X) when I try to apply it. “In the night, perhaps enslaved crossing a river in winter” can work, but “In the night, perhaps enslaving winterly river crossers” is confusing. “Scheming, perhaps enslaved by fear of neighbors on all sides” makes sense, but “Scheming, perhaps enslaving fear of neighbors on all sides” is awkward at best. However, “Bold, perhaps enslaved by strangers/guests” makes no sense, but “Bold, perhaps enslaving strangers” *is* coherent. “Stunned/watching in horror, perhaps enslaved by happiness” and “Stunned/watching in horror, perhaps as if enslaving true happiness”, in my opinion, are both comprehensible. “Struggling, perhaps enslaved by unworked wood/simplicity” makes less sense than “Struggling, perhaps enslaving unworked wood/simplicity”. “Obstructed, as if enslaved by defilement” makes more sense than “obstructed, as if enslaving defilement.” Perhaps someone wiser than I can make sense of it – perhaps it is nothing but a visual pun, mocking the state of these lofty-seeming people – but I could not leave it undiscussed.

Received 15 (A:5)

古之善為士者

Old/ancient [‘s] skilled/good/advantageous do/act-as/use nobles/knights

The skilled nobles of old,

微妙玄通

Subtle/tiny/secret/barely-there subtleties/marvels/wonder murkiness/mystery/dim pass-through

Were wondrously subtle, penetrating through murky mysteries.

深不可識

Depth not able/can record/informed-about/aware-of/familiar-with

Their depth cannot be known.

夫唯⁹⁹不可識

In-any-case only not permissible/able/possible informed-about/aware-of/familiar-with/record

It is that they are unknowable,

故強為之容

As-a-result/thus strong/try-hard do/use/act-as [‘s] appearance/permit/receive/tolerate/pardon

So we forcibly put effort into acting as they appeared.

豫¹⁰⁰兮¹⁰¹若冬涉川

Happy/content/comfortable/preparatory [!] like/as winter wading-through river/stream

Prepared! Like winter wading through a river,

猶兮若畏四鄰

Hesitant/planning/yet [!] like/as fear four neighbors,

Hesitant! Like being in fear of neighbors on all sides,

⁹⁹ This 夫唯 seems to be a fixed phrase, meaning “It is this that does/causes....” As well as “Only this explains ...”

¹⁰⁰ In Kroll, Wiktionary nor in zi.tools can I find a meaning of “cautious” or “circumspect” specifically for 豫; the Shuowen Jiezi offers a large elephant that does not harm things. Most definitions, in fact, point to joy, generosity, being relaxed, and comfortable. In both Mawangdui, this is 與, (give, grant, assist, join with, unite with, participate in, from Kroll; by zi.tools, deliver, “fellow partisans”). In Mawangdui B, 川 is 水.

¹⁰¹ For this line only, for the Wang Bi, Henricks has 焉 instead, and both Mawangdui have 呵 for every 兮.

儼兮其若 (客/容¹⁰²)

Serious/grave/solemn/ceremonious/neat [!] it/its like/as stranger/guest/appearance/permit/pardon
Solemn! They are like being a guest.

渙兮若冰¹⁰³ 之將釋

Disperse/diffuse/dissolve [!] Like/as ice [‘s] bring release/expel/explain/set-free/discard
Dissolving! Like the breaking free of ice.

敦¹⁰⁴兮其若樸

Thick/genuine/sincere/generous/honor [!] It/its like/as unworked-wood/adhere/simple/honest/rough
Genuine! They are as if simple (uncarved wood).

曠兮其若谷

Brilliant/clear/vivid/bright/vast/unrestricted/expansive/barren/bleak [!] it/its like/as valley/cave
Vast and barren! They are like a valley.

混兮其若濁

Muddy/murky/confused/jumbled [!] its/it like/as muddied/turbid/murky/confused/corrupt/defiled
Confused! They are as if turbid.

孰能¹⁰⁵濁以靜之徐清

Who/which capable/able/arrive turbid/confused/defiled by-means of motionless/stillness [‘s]/this
calmly/leisurely/dignified clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent
Who is able to, through stillness, calmly bring turbidity to clarity?

孰能安以久¹⁰⁶動之徐生

Who/which able/capable peace/quiet/stable/install by-means-of long-standing/old/enduring/familiar
move/shift/act [‘s]/this calmly/leisurely/dignified life/born/create
Who is able to, through long enduring movement, calmly bring what is stable to life?

保¹⁰⁷此道者不欲盈

Protect/sustain/persist this Dao/way people, not want/desire/crave fullness/filled-up
Those who persist in this Dao do not desire to be filled up.

夫唯不盈¹⁰⁸

In-any-case only not filled-up/fullness
It is that they are not filled up,

故¹⁰⁹能蔽{而}不新¹¹⁰成

Thus/as-a-result can/able/capable conceal/hide/camouflage/protect/mask/shelter/decide and/yet not
new/fresh achievement/accomplishment/complete
So they are able to be covered, and yet not freshly accomplished.

¹⁰² Only WangBi has 容 here.

¹⁰³ In Mawangdui, 冰 is 凌, and 之將 is not there.

¹⁰⁴ Mawangdui B has 沌: uneducated, unaware, ignorant, and benighted

¹⁰⁵ In both instances, Mawangdui do not have 孰能 or 竺能

¹⁰⁶ Only WangBi has this 久

¹⁰⁷ Mawangdui has 葆 instead.

¹⁰⁸ Mawangdui A has 欲 before 盈 here.

¹⁰⁹ Mawangdui B (and likely A) have 是以 instead of 故

¹¹⁰ Only in WangBi.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The largest difference between the received Dao De Jing (Chapter 15) is the way the shi (士), or nobles, are treated. The Guodian flatly states that they are not drowning in mysterious insight, negating their capacity. The received versions, however, say that they were unfathomably subtle and penetrated through the murky mysteries the Guodian claims they could or would not reach.

Having erased the negation of the mysteriousness of the shi (士), the received texts proceed to describe their behavior in similar ways as the Guodian, but reframing it as praise rather than a description of suffering. This self-destructive (and outwardly destructive) way of life is morphed into an elite behavior manual, something to be emulated and copied. This forcible trying, relies on the hope that performatively following this choreography will bring one's internal state to match these mysterious people.

What follows is the resulting reframing of the unwholesomeness of chasing prestige and glory into a display of exquisite, mystical aristocratic grace. The darkness and insecurity of night is turned into "preparedness" at least confusing and "joy" at most, as one wades the river in the winter. The scheming, planning, or hesitation and fear of one's neighbors remains consistent between the two versions, but the Guodian's "bold/daring" becomes "solemn/grave/serious", turning a lack of respect into deep reverence. "Watching in horror" or being stunned, is replaced by "dissolving", and true happiness, or even release, is transformed into the breaking apart of ice. "Struggling" becomes "genuine" or "sincere", and "obstructed/blocked-up" becomes "confused, jumbled". The portrait of anxiety, terror, mania, and scheming of the Guodian becomes domesticated to describe a careful, graceful, polite, mysterious, confusing person.

Ultimately, the received version seems to explain that this behavior comes from knowing the unknowable cosmic secrets. The Guodian offers no such excuse; the deep, murky mysteries of reality are not inherently unknowable to humanity, but they are incompatible with political and social ambition. The ambitious shi (士) remain oblivious to the Dao because the murky mysteries have no value in their prestige-based economy. The received seems to encourage masquerading and imitating the mysterious, lofty behavior of these people, who are NOT referred to as sages in either version, but if the prescription is to put on an act, how is it we are sure that the nobility themselves don't just put on this act for the sake of seeming superior and untouchable?

The received asks who can calmly bring the murk to clarity through stillness. The Guodian answers that it is the genuine ability to pierce through the murkiness that brings clarity. In the Guodian, the solution is not a passive waiting for the particles to settle into stillness, but rather a precise, piercing strike to break out of the defilement of the artificial world. The received asks who can calmly bring what is stable into life. The Guodian answers that the genuine ability to move in twisting and flexible ways brings survival. In the Guodian, the solution is not a magical transformation from stable to living, but movement as the key to living. The Guodian's remedies are not necessarily abstract, lofty methods of scrubbing clean the mind as in the Guanzi, or the emptiness of Buddhist asceticism. The Guodian's medicines are those of nature: pierce the confusing cage, dodge the golden leashes. It remains a low-to-the-ground, defensive survival strategy for a living animal that refuses to be contained, factionalized, or sacrificed to the spectacle of power.

The Guodian mentions that those who preserve this way, the way of clarity and living, do not wish to take sides in factions or present themselves before the world. Indeed, the received, depending on how one translates it, retains the desire of those with the Dao to remain hidden or concealed, but embeds this in an explanation of how they also do not desire to be "full." To become "full" of one's achievements, display too much gaudy excellence, flaunt wealth, is to attract the attention, envy, and malice of rivals and the suspicion of rulers. The received advises, therefore, to conceal, or cover, to keep a camouflage, to dodge this dangerous attention, but it does not explicitly advise withdrawal. The Guodian reiterates

that the way to win the game is not to play: do not align with factions, do not advertise oneself in any way at all. Through these subtle additions and wording changes, the received version transforms escape into hiding. In the received, one avoids 'fullness' merely to continue to operate within high society and politics more safely and subtly. In the Guodian, one looks upon the pursuit of whatever it is to be "full" or "empty", and simply walks away.

Guodian (A:6)

為之者(𠄎/敗)¹¹¹之,

Manipulate [‘s]/this [person] corrupts/defeats/spoils/destroys/ruins [‘s]/this

Those who manipulate it, corrupt and destroy it.

(𠄎¹¹²/執)之者(𠄎/遠)¹¹³之。

Grasp/seize/clutch/take-control [‘s]/this [person] distant/far/separated/estranged/far-reaching [‘s]/this

Those who clutches it close makes it distant.

是以聖人亡為,

This by-means-of sage lack/no do/act/use/manipulate

By means of this, the sage does not manipulate,

(古/故)亡敗; 亡執,

Old/ancient//therefore, lack/not corrupt/destroy, not grasp/seize/clutch-close

And as a result, does not corrupt and ruin, does not seize to hold close,

(古/故)亡(𠄎¹¹⁴/失/逸)。

Old/ancient//therefore, not escaping/breaking-free.

And so, it does not break free and escape.

(𠄎/臨¹¹⁵)事之(𠄎/紀¹¹⁶),

Look-from-above/preside-over/on-verge-of/oversee /matters/serve [‘s] strand/unravel/arrange/rule

The rule of presiding over matters:

(𠄎/誓¹¹⁷/𠄎→慎)(各/冬)(女/如)(𠄎¹¹⁸/殆),

Swear/oath//Cautious winter woman//like/as-if/ in-danger/in-peril

Caution and winter, like there’s danger,

¹¹¹ In Henricks, the left part is 貝, but Cook doesn’t address this. 𠄎 expressed as 敗 or 𠄎 in zi.tools, under 敗.

¹¹² In zi.tools as (𠄎幸𠄎𠄎女), under 執, so the components are consistent.

¹¹³ Cook says that 遠(𠄎) was also meant to be 𠄎 and translates both to 失, but the resemblance between the two characters in the Guodian is insufficient. Far/ distant/remote still works in context as well.

¹¹⁴ 𠄎: Zi.tools has similar (𠄎) as (𠄎𠄎止𠄎) (handcuffs/fetters), giving a sense of breaking out of jail, escaping and running away. This can relate to 失 (lose) in the sense that the guards lost their charge, but also you can relate this to escaping, or even 逸 (a rabbit running, the way this concept was expressed in kingdoms west of Chu).

¹¹⁵ This transcription is probably sound, but in zi.tools, it is an “odd one out”.

¹¹⁶ 𠄎: cannot find in zi.tools but Cook, Henricks both have 紀 which is plausible. Possibly, left is 幺 over [???].

¹¹⁷ 𠄎. In zi.tools as 𠄎𠄎十言斤, to mean 慎 (Cook agrees). The top part looks like Zhou bronze-inscription style 土 (𠄎), or maybe just a very reduced 糸. Compare with C:4’s 𠄎 A:15’s 𠄎, as 𠄎, which could also mean 慎.

However, 𠄎→𠄎 is attested in the Shuowen to be equivalent to 慎. The only evidence I’ve seen so far that these characters are 慎 comes from the Mawangdui and WangBi. Henricks has 誓 (to swear; but see 𠄎 from Wiktionary, zi.tools has this as 𠄎𠄎斤言女). 𠄎 itself means “happiness”. Following A:15, I take this in the sense of 慎, but the etymology is not the most convincing to me, though “happiness” makes no sense in context.

¹¹⁸ Compare to Guodian A:9 (𠄎), this one in A:6 has an extra line. Both Henricks and Cook have 𠄎 without the box (𠄎). Zi.tools has this as 𠄎. Meanings range from 殆 (danger (危, from Shuowen Jiezi); 漢語同源詞大典: broken-down/deteriorated/decayed (Analects: doubtful), 治 (to control, to harness, to manage, to govern, to channel like water), 怠 (slow, leisurely, sluggish; 漢語同源詞大典: exhausted, fatigue; I think this is unlikely as 怠 already used in the Guodian and they are not that similar: 𠄎 vs 𠄎 from here), 怡 (joyous, harmonious), 辭 (governance, to govern through law/litigation), and 貽 (to give as a gift), at least by zi.tools under 𠄎. I find 殆 or 治.

(𠂇/此)亡敗¹¹⁹事矣。

This no/lack corrupt/ruin/destroy matters/to-serve [!]

This lacks the corruption of matters!

聖人(谷/欲)不(谷/欲),

Sage want not/no want

The sage wants the unwanted,¹²⁰

不貴(𧰨/難)(𧰨/得)之(𧰨/貨),

Not prizing/valuing/seeing-as-precious difficult obtain [‘s]/this goods/items

Not valuing items difficult to obtain as precious;¹²¹

(𠂇/𠂇/教¹²²)不(𠂇/𠂇/教),

Reveal/release/exile/set-free//follow-superiors not reveal/release/exile/set-free//follow-superiors

Reveals the untaught¹²³

(復/復)¹²⁴(𧰨/眾)之所¹²⁵(𧰨/化/過)¹²⁶。

Return multitudes/crowds [‘s]/this /that-which/place-(x2)/wherever change//pass-through/trespass

Returning to wherever the multitudes pass through to be converted.

是(古/故)聖人

This old/ancient//therefore/as-a-result sage

This, as a result, the sage,

(𧰨/能)(𧰨/尊¹²⁷)萬(勿/物)之自然¹²⁸,

Can/able spread-out/expand ten-thousand things [‘s]/this self-nature/self-so

Is able to spread the self-nature of ten-thousand things,

而(授/弗)能為。

But/and/yet not able/can do/use/manipulate,

But not able to manipulate them.

¹¹⁹ Messier, but definitely this character 𧰨 is still 敗

¹²⁰ Or, “the sage wants not to want”. The “verb-不-verb” construction is somewhat flexible in this way.

¹²¹ Alternatively, “not valuing rare items as precious.”

¹²² See also A:9. Could also be 學 (mimic, imitate, emulate, learn), but this doesn’t change the connotation of studies/teachings. Guodian slip photos support 𠂇 at least. Zi.tools also has 𠂇. Wiktionary lists 𠂇 and 𠂇 as a variant of 教, but Shuowen Jiezi equates 𠂇 with 放 (release, abandon, expel, exile, cast aside, put down, fully revealed (open and expressed fully), set-free, act with no constraints; though Cook says the Shuowen calls it as 放, “to emulate”?), but also follow and adhere to according to 說文解字注.

¹²³ Or “releases not to release”, which makes less sense, or “follows not to follow”/ “teaches not to teach”, if 教

¹²⁴ Henricks and Zi.tools accurately has this as 復, probably emphasizing the walk/going aspect.

¹²⁵ Indicated with a duplication mark, also in this form 𧰨.

¹²⁶ Cook, Henricks and zi.tools appropriately have this as 化 over 止. Zi.tools connects this to 過, which has 𧰨, found in C:4.過 appears as 𧰨 in the Guodian as well, though. I am more inclined to read this in the sense of 化, change – perhaps a movement that changes someone? Journey in the learning sense? 化, according to the Shuowen Jiezi, had an early meaning of “change people by talking and teaching”, a sense of perhaps convince or convert.

¹²⁷ Somewhat unique compared to other examples of 尊 in zi.tools (𧰨), but within variation. Shuowen Jiezi defines this as 布 (to spread out, all around, spread out). This character is now used as 敷.

¹²⁸ An odd form, 𧰨, within variation.

A:6 Commentary:

Using and manipulating corrupts, grasping close drives separation, and by doing neither, the thing remains. Water is not water when polluted or modified, trying to grasp it in the hands will leave it slipping between the fingers. A captured and caged bird no longer acts as its pure wild self; it will resent the cage and will resent you for your “love”, and given any opening, it will fly out and away at first chance. Even more gravely, the same holds for a person forced or coerced rather than freely associated. To use or manipulate a person is to damage and traumatize them; the more forcefully you demand love, the further away it gets; no one wants more than to leave when the door is locked. But when the door is always open, leaving is free, and they stay. Such is like water, such is like a wild animal, such is like a lover, such is like the Dao.

Connecting this to B:6, the closed gates are not to trap in, but to keep out. B:6 instructs one to close the gates and block passages in so that one does not end up somewhere dangerous and hard to escape. The closed gates are like a tortoise's shell -- the tortoise is not in prison, it is protected. Those closed doors are armor. Those closed doors keep out, not trap in. The sage's gate is no prison, it is a refuge. The tortoise emerges at its choosing, but will not be forced out.

“Wanting the unwanted” is a rarer translation for this line, which is usually rendered in the received as “want not to want” or “desire not to desire”. I keep “want the unwanted” because the sage, at least in the Guodian, wants the simple sufficiency, the raw and sincere nature, the unembellished, unsung, mundane life when everyone else wants prestige, wealth, status, power, and everything along that line. The sage does not need to want not to want if the sage wants the right things. If the sage does not want excess, or attention, or control, or clout, how can there be misfortune? Keeping this construction allows me to maintain consistency in translating “reveals/teaches the untaught” or “learning the unlearned”; otherwise this would have to be rendered “teaching not to teach” or “learning not to learn”, which does not seem compatible with the rest of the teachings of the Guodian.

Returning to the “place of conversion”: I think this refers to the process of “unlearning” (or perhaps in A:6, “unteaching” or “unfollowing”) what society has hammered into everyone. This is going back through the transformation in the other direction, unlearning the learned and learning what was unlearned when that initial transformation took place, and putting it into practice to be “revealed” or “released”. By releasing what is not released, what is against convention or expectation, by not trying to block up one's nature, one reverts back to a truer version. This is not forcing oneself against the grain, but rather releasing what already has a natural force behind it, choosing not to constrict it. By revealing, letting out in its full expression, what is not “set-free”, what is forced into hiding, the conversion process of conforming to the expectations, aims, and imposed ways of society is reversed.

The sage spreads ten-thousand things but does not use them. The ten-thousand things are not tools or slaves to the sage. By learning them, respecting them, making room for them, working along with them, what needs to be done is done itself.

Received 64 Part 2 (A:6)

為 {之} 者敗 之執 {之} 者失 之

Act/do/use [person] corrupts/ruins/destroys [‘s]/this, seize/capture/grasp [person] loses [‘s]/this

Those who manipulate it ruin it, those who seize onto it lose it.

是以聖人無為 {也} 故無敗

This by-means-of sage no/without act/do/use thus/as-a-result no/without ruin/destroy/corrupt

By means of this, the sage does not manipulate, and so does not ruin.

無執故無失

No/without seize/grasp/capture thus/as-a-result no/without lose

Does not seize, and so does not lose.

民之從事{也}常於幾成

People ['s]/this follow/join matters constant/persistent in/at/from almost//how-much complete/achieve
The followed matters of the people are constantly almost complete,

而敗之

And/yet/but ruin/destroy/corrupt ['s]/this
And yet they become ruined.

{故}慎終如始

Cautious/vigilant/attentive finish/end/finally like/as/similar-to start/initiate/begin
When one is cautious at the end as one is at the start,

則無敗事

when-then no/without ruin/destroy/corrupt matters/affairs/to-serve
Then matters will not be ruined.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage
By means of this, the sage

欲不欲

Want/desire not/no desire/want
Desires the undesired¹²⁹

不貴難得之貨

Not prizing/valuing/ seeing as precious difficult-to-obtain/(rare) ['s]/this goods/items
Not valuing rare items as precious

學不學

Learn/mimic/emulate not learned/mimic/emulated
Learns the unlearned,

復眾人之所過

Return multitudes/crowd people ['s] place passed-over/through/excess/go-beyond/trespass/mistake
Returning to the place the multitudes of people passed over.

以輔萬物之自然

By-means-of carriage-stabilizer/jawbone/stabilize/aid ten-thousand things ['s]/this self-so/self-nature
By means of stabilizing the true nature of the ten-thousand things,

而不敢為

And/yet/but not dare/bold use/do/act-as/manipulate
Yet not daring to manipulate them.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The differences in this case to the latter half of Chapter 64 of the received are not actually very many. Where the Guodian discusses how to oversee matters, treating them with the caution one would treat winter with, the received version instead bemoans the tendency of people to ruin the affairs they nearly achieve, and advises to treat the end of matters with the same caution as one would the start.

Additionally, A:6 has “reveals/teaches the untaught” whereas the received has “learns the unlearned” or “mimics what is not mimicked.” What is returned to is also slightly different. The Guodian has the sage return to the place where people are converted, presumably where they learn and accept artificial classifications, the attractiveness of prestige, wealth, glory, and favor, and other socially imposed

¹²⁹ Nearly all translations outside of Waley have this line as some form of “desires not to desire”, and, take 學不學 to be “learn to unlearn”, though Lin switches to “learns the unlearned” (Waley keeps “teaches things untaught”).

constructs; the sage returns here to undo that metamorphosis. In the received version, the sage merely returns to where the people have passed over, or returns the people from their excesses or mistakes, depending on the style of translation.

The last major difference is where the Guodian “spreads” the true nature of ten-thousand things, the received text “assists” or “aids” or “stabilizes”, yet both claim the sage dare not act, manipulate, or interfere. The Guodian’s sage only opens the gates and lets the ten-thousand things follow their nature as they may, but the received text’s sage, though still claiming not to act, puts guardrails on the ten-thousand things. I admit I am struggling to understand how this stabilizing and aiding is not interference.

Guodian (A:7)

(衍/道) (恒/互) 亡為也,

Way/Dao constantly/persistently without/not do/act/manipulate

The way is constantly without manipulative action.

(侯/侯)王能(𠂔/宥)¹³⁰之,

Marquis/mark/target/scope/title king able be-magnanimous-toward/forgive [‘s]/this

Marquis and kings are capable of forgiving this,

而萬(勿/物) (𠂔/將)自(𠂔/愚)¹³¹。

And/but/yet ten-thousand things bring themselves/naturally intentional-action

And ten thousand things bring themselves to intentional action.

愚¹³²而雒¹³³作¹³⁴,

Intentional-action and/but/yet transgressing arises

Intentional action, and yet transgression arises;

(𠂔/將) (𠂔/貞)之以亡(明/名)之僕¹³⁵。

Bring divination-result/steadfast/chaste by-means-of without/no name [‘s] manual-work

Bringing respectable firmness to them is the manual work of the nameless.

夫亦(𠂔/將) 智,

In-any-case/anyone in-this-case will/bring knowledge/wisdom

Anyone for their part can bring themselves wisdom,

智足¹³⁶以(束/刺),

Wisdom/knowledge foot/go/is-sufficient by-means-of spike/thorn//to-pierce

The wisdom is sufficient by piercing.

萬(勿/物) (𠂔/將)自定。

Ten-thousand things bring themselves/naturally settle-down/set-in-place/decide/secure/stabilize

The ten thousand things bring themselves to stability.

¹³⁰ Looks to me like 虫 over 又; but Cook merely calls this a variant of 守. It is listed in zi.tools under 守, with the up-arrow being 𠂔 rather than 虫. This is not how 守 is normally expressed in the Guodian: 獸 (hunt, beast).

Perhaps a synonym, but it is odd. If it is really 爻, then it may be a form of 宥 (generous, to pardon, magnanimous)

¹³¹ Originally 爲 over 心 → 愚 (which zi.tools agrees with), which may be a phonetic loan word for 化 (change) but I can't find a source for this. It could be 偽 (harmonious accord), or this for 偽 (artificiality, deception, departure from the uncarved wood). But see Cook's "Bamboo Texts of Guodian" page 226: I actually agree with him, that this is 爲 (to do, to act) with the heart radical giving a sense of emotional/mental aspect: intentional action.

¹³² On the actual strips, the character is not duplicated but there's a = mark below it, signifying duplication.

¹³³ Associated also with 鵲, a mynah bird, most likely the crested mynah. 鵲. This bird is recorded as not crossing the Ji river, and then doing so. It is associated with barbarians and powers shifting according to the Shuowen Jiezi. This bird was also a very capable vocal mimic (comparable to parrots), and were often caged for this reason. At least in later traditions, they are associated with independent thinking, honesty, and resistance to conformity. Keeping in the connotation of the mynah as expressed in the Shuowen Jiezi on Zi.tools and the Zuozhuan, of this bird crossing a boundary, I translate this as "transgression"

¹³⁴ 𠂔 → 𠂔. Original was 𠂔 with a 又 under it, unlike Chapter 2 (Guodian A:9), more similar to the one in A:13.

¹³⁵ 𠂔 Originally 又 below 𠂔 over 臣, apparently, according to Cook and Henricks. Zi.tools has this listed under 僕, apparently not acknowledging the hand on the bottom. Could be to do servant work with the hands? Or to physical hold someone captive? Maybe 朴, but see Guodian A:1 and A:5 – if this were wood, I'd expect that radical.

¹³⁶ There's a repetition mark after 智, some think that 足 should have occurred after both.

A:7 Commentary:

The Dao does not manipulate anything; it is the source of the self-nature of everything else, and so there is no need for manipulation, as everything is naturally in accordance with the Dao. Kings and marquis are capable of pardoning this, or forgiving this, probably because they have no choice. (A translation note: Kings and marquis are capable of being magnanimous toward it relies on 宥 here rather than 守 (to guard/hold), since the graph departs from how the Guodian normally writes 守 elsewhere (compare 獸 in A:10, A:13, A:20). However, while it is specified these rulers are able to forgive or be magnanimous, the Guodian is not claiming that they actually do forgive it. So, by the Dao, all ten-thousand things have their own nature, their own will, their own intentional action. This intentional action is not equivalent to ambition or aspiration – it is merely the actions that reflect their nature. This is not the same 為 as in A:5, the manipulation of others or the corruption of one's own nature. This intentional action comes from true nature, from the self, not directed or imposed from anyone else.

Transgression is corrected by the manual work of the nameless. I read 僕 here as I did in A:1's

"ropes/protect the dependent," since both graphs share the same 辛 over 臣 structure. That the same component pairing points toward servant/dependent-labor imagery in two separate places in the manuscript is worth noting on its own: it's a small but real internal consistency check for a reading that, in A:1, rested mainly on a missing wood radical and a cognate dictionary. Here, correction is imagined not as a lofty act of a sage but as unglamorous, hands-on labor, the nameless doing the quiet work of putting things right. Deviations, disruption, is brought back to homeostasis by nature itself. Things that get off track can recalibrate and return to working order, and often this does not require interference to accomplish (although sometimes, on a small scale, it may). Transgressions, unnatural behavior or states, are against the forces of the Dao, and indeed left to its own devices, the Dao will return abnormal states back to their natural, original forms if the disruption ceases.

The Guodian goes on to claim that anyone can acquire real wisdom, through piercing the same way one pierces through artificiality and aspiration in A:5 (expressed by the same character). This wisdom and insight is not monopolized by mysterious sages or noble warriors and scholars. In fact, this piercing, through returning to one's true nature, may be the key to stabilizing everything.

Received 37 (A:7)

道常無為

Dao/way constantly/persistently lacks/without use/do/manipulate/act

The Dao is constantly without doing

而無不為¹³⁷

And/yet lacks/without not do/use/act/manipulate

Yet nothing is left undone.

侯王若能守之

Marquis kings like/as/similar-to/if able/capable guarding/maintaining/defending/abiding-by

The marquis and kings, if they were able to maintain it,

萬物將自化

Ten-thousand things bring themselves change/transform/convert

The ten-thousand things would bring themselves to transformation.

¹³⁷ This line only occurs in the Wang Bi.

化而欲作

Change/transform/convert and/yet want/desire rise/create/organize/start

Transforming, yet desire arises,

吾將鎮¹³⁸之

I/we bring/will weighed-down/quell/suppress/restrain/defend [‘s]/this/it

I will bring it to be quelled

以無名之樸

By-means-of without/no name [‘s]/this unworked-wood/simple/sincere

Through the simplicity (unworked wood) of the nameless

無名之樸¹³⁹

No/without name [‘s]/this/it unworked-wood/simple/sincere

The nameless one’s simplicity (unworked wood)

夫亦將無欲

Anyone too/as-well/in-this-case bring/will no/without desire/want

Anyone, too, will be brought into lacking desires

不欲以靜

Not/no desire/want by-means-of stillness/motionless

Not desiring by means of stillness.

天下將自定

Under-heaven bring self stability

The world will bring itself to stability.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Instead of simply describing the nature of the Dao, the received version, in Chapter 37, again tries to use the Dao as a template for ruling over people. The Dao does nothing, yet leaves nothing undone –on that point the Guodian and the received text would agree, but the received goes further, saying that if kings and marquis were able to do the same, the ten-thousand things would transform by themselves. By the Guodian this is wholly unnecessary: the ten-thousand things already bring themselves to intentional action, presumably by their self-nature, their inherent way, their will.

Because the ten-thousand things are acting intentionally, there will be transgressions. The system will not always be perfect, fluctuations occur around a mean that can get knocked off by disturbance. The Dao is the one that corrects these transgressions, manually correcting, silently bringing systems back into balance naturally. According to the received text, though, desire is the most offensive transgression, and the narrator, presumably a sage or noble, actively quells it, stomping it out like a rebellion, using “the unworked wood”, as though it is the name of a sword or secret technique. The very concept of using something unmanipulated to, quite frankly, manipulate the other ten-thousand things, feels like a contradiction. Again, the received mentions that this using of the “unworked wood” works because it brings the world to stillness, and this stillness brings stability. It is also interesting that desire in particular is singled out as needing such complete shutting down; perhaps this fixation on desire is a result of other influences (perhaps “Huang-Lao” Xinshu or Buddhist ones, see A:3) on Daoist traditions. The Guodian, however, maintains that stability comes from the ten-thousand things themselves, without needing to be arrested, or quelled, or made motionless.

¹³⁸ Originally 鎮 in Wang Bi and Mawangdui B, though A has 闡

¹³⁹ Mawangdui A has 樸 here and in the line above

Guodian (A:8)

為亡為，事亡事，

Do/use/manipulate lack/not do/use, business/serve/matters lack/not business/serve/matters

Do without doing, have business without business,

未¹⁴⁰亡未。

Still-not/not/haven't lack/not still-not/not/haven't

Not yet there without being not yet there.

大，少之；

Great, reduce/few [this/its]

The Great, reduce it.¹⁴¹

多¹⁴²愆必多(𠄎/難)¹⁴³。

Much/many/excess guardedness/anxiety/alertness certainly much/many/excess difficult-terrain(?)

Exceeding guardedness is certainly exceedingly difficult to navigate.

是以聖人(𠄎/猷/猶)(𠄎/難)之，

This by-means-of, sage plan/design/method/like/similar-to difficult-terrain(?) its/it

By means of this, the sage plans for difficulty navigating,

(古/故)(𠄎/終)亡(𠄎/難)。

Therefore/as-a-result, end-finish-finally lack/gone difficult-terrain(?)

As a result, in the end there is no difficulty navigating.

A:8 Commentary:

Doing without doing, business without business: these phrases are familiar. Productivity and doing what needs to be done does not need to be a highly involved, manipulative process. Business does not need to be formalized or performative – it just needs to be functional. As for what is not yet without being not yet – if one can detect, through careful attention, hints of what's to come, it is not so “not yet” as it may initially seem, and thus, can be planned around.

¹⁴⁰ 未 This is the normal form of 未, as it occurs throughout the Guodian as meaning not yet, still not, haven't. Here, the grammar suffers for it. I just don't think it's 味 (elsewhere in the Guodian). According to Cook, the *Wenzi* cites this line with this character as “知”, so Gao Heng and Zhu Qianzhi at some point thought this was 知 (according to Cook). Being as faithful to the text as I can be, I'll put “not yet there without being not yet there”.

¹⁴¹ This could also be translated as “The Great reduces it”, but what “it” is, is not clear.

¹⁴² 𠄎: Unusual compared to its comrades (𠄎), but under 愆 in zi.tools, and with Henricks and Cook. I don't know if I trust this, and encourage more educated and skilled eyes than mine to reconsider. I default to 愆, maybe idiosyncratically. Cook and Henricks, and most people assume this means 易, and the heart radical added to suggest the sense of mental/emotional states for difficult and easy. That feels like back-reading to me, and the scribe had other characters they could use to convey hard and easy. Much of the Guodian has concerned minding one's body, one's nature, internal and in the world. Describing the psychological and physical manifestations of the protective response does not come out of nowhere in the Guodian. While this doesn't appear to fit the whole “opposites” pattern, that logic is not convincing enough for me to dismiss the character choice here.

¹⁴³ Original had 土 under it, for whole chapter. Zi.tools has this under 𠄎莫 𠄎佳土. Difficult over ground, “difficult terrain?” Tricky to navigate or get through? The scribe, however, may just like to put 土 under the rest of this character for some reason: see A:9's 𠄎, where you can kind of make it out over the heart component.

As a translation note, 未 is often not translated as this for reasons of awkward grammar. Other characters have been suggested, such as Wenzi's 知 and 味 from the received, but in trying to stay with the literal graph, I have tweaked the grammar to preserve the meaning.

Again, the sage is portrayed here as a careful planner and methodical thinker. What great, intimidating things there are, they are reduced by taking paths of least resistance and intentional action. Difficult terrain, or difficulty in general, can be worked with so long as one plans accordingly, anticipates the potential problems and solutions. A:14 describes similar preparatory thinking and foresight. If what is great, one reduces, the need for high anxiety and excessive defensiveness is also reduced.

If one steels themselves for complication and is ready to face them, rather than being consumed by excessive alertness and anxiety that consumes more than protects, the difficult becomes not that bad. This is obviously not telling us the sage is not cautious or circumspect at all, but that they are these things in moderation, rather than launching headlong into panic and obsession, but certainly not carefree and oblivious. The sage remains aware, and that is sufficient.

Received 63 (A:8)

為無為, 事無事, 味無味

Do/act/use without/not do, matters/serve without matters/serve, taste/significance without taste

Do without doing, have business without business, taste what is without flavor

大小多少

Big/great small/little many/exceed few/reduce

The great is small, the many are reduced.¹⁴⁴

報怨以德

Repay/reward/retribution/vengeance/judge/reply complaint/grudge/resent/hate by innate-power/virtue

Respond to complaint and resentment with virtue

圖難於其易

Design/illustrate/devise/plot/draw-up/evaluate difficulty in/at/from it/its easy/change

Draw up plans for difficulty at its easiest.

為大於其細

Do/act/use big/great in/at/from its minimal/miniscule/slight/thin/fine/delicate/precise

Act on the great at its tiniest.

天下難事必作於易

Under-heaven difficulty matters/business/serve certainly arise/create/organize/start from easy/change

In the world, difficult matters certainly arise from easiness.

天下大事必作於細

Under-heaven great/big matters/business/serve certainly arise/create/organize/start from miniscule

In the world, great matters certainly arise from miniscule ones.

是以聖人終不為大

This by-means-of sage finish/end/finally not/no do/act/use great

By means of this, the sage in the end does not act on the great,

¹⁴⁴ The variation in how this line is translated is considerable. Linnell: "Greatness is insignificant, too much is less." Henricks: "Regard the small as large and the few as many." Lau, and also Waley: "Make the small big and the few many." Chan and also Lin: "whether it is big or small, many or few, ..." Feng & English: "Magnify the small, increase the few." Following the grammar in A:8 of the Guodian, I treat 少 as "reduce", and match the logic from there.

故能成其大

Thus/therefore/as-a-result able/capable achievement/accomplishment/complete its/it great
And as a result, is able to achieve its greatness.

夫輕諾必寡信

Anyone light/frivolous/superficial/shallow assent/agree certainly few/scanty/lessen trustworthy/trust
Anyone who agrees superficially certainly is scarcely trustworthy.

多易必多難

Many/exceed easy/change certainly many/excess difficult
And anyone who considers many things easy certainly will find many things to be difficult.

是以聖人猶難之

This by-means-of sage plans/schemes/hesitant difficulties this/it/['s]
By means of this, the sage plans for it to be difficult,

故終無難矣

As-a-result/thus end-finish-finally no/lack/without difficult [!]
And so, in the end, has no difficulty!

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: In Chapter 63 of the received text, the theme of being prepared and forward-looking is retained. In both, the sage plans for things to be difficult and adjusts accordingly. Both sages are doing without doing, having business without business, and, depending on how you translate “大小多少”, reducing more complex things into simpler, easier to manage forms. From there, the Guodian and the received text may diverge.

The received Dao De Jing identifies “much easiness” to be the culprit of making things “much difficult”, not “much guardedness.” To be fair, my translation to “excessive guardedness” relies on an added component, and indeed the meaning could be “excessive easiness” in the Guodian as well, though in this context, the added heart radical does not match the added earth radical to difficult that nudged me to translate it as “difficult terrain”. Cook, Henricks, and zi.tools all read 易 as a variant of 易 (easy), with the added heart radical taken as emphasis. I'm not fully convinced by that consensus, as nothing else in the text suggests this scribe needed to mark “easy” as an emotional or psychological state, and adding a heart radical just for emphasis feels like it may be reading later assumptions about the passage's “opposites” structure (great/small, much/little, easy/difficult) back onto the graph. (The consensus reading has real institutional weight behind it and mine does not, but the thematic fit with the rest of the Guodian is, to me, worth the risk of departing from it.) If my translation does indeed have legs despite its speculative nature, it fits the Guodian's existing criticism of the paranoid and stressful life of the prestige-chaser. In contrast, the received points toward complacency rather than paranoia as the problem. In truth, careful but balanced planning addresses both issues in most cases. The received adds that anyone who agrees lightly to things cannot be trustworthy, and echoes the logic in A:14/Chapter 64 about how the large comes from the small. However, the advice to attack problems before they become big and difficult, is not inconsistent with the advice of the Guodian, though the words are not in this chapter specifically. If anything, the received adds phrases that simply further hammer the point home.

Guodian (A:9)

天下皆智 (𠂔¹⁴⁵/美)之為¹⁴⁶美也, (亞¹⁴⁷) (已/已)

Below heaven all know finest this[‘s] do/use finest, inferior/second-rate already/finish/complete

Under heaven when all consider the finest as the finest, there is already inferior.

皆智善¹⁴⁸此,其¹⁴⁹不善已.

All know excellent/good/favorable this/here its/likely not favorable/skilled already/complete/finish.

(When) all know excellence here, its non-excellence is complete.¹⁵⁰

(又/有) 亡之相 (𠂔¹⁵¹/生)也

Having/existence loss/disappearance/lack [‘s]/this each-other produce/birth

Presence and absence create each other,

(𠂔¹⁵²/難) (𠂔¹⁵²/懸)¹⁵² 之相 (埜¹⁵³/成)¹⁵³也

Fear/dread//difficulty/badness guardedness/anxiety/alertness [‘s]/this each-other complete.

Fear and guardedness complete each other,¹⁵⁴

(𠂔¹⁵⁵/長) (𠂔¹⁵⁵/耑)¹⁵⁵ 之相 (型¹⁵⁶/形)也

Long/old/mature/developing and sprouting/starting [‘s] each-other mold/shape/outline/contrast/form

Maturing and sprouting shape each other,

¹⁴⁵ In zi.tools 𠂔 as 𠂔 to the left of 𠂔 (or 𠂔 to the left of 𠂔), though Cook and Henricks put 𠂔. This character is often just treated as 美 (beauty, lovely, fine(st) of the best quality, excellent, so everywhere in this chapter there is 美, it is 𠂔. However, the Shuowen Jiezi (according to zi.tools), though 𠂔 alone is related to 美, the complete 𠂔 → 𠂔 + 𠂔 → 𠂔 (subtle, tiny, between being and non-being, secret). However, zi.tools does claim that 𠂔 → 𠂔 + 𠂔 → 𠂔 → 美, and “beautiful” makes more sense in context here. Compare with 𠂔 → 𠂔 found in B:3, and see C:3.

¹⁴⁶ 之為, taken together, is a compound in Classical Chinese, so X 之為 Y can be translated as “X’s being Y”, so in this case it would be “beauty being beauty”. Another translation of 之為 is “considered as/to be”.

¹⁴⁷ Here, technically 亞 around 十 according to zi.tools. This character 亞 was likely originally the overhead view of construction, likely a 亞 shaped tomb. Kroll’s dictionary defines it as “next in order, secondary, junior; inferior”.

¹⁴⁸ In Warring States, 善 means “good at doing”, “excelling at”, “advantageous”. The moral benevolence reading came later, with Confucius, Mencius. So think of this as “skilled” or “talented”.

¹⁴⁹ Equivalent of 其 is 𠂔, how it always appears in the Guodian. Here for 此其: all other versions simply read 斯 (this), 此 may be grammatical, or it’s just “this-this” or “this itself”. This likely doesn’t change the meaning.

¹⁵⁰ Alternatively “When all know (it/ something) as good, (its) not-good (aspect) already (exists).”

¹⁵¹ Missing middle stroke.

¹⁵² Cook and Henricks, and most people assume this means 易, and the heart radical added to suggest the sense of mental/emotional states for difficult and easy. That feels like back-reading to me. The heart radical in the first character makes it “fear”. Much of the Guodian has concerned minding one’s body, one’s nature, internal and in the world. Describing the psychological and physical manifestations of the protective response does not come out of nowhere in the Guodian. While this doesn’t appear to fit the whole “opposites” pattern, that logic is not convincing enough for me to dismiss the character choice here. See A:8 as well.

¹⁵³ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 埜. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Probably phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and 漢語同源詞大典.

¹⁵⁴ More specifically, psychological fear/dread and physical arousal/alertness/guard complete each other.

¹⁵⁵ Meanings include: point of true beginning, end point, aspect, contingency, straight, and careful. Shuowen Jiezi says this is the “initial growth of things”, with the bottom part being roots and the top being shoots. Most translations have 短 (short, to 長 long). I’m not finding an etymology that links the two 𠂔 together—it may be phonetic.

¹⁵⁶ Technically 𠂔 over 土 as listed in zi.tools, 𠂔, contrast with B:5’s 埜

(商/高)下之相(𣶒/涅/盈)¹⁵⁷也,

High low [‘s]/this each-other fill-out/overflow/expand

High and low fill each other up,

(音/音)¹⁵⁸ 聖¹⁵⁹ 之相(和/和)也,

Tone/music sound/messages/noise/speech//paragon/sage [‘s]/this each-other harmonize

Tones of music and clear hearing¹⁶⁰ can harmonize with each other,

(先/先)(後/後)之相(墮/墮)¹⁶¹也。

First/front/prior/before and rear/late/after [‘s] each-other collapse/drop/fall-into

Before and after collapse into each other.

是以聖人(居/居)亡為之事,

This by-means-of sage resides/stays/rests without use/do/manipulate [‘s]/this business/serve

By means of this the sage dwells in the business they do not do,

行不言之(教/教)¹⁶²。

Transmit/walks/move/engage without words [‘s]/this teachings

Transmits teachings they do not speak,

萬(勿/物)作¹⁶³而弗¹⁶⁴(殆/殆)¹⁶⁵也,

Ten- thousand things create/organize/start/arise, but not danger/peril

Lets arise the ten thousand things without danger,¹⁶⁶

¹⁵⁷ 涅 Literally means mud under water. In other Chu writings, 涅 has meant “expanding, filling, fill-out a space (Elsewhere in Laozi A, Hengxian, Guanzi in Zhouhe), as a stand-in for 盈.

¹⁵⁸ Actually written as 立 over 田, which would mean livestock. Zi.tools has this as 音, as does everyone else.

¹⁵⁹ 聖 = 聖 This character, later “noise”, means peerless, paragon, possessing wisdom/judgment/moral excellence, profoundly wise and virtuous, master. It is meant as sage, the same character, later in this very chapter. I read it as “Hear correctly” or “hearing clarity”; and so the sage (聖人) is “person who hears clearly.”

¹⁶⁰ Because 聖 also means “master practitioner of an art” (Kroll), you could read this as “music and the musician”.

¹⁶¹ Very technically, [𣶒 to the left of (土 over 田)] all over 土, reflected by zi.tools (listed under 墮). This probably means “to destroy”, “to fall”, or “to press into the earth”, especially of a city wall or sacrifice.

¹⁶² See A:6 Could also be 學 (mimic, imitate, emulate, learn), but this doesn’t change the connotation of studies/teachings. Zi.tools also has 孝. Wiktionary lists 孝 and 孝 as a variant of 教, but Shuowen Jiezi equates 孝 with 放 (release, abandon, expel, exile, cast aside, put down, fully revealed (open and expressed fully), set-free, act with no constraints), but also follow and adhere to according to 說文解字注.

¹⁶³ 𣶒 Original has 又 under right part, expressed in zi.tools as 𣶒 to the left of 𣶒. Different from A:7 and A:13, this extra 𣶒 is unique. I’m not clear on why the scribe would add it, but it may contribute to the meaning.

¹⁶⁴ In this chapter, in the form of 𣶒.

¹⁶⁵ 𣶒/ 𣶒? Both Henricks and Cook have this as 𣶒. Zi.tools has this as 𣶒 to the left of 𣶒 around 一 = 𣶒 (which is the most accurate in my opinion). Meanings range from 殆 (danger (危, from Shuowen Jiezi); 漢語同源詞大典: broken-down/deteriorated/decayed (Analects: doubtful), 治 (to control, to harness, to manage, to govern, to channel like water), 怠 (slow, leisurely, sluggish; 漢語同源詞大典: exhausted, fatigue; I find this one unlikely as there were already 怠 used in the Guodian and they do not look that similar: 𣶒 vs 𣶒 from here), 怡 (joyous, harmonious), 辭 (governance, to govern through law/litigation), and 貽 (to give as a gift), at least by zi.tools under 𣶒. I find 殆 or 治 most likely, and even these raise multiple possibilities. See also A:6 (𣶒)

¹⁶⁶ Or, if 治. “The ten thousand things arise, but [the sage does] not govern/harness them” or “The ten thousand things arise, but are not controlled.” If 殆: “The ten thousand things arise, but are not endangered/deteriorated (by the process),” or “The ten thousand things arise, but [the sage does] not endanger them,” or “Creates the ten thousand things without breaking down (himself) / endangering them.”

為而弗志也，

Doing/using and/yet not intend/remember/record/command/expect/aspire

Doing, and yet not aspiring. ¹⁶⁷

(成/成)而弗居

Accomplishing/completing/becoming/developing but not resting/dwelling/inhabiting

Completing but not settling in the finished work¹⁶⁸.

天(佳/雖¹⁶⁹)弗居也，

Heaven/sky although not rest/dwell,

Although Heaven does not settle in its actions,

是以弗(去/去)也。

This by-means-of not depart/leave/go away

By means of this, the actions do not leave.

A:9 Commentary:

The distinguishment of one thing to be favorable than others leads to the finding that the other things are less favorable than others. This favorableness can be value, desirability, or even perceived auspiciousness. Without such a distinction, there is no beautiful or not-as-pretty, there's no excellent and not-as-excellent. When there is no distinction, one is just as content with a form of something as any other, so long as it functions. The existence of something as the finest thing means that inferior things must exist. Additionally, this may also be discussing a frequency-based selection effect, in which whatever everyone considers to be the best suffers a disadvantage as a result, and a more uncommon or alternative thing or way offers more success or value. It may be a combination of the two things: distinguishment creates a scenario where there is finest and inferior, and the consensus around what is finest in and of itself gives what is inferior an advantage in some way.

In this similar vein, existence cannot exist without absence, and vice-versa, high and low fill each other, and before and after press on each other. However, the Guodian does not limit itself to discussing strict opposites. Fear or dread, the internal state, completes the external state of alertness and being on guard. The inside (thoughts and feelings) and the outside (physiological state, physical arousal, and defensive, guarding behaviors) reflect each other. Although these are internal and external states and opposites that way, they are not pure opposites, and yet they complement each other. Maturing and sprouting shaping each other is another example of this semi-opposite pairing. To start and to continue are different points in development. The old instruct and protect the young, the young delight and motivate the old; the young will become older, influenced by the older, and the older will shape their whole lives protecting the young they planted to “sprout”. There is no maturing without sprouting, there is no sprouting without maturing (barring early death). Another such not-really-opposite is the sounds and the careful hearing harmonizing with each other, or, depending on how you translate, the

¹⁶⁷ Could alternatively be “Acting, but not expecting/intending [the results or any particular thing]. This could also be read as “Acts without intending”; this comes off as “acts carelessly” in English. The Shuowen Jiezi this “direction of the heart” is described as aspirations or ambitions rather than intentions writ large. So, “Acts without the heart pointed in any direction/ set on anything” may be more precise. “Acts but does not record” is also a reading that could stand—doing but without feeling the need to have any of it go down in history.

¹⁶⁸ There's a dwelling/city theme here. “The sage builds the city walls, but does not dwell within the city” is a more imaginative way of trying to encapsulate this, but it is stretchy with the original wording.

¹⁶⁹ 佳 literally means short-tailed bird. This instance is faded or cut off at the bottom. Likely a phonetic loan for 唯/惟, both of which have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though, even if). 惟 also means “to consider, to contemplate, think of”.

music and the musician harmonizing with each other. I tend toward viewing 聖 as “listens clearly” or “listens with skill”, and so technically everywhere I put sage, I am putting “person who listens/hears clearly”. Especially of music, music is nothing if it does not resonate with the listener, and the listener needs sound to resonate with. In this way, the two complete each other, and give each other meaning. Even the clean opposites of high and below, and presence and absence, create the conditions to allow the other to be what they are. That is the point the Guodian is making – that what appear to be in opposition cannot exist without each other, are shaped by each other, are balanced by each other, and complete each other.

The Guodian sage uses these processes to accomplish what they need to. A quick note about what the sage is: the Guodian expresses them as 聖人. This first character has a massive ear component and a small mouth component, and has shared etymological roots with 聽 (to hear, listen), and 聲 (sound). While 聖人 could be “someone who there is sound regarding”, I think it is more likely to be along the lines of “listening person”. So, I translate 聖 as “hear clearly” or “listens correctly/with skill” and so the sage is “one who hears clearly.” The sages have affairs and business, but it is accomplished by not being actively done or carried out directly. What the sage does do, they do not dwell in it or on it, and with their way of doing things, it may not even be obvious that their accomplishments are their own. Depending on how you translate the passage, the accomplishments, the completions, may go unrecorded, unremembered.

The sage lets the ten-thousand things arise, but does not imperil them or put them in danger (聖=殆) or govern or control them (聖=治 or 辭)¹⁷⁰. The sage does not exploit or force them to do what the sage prefers they would do, and does not create that situation. To give an example, one I used in A:6, when someone locks a door, those inside without the key become anxious about leaving, but if the door is left wide open, the will of those inside tends to favor remaining within. Even simpler, anyone can tell you that when something becomes compulsory or mandatory, or forced upon them, even just that difference makes them much less inclined to accept it and cooperate, even if otherwise they may have naturally done what was ordered. To endanger or use violence on the ten-thousand things, to gain compliance or assert dominance, is also likely to breed resentment, defensive and counter-attacking behaviors, or the deterioration of that which you are trying to use; certainly not the most efficient or helpful choice, to say nothing of compassion. The sage is the master of consent: in all that they do, it is successful because every entity involved has chosen themselves to follow the will of the sage, as it matches their own. The sage brings about the conditions to bring their wills, their natures, into alignment, so that all that is left to do is let the business do itself.

In everything the sage does, there is no aspiration to be anything more or greater; their will and their intentions will in no case override the will of any other being. Through this non-action, this allowing for freedom and natural behavior and natural processes, without forcing or fixing it into what anything “should” be or what they want it to be, the world becomes more favorable. The artificial constructions and expectations do not enhance the process, and so are left out. The sage does not need to manipulate

¹⁷⁰ If 聖 = 怠, and the ten thousand things rise without delay, this would then suggest more of the effortless nature of WuWei. If 聖 = 怡 as harmony or happiness, this makes less sense in context, though I guess one could spin it to be “without celebration” or “without actively trying to balance/harmonize them.” If 聖 = 貽, and the ten thousand things are not given as gifts, this is less easy to make sense of, though perhaps if one does not own or control the ten thousand things, certainly they cannot be given away like property. I find all these readings less convincing than those discussed in the body text, but I do consider them.

anything to get ahead, because the sage is not really trying to get ahead, not further than preparing for possible difficulty on the horizon.

Not dwelling in finished work, the sage moves on to the other matters that need attention rather than congratulating, celebrating, announcing, or otherwise lingering on the task. Life is full of tasks and work, even if some of those matters are resting, checking on things, observing ones environment, or taking care of oneself. Heaven, similarly, does not need to write records of the rain or praise itself for producing a clear, pleasant day; its work will do that itself to the extent that is natural. So, the weather changes, days and nights and months and years continue, ever moving, never stagnant.

Received 2 (A:9)

天下皆知美之為美斯惡¹⁷¹已。

Below Heaven all know beauty [‘s] use/do beauty, then ugly/hateful already/finish/is-apparent¹⁷².

Below Heaven, if all can recognize beauty, then ugliness is known.

皆知善之為善¹⁷³斯不善已

All know good/favorable/advantageous [‘s] use/do good/favorable, then not good already/finish

If all know the favorable as good, then what is not favorable is known.

故有無{之}相生{也},

Therefore/as-a-result, non-being being each-other produce/birth/create,

Thus, non-being and being are born from each other,

難易{之}相成{也}

Difficult easy each-other complete.

The difficult and easy complete each other,

長短{之}相較¹⁷⁴{也},

Long short each-other juxtapose,

Long and short contrast each other

高下{之}相傾¹⁷⁵{也},

High/tall low/below each-other overturn/slant toward/incline/lean-upon.,

High and low rely upon each other.

音聲¹⁷⁶{之}相和{也},

Sounds voices-and-tones/music each-other harmonize,

Musical tones and sounds can harmonize with each other,

¹⁷¹ In Mawangdui this 惡 is 亞 (secondary, junior, inferior, also possibly derived from pictogram of construction). 之 (in A) and 斯 (in A and B) is also absent in the Mawangdui versions. 斯 is also missing in the first line and replaced with 訾 in line two in Mawangdui B (meaning vilify, bad-mouth, detest, reproach), but this is most likely a mistake for 此, present in Guodian, meaning “this/here”, similar to 斯 (this/then) in Wang-Bi and Mawangdui A.

¹⁷² This translation of 已 is from Edwin G. Pulleyblank’s “Outline of Classical Chinese”, on pages 19 and 116, where 已 is discussed as an aspect particle after a verbless noun predicate, contrasting when 已 is used before a verb as in 已经, or in expressing “very/excessive/too” of something. It also means to stop/to finish as a verb. In this ending position, Pulleyblank maintains it has a function similar to 了 in modern Chinese, giving a sense of realization. So I translate this to “apparent”, though “observable”, “known/knowable” could also work, “obvious” may be too strong a word.

¹⁷³ “之為善” is absent in Mawangdui A and B as well as Guodian, but the impact in meaning seems to be minimal

¹⁷⁴ 刑 in Mawangdui texts – model, form, correct, torture or disfigure, change to the right shape, mold.

¹⁷⁵ 盈 in Mawangdui – plentiful, abundant, overfilled, sufficient, enlarged. 傾 and this share the meaning “overflow

¹⁷⁶ Also has a connotation of noise, or anything that can be heard, music and not.

前後{之}相隨¹⁷⁷{也}

Front/before behind/after each-other pursue/follow-after.

And before and after follow each other.

是以聖人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage

處無為之事，行不言之教

Stays/secluded¹⁷⁸ non-action [‘s] affairs, transmit/walks/move/engage no words/speak [‘s] teaching(s).

Stays alone with business of non-action, transmits the teachings unspoken.

萬物作¹⁷⁹焉而不(始¹⁸⁰/辭)

Ten-thousand things devise/create/start/rise from-this, and/yet not (start//explain/express/refuse)

Ten-thousand things arise from this, and yet it is unexplained.¹⁸¹

生而不有¹⁸²，為而不恃

Born and/yet not have/possessed/existing¹⁸³, being/acting and/yet not confident/depending/relying,

Born but without ownership, doing but without being depended on,

功成而弗居

Work/accomplishment/excellence complete/achieve/accomplishments, and/yet not settled/dwelling.

Completing accomplishments, yet not dwelling in them.

夫唯弗居

In-any-case who/which, only not settling/dwelling,

For anyone, only those not settling in the results

是以不去

This by-means-of not leave.

By means of this have results that do not leave.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: There are subtle but important differences between Guodian’s A:9 and the received Chapter 2. In the received text, the pairs are strict opposites with the exception of the music and tones harmonizing. The Guodian has a slightly different tone, though not drastically so. Instead of “easy” and “hard”, I’ve translated fear/dread (internal thoughts and feelings) and alertness (physical arousal and guard) complete each other. I interpret this further as a statement of the internal and the external reflecting each other. Sprouting and maturing shape each other, another departure my

¹⁷⁷ 隋 in Mawangdui—a surname, but could be 墮- to fall from, falter, or 惰-careless, indolent, dissipated, lazy

¹⁷⁸ This 處 character is often translated as “manages”, or “lives by”, but I have seen no evidence in dictionaries or grammar books so far to suggest this character has this meaning at this time period (Warring States), though there is evidence for this meaning later. I have seen the meanings of “pause, stop, cease (from)”, and alternatively this line could be translated as “Stops without ado his affairs, implements without words their teaching(s).” The most recent form is 处 (place, to be situated at, to stay). Both the Mawangdui and Guodian instead have 居

¹⁷⁹ 昔 in Mawangdui B, formerly, long ago, yesteryear (can also be 夕). Can also mean rise, stand up, raise up, organize, begin, compose.

¹⁸⁰ From Mawangdui B

¹⁸¹ Alternatively “The sage arises ten-thousand things, and refuses them nothing.” (similar to Chan, Wu, Waley, Lin)

¹⁸² 生而不有 only occurs in the Wang Bi.

¹⁸³ Also translated as “creating but not possessing”. 生 means both “alive, to live, to exist” and “cause to live, bring into existence, give birth to.” Weirdly enough, this could kind of be translated as “born but not existing”.

translation takes from the conventional Wang Bi version, also brings these comparisons from abstract concepts into visceral processes. I outline this subtle difference above.

The ten-thousand things, in the Guodian, arise but are not endangered, but in the received, they arise and either do not start (Mawangdui B) or express. The received then elaborates that they are “born without being owned and acting without being relied on” (my translation) or, “rears them, but lays no claim to them” (Wu), “Gives them life yet claims no possession” (Lau, with Chan similar), or “Acts on their behalf but doesn’t make them dependent” (Henricks). The Guodian does not have a corresponding line for this. The received also places 恃 in place of 志, relying on, depending on, or trusting in, in place of aspiring, recording, or striving toward. This reflects the possibly softer view toward ambition and status of the received version as compared to the Guodian (see also the commentary of A:2.)

The last significant difference between the Guodian and the received is that the Guodian uses Heaven as an example of the success of not dwelling in one’s accomplishments, and the received more explicitly says that this is the result for anyone. I don’t think that the Guodian is reserving this quality for heaven, so the two are essentially saying the same thing.

Guodian (A:10)

道(𣎵/互)¹⁸⁴亡名,

Dao/path constantly/persistently lacks name,

The Dao constantly lacks a name.

僕¹⁸⁵(唯¹⁸⁶)妻¹⁸⁷,

Servant only/concur/assent/approve wife/get-wife

As a servant agrees with his wife,¹⁸⁸

天(𡗗/地)(𡗗/弗)敢¹⁸⁹臣.

Heaven Earth not dare minister/treat-as-inferior/subject/slave

Heaven and Earth do not dare treat it as their ruled-over subject.

(侯/侯)王(女/如)能(戰¹⁹⁰/守)之,

Marquis/Mark/scope/title king woman/maiden//like/if can/able/ability hunt//defend it,

If marquis and kings were able defend it,¹⁹¹

萬(勿/物)(𡗗/廼/將)自(𡗗/置)¹⁹²。¹⁹³

Ten-thousand things bring themselves be-installed/be-established.

Ten thousand things would bring themselves to be installed.

天地相(𡗗/會/合¹⁹⁴)也,

Heaven Earth combine/fit/meet/close-with each-other

Heaven and Earth combine and fit with each other,

以逾¹⁹⁵甘¹⁹⁶(𡗗/零/露)。

By-means-of even-more/additionally sweet/pleasant/willingly drizzle///dew/reveal/moisten/nectar

By means of the exceedingly sweet falling dew.

¹⁸⁴ Technically 𣎵, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary). However, 𣎵 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆.

¹⁸⁵ 僕, so originally 亼 on the left of 𡗗 over 臣. May be 僕 where zi.tools lists it especially given the two radicals associated with people (亼 and 臣). see Guodian A:1: 𡗗 or A:5: 𡗗

¹⁸⁶ 唯; in zi.tools under 隹, literally means short-tailed bird. The mouth part on the bottom may support 唯. 唯/惟, both have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though/if). 售 means to sell. See B:1 and B:3. I usually translate this as only, but assent/approve/agree are the only alternative that makes sense in this context.

¹⁸⁷ 妻, listed in zi.tools as 妻 but looks to me more like the top part of 貴 on 女, but the fellow examples in zi.tools share strong resemblance, and the Shuowen entry on zi.tools explains that one form was 貴 (as 𡗗) over 女. The Shuowen Jiezi describes the early forms of this character as a hand holding a woman’s hair, signifying (potentially forced) marriage, meaning wife, though also mentions links to the word 貴. Maybe technically 娶?

¹⁸⁸ By Cook, LXF reads “(as) a servant agrees with his wife”, taking 唯 as “agree, concur, approve” rather than “only”; better than my initial tries “like a servant, or only a wife” and “A servant only then finds a wife.”

¹⁸⁹ 敢 Zi.tools has this under 敢, this is a variant of 敢. See also A:5

¹⁹⁰ 𡗗 → 𡗗 A bit blurry. Enough resemblance to 戰 → 獸 (𡗗) for me not to challenge it

¹⁹¹ Or if 女, “Marquis and kings femininely can preserve it”, “softly can preserve it”, or “vulnerably can preserve it.”

¹⁹² 𡗗 Originally 貝 under 宀 → 寘 in zi.tools, but it looks different from other Chu comrades under 寘. Could be 冥 (dark, gloomy, unseen, deep and dark, faint, far, undercover, mental dullness), as zi.tools also seems to suggest. Zi.tools also suggests 寘 → 置, meaning “to install, to establish,” and this makes more sense to me than either.

¹⁹³ Some start (A:11) here due to a passage marker between these lines. So my chapter count differs from Cook’s.

¹⁹⁴ Compare to A:17, A:14. Might be 會 (combine, gather, meet), or 答 (respond)

¹⁹⁵ 𡗗 zi.tools lists this as 俞 over 止, though technically the knife is on the wrong side (or it may be a person).

¹⁹⁶ 𡗗 looks like 回 to me (zi.tools for 回 = 𡗗; for 甘 nearly all look like 𡗗.) Also like what is listed under 昌 (𡗗).

民莫之命(夬/而)自(均/均)(夬/玄/焉)¹⁹⁷。

People in-no-case it/its command and/but itself equal/uniform/regulated [interrogative-pronoun]/by-it
The people (would be) under no one's mandate, yet balance themselves by it.¹⁹⁸

(夬/訇¹⁹⁹/辭)(夬/折)(又/有)名。

Explain break/twist/bend/analyze/determine/decide have/exist name.

Explain and determine something, and it will have a name;

名亦(夬/既²⁰⁰/既)(又/有),

Name in-this-case completely/just-now exist/have.

For its part, the name only just now came into existence.

夫亦(將/將)智(止²⁰¹/止),

In-any-case/anyone in-this-case bring knowledge/wisdom limit/end-of

And anyone for their part can bring themselves to knowing to stop,

智(止/止)²⁰²(夬²⁰³/所)以不(訇/辭)。

Wisdom limit/end-of mechanism-by-which not govern//start//danger/be-close//explain

Knowing to stop is the mechanism by which things are not explained.

(夬/卑)道之才天下也,

Low/vulgar/decline Dao/way ['s]/this talent/genius/ability/just-then under heaven

The lowly Dao's talents²⁰⁴ under heaven,

(夬/猷/猶)少(浴/浴)之(夬/昇/與)²⁰⁵(江/江)(海/海)。

Similar-to/design/plan few/slightly purify/wash/bathe/swoop/stream it['s] join/give/grant river sea.

Are like a few streams joining rivers and seas.

¹⁹⁷ Originally like 夬 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安 and 玄..

¹⁹⁸ Alternatively, like Harold Roth, "[Falling rain] is under no one's mandate, by itself it falls equally on the people." His version: "No one causes this to be so; of itself it falls equally on them."

¹⁹⁹ 夬 Listed under zi.tools as 言 to the left of 訇; on page 詞. See A:6 and A:9. Could be 訇, I suspect it may be 訇.

Zi.tools says this may be 訇, or 治 (govern), 始 (start, only now), 殆 (danger, be close to, had better), or 辭 (words, explain, decline). This goes for both instances in this chapter. Given the clear inclusion of 言, I opt for 辭.

See also C:4 (夬)

²⁰⁰ See C:1 and A:10. This instance, in zi.tools, is listed under 巳 to the left of 、 inside of 次, listed itself under 既. 既 can mean completely, wholly, but also "just after" or "upon completion" or "as soon as".

²⁰¹ 止 Unable to find on zi.tools. To my eye looks like 止 or 止, or 止. 止 is from Cook; Henricks has this as 止 (止 over 止). 止 can be run, or go, or limit (the end of, stop, halt). Conversely, 之 can mean "to go." To reach limit?

²⁰² This double-character repeat is indicated by = next to both characters on the slips. But while we're here, 智止 may be "the edge of knowledge", but also "knowing when to stop/halt."

²⁰³ Atypical form of 所, usually like 夬

²⁰⁴ Or, if equivalent to 在, "position", "placement". See A:2

²⁰⁵ 夬 Henricks has 与 over 夬, zi.tools has 昇 which is more accurate. The Shuowen, through zi.tools, insists this is an old form of 與, but then why use both? A:2 also has 夬 (join). 夬 (rhetorical) from A:12, and from B:3 夬 (communal giving); Also from B:3 夬/与 (bestow). See also A:18 (grant)

A:10 Commentary:

This chapter is admittedly a bit rambling in my perception. To ease discussion, I will break it into sections, the first being servant and wife, the second being Heaven Earth and Dao analogy, the third being the union of Heaven and Earth by rain and the people without mandate, the fourth being explaining and knowing when to stop, and the fifth revisiting the position of the Dao.

The Dao lacking a name reoccurs several times in the Guodian. In Warring States society, both wives and servants lacked independent identity in the eyes of the law and the record. Wives were always someone's wife, servants were someone's servant; they are referred to and defined by relation to someone with a "name" rather than having one themselves. Perhaps, if the servant mentioned in the Guodian is answering to not even the household authority, but to a wife of his, he is made doubly removed from "named" rank, subordinate to a subordinate. Yet, despite this extremely low position, despite the utter namelessness, this is where the Dao resides. However, despite not having a name, like a wife or a servant, the Dao is no one else's Dao. A name brings definition, artificial categorization, but also recognition, reputation. The Dao has neither of these, so is limited by neither of these.

Alternatively (though not mutually exclusively), the image of a servant agreeing with, or perhaps surrendering to, his (own) wife (who, as a servant's wife, is also very "nameless" and subordinate), may serve as a comparison point for Heaven and Earth, which similarly dare not lord over the Dao despite its namelessness. Despite the lower rank of women and wives in theory, the trope of the wife and mother having authority in the house is not a mere stereotype. This kind of hidden power is applied to describe the relationship between Heaven and Earth and the Dao. As a servant dare not lord over his wife, so Heaven and Earth assent to the Dao.

This, in combination with mentioning the Dao's talent/position as lowly, yet joining like streams to the rivers and seas, connects back with similar wording from A:2, where the low position of the rivers and seas made them king of the hundred streams. If the analogy carries, the Dao is the king of under heaven because of the same low position that empowers the rivers and seas.

If the marquis and kings could also be like the Dao, and the rivers and seas, then the ten-thousand things would establish themselves and nothing would need to be forced. The operative word here may be "if" (女→如), and "able", making it apparent that this does not seem to be the default state of things.

Let us consider for a moment that the character 女 may be doing two things at once, functioning both as a conditional marker ("if") and as representing the idea of "female, feminine." Whether the scribe intended the reader to notice this overlap is unclear, but it's hard to ignore given the servant-and-wife image that opens the chapter. If the resonance is intentional, the passage may be suggesting that rulers would need to adopt something read as a "feminine" register (yielding, indirect, gentle) to access this kind of effortless authority. While anyone who knows women can tell you they can be sharp-tongued, decisive, assertive, and have qualities associated with yang (and are certainly capable of violence and dominance), the usage of this word in Classical Chinese is associated with the softer yin traits of receptivity, vulnerability, and the like (see Kroll's definition for 女).

The mention of Heaven and Earth fitting together through dew (or scattered rain/drizzling) seems to be setting up an analogy describing how the people, without being harshly commanded or forced, find their own balance and stability. This could also illustrate the superior management power of the Dao if we adopt Harold Roth's interpretation of, in paraphrase: falling dew is under no one's mandate, by itself it falls equally on the people. The distribution of dew is even and stable, without the Dao exerting any manipulation to make it so. Commands and mandates cannot accomplish this perfect distribution.

Then the Guodian veers off for a bit to discuss more about names and the nature of knowledge. To be honest, this seems like a clean change of focus to me; it is not obvious to me what the connection is between these sections, though there very well may be one. Knowing to stop is how things are not explained: perhaps this is recognizing when naming and words drift too far from grounded reality that

accuracy, and all real knowing, is lost. Leaving things unexplained preserves the truth of the matter without muddying things up with concepts and theoretical assumptions. This does not necessarily represent the refusal to investigate further, but it may represent the acknowledgement of the limit of what can be observed, tested, known, and therefore explained. It may well be the difference between “I don’t know,” and speculation on speculation on speculation, or making up what they desire the reality to be. Explaining and making determinations are possible only through titling and naming, and while this is sufficient to communicate the outline, the subtleties are under no obligation to adhere to these arbitrary decisions and conclusions. The subtleties of the Dao, of nature, of life, cannot be rendered completely accurately through words and explanations. Experience, direct observation, keeping oneself unchained by theory of how things are supposed to be: these are how one pierces through to reality. In this case, perhaps in this instance of 智止, “knowing to stop” and “the limit/edge of knowledge” are roughly equivalent to each other.

Names are artificial tools, arbitrary symbols and sounds to convey information, from the very concrete to the very abstract. Names and labels only exist because humans create them. By the same process, humans should also recognize the limitations of these names, when to stop relying on them. When explanations become a house of cards of words representing abstract, hard-to-conceptualize things, it is more likely than not that the complex, raw, untamed reality is drifting farther and farther away.

Received 32 (A:10)

道常無名

Dao/way constantly/persistently without/lack/no name

The Dao constantly lacks a name.

樸²⁰⁶雖小

Unworked-wood/simplicity/plain/sincere despite/even-though/although small/little

Although the unworked wood is small,

天下莫能臣也

Under-heaven in-no-case can/able/capable minister/treat-as-inferior/subject/slave

Nothing under heaven can rule over it as a subject.

侯王若能守之

Marquis/mark/target king like/if can/able/capable defend/maintain/preserve it/this/[‘s]

If the marquis and kings preserve it,

萬物將自賓

Ten-thousand things bring/will self/naturally behave-as-guests/submit/guest

The ten-thousand things would bring themselves to behave as well-mannered guests.

天地相合

Heaven Earth each-other combine/fit/meet/close

Heaven and Earth combine with each other

以降²⁰⁷甘露²⁰⁸

By-means-of fall/descend/drop/bring-down/deign-to-give sweet dew

Through bringing down sweet dew²⁰⁹;

²⁰⁶ Mawangdui A has 樞 (house-tent, with wooden roof)

²⁰⁷ Mawangdui A and B have 俞 (respond, satisfied)

²⁰⁸ Mawangdui A and B have 洛 (tributary of the Yellow River)

²⁰⁹ I seem to be in the minority in how this is translated, Linnell has “Heaven and Earth would join each other, *thus* dropping sweet dew.” Henricks has “Heaven and Earth would unite to send forth sweet dew,” and Lau, Chan, Wu,

民莫之令

Common-people in-no-case [‘s]/this/it command/order/enable

The people (would be) under no one’s mandate²¹⁰

而自均

And/but/yet itself/naturally equal/uniform/regulated

And yet, by itself, things would be uniform.

{焉} 始制²¹¹ 有名

[So/therefore/how?/where?] start/begin/initiate cut/fabricate/arrange/craft/regulate has/exists name

So, start conforming things to a design, and names will exist;

名亦既有

Name in-this-case completely/just-now exist/have.

For its part, the name only just now came into existence,

夫亦將知止

In-any-case/anyone in-this-case-too bring/will know stop/cease/halt

And anyone, for their part, would know when to stop.²¹²

知止(所)以不殆

Know stop [place/that-which by-means-of]/mechanism-by-which no/not danger/peril

Knowing when to stop is the mechanism by which there will be no danger.

譬道之在天下{也}

Draw-a-parallel Dao/way [‘s]/it/this position/be-at under-heaven

As an analogy, the Dao’s position under heaven

猶川谷之(與)江海{也}.

Similar-to/hesitant/scheming stream/small-river valley/cave [‘s]/this/it (join/share) river sea

Is like that of valley rivers joining into rivers and seas.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: In Chapter 32 of the received,

The servant and his wife (or someone’s wife) of the Guodian is erased in favor of the unworked wood, or, “uncarved block” symbolizing the native, true nature, and it is this that Heaven and Earth cannot rule over. In the Guodian, Heaven and Earth would not dare to lord over the Dao (which is probably the same essence as what is meant by the “unworked wood”), but in the received, it is that Heaven and Earth simply lack the ability to do this in the first place.

In the received, I translate 制 as “to conforming things to a design”, a bit different than Guodian’s 折 (determine, decide, analyze, break, bend, twist), but I honestly think the received is a

Waley has very similar. Even Cook for the Guodian has “Heaven and Earth join together, so as to send down sweet dew.” The character 以 can be used as “by means of this”, and perhaps that is their reasoning, but the image of dew condensing from air (heaven) onto the earth makes it seem to me like this is the form of their union, not the result.

²¹⁰ This follows my, and Cook’s, translation of the Guodian; Feng & English, Waley has a translation that somewhat agrees, but Cleary, Lin, Henricks, Chan, Lau, and Linnell all translate to the effect of “no person commands [the dew to fall uniformly].

²¹¹ This 制 has interesting connotations. By Kroll, the definitions are: cut to measure (as in tailoring), work from plan or pattern to make fit, complete a design, fabricate, craft, compose (writing), arrange, control, regulate, make conform, restrain, prohibit, subdue.

²¹² Henricks, Chan, Lau, Wu (kind of), Waley, Cleary, Feng & English (kind of), and Linnell all have some form of “When names appear, know that it is time to stop.”

clarification of the Guodian, and not a departure. In both interpretations, something is rendered into something categorical, theoretical, rendered into words, names. In this rendering, information is lost. The Guodian and the received are describing the same problem here, and do not seem to disagree in any major aspect. The received says that knowing when to stop avoids danger, which is rather dramatic compared to the Guodian's "explanation". A false explanation, error and confusion, is perhaps its own kind of danger. In the Guodian, the same character is used for the start of the line regarding the birth of names and the result of knowing when to stop (止) whereas the received has two different characters substituted in for this one, (始 and 殆 respectively). I opted to translate 始 as "explain" given the speech component (言) and that this definition makes sense in both locations.

With respect to the section about Heaven, Earth, dew, and the self-arrangement of the people, there is considerable variation in how this could be translated in both the received and the Guodian, but from what I can see the variational range is the same. Despite some slight wording differences in the last two lines of both, I see the analogy of the streams to rivers and seas as essentially equivalent as well.

Guodian (A:11)

(又/有)(𠂔/狀)²¹³(𧈧/蟲²¹⁴/昆)(壁²¹⁵/成)(𠂔/先)天地²¹⁶生,

Have/exist form/shape/condition/describe insects//togetherness complete

Having a form, a swarm was whole before Heaven and Earth first came into being,

(𠂔/斂)(𧈧/穆)²¹⁷, (𧈧/蜀²¹⁸/獨)立, 不(𠂔/亥)²¹⁹,

Take-by-force/seize/lose generosity/harmony/tranquility stand-straight/confirm/install not boar

Abducting full harmony, solitarily standing, not hoarding itself away.²²⁰

(𠂔/𠂔²²¹)以為天下母。

Impossible/thereupon [by-means-of act-as]/make-into/use-as all under heaven mother/source

Impossible to be used as the mother of all under heaven²²².

²¹³ Originally 𠂔 + 首 according to Cook and Henricks, the reality looks like this: 𠂔, however I have not seen many other Chu characters with 𠂔 in this spot that look like this, even if this character is faded, and 首 has a

similar problem unless you rotate it but it doesn't open at the top. Specifically 𠂔 𠂔 首 in Zi.tools (𠂔) This character is one even the experts argue about. While I'm iffy on it, Cook's notes convinced me and I default to 狀.

²¹⁴ 蟲 Literally means insects, bugs, creepy-crawlies in general, and the graph is three (many) bugs together.

However, by the ShuowenJiezi listing in zi.tools (段玉裁 commentary), this may have connotations of multitude (眾) Mawangdui has 昆 (together, mass, last in a sequence, numerous, sameness, unified-as-one, posterity, but also worm). Capturing the bug and togetherness meanings, both having connotations of mass and multitude, I translate this as “swarming” or “swarm” – multiple small individuals in a mass, not necessarily coordinated in any way.

²¹⁵ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 壁. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it's a phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

²¹⁶ Originally 陀 with 土 under, but original fits perfect for the Chu silk script rendering of 地, derived from 墜

²¹⁷ 𧈧 Honestly I'm having a hard time parsing this personally, but apparently the original was 穆 over 糸 and reflected like this in zi.tools (a full ear of grain hanging downward in the sunlight → harmony, beauty, well-ordered, generous, tranquil, friendly ...then over silk? Cook has 𧈧 糸 穆). Looking at other samples in zi.tools, this could just be 穆 itself without silk. Maybe could be 𧈧- fly high (see Mawangdui) → empty/silent/profound (𧈧), though I still see the grain element in 𧈧. The oracle bone and bronze script versions of 穆 bear resemblance to this character.

²¹⁸ 𧈧 Original appears to lack 𠂔: Huge eye 目 over the up-arrow that is 虫, representing a large-eyed insect, a caterpillar (variant of 蠅, in zi.tools and Wiktionary) or a silkworm in a flower (Shuowen Jiezi). This came to have the meaning of solitary, maybe because caterpillars live alone, isolated, sometimes in cocoons. In zi.tools as 蜀.

²¹⁹ This literally means the 12th branch of the earthly branches, associated with boars (and pigs). Han texts also describe this as blocking or closing off (Han Shu, section on Astronomy and Calendars), and storing up all things (Shiming, Explaining names). This COULD be a phonetic loan for 改 (changing).

²²⁰ Or, “Forcibly taking full harmony, solitarily standing like a caterpillar, but not hoarding itself away in a cocoon.”

²²¹ This is not just backwards 可; this is listed as 𠂔 in zi.tools, the Shuowen Jiezi (and San Cang) defines this as 不可, “cannot do”. This means impossible. (Kroll also lists “thereupon,” but I cannot find this use before the Han.)

²²² The Guodian slip unmistakably has 𠂔 (cannot/impossible, inversion of 可). Crucially, this negation modifies the compound verb 以為 (used as, make into, take as, consider to be). In Warring States syntax, 以 functions as an instrumental verb (by means of, use X for) and 為 can occasionally be translated as “to act as”, in addition to “to manipulate, use, do.” On this reading the swarm cannot be used as (or taken as) “mother”. 以為 is critical in this sentence. I reckon (and this is speculative) the swarm probably IS the source of life (and in this sense a mother), but you cannot harness or utilize this to make a comforting power structure with a maternal flavor. Alternatively, 𠂔

未智其(明²²³/名),

Still not/not/haven't knowledge its/their name

Their name is still not known.

(𠄎/𦉳/茲)²²⁴之曰道,

This says/call Way/Dao/path

This here we call "the Dao".²²⁵

(𡗗/吾)(𠄎/𦉳)²²⁶為之名曰大。

I/we powerful/forced/vigorous use/do ['s]/it name say/call big/great

We forcefully use this name and call it "great."

大曰(𡗗/𡗗/𡗗)²²⁷, (𡗗/𡗗)曰(𡗗/連/轉), (連/轉)曰反。

Great/big calls overflow/surge, “” calls turn/roll/change/rotate, “” calls turn-back/reverse/invert/oppose

Great is called overflowing, overflowing is called rolling, rolling is called turning back.

天大, 地大, 道大, 王亦大。

Heaven great, Earth great, Dao great, king for-his-part/too great.

Heaven is great, Earth is great, the Dao is great, and the king too is great.

(國²²⁸/域)(𡗗/中)(又/有)四大(𡗗/焉)²²⁹王(𡗗/居²³⁰)一(𡗗/焉)。

Territory/capital-city core/middle has/exists four great/big there, King rests/lives/sits one from-them.

A territory's center has four greats there, the king dwells as one of them.

人灋²³¹地, 地灋天,

People model/ruled-by earth, earth model/ruled-by heaven

People are ruled by the Earth, the Earth is ruled by Heaven,

can be used for 'thereupon', so this can be translated as “Thereupon this acts as the mother of all under heaven,” or “Thereupon this is taken as the world's mother.” But then we risk ignoring or flattening the 以 or 為.

²²³ From zi.tools, on the origin of 明/名, describing the act of using the mouth to announce oneself in the dark when people cannot see each other. This is establishing of one's identity, to distinguish oneself from foes and danger.

²²⁴ Zi.tools lists this as 𦉳, as do Henricks and Cook, as 𦉳 over 才, but it technically looks like 𦉳. Two threads over “talent (grass growing on soil).” According to zi.tools, could be 災 (calamity, disaster; phonetic loan), 蕙 (afraid; unclear connection), or 茲 (this, visual similarity), or 哉 (used for question or rhetorically).

²²⁵ Alternatively, “This calamity we call the Dao.” A swarm of forces and spirits and everything can look disastrous and scary, even if it is sacred and the origin of all things. Perhaps what cannot be utilized, what is untamable, is scary and formidable. But the dry, drawly, “this here we call the Dao” honestly resonates with me a bit more.

²²⁶ In zi.tools as 𡗗 over 力, under 𦉳. This is a Warring States form of 𦉳. See A:17, and A:4 (rigid-power). The two lines may be an abbreviation. Consider, though, 𡗗 (𡗗), a variant of 𡗗 in zi.tools but attached to 剛 (hard interruption, rigid, unyielding, firm, strong) → “rigid” over “power” (力), to mean forceful, “brute forcing”.

²²⁷ Originally 𡗗 → 𡗗 → 𡗗, see Cook's “Bamboo Texts of Guodian”, page 258. Bottom is probably 水 above 曰. With maybe 𡗗 above that? I wasn't able to confirm with zi.tools and get a match, so I defaulted to Cook's 𡗗, which many paleographers appear to have agreed on, but with the sense of 𡗗 and 𡗗, flooding and overflowing, following Zhao JianWei, Hantang Di, Liu Zhao, and Harold Roth.

²²⁸ 𡗗: Rounder than the other samples for Chu script I've seen on zi.tools so wanted to flag it, but likely this is 國.

²²⁹ Originally 𡗗 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安.

²³⁰ 𡗗 means sit leisurely at a table, idle, at ease, to live somewhere; considered a synonym for 居 and 𡗗 (zi.tools)

²³¹ Technically 𡗗 to the left of 夫 all over 水 (in zi.tools: 𡗗 𡗗 𡗗 夫 水). Most of the entries there are from here.

天灋道，道灋自(夬/然)²³²。

Heaven model/ruled-by Dao/way, Dao ruled-by what-is-naturally-so/itself/its-own-nature.

Heaven is ruled by the Dao, and the Dao is ruled by its own nature.

A:11 Commentary:

The Dao seems to be being described as a swarm, an ancient swarm existing before Heaven and Earth.

The choice of 𧈧 is important, literally depicting three crawling creatures in tight formation. The primordial is not an empty void, but rather perhaps like a nest of ants or bees, or a *hibernacula* cave full of vipers. This translation as “swarm” is not certain, and a departure of the usual translation of these words, but see the footnote for my reasoning, and I invite you to follow this thread with me in the next few paragraphs.

This swarm forcibly obtains harmony, a beauty like the sun hitting full ears grain. If this swarm is the Dao, this is a rare example of the Dao taking a “yang” action, initiating, using force to accomplish what it needs. Perhaps it is a mistake to see the Dao as completely yielding and reactive; perhaps the Dao is more balanced than this. This source of life, the soul of the swarm takes harmony for itself, standing alone and exposed. Perhaps it is strange to think of a swarm as “alone”; after all, a swarm is a mass of countless individuals. Looking at the characters on the slips, suddenly, the swarm is reduced to the image of a solitary caterpillar (𧈧), the huge-eyed crawler. Though a baby, the caterpillar has no parents to answer to, no commands to heed. It simply crawls from one leaf to the next, alone but not hiding, soft and squishy but perhaps somehow unafraid.

This wild mass of everything, unified but inconceivably complex, composed of infinite pieces, answering to nothing but itself, is nothing that can be tamed to serve as something to “act as a mother” (if my translation is correct). To discuss this further, I expand into imagery beyond what is explicitly stated in the Guodian in this paragraph. A mother guards and hides her children from danger, tells them what to do and what not to do, shapes and molds, to a degree, who they will become. The swarm cannot be used against itself, the swarm cannot be used in a manipulative sense at all. Sure, it can be studied, it can be harnessed, to a degree, but in the way a river can be used to power a watermill; the river will run as it pleases, all you’ve done is found a way to benefit from the course it has chosen. There is no magic that can make the river reverse course, no magic that can prevent it from flooding or drying out. One can redirect the river, but only by appealing to its nature, its want to go down, but this is grueling digging work, and in doing it, the nature of the river remains unchanged. How, if it takes so much planning and labor to do something like this, can one use the Dao as a simple tool, especially to control something else?

Initially, I read this line as denying the instrumental use of the Dao/swarm as mother of everything in the world. With this instrumental reading, one cannot enslave the mother, not this wild mother, to enslave her ten-thousand children. She does not lord over her offspring, they bring themselves their own harmony, balance themselves out, in a deeply complex chaotic alignment, or organized disorganization. The order is messy, but it is indeed order in its own way. The swarm will adhere to that natural way. Their mother will never decree anything to change that, and so she cannot be used; it is not in her nature to be used. However, upon further consideration, the word used, 以為, does not only just mean “used as, taken as”, but also “consider(ed) as.” The Guodian may indicate that perhaps is also saying that the swarm cannot be classified as a mother either – perhaps the reality is not as neat and clean or easy to understand. Both readings may be true, or one or the other (though the latter is much more likely if 𧈧 is being used in the sense “thereupon”).

²³² Actually 夬, which is 然 without the fire radical on bottom. This is the case for the entirety of the Guodian.

This vast swarm, this uncontrollable mother, does not come with a name. The swarm does not need names to exist: it just exists. Again, names are just a convention, to make it possible to talk about something, refer to something. We cannot know its name because it does not bring us a name to work with, does not introduce itself because it does not need to. In order to explain this mysterious, murky source and process of all that there is, we assign a name. The name isn't "real" in the sense that it is not an emergent property of the swarm/Dao, we just need something to call it so we call it that.

We call it "great", but great does not tell the whole story. Great overflows, like a river in flood, and the overflowing is like rolling, and rolling is like reversing, rushing back. This overflowing and rolling and retracting reminds me of the advancement and retreat of ocean or sea waves, or the way waters constantly churn in rivers and seas. This being great is not just a static filling of everything; it is moving, circulating, pushing forward and rolling back. Heaven and Earth get to be called "great", the Dao of course earns this title too, and finally the king is also great. A territory's four greats are these four, and the king is just one of them. The king is a person, and people are at the mercy of Earth; what grows from the earth, what can be used as shelter, what can be made for tools. Earth, in turn, is ruled by Heaven; the patterns of weather, the falling rain, the scorching sun of the summer, the distant sun of the winter, the direction of the winds. Even Heaven has to answer to the Dao for its movements, but the Dao only answers to the Dao. The Dao regulates itself, obeys only itself, following only its own nature; and so the swarm regulates itself, obeys their natures, each crawler following only their own nature and the nature of the swarm, of the Dao.

Received 25 (A:11)

有物混²³³成, 先天地生

Have/exist things murky/confused/inchoate-chaos complete/achieve first/prior Heaven Earth born/live
There existed disorganized, complete things, before heaven and earth were created.

寂²³⁴兮寥兮, 獨立不改

Silent/still/forlorn [!] deserted/empty [!] solitary/alone/unique stand/confirm/install not change/modify
Silent! Deserted! Standing alone, not altered.

周行而不殆

Dense/thick/thorough/encircle/encompass transmit/walks/move/engage and/yet/but not danger/peril
Thoroughly transmitted, but not dangerous.

可以為天下母

Permissible/possible by-means-of use/do/act-as under-heaven mother
It can be used as the mother of everything in the world.²³⁵

吾不知其名, 字之曰道

I not know it/its name, procreate/foster/love/name ['s]/this/it say/called Dao/way
I do not know its name, the name I call it by is "Dao."

強為之名曰大

Strong/try-hard/dominate do/use/act-as ['s]/this name says/called big/great
Forced to use a name, we call it "great."

²³³ Both Mawangdui have 昆 here (together, mass, unified, numerous, sameness, worm.)

²³⁴ For 寂, Mawangdui A has 繡 (embroider, gorgeous, colorful) and B has 蕭 (untouched by outside influences, somber, grave, sedate, cool, brisk; for 寥, A has 繆 (silk, entwine, solemn, reverent, interlock) and B has 漻 (clear, pure, limpid, transparent, flow through, run through, saddened, disturbed).

²³⁵ Or, "It can be considered the mother of (everything in) the world."

大曰逝²³⁶

Great/big says/called go-away/pass-away/die/depart

Greatness is called departing,

逝曰遠

Depart/go-away/pass-away/die says/called distant/far/separated/estranged/far-reaching

Departing is called distant,

遠曰反

Distant/far/separated says/called turn-back/reverse/invert/oppose

Distant is called turning back.

故道大, 天大, 地大, 王亦大

Thus, Dao/way big/great, Heaven big/great, Earth big/great, King too/for-his-part big/great

Thus, the Dao is great, Heaven is great, Earth is great, and the King, too, is great.

域中有四大, 而王居其一焉

Territory/state center/middle exist/has four big/great, and/but king dwells it/its one of-them

The territory center has four greats, and the king dwells as one of them.

人法地, 地法天, 天法道, 道法自然

People lawful/rules/norm Earth, “” rules/norm heaven, “” rules/norm Dao, “” rules/norm self-nature

People are ruled by Earth, Earth is ruled by Heaven, Heaven is ruled by Dao, and Dao rules itself.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Chapter 25 of the received, which corresponds to A:11, changes the content substantially. The swarm is reduced to “confused”. It’s seizing of harmony is replaced with silence and emptiness. The solitary nature remains, in the received version “unaltered”, in the Guodian, “亥” which could be a loan for the same character in the received (改), but could also mean “stored up”. The received adds that the Dao is transmitted thoroughly (through everything), but does not do harm; this is missing in the Guodian, although I have little doubt that the Guodian would agree the Dao is thoroughly transmitted. A drastic difference is while the Guodian states that the Dao cannot be used as a mother for the world, the received swaps 可 for 不可, “not possible” to “possible”. While Kroll states that 可 can also be used as “thereupon”, normally 故 is used for this kind of “thus” function, and the Shuowen Jiezi’s listed meaning is “不可”, and I defer to the older definitions where the Guodian is concerned. This transformation from impossible to possible is significant. The Warring States version describes the Dao as untamable, and the received version suggests that the Dao can be used, or at least can act, as a mother to all under heaven. The fact that this is not flat “is” or “is not” is significant, suggesting that 為 is not simply “act as”, but a more active “use” meaning. This cosmic swarm, untamable, active and teeming with life, was converted into a jumbled mess, silent, empty, still and unchanging, and yet motherly. The only thing that they share in common is their solitude and their forcibly applied name: the Dao.

Confucian thought (and later Huang-Lao traditions among others) is often read as treating the cosmic order, sometimes called the Dao, as something that can be harnessed and applied to achieve harmony: a standard to be modeled, a power to invoke, a system with which to bring everything into alignment. Even if this is reverent, this is the use of the Dao, using it as an instrument or tool to bring order. If my translation is correct, A:11 seems to assert that no, one cannot do this, one cannot reduce that mysterious complexity, that teeming swarm, into a tool to bring the unruly subjects to compliance. The

²³⁶ Mawangdui has 筮

swarm abducts harmony, taking it on its own terms, wild and free. It is older than the powers of Heaven and Earth, and was whole without them, and in this way perhaps outside of their authority. If the swarm is not even a subject to Heaven and Earth, how can a person, however royal or mighty, hope to use it as a whip or magic wand to bring about what they desire?

How “Great” is described also differs a bit. Guodian has “great” as overflowing, rolling, and turning back. The received has it as departing, far away, and then coming back, somewhat diminishing the watery, oceanic feeling of this description, and immediately diminishing “Great”. There is no overflowing, immediately it is already leaving. The Guodian at least allows “Great” to have some power or saturation of everything before letting it crash and recede. The received seems to want to keep the Dao as “yin”, as yielding, and empty, and silent as possible, a still and stagnant lake rather than a breathing, pulsing ocean, a similar observation I made in my discussion of stillness in A:2.

Guodian (A:12)

天地²³⁷之外²³⁸,

Heaven Earth [‘s]/this outside/beyond

Beyond Heaven and Earth,

其(𦉳/猷/猶)(𦉳²³⁹/舊)(𦉳/簾)²⁴⁰(𦉳/與)²⁴¹?

Its/maybe plan/design/method/like/similar-to old loom’s-bamboo-shuttle, is-it-not/grant/join? ²⁴²

Isn’t it like an old loom’s bamboo shuttle?

(𦉳/虛)而不(𦉳/屈),

Empty/depleted/stretched-thin/subtle/humble, and/yet not exhausted/used up/bent/curled

Empty, yet inexhaustible,

(𦉳/適)²⁴³而(𦉳/愈)²⁴⁴(𦉳/出)。

Moving, yet/and increasingly/heal go/emerge/produce/emanate/send/expel/reach-beyond/exceed.

Moving and in doing so producing even more.

A:12 Commentary:

The Guodian is discussing what is beyond Heaven and Earth, considering that these may not be the limits of all that exists. A bamboo shuttle of a loom carries the horizontal yarn (called a weft) back and forth through the vertical yarns (the warp). Shuttles must be long, narrow, and tapered at both ends to allow sliding smoothly between tight threads. Bamboo is also naturally hollow, lightweight,

²³⁷ Technically 陀 over 土, 𦉳

²³⁸ 𦉳 Cook has this as 𦉳, zi.tools has 外 better and indeed they seem to mean the same things, but it is not a perfect match and zi.tools doesn’t have 𦉳 in Chu script, but lists its meaning as 外 as well.

²³⁹ Originally 𦉳, maybe the leather bag indicated by 囊. Maybe best expressed as 𦉳? Cook and Henricks have this as 𦉳 inside 𦉳, but I honestly do not see it (𦉳=𦉳). Listed in zi.tools as 𦉳 (old (as 舊), (Wiktionary has prisoner, 囚) [Also worth mentioning that 𦉳 and 𦉳 is an alternative form of 𦉳, though most forms of this in Chu script have a cross on the first vertical, not the second as it is here, see zi.tools: 𦉳 from the 望山 is listed but it is the odd one out]. Also may related to 𦉳 (top of a baby’s head, known as fontanelle before bones fuse). I select as 𦉳 (old (as 舊, though see A:18;s 𦉳, B:1’s 𦉳), similar to 久, mostly because it makes the most sense – the character identification on this one is iffy.

²⁴⁰ Maybe 管? 簾? 簾? 簾 is much closer. Couldn’t help feeling like this is 竹 over 𦉳 over 𦉳, and indeed I was close. Zi.tools has this as 簾 (𦉳 over 簾), a bamboo shuttle on an old fashioned loom.

²⁴¹ Can also mean to give to/grant to, to be associated with, but also a blend of 𦉳 and 也 when ending sentences. Normally I translate this as “join/joining”, or “grant/give” in A:18

²⁴² Very untraditional translation on my part. The 𦉳 is very ambiguous and to write it off just as 囊 seems to me a bit of a stretch, given what the character looked like in other Warring States kingdoms at the time. The definition associated with its shape that macks most sense is “old”, so we end up with “the bamboo shuttle on an old loom.”

²⁴³ 𦉳 According to zi.tools, equivalent to 動, listed under 適

²⁴⁴ 𦉳 In zi.tools, listed under 愉 for some reason – the heart radical is undoubtedly on the bottom. A little troubling, as the 愈 character itself is, by Wiktionary and zi.tools, an alternative form of 癒 meaning “cured (of an illness).” This line, therefore could also perhaps be translated as “Moving, and in doing so, healingly emerges/emanates.” I find this reading weaker, and not thematically different than increasing production. See also B:5 (𦉳)

but strong, allowing craftspeople to shave it down into remarkably thin shapes without breaking them. This thin but strong shape allows the shuttle to operate amidst the high tension of the warp, its small form reducing friction that could snap the yarn, and move quickly but smoothly through the loom without much effort from the weaver. So, the bamboo shuttle is small and hollow, holding the yarn, but these qualities give it function that cannot be used up. As long as the shuttle moves, it will produce more and more fabric. So, although what lies outside of heaven and earth, the latent parts of the universe, seem empty and imperceptible, their movement is what creates everything that can be perceived.

Another work found in the Guodian tombs, 太一生水 (Taiyi Shengshui), which may have been part of Guodian Laozi C, also deals with what is beyond heaven and earth, and bears some relevance to the contents of A:11 as well. I do not translate it here, as I don't have access to clear photographs of the slips for this, but I will quote Henricks' translation.

“The great one gave birth to water. Water returned and assisted Taiyi, in this way developing heaven. Heaven returned and assisted Taiyi, in this way developing earth. Heaven and earth [repeatedly helping each other], in this way developing the “gods above and below”. The “gods of above and below” repeatedly assisted each other, in this way developing Yin and Yang. Yin and Yang repeatedly assisted each other, in this way developing the four seasons. The four seasons repeatedly assisted each other, in this way developing cold and hot. Cold and hot repeatedly assisted each other, developing moist and dry. Moist and dry repeatedly assisted each other; they developed the year, and the process came to an end. Therefore [...] the Great one is concealed in water and moves with the four seasons. Completing a cycle, [it starts] over again; the mother of the ten-thousand things: first it is depleted, then it is full; we regard this as the guiding principle of the ten-thousand things. This is something that heaven cannot destroy, earth cannot smother, and Yin and Yang cannot produce. The gentleman knows this is referred to as [“the Way/Dao”]...” (Henricks, page 123).

Received 5 (A:12)

天地不仁

Heaven Earth not humane/kind/benevolent

Heaven and Earth are not benevolent,

以萬物為芻狗

By-means-of ten-thousand things act-as/do/use straw-dogs²⁴⁵

Using the ten thousand things as disposable.

聖人不仁

Sage not humane/kind/benevolent

The sage is not benevolent,

以百姓²⁴⁶為芻狗

By-means-of hundred surnames²⁴⁷ for/as straw-dogs.

Using the people as disposable things.

²⁴⁵ Sacrificial object, disposable after use.

²⁴⁶ In Mawangdui A, 省- scrutinize, discern, reflect, recall, realize, diminish, reduce, spare, save, cancel, skinny.

²⁴⁷ the people, esp. common

天 地 之 間

Heaven Earth [‘s]/this space/between,
The space between Heaven and Earth,

其 猶 橐 籥 乎²⁴⁸

[Is possibly/how is it]²⁴⁹ similar-to (bag-pipe →)bellows(that blast air) (?/!)
How can it be like a bellows?

虛 而 不 屈²⁵⁰

Empty yet not curled/reduced/diminished/bent/made-submissive/exhausted/wronged,
Empty, and so not diminished,

動 而 愈²⁵¹ 出

Moving/shifting yet/and increasingly/even-more producing/expending/put forth/leave/go-out.
Moving, and so producing even more.²⁵²

多 言²⁵³ 數 窮

Exceed/accrue/many/more words counts/frequently/often/figures expends/spent/to-the-end,
Many words often exhausts. / More words count only toward exhaustion/one’s limit.

不 如 守²⁵⁴ 中

Not-following/inferior-to guarding/maintaining/defending/abiding-by inner/center/core/middle.
Not better than maintaining one’s center.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Indeed, only the latter lines in the received Chapter 5 are in the oldest known version of the Daodejing (Guodian). In having nothing, it does everything. The Guodian’s translation, at least the way I have done it with the unresolved character identifications there are, departs a bit from the void/emptiness imagery and instead of a bellows blowing air, uses a shuttle of a loom. This departure from the bellows was more in the name of staying as faithful as possible to the literal characters on the slips, but perhaps a shuttle of a loom and bellows have more in common than it would first seem. Like the bellows, the emptiness within the shuttle is what gives it functionality. Like the bellows, as the shuttle moves back and forth, the cloth is produced through this movement. The fact that the loom is old or worn does not affect its efficacy, and it is more independently operating and rhythmic than the bellows of Wang Bi, not requiring a human operator all the time, and thus fitting the flavor of *WuWei*. Also interesting in the Guodian is that the shuttle of the loom describes what is *outside* of heaven and earth, not between it—the forces or processes beyond the perceivable world. What is between Heaven and Earth likely also refers to these forces as well, or it could refer to the empty space between Heaven and Earth instead.

The received also includes a discussion of the lack of benevolence of Heaven and Earth, using the ten-thousand things as disposable, and how the sage uses the people the same way. This seems to be more of a reaction to Confucian ideas, though it puzzles me why the received would compare the

²⁴⁸ In Mawangdui and Guodian, 與, probably meant as a blend of 乎 and 也

²⁴⁹ 其, besides possessive nature, is used as “perhaps”, “maybe”, “likely”, or with 乎 at the end, “are likely...” or “how...?”, indicating incredulity, subjectivity, uncertainty. 乎 itself indicates a question OR an exclamation.

²⁵⁰ 澁 in Mawangdui texts, also can mean exhausted, but also stir up, agitate, circulate, muddy, plunge into, used up

²⁵¹ 俞 in the Mawangdui texts,--“approved!” “agreed!”, reply.

²⁵² Linnell, Wu, Lau, Lin, and Feng & English have “the more it works, the more comes out of it.” Chan has “when active, it produces even more.” Henricks has “Move it and more always comes out.” Cleary has similar. Waley has “Work it, and more comes out.” Linnell has

²⁵³ 聞 in the Mawangdui texts – hear, make heard, rumors, hearsay, reputation, renown. Similar in meaning

²⁵⁴ 於 inserted in Mawangdui texts here, to/from/with regard to, or likely grammatical. 若 instead of 如 on same line

sage to Heaven and Earth rather than the Dao, and the lack of “motherliness” in this description. Certainly a (good) mother does not treat her children like ritual straw dogs, treating them reverently in front of an audience and discarding them as trash when the gazes turn away. Confucian ideas would advocate for a caring relationship between the sage and the people; his care of them would bring good behavior from him, and thus there would be harmony. Is this contrarian for its own sake? There is also discussion on how talking is exhausting, putting one closer to their limit, and that “defending one’s center” is better. The Guodian also has its fair share of less-than-flattering opinions about talking, see especially A:15, and to some degree A:10.

Guodian (A:13)

(𠂔/至)虛(𣎵/瓦)²⁵⁵也;

Arrive-at/with regard/ultimate/utmost to/utmost empty/diminished constant/eternal

To arrive at emptiness constantly,²⁵⁶

(獸/獸²⁵⁷/守)(𠂔/中)²⁵⁸(𠂔/管)²⁵⁹也。

Hunt/beast//protect center/middle/core thick/devoted

Defend the core with devotion;

萬(勿/物)²⁶⁰(𠂔/方)(𠂔/作)²⁶¹

Ten-thousand things only-then/just-then/means/direction/proper/square arise/begin/create

When the ten thousand things are just now arising;

居以須²⁶²(復²⁶³/復)也。

Dwell/rest by-means-of need-to/require/want/wait for/stay for/slow return/go-back/repeat/revert/reply

Dwell through needing to go back.

天道(員員/圓圓)²⁶⁴,

Heaven way is round/circular x2

Heaven's way is truly circular;

各(復/復)其(𠂔²⁶⁵/堇)。

Each/in-each-case return/retreats/repeats to its scarcely?/clay/soil

Everything reverts to its soil.

²⁵⁵ Technically 𣎵, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𣎵 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆, though without support from Shuowen Jiezi for this latter form with 心. This cluster is also related to 恒, which Cook seems convinced this means 極 in B:1 and here, but 恆 in strips 6, 13, and 18.

²⁵⁶ Keep in mind, this chapter appears right after A:12, which discusses the ability of emptiness to create without being exhausted. This does not necessarily mean the erasure of the self, but just allowing oneself the capacity within to allow work to move through. A:12 is on one slip and A:13 on another, but I really believe they connect.

²⁵⁷ Zi.tools says this means 獸

²⁵⁸ 冲/盅 is suggested here by Yan LingFeng (through Cook), to mean “void” or “empty”

²⁵⁹ See also A:18. This character could be a synonym of 𠂔 (genuine) and so therefore 篤 (all of which are du3) thick, relentless, genuine, which I am hesitant about because this character 𠂔 already appears, but the Shuowen Jiezi, by zi.tools, seems to also say this means “thick.” It appears the thick/devoted meaning is more likely. Shuowen Jiezi says “thick and winter-poisonous”, but the poisonous bit may be pronunciation. This may be a Chu version for 孰, meaning “in which cases, which, who, what”, according to zi.tools.

²⁶⁰ Treated like 物 because 勿 means no, do not, and doesn't make sense here.

²⁶¹ 𠂔→𠂔 Original was 𠂔 with a 又 under it, unlike Chapter 2 (Guodian A:9); there is a stray vertical mark to the left of the character: 𠂔, but it bears enough resemblance to other examples of 𠂔 (for instance 𠂔). Compare to A:7

²⁶² 𠂔 Controversial, usually rendered 寡, sometimes rendered to 須 (await) which is most supported by zi.tools, but may be an abbreviation of 寡. Maybe should be read as 顧. (See A:1)

²⁶³ 𠂔 Robert Henricks has this as 復 inside 𠂔.

²⁶⁴ Controversial. 𠂔→𠂔 Anyways, This is usually rendered as 員, which zi.tools supports, Mawangdui has two different things, see above. Some others have just 云云, or 圓圓, as 員 was 圓's original form. Henricks has 員 over 火, which is closest to what I see, but renders it as 云 without explaining why. The confidence seems to stem from the fact that this should sound like yun/yuan, but this is not particularly convincing to me

²⁶⁵ Cook, Henricks, + Zi.tools list as 堇 but it's 黄 over 土, so 堇. Shuowen Jiezi defines this as soil. See B:5 (堇)

A:13 Commentary:

“To arrive at constant emptiness, defend the core with devotion²⁶⁶” perhaps refers to keeping the core, the middle of the analogous bamboo shuttle of A:12, empty. Do not let this hollow area that allows the work to move through become stopped up by anything, as that would increase the friction. The bamboo shuttle needs to remain hollow to move –if it holds onto its work, dwells in every success, it cannot continue to function, it gets stuck, the source of its productivity is gone. One must keep their core free of extraneous debris, keep it hollow, in order to preserve it. For a person, this extraneous debris, this attempt of a loom shuttle to hoard yarn (resulting in a jam and stalling the machine), would be the vanity, greed, envy, and pride of the achievement-chasing, wealth-longing, power-hungry, fame-driven people of ambition. They hold tight to their achievements, their piles of riches, and this is the friction that breaks their ability to work endlessly. A hollow shuttle, a person with no temptation to hang on to these excesses, stays hollow, and their work becomes effortless and natural, one task after the next.

The shuttle also needs to go back once it goes in one direction. It is through going back and forth that it accomplishes its work. Go one way, loop back and go the other, returning to where one was, never losing that. The biological fluctuations of homeostasis work in much the same way – every movement in one direction is countered by a movement in the other. Staying in place is not always standing still, sometimes it is looping, circulating, fluctuating. The people of ambition are only trying to go in one direction: up, or forward. They dwell in their achievements instead of dwelling in themselves. Even in the face of ten-thousand things arising, all of the opportunities and developments and prizes to be won or history to be made, do not chase those things in one direction; dwell by needing to go back to where you came from, where you started. An osprey flies out over the sea, catches a good fish, and flies back to the nest.

Heaven’s way is truly circular: rain falls and evaporates and falls again, the seasons move in their endless wheel, night and day chase each other endlessly, back and forth, over and over. The largest tree from the smallest seed will burn or decay and become soil again. Even the mighty kings and fiercest warlords will return to the soil from which their food and their food’s food grew. In this way, Heaven’s work is everlasting because it is constantly changing form, going back and forth, back and forth, over and over again.

Received 16 (A:13)

致虛極，守靜篤。

Attain/bring-about empty standard/zenith/supreme/utmost, Defend/preserve stillness thick/devoted

Attain the pinnacle of emptiness, defend stillness with devotion.

萬物並²⁶⁷作，

Ten thousand things side-by-side/coordinate/equally/altogether/uniformly arise/begin/create

Ten thousand things arise with coordination,

²⁶⁶ As an aside too far afield to put in the body text, Taijiquan and the focus on cultivating and harnessing “Lower Dantian (下丹田)”, sometimes called the “field/sea of qi”, located in the abdomen. In various Chinese, Korean, and Japanese martial arts, this lower dantian is the center of gravity, a critical origin point or pathway for energy in movement, and a root for standing, grounding, breathing, and body awareness. Being attentive to the core in meditation, combat, action and rest has deep cultural associations with health and self-defense. Energy is stored (and potentially refined) here, movement and circulation is so deeply important for this core. The core of the shuttle and the Xia Dantian are both allowing for movement, and both need to be protected and minded in order to function best.

²⁶⁷ In both Mawangdui, this is 旁

吾以觀[其]復

I by-means-of observe/display/behold/watch-intently [it/its] return/revert/go-back/repeat
And I, through observation, return [them],²⁶⁸

夫物芸芸各復歸其根

In-any-case/these things manifold/plentiful each return go-home/restore/refuge-with it/its root/base
These things, manifold – each of them return by restoring their roots.

歸根曰靜

Restoring/go-home/refuge root/base says/called stillness/motionless
Restoring one's roots is called stillness,

[靜]是謂復命

[stillness] this called return/revert/go-back command/orders/name/heavenly-ordained-command
This is called returning to one's orders,

復命曰常

Return/revert/go-back command/orders/heavenly-ordained-command says/called constant/persistent
Returning to one's orders is called constant.

知常曰明

Know constant/persistent called/says luminous/light/evident/illuminate/perceptive
Knowing constancy is called perceptive;

不知常妄作凶

Not/no know constant/persistent careless/unseemly/absurd arise/begin/create ill-omen/deadly/lethal
Not knowing constancy is careless, and misfortune arises.

知常容,容乃公

Know constant appearance/permit/tolerate/pardon, “” then/indeed impartial/common/public
Knowing constancy is tolerant, tolerance is indeed impartial,

公乃王,王乃天

Impartial/common/public then/indeed king, king then/indeed heaven
Impartiality is indeed kingly, kings are indeed heavenly,

天乃道,道乃久

Heaven then/indeed Dao/way, Dao/way indeed/then long-lasting/enduring/familiar
Heaven is indeed like the Dao, the Dao is indeed long-enduring and familiar,

沒²⁶⁹身不殆

Sink/dissolve/disappear/submerge/overcome body/self not/no danger/peril
Such that dissolving oneself is not dangerous.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Chapter 16 of the received goes into a totally different direction than A:13 of the Guodian. While the Guodian instructs to preserve the middle, or core, the received places that protection onto stillness. Instead of dwelling by needing to go back, in the received, the narrator, by means of observation (以觀), returns the ten thousand things that arises, doing this by “restoring/returning their roots”, which means to make them still, which means to return them to their 命, which, while often translated as “destiny” or “fate”, in Warring States and early dynastic Chinese means “commands, orders”, sometimes originating from heaven. So, this returning

²⁶⁸ Linnell translates this as “And thus I observe their return,” and Lau, Chan, Henricks, Cleary, and Feng & English have very similar. Wu has “While all things are stirring together, I only contemplate their return.”

²⁶⁹ 沒 later meant “not have”, “to be not so...” (Wiktionary), but Kroll doesn't list these for Classical Chinese

the ten thousand things to their roots is to make them still and obedient. This is much different than the Guodian's going back even as the ten thousand things rise. The sage of the received bends the world to their will, the sage of the Guodian goes back and forth, letting the ten thousand things do what they do. The Guodian ends by explaining that Heaven's way is circular and round, everything returning to its "soil" or from where it came. The received turns in a whole different direction: calling "knowing constancy/returning to one's orders" as perceptive, and describing the failure to do so as haphazard and dangerous. Then, this "knowing constancy" becomes a ticket to tolerance, impartiality, kingliness, heavenliness, the Dao itself, and, possibly, the Dao's lack of need for a body (this reading is most similar to Cleary's translation, as well as that of Feng & English). Read alternately, the final line could claim that "Dissolving one's self/body is not dangerous/makes it such that there is no danger", which has a decidedly Buddhist flavor to it, and runs contrary to all of the protection of the self the Guodian instructs elsewhere. Linnell translates this line in this way, writing "When the self disappears, there can be no danger." The more common translation is that someone who is one with the Dao will be some kind of safe either until the end of their lives (Lau, Chan, Henricks, and Lin) or even after the loss of their body (Wu and also Waley). The former is perhaps an extension of the self-protective logic of the Guodian. The latter wanders into the mystical pursuit of immortality, or even the merging oneself with the Hindu concept of the Brahman, the universal consciousness, total freedom and invincibility at the cost of the individual identity, the self. The Guodian would have no issue with the prolonging of life, though it may take issue with using "kingliness" to get there, but eternal life and destruction of the self, or even the body, would run contrary to the circular nature of nature itself, the circular nature of the Dao.

In B:4, the Guodian does say that worries originate from having a body/self, but the solution is not to forsake the body, but to value it, to protect it. The "if I lose my body/die, how could I worry", in my opinion, should be read in a snarky way, like a sassy person pointing out the dead have nothing to worry about anymore. This is not offering up "losing the body" or death as a solution; it is only explaining that the function of worry and anxiety is to keep oneself alive. If one views this line from a Buddhist lens, one would be tempted to make it a statement of escaping Samsara, the cycle of life and death, but this simply is not consistent with the rest of what is written and the themes of the Guodian, which are impressively consistent in my opinion. A:13 itself insists on return; everything, no matter how mighty, returns to soil. A reading of the received text that offers permanent escape from this cycle is not just uncharacteristic of the Guodian's values generally, but also this specific chapter.

Guodian (A:14)

其²⁷⁰(𠂔²⁷¹/安)也, (𠂔/易)(𠂔/朱/困)²⁷²也;

Its stability/safe/calm/install, change/exchange/easy/relieved bound/constricted/arduous/exhausting

Those that are stable, they transform into being constrained,

其未(𠂔²⁷³/兆)也, 易(𠂔²⁷⁴/誨)也;

Its not-yet/hasn't peach//omen/origin(ate), change/easy motherly-love(?)nurture(?)//instruct/guide

Those that are not yet begun, they transform into being nurtured.

其(𠂔/脆)²⁷⁵也, 易(𠂔/畔²⁷⁶/叛)也;

Its drizzle/misty-rain//weak/frail/delicate, change boundaries/alongside//betray/contradict/rebel

Those that are delicate like misty rain, they transform into being rebellious.

其(𠂔/幾)也, 易(𠂔/踐/踐)也。

It/its latent/invisible/nearly/few/imminent-danger change trample/tread/walk-to/climb-to/carry-out

Those issues that are tiny, they transform into being tread on.

為之於其亡(又/有)也。

Do/use/manipulate this/[‘s] in/at/than/to/regarding its lack/no have/exist.

Use this at its not-existing.

(𠂔/絢)²⁷⁷之於其未(𠂔/亂)²⁷⁸。

Oversee this/[‘s] in/at/regarding/to/than its not-yet disordered.

Oversee this at its not-yet disordered.

²⁷⁰ 其 is often a 3rd person possessive, but can be “of those/these”, making subjects a subpart of something (Kroll).

²⁷¹ 安 in zi.tools; very variable in Chu script, but this feels like it may be a different character to me. Probably nothing, but I wanted to note it just in case. It does not resemble the 𠂔 of suspected 焉.

²⁷² Cook and Henricks has 柴; Zi.tools renders this 𠂔(之) over 木, (for zi.tools, also 持 (By the Shuowen Jiezi: 槌 (strike, hammer), as mallet or horizontal beam). Received has 持 (hold in hand, support, bear up, maintain, restrain), perhaps itself in place of 序(store up, stock, reserve), but this could also be 殖 (generate, breed, cultivate, implant, trade), or 植 (plant in the ground, growth of plants, implant), and Mawangdui has 植(throw, pitch, send). Cook suggests 柴 could be an ancient form of 困. The wood component of this character is very prominent. 𠂔 being a form of 之 (to go) (and very visually similar to 止), over wood, maybe this means to support, like a wooden bridge, or restrain, like a wooden pen for livestock. This ends up looping back to 柴 being an ancient form of 困, which the Shuowen Jiezi through Zi.tools agrees with. Visual similarity supports 柴→困. (See A:20)

²⁷³ Zi.tools, Cook, and Henricks have 茱. May mean 桃 (peach, though see from Baoshan Chu 𠂔) according to zi.tools. 兆, by the Shuowen Jiezi, referred to the cracks on the tortoise shell used for divination, as 𠂔; took on the later meaning of omen and sign. As it is, 未茱 I originally translated as “unripe peach”

²⁷⁴ Listed in zi.tools as 𠂔, mother over heart (motherly love?). Henricks agrees. according to zi.tools may be equivalent to 誨 (instruct, guide). Cook has 𠂔. Zi.tools mentions that 𠂔 and 𠂔 (insult) may be for 𠂔 over 心.

²⁷⁵ As listed in zi.tools and Cook, Originally 雨 over 𠂔 (maybe something like 用 on top?) Could be an early form of 𠂔, itself an alt. form of 脆. 𠂔 is also an alternative form of 脆 (weak, frail, fragile, dainty), but also means bird down, downy, wooly. I’m tempted to think about this as soft, delicate, misty rain, and apparently so was Cook, speculating it could be an early form of 𠂔. 𠂔 seems to mean the uropygial oil birds use to preen their feathers.

²⁷⁶ Technically 半 over 田, 𠂔. Was taken in the sense of “rebellion” 叛 in A;16. Could also mean 離, or 叛

²⁷⁷ In zi.tools under 𠂔, looks very close to 𠂔 (listed 絢 in zi.tools) See B:1 (𠂔) In my opinion this is 𠂔 (which zi.tools defines as “repair” from a Song dynasty text) Zi.tools suggests 治 (govern, control, harness), 始 (start, beginning), or 怡 (joyful, happy, convenient) for 𠂔. Given 司 means “oversee, supervise, examine” I opt for that.

²⁷⁸ 𠂔→𠂔 as Henricks. (in zi.tools, listed under 吕 left of 𠂔 left of 吕, but it is the odd one out. Probably still 亂.

(倉/合²⁷⁹)□□□ (抱之木)²⁸⁰,

Combine/fit/meet/close □ (embrace/hug/enwrap/surround ['s]/this tree)

{The tree one can} fit {their arms around in a hug,}

□□□(𣎵/末)²⁸¹, (生於毫)

Tree-Branch/tip/peripheral, (born/alive/create in/at/to/regarding/than fine-hair/slightest-bit/plant-fuzz

{Was born in a hairlike} branch.

九(盛/成)²⁸²之(臺/臺)²⁸³,

Nine completion/containment/accomplishment ['s]/this terrace/lowly-official/raised-platform,

The nine completed terraces,

(𠄎²⁸⁴/甲)□□ (於募土)

Sheath/shell/armor/first-rate/first-in-sequence □²⁸⁵ (at/in/to baskets-for-dirt earth)

Were first {in baskets of dirt}.

□□□□ (百仞之高)

(Hundred [length-of-distance,-approx-267-meters] ['s]/this high/tall/ascent

{A 26.700 meter /16.5 mile ascent,}

□□□足下。(始於)

Step/foot/leg down/below/under □ (starts in/at/regarding/to)

{Begins in} single steps.

A:14 Commentary:

In later texts, 易 is often translated to easy, but there are well known old examples using 易 that refer to change or transformations, (the Zhou Yi or YiJing to name a very famous example). This, in addition to translating 愇 elsewhere in the Guodian as alert or guarded (heart/minding change→ staying highly aware→alert and guarded) convinced me to translate 易 as “change” or “transform”. That being said, both “easy” and “transform into” do not really function terribly different from each other. If it is easy for A to be B, A will transform into B. As it is, this chapter does deal in other transformations; the long ascent transformed from the single step, the completed terraces from baskets of dirt, the massive tree from the hairlike branch (or sprout).

Stability can become complacency, complacency can become trapped. Attaining or maintaining peace can be used to justify a loss of freedom, a loss of movement or the ability to move. What is comfortable

²⁷⁹ See A:10, and A:17. Might mean 會, or 答

²⁸⁰ Missing characters supplied by Cook

²⁸¹ The top part of the character is cut off, the bottom is consistent with a wood radical, not typical for other instances of 未. Throughout the Laozi, it looks like 𣎵, but this is not, 未 but 未, and so is consistent (𣎵)

²⁸² In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 盛. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Probably phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

²⁸³ 臺, Cook has 止 over 室, Henricks has 臺 (zi.tools listing found under this character). To me, looks like it could be a 𠄎 over a ghost, which I guess 室 kind of looks like (𠄎)

²⁸⁴ 𠄎 Both Henricks and Cook have 甲 (𠄎, 𠄎, ours 𠄎), maybe the stroke on the left faded? Cook mentions it may be an error for 𠄎, (𠄎, 𠄎, 𠄎). 一 over 上? This is most likely 甲.

²⁸⁵ Missing characters from Cook

can lead to much more limited (and much less comfortable) situations later if one does not remain aware.

The unripe peach, hanging from the tree, is growing, and this growing is an invitation to be nurtured, either by the tree itself or the gardener. An unripe peach, left on the branch, will usually mature because of the nutrients and investment into that fruit from the tree, and of course the gardener who fancies peaches will additionally protect and nourish the tree and its fruit.

Misty rain, simple drizzles, going on long enough or as the first hints of a downpour, can result in its fair share of damage by flooding or incoming storms. The gentle, diffuse rain can saturate the soil, and then one may realize this unassuming weather has risen to “rebellion”: flash flooding, oversaturated soil becoming mud, risking landslide. A storm starts with a drizzle – one has to make their preparations before it goes on too long or intensifies.

When problems or important matters are tiny, they are often ignored, stepped over like they aren’t there. A small, dull-colored snake curled up on the ground may be tread on, but that small problem becomes true disaster if that snake is venomous and strikes out in defense of itself. Small details can be ignored, and the opportunity to avert misfortune, or reap benefit, can be easily missed.

Therefore, problems need to be managed while they are still easily manageable, or manageable at all. Act on things when they haven’t materialized yet, at their “non-existing”. Simple prevention is certainly better than complex solutions after the fact. Big problems can be solved when they are still tiny, complicated issues can be sorted out while they are still straightforward.

The transformation of things from small to big continues, assuming the wording from the received fits the way Scott Cook believes it does: massive trees that you can barely wrap your arms fully around the trunk of started as miniscule seeds from a very thin, fine branch. The mighty tower overlooking what is below was originally earth gathered in baskets for the purpose of building it. A long hike up a mountain starts with putting one’s foot down for the first step. What is massive starts small; plan accordingly.

Received 64 Part 1 (A:14)

其安易²⁸⁶持

Its peaceful/stable/quiet/calm/install change/exchange/easy/relieved hold/restrain/maintain

That which is stable is easy to hold on to,

其未兆易謀

Its not-yet omen/sign change/exchange/easy/relieved consult/advise/counsel/strategize/scheme/plan

That which has not yet been augured is easy to advise,

其脆易泮

Its brittle/frail/fragile change/exchange/easy/relieved dissolve/melt-away/break-apart

That which is fragile is easy to break apart,

其微易散

Its subtle/tiny/secret change/exchange/easy/relieved scatter/give-up/turn-loose/disperse/divert

That which is subtle is easy to scatter,

為之於未有

Do/use/act-as/manipulate [‘s]/this in/at/from/regarding not-yet exist/have

Do things when they do not yet exist,

²⁸⁶ Despite the various definitions this character could have, every translation I have read treats this as “easy”.

治之於未亂

Govern/harness/control this/['s] in/at/from/regarding not-yet disordered/rebellious

Govern things when they are not yet disordered.

合抱之木

Combine/fit/box/unite/join/meet embrace/encircle/put-arms-around ['s]/this tree

A tree huge enough to get one's arms completely around

生於毫末

Born/alive/create in/at/from fine-hair/slightest-bit/plant-fuzz tree-branch/tip/peripheral

Was born from a hairlike branch.

九層之臺

Nine layered/tiered ['s]/this tower/terrace

The tower of nine floors,

起於累土

Rise/help-up/raise in/at/from/regarding pile-up/heap/mound/gather earth

Was risen from a mound of earth.

千里之行

Thousand li(measure-of-distance) ['s]/this transmit/walk/move/engage

A walk of a thousand li

始於足下

Begins/starts/initiate foot/leg down

Begins with dropping one's foot.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Chapter 63 of the received is very similar to the Guodian's A:14; the most major difference, to be fair, results in a difference in translation. Indeed, if I had translated 易 as easy, there would not be much difference at all, and indeed, one could probably make the received version work translating 易 as change as well. As I said above, this difference, in my opinion, does not substantially change the meaning outside of perhaps giving more agency for someone to do something; the sage would easily "hold" (or "restrain") the stable/peaceful, the sage would "advise" what has not yet been predicted (or "nurture" the "unripe peach"), the sage would "break apart" what is "fragile" (this does not work as well with easily "rebellious" against the "drizzle"), the sage easily "scatters" what is "subtle" or tiny (or easily "treading on" these). Beyond these nuances, actively easily doing something in contrast to natural, automatic or almost-automatic change, these two versions are extremely similar.

Guodian (A:15)

智之(𠄎/者)(𠄎/弗)言²⁸⁷,

Knowledge/wisdom [‘s]/this people do not words/talk/speak

People of knowing do not speak,

言之(𠄎/者)(𠄎/弗)智。

Speaking/talking/word [‘s]/this people do not know.

People of words do not know.

(𠄎/閔²⁸⁸/閉)其(𠄎/逆²⁸⁹/兌),

Close-off its/their open-passages

Close off one’s open passages,

(𠄎/賽²⁹⁰/塞)其門,

Compete/rival//supply/fill/obstruct its/their gates,

Block one’s gates,

和其(𠄎²⁹¹/光),

Harmonize/balance/peace its/their brightness/glory/luster

Balance one’s brightness,

(𠄎/迴²⁹²/通)其(𠄎/斷²⁹³),

Pass-through/unobstructed-access/thoroughly-understand its/their caution/vigilance/attention x2

Pass through one’s extreme caution,²⁹⁴

²⁸⁷ There’s a = duplication mark here.

²⁸⁸ Written like 𠄎, zi.tools has this under 閔. (𠄎 and similar have been used to express 戈 in Chu script). This is not the same as 閔(𠄎) in B:6, meaning shut or close. Zi.tools has 閔 as the same as 閔, which both zi.tools and Wiktionary call a “test hammer”, used to test the arm strength of a strong man. A weapon like a dagger-axe 戈 connected to a gate 門 may have a similar meaning of “close off”, to guard with weapons. Cook and others think this is in some way 閉, also “to close, to shut, obstruct”. It could be these are all synonyms with different connotations or stresses by way of swapped components. Either way, “close off” would be consistent here.

²⁸⁹ 𠄎 Happy (𠄎)(man with a smiling mouth) within 𠄎 (walking/moving). Zi.tools is under the impression this means 稅 (taxes) Has been read as 穴 (cave, hollow) and 遂 (progress, channels, administrative processes, institutional conduits, responses). I wonder if it could be 逸 (to flee). 兌/兌 means joy, delight, open a passage, hole/cave. I speculate that this running happy talker is enthusiasm, outward-seeking adventure? “Open passages”, through which one could walk, be it a hole or some sort of entrance/exit, resonates most convincingly with 𠄎. See B:6. I treat this as “open passages.” Character is damaged but still definitely 逆.

²⁹⁰ zi.tools has this as 賽, though see B:6. Originally a ritual/offering of thanks to the spirits or tutelary deity for prosperity, but also “compete, rival”. 賽, the precursor to 塞, means “to obstruct, stop-up, restrain, fill, supply.”

²⁹¹ 𠄎 Fire over something, may just be 光. Wiktionary lists several plausible variants (𠄎, 𠄎, 𠄎, 𠄎)

²⁹² 同(𠄎) in 𠄎, precisely how zi.tools has it. Wiktionary has 迴 as synonymous with 通 (pass through, pass along, thoroughly, unobstructed, transmit, communicate, have access to). Zi.tools, citing the Shuowen Jiezi, defines this as 迭 (to alternate, change), but also as meaning “通達” (to understand, be reasonable, thoroughly understand).

²⁹³ 𠄎. Duplication mark (=) present, though some think this is an error. This duplication can be for emphasis, which is how I translate it. Usually translated to 慎 (cautious, quiet, vigilant, attentive). However, 𠄎 → 𠄎 in the Shuowen is the same as 慎. The only evidence I’ve seen so far that 斷=慎 is from Mawangdui and WangBi. Henricks has 誓 (to swear; but see 𠄎 in Wiktionary, zi.tools has this as 𠄎斤言女). 斷 itself means “happiness”. Following A:15, I use 慎; the etymology is not very convincing to me, but “happiness” doesn’t make sense. (See also A:6/C:4).

²⁹⁴ Or, “Thoroughly understand one’s vigilance” or “Alternate one’s attention.”

(劉)²⁹⁵其(繫)²⁹⁶,

Slaughter/kill its/their entanglements/binds/strings

Slaughter one's entangling,

(解)²⁹⁷其(紛),

Untie/loosen/release/dissect/remove/liberate/dissolve its/their tangled-threads/bewilderment/confusion

Release one's confusing knotted threads,

是(胃/謂)玄同。

This stomach//called translucent/mysterious/unknowable/dim/murky sharing/sameness/join

This is called mysterious joining.²⁹⁸

(古/故)不可(得/得)(天/而)²⁹⁹新³⁰⁰,

Old/ancient//thus not possible obtain/gain heaven//yet/and/but/?? new/fresh

As a result, it is not possible to obtain and yet be new,

亦不可(得/得)而(足/足)³⁰¹;

In-this-case/too/then not possible obtain/gain legs/sufficiency/match/equal/correct/upright

And it is also not possible to obtain and yet be sufficient.

不可(得/得)(天/而)(利/利)³⁰²,

Not possible obtain heaven//yet/and/but sharp/smooth/benefit/abundance/cleverness/swift/profit

It is not possible to obtain and yet have benefit,

亦不可(得/得)而(害/害)³⁰³;

In-this-case/too/then not possible obtain yet/and/but misuse/abuse/harm/destroy

And it is also not possible to obtain and yet be abused.

²⁹⁵ 劉 Zi.tools and Henricks has 畜 to the left of 刃. Domestic animals / livestock next to a knife: perhaps

“slaughter”? May be equivalent to 劉 (kill, slaughter), though perhaps 留 (remain; 留) should be considered, probably not. WangBi and DaoIsOpen has 挫, zi.tools agrees, but evidence for this seems to be the Mawangdui.

²⁹⁶ Original appears to be 尔 over 賈, Cook, Henricks and zi.tools agree. (The top part should perhaps be 尔 instead, but this is equivalent). Cook lists that it could be equivalent to 嬰(necklace→encircle, bound, surround, suffer) or 櫻(damage, harm, unsettle, attack) or 纓(strings, cords, enwrap). It bears the same components as 賈 over 爾 (though in the wrong orientation), seeming to mean 遂 (progress, to further, succeed, achieve, respond, comply). 賈 itself means a string of beads. From here some that Cook cite relate this to “entanglement” (like 縈 from CRY, 嬰 from LXF) WQP sees this as a variant of 覲 (who has the components in reverse); they think it is a variant for 邇 (nearby, easy, simple, read as “advancement” (?)) but following this thread I would have looked at 覲 (considered variant of 診 (medically examine/diagnose, investigate) or 覲/覲 (painstaking detail)). Going by the graphical evidence, I will not speculate which of these characters this is, but will translate it as “entanglements/binds/strings”

²⁹⁷ Technically 阜 left of 刃 in zi.tools, a rearrangement of components

²⁹⁸ By isolating oneself, one becomes mysterious, and thus shares commonalities with the Dao? Or joins with it?

²⁹⁹ In this section, 天 and 而 look VERY similar. 天 tends to be less curly or less angled down. However, I use 而 throughout due to grammar.

³⁰⁰ Technically 木 over 辛 to the left of 斤 under zi.tools and actually: 𣎵

³⁰¹ I initially called this 足, but Cook renders 疋 and it's nearly the same, thankfully also likely right to mean

leg/foot. These look identical to me outside of the fact that this character's top part is more rounded off. (彳 vs 彳)

³⁰² Not the same form as A:1, see also A:13, where the notch is on the bottom.

³⁰³ Technically 害 above-ish 又, according to zi.tools, and I agree: 𠂔. This does not resemble the character in C:1 at all. Neither Cook nor Henricks mention this hand component. Perhaps the hand component signifies direct action

不可(得/得)而(貴/貴),

Not possible obtain yet/and/but expensive/valuable/costly/value

It is not possible to obtain and yet be valued,

亦可³⁰⁴不可(得/得)而(戔/殘³⁰⁵殘)。

In-this-case/too/then possible not possible obtain yet/and/but tiny-tiny//kill/wipe-out/decay/ruthless

And yet, is it possible or not to obtain and yet be utterly destroyed?

(古/故)為天下(貴/貴)³⁰⁶。

Old/ancient//Therefore, manipulate/use/act-as/do under-heaven expensive/costly/valuable/valued.

So, using the world is costly.³⁰⁷

A:15 Commentary:

It is not likely that the Guodian is advocating for a vow of silence (forcing oneself not to communicate at all would be unnatural) – rather, I think this is talking about the insane classification/word/theory/record culture that most of the nobility would consider "knowledge". For this reason I translate “people of words” rather than “people who talk” or “talking people”; “people of words” have made themselves about the words, have lost themselves in the words.

Likewise, the obtaining is also not absolute. One can certainly obtain a fresh apple and have it be sufficient to sate hunger; the kind of gaining that cannot be new and sufficient are social, political, societal. By shutting out that part of life and society, chasing favor and prestige and control, one cannot benefit from it but also cannot be harmed by it. Isolation is safety, but sacrificing the gains one could gamble on by playing the societal game. The Guodian clearly has an opinion about whether these gains are worth it: they very much are not. The selves that chase it lose more than their gains are worth.

Closing off the open passages and shutting (and defending) one’s gates is enforcing this isolation, keeping trouble out, not entertaining strangers or guests, not opening oneself up to be seen and heard. To balance one’s brightness means to be successful but not conspicuously so. A bright light turns heads. Dim the light to pass by unnoticed, not getting recognition or fame but also not drawing jealousy, envy, or the eyes of danger. Of course be skillful and do your best, but don’t become so bright and so outstanding as to become the center of attention.

As for the attention, or vigilance, or caution, translating this line gives a few possibilities. To alternate this would be to stay aware of multiple things, never getting distracted by focusing too hard on one thing. To pass through this, most likely extreme caution, is to regulate between being complacent and paranoid, balance vigilance so that it is adaptive but does not strangle or cease to exist. To thoroughly

³⁰⁴ It’s on the slips. Not sure why it is often left off. Cook seems to think this was an accident. This could, instead, pose a strong rhetorical question for the finale of the chapter.

³⁰⁵ Really the 戈 are to the left and right of each other, not stacked up-down. This can mean tiny, or apparent if reduplicated, but it was also the original form of 殘: destroy, wipe out, kill, harm, injure, damage, ruthless, merciless, cruel, and also fade away, wither, decompose, dim, incomplete.

³⁰⁶ The first instance had wings on the middle component, this one does not.

³⁰⁷ 為 can also be used as a ditransitive beneficiary construction, according to Kroll, making this sentence, “Therefore, [this] for the world is valuable/precious.” For the received, Linnell translates this to “Therefore, you become valuable to the world.” Lau, Chan, Henricks, Lin, and Cleary all translate similarly. Waley, Feng & English, Wu, and Henricks (“noblest”) translates “highest” thing in the world. However, this is inconsistent with how I’ve used 為 in the rest of the project. Both could work: This could be an argument on how valuable the “mysterious joining” is to the world, but I find it more convincing that, especially for the Guodian, this is more of an argument that going after “gain”, the achievements and disaster, is costly, not only to oneself, but to the whole world that it runs. My initial translation was “Therefore, using the world is costly”, and hesitantly, I choose to keep it.

understand it would likely have a similar meaning as going through it, or a mix between the two possibilities I offered.

Slaughtering entanglements and releasing knotted threads is eliminating the connections to the prestige-chasing that have already been established, ensuring one is truly free of that destructive world of status, power, wealth, and fame. This does not mean detaching from everything in the world; after all, one still has at least a gate to close, and the Guodian has expressed importance of protecting the “dependents” (A:1). Certainly cutting those ropes would not be consistent with protecting them. All of this removal of oneself from the entanglements, complicated tangled threads, vigilant of any trouble that could get one sucked back in, and closing opportunities for these to invite themselves in easily, one can join with something else. Through this, one achieves the “mysterious joining.”

What is the “mysterious joining?” To be honest, this is not so clear to me, though I have ideas. It could be, by cutting oneself off from society’s expected ambitions, one joins with mysteriousness because one becomes mysterious, one becomes hard to see, hard to get a read on. Alternatively, one joins with the mysterious in that one connects more deeply with the Dao, through connecting more deeply with their own nature, their own native values. One shakes off the artificial categories and scripted social to-do lists and comes back into their own skin. Perhaps it is mysterious because it does not rely on words, or names, or recognition, or reputation; it relies on knowing what they don’t. Perhaps it is both simultaneously, two perspectives from either side of the closed gate.

One cannot obtain wealth, favor, fame, or power by being both completely new or fresh and being sufficient. The new interesting, shiny person on the scene is not the experienced person who has enough skill and means to navigate it. Similarly, one is not truly reaping a benefit if the cost of that benefit is abuse. Is the benefit really a benefit if the cost is so painful and steep? Similarly, can one really be valued if one is utterly destroyed? If the process of obtaining, in order to be someone of high value, destroys someone, is someone who is in shambles, regardless of what they managed to achieve, high-value? In trying to obtain, one defeats the purpose. In trying to manipulate the world to get further, one loses more and more of oneself: is that truly a gain?

Received 56 (A:15)

知者不言,

Know people not speak/words, Speak/words people not know

People of knowing do not speak, people of words do not know.

塞其兌,閉其門³⁰⁸

Block it/its open-passages/joy/delight, close/obstruct it/its gates

Block one’s open passages, close one’s gates,

挫其銳,解其紛

Crush/humble/weaken its sharpness/ precision, Untie/loosen/release one’s tangled-threads/confusion

Crush one’s precision, release one’s confusing knotted threads,

和其光,同其塵

Harmonize/balance/peace one’s brightness/glory/luster joins/sameness/unites its dust/mundane/worldly

Balance one’s brightness, unite with one’s dust.

是謂玄同³⁰⁹

This is-called mysterious sameness/join/unite/share

This is called mysterious joining.

³⁰⁸ After this until the next 故, Mawangdui’s order resembles the Guodian more—see the footnotes for that section.

³⁰⁹ Mawangdui aligns with Wang Bi again after this point.

故不可得而親

Therefore not possible/permissible/can obtain/gain and/but/yet parents/kin/intimate

Therefore it is not possible to gain and be close like family

不可得而疏

Not possible/permissible/can obtain/gain and/yet/but wide-apart/separated/estranged/ignore

It is not possible to gain and be estranged.

不可得而利

Not possible/permissible/can obtain/gain and/yet benefit/sharp/smooth/abundance

It is not possible to gain and have benefit,

不可得而害

Not possible/permissible/can obtain/gain and/yet harm/destroy

It is not possible to gain and have harm.

不可得而貴

Not possible/permissible/can obtain/gain and/yet/but value/costly/precious

It is not possible to gain and be valuable,

不可得而賤³¹⁰

Not possible/permissible/can obtain/gain and/yet cheap/lowly/insignificant/lacking/disrespect

It is not possible to gain and be cheap.

故為天下貴³¹¹

Thus/therefore/as-a-result for/use/act-as under-heaven/world precious/costly/valuable

Therefore for the world it is valuable.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing:

In the received, “crush one’s sharpness/acute/precision” and “join with one’s dust/mundanity” is introduced, while “slaughter one’s entangling” and “pass through one’s extreme caution (see above)” is lost. Again, the received seems to bring wording in to actively lessen one’s skill, ability, awareness, or knowledge (A:1, to a lesser degree A:5), and join with one’s dust could have an implication of reduction of the self (A:13).

The meaning of both the received and the Guodian may change depending how one reads 得 (obtain/gain) here: as just obtaining (having some kind of gain of wealth, fame, power, etc.) or as obtaining *it* (it being the “mysterious joining”). This single choice decides whether the chapter’s final line reads as praise for the “mysterious joining” (“Therefore [it] is precious to the world”) or as a warning about the using the world for this gain (“Therefore using the world is costly/ comes at a cost.”). I favor the latter direction, for reasons I will outline below:

First, we should consider the grammar. The Guodian has the particle 亦³¹² (in this case, too, then) joining the pairs of “not possible” phrases, showing that the conditions contradict one another; one cannot be totally new and already sufficient, or be abused and benefit, or be valued and utterly destroyed (at least not meaningfully), in this pursuit of “gain.” If 得 referred to obtaining the mysterious joining

³¹⁰ Mawangdui A has 淺 (shallow, superficial)

³¹¹ Linnell translates this to “Therefore, you become valuable to the world.” Lau, Chan, Henricks, Lin, and Cleary all translate similarly. Waley, Feng & English, Wu, and Henricks (“noblest”) translates “highest” thing in the world.

³¹² The received lacks this 亦 in some reproductions (although Henricks includes it in the WangBi just as it is in the Guodian and Mawangdui, but Chinese Text Project and Linnell’s work omits it), and so while 得 could still be general “gain”, it is likely that those looking versions that lack 亦 may read it slightly differently.

specifically, I would expect a particle like 之 or 其 to make it clear there was a defined direct object, especially one already mentioned. There are no such particles in this part of the chapter. This does not rule out the possibility that gaining the “mysterious joining” was the intention, but in my eyes makes it less likely.

Second, even setting grammar aside, reading 得 as obtaining the “mysterious joining” becomes confusing quickly. In this case, then obtaining mysterious joining would not be compatible with sufficiency, or benefit (The translation of one line would be “It is not possible to gain [mysterious joining] and be sufficient” for instance). Sufficiency is a central value of the Guodian (see A:3, A:18); a state of being that makes it impossible to have “mysterious joining” and sufficiency would not be a desirable outcome, or even a coherent chapter closing point. The gates are closed and brightness dimmed, entanglements removed, life simplified, presumably to achieve this safe sufficiency. This reading is just not viable for the Guodian translation.

One of the differences between how I translated the Guodian and how the received is normally translated is in this line: 故為天下貴. Taking 為 as “to do, to use, to manipulate, to act as”, as I have done throughout the translation, this line becomes “Therefore, using/manipulating the world is costly/valuable,” or “Therefore, acting as the world is valuable,” but this second option is more of a stretch, at least for the Guodian, after going through the harms of getting involved for the purpose of gain. 貴 can be translated as prized and precious (as is most often the case in this translation), but also as expensive and costly. “Valuable” covers both aspects of this: one can praise its worth or grumble about its cost. After a list of what one must endure in seeking “gain” (cannot be both new and also sufficient, cannot be both beneficial and also abused, cannot be valuable and also destroyed), it would be an unlikely tonal shift to call this state of affairs valuable to the world – if anything, this section just outlined the inherent risk and damage to oneself and potentially the world as well.

The received does not have asymmetric contradictions in the 得 section, but mere antonyms: intimate vs estranged, expensive vs cheap, benefit vs harm. In context, this could paint one who has obtained the “mysterious joining” as someone who transcended and escaped these categorizations entirely. Instead of coming off as a list of injuries inherent to “gain”, this section becomes a description of becoming outside of these binary judgments, a much more airy, mystical reading. For this reason, 得 could refer to just “gain” (of fame, wealth, power, favor, etc.) or gaining the “mysterious joining” because the structure of the received (symmetric antonyms) does not produce the same contradictions as the Guodian, reading as more of a transcendence of categories than a warning about the costs of chasing gain. For this reason, and for the reason that the received tends to lack the amount of particles (like 之) that earlier versions like the Guodian and Mawangdui have anyways, I read 得 as most likely meaning “gaining the mysterious joining” and 貴 in its more precious connotation.

Guodian (A:16)

以(𠄎/正)之³¹³邦,

By-means-of correct/proper/rectify ['s]/this/to-go state/country

Go to the state by means of correctness,

以(𠄎/奇)³¹⁴(甬/用)(𠄎/兵),

By-means-of uncommon-warfare(?) bell//employ weapons

Employ weapons by means of strangeness.

以(𠄎/亡)³¹⁵事(𠄎/使)³¹⁶天下

By-means-of lack/no business/serve/matters employ/dispatch/allow-action under heaven.

Authorize the world by means of lacking affairs,³¹⁷

(虐/吾)可以智其然³¹⁸也。

I/me possible by-means-of know its be-like-this/be-so

It is possible for me to know the natural way of these things.

夫天多(𠄎/期)³¹⁹(𠄎/韋/違)³²⁰,

Anyone/in-any-case heaven many/much/exceed term/date/promise/expect/certainly leather//wayward

In any case, Heaven has much waywardness with its appointments,

而民(𠄎/爾)(𠄎/畔/叛)³²¹。

And/yet/but people such/you/that/so³²² boundaries/limit/alongside//betray/contradict/rebel

And the people are that rebellious.³²³

³¹³ I nearly never translate 之 as a verb, but there's no choice here. This means "to go" (Cook has "manage").

³¹⁴ 奇 to the left of 戈 this goes for the whole chapter (zi.tools agrees). 奇 itself means singular, uncommon, strange, rare, remarkable, deviating (as the antonym of 正). With the dagger-axe component, perhaps there is something weird in a combat or military sense, just as 畸 means irregular plot of land, 倚 is to lean against, incline, or rely on, 謔 means playful or false talk, and 跛 means limping, lame, or one-legged.

³¹⁵ Normally looks like 𠄎. No one mentions the cross abnormality (accident?). This may be 甲 (𠄎, 𠄎) (meaning "Sheath/shell/armor/first-rate/first-in-sequence", but elsewhere in the Guodian (A:14) it is expressed as 𠄎.

³¹⁶ Listed in zi.tools under 取, under 取 (take ear (of enemy) → seize/capture/acquire; which zi.tools says is the Chu meaning), possibly meaning 取→使 (dispatch, commission, send on an errand, carry a message, cause, employ, allow unrestricted action), or 聚 (gather, assemble). Shuowen jiezi, through zi.tools, defines 取 as 使.

³¹⁷ Alternatively, taking 𠄎 as 甲 "By means of first affairs, allow freedom of action to the world," or taking 甲 as a metonymy for soldiers (see Kroll) and 取 instead of 使, "By means of soldier matters take the world." I think this reading is unlikely because weapons were mentioned in the line above, and correctness, strangeness, and absentness make three distinct categories. While 𠄎, depicting an ear, a hand, and lines above it representing a stick or tool, could be "take", I think it is more likely this is 使 (carrying something to an ear, maybe?) in the messenger or agent sense of the word "dispatch" (not to kill). With "dispatch" having some meanings of killing, and "sending off/sending forth" or "allow unrestricted action" potentially being vague, I translate as "authorize". While I am reluctant to assume 𠄎 is just 亡, 亡 would be consistent with other parts of the Guodian, and "shell/armor matters" or "sheath matters" or "first (in a sequence) matters" is harder to understand. Additionally, the stroke order and orientation makes it plausible to produce 𠄎 trying to write 𠄎, if one started the horizontal stroke too far back.

³¹⁸ Actually 𠄎, which is 然 without the fire radical on bottom. This is the case for the entirety of the Guodian.

³¹⁹ Technically 日 over 丌 by zi.tools, under 期 (𠄎). Wiktionary has this, as 晃, a variant of 光 (so does zi.tools 晃).

³²⁰ The original form of 圍 (circumference, surround, enclosure) may be 韋 (Wiktionary), though Baoshan Chu has 𠄎. By Kroll, 韋 was also used in place of 違 (turn against, wayward, disobey)

³²¹ Technically 半 over 田, zi.tools agrees. An early form of 叛, could also be 𠄎.

³²² See Pulleyblank's "Outline of Classical Chinese Grammar," page 90.

³²³ Or, reading 畔 as is instead of as an early form of 叛, "And the people are so limited/within-boundaries."

民多(𠂔/利³²⁴)(𠂔/器)

Common-people many/exceed benefit/smooth/sharp instruments

The common people have many beneficial instruments,

而邦(𡇗/慈³²⁵)(𡇗/昏³²⁶)。

And/yet/but state/country tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence dim-and-confused

And yet the state is dim and confused from loving kindness.

人多智而(𡇗/奇)³²⁷(勿/物)(慈)(𡇗/起)³²⁸。

People exceed/many knowledge and/yet/but strange/uncommon things merciful-care rise/help-up/raise

People know much and yet weird things are raised up by loving kindness.

(𡇗/灋³²⁹/法)(勿/物)(慈)(𡇗/章)

Lawful/rules/normal things benevolent/loving decoration/insignia/illustrate/model

Lawful things are emblazoned with loving kindness,

(𡇗/覩)(𡇗³³⁰/惻)多(又/有)。

Gazing-from-afar sorrow/pain exceed/many have/exist

Gazing from afar in sorrow is plenty.

是以聖人之(𡇗/言)曰：

This by-means-of sage [’s]/this words say

By means of this, the sage’s words are said:

我(𡇗/無)事而民自(𡇗/富)³³¹。

I no/lack affairs/serve yet/but/and people themselves rich/wealthy

“I have no matters, yet the people are rich by themselves.

我亡為而民自(𡇗/逵)³³²。

I lack/no do/use/manipulate and/yet/but people themselves curve/wind/meander/approach-indirectly

I lack manipulation, and yet the people themselves wind their way there.

我好(𡇗/青)而民自正。

I good/excellent/agreeable/to-like green and/yet/but people themselves correct/proper/rectify

I’m agreeably green as a thriving plant, and yet the people correct themselves.

我(谷/欲)不(谷/欲)而民自(𡇗/樸)³³³。

I want not want yet/but/and people themselves plain/sincere/honest/unpolished/unworked-wood

I want the unwanted, and yet the people themselves are unadulterated.”

³²⁴ See A:15, where the notch is on top, not the same form of 利 found in A:1. This could be translated as “sharp”, meaning the people have many/ too many sharp instruments, but 利 is almost always translated as “benefit.”

³²⁵ Technically 𡇗 over 心. Usually translated as 慈 (tenderness, loving-kindness, merciful care, benevolence)

³²⁶ See B:5, I translate this as dim and confused

³²⁷ Different: the top left component is reduced to a horizontal line. In zi.tools this is 𡇗→𡇗, a wooden stake

³²⁸ Actually 𡇗 around 己, confirmed by zi.tools. Both Henricks and Cook have 𡇗 below 己, probably a different form of the same. On the slips it superficially already looks like 起: rise, stand up, prosper, begin, help up, lift, heal.

³²⁹ Technically 夫 to the left of 鴈 all over 水

³³⁰ See A:1. Listed as 鼎 to the left of 丿 in 勺 all over 心 in zi.tools, though it’s technically 鼎 over 心.

³³¹ 𡇗 Listed in zi.tools as 𡇗 over 酉 over 示. Could be 備, could be 福. 富 seems to also mean 福 or 富. The 富 in A:20 (𡇗) meaning “opulence” only lacks 𡇗 on top. The older meaning is “rich/wealthy”, which supports the roof.

³³² 為 over 𡇗 (by both Henricks and Cook. Zi.tools has 為(same as 為) over 𡇗, → 逵. Shuowen Jiezi supports.

³³³ 𡇗 Compare with A:5 (𡇗), not the same Originally 木 to the left of 𡇗 over 臣.

A:16 Commentary:

This is definitely one of the stranger chapters of the Guodian, so much of what I write in this section is tentative and less sure than usual.

Using regular, proper, typical behavior to enter “the state”, perhaps meaning politics and government, but using unusual, strange, unique behavior in combat are two methods that bring success in different contexts. The Guodian offers the third pairing, succeeding in letting the world operate itself (like sending off a messenger to deliver a message, trusting they will, by their own free will, do as they should without having to police or even oversee it at all) by lacking affairs (probably – see the footnotes about 甲). In my opinion most likely through observation and experience, the narrator (“I”) can know how these things go through acknowledging these different approaches to different successes.

The next section of this chapter discusses the problems with, or despite having much (多) or with excess.

My initial reading was that Heaven had many appointed enclosures, and I will discuss that alternative first. Although Heaven has many appointed places, the people still rebel. Heaven, often referred to as responsible for directing and ruling over earth and man, has such a huge range and yet does not prevent disorder below. (alternatively, if 畔 is read as-is rather than as an ancient form of 叛, the people are limited and within boundaries despite the expansiveness of Heaven.) However, upon reading with 違 rather than 圍 (as 韋 may be an early form of both or either), Heaven itself becomes something of a contrarian, disobeying dates and expectations. Perhaps this is in reference to unseasonable weather (for example, hot days too early in spring, cold days in summer, not enough or too much rain, or rain at the wrong times, etc.). Perhaps the wayward nature of Heaven is reflected in the rebellious nature of the people. Perhaps this waywardness is a characteristic of the Dao, resisting artificial classifications and answering only to its own nature. If Heaven is ruled by or modeled after the Dao (which it does/is, A:11), perhaps this is the origin of the wild, unruly nature of nature.

The common people have lots of beneficial technology –indeed, advancements in technology and better tools could enable the people to do great and productive things for themselves and their communities. Despite this, their leaders, their governors and politicians, are fumbling, confused and overly doting and lenient, and so unable to manage the unintended consequences of otherwise beneficial tools. Despite the people being wise or knowing many things, they still fall for weird, unique, perhaps “trendy” ideas and cherish and dote on them inappropriately. People who have access to knowledge, people who should know better, still become enamored by silly things. “Loving kindness” (慈) is detrimental if not judiciously applied, and even many benefits (tools, knowledge, places for Heaven to be), do not necessarily lead to the positive outcomes one might assume. While these standardized, “lawful” things (things that set the rules or law, see its use in A:11) are emblazoned with the same loving kindness, the discernment is gone, and the gazing afar in sorrow (envy, jealousy, worry) is therefore in no short supply.

If one reads 多 as “to exceed”, which one may, a different interpretation of this chapter may emerge. One could then read Heaven as exceeding their appointed enclosures, and the people’s rebelling in the way they do mirrors this or is a result of this (or people are limited and stuck within boundaries as a result of heaven’s expansiveness). The common people having too many beneficial instruments, or exceeding their purposes, is paired with the confused and tender state that cannot bring themselves to bring the chaos arising from good inventions to order. The excessive knowledge of people is the root of their tender elevation of strange ideas. In the Guodian, knowledge (智) is treated as a good thing, a necessary thing. Here, this “excessive knowledge” (if this indeed is the intended meaning) pertains to the rare and strange, and its subsequent increase in value. This gained awareness of these novelties just confuse the people—they are learning and knowing about the wrong kind of things, perhaps leading

them to the dazzling confusion that is favor chasing and power games (B:4). This would be an artificial knowing, not a knowing from genuine insight and observation as advocated for in A:1. This same excessive knowledge is the source of their gazing in sorrow at what they do not have, in a world where the rules that enable such excesses are celebrated and beloved. I present my translation using “much/many” over “exceed” because I usually translate 多 this way, but in my eyes, both readings work, and I won’t claim to know which was intended.

In the next section, the sage, realizing the limits to the abundance, discusses what is possible without it. They don't have matters to assign, yet the people are not in need. They do not manipulate them, and so they naturally figure themselves out. They are green, perhaps pliable like a green stem and not rigid and hard like mature wood, and yet the people are straight and correct. They want what others don't, and the people remain uncontaminated by their desires. The sage's own desire for the unwanted creates a kind of field where the plain and genuine can exist without being competed over or classified as desirable³³⁴. It is perhaps worth noting that the sage is being directly quoted here, somewhat unusual for the Guodian that normally just describes their conduct.

Received 57 (A:16)

以正治國³³⁵, 以奇³³⁶用兵

By-means-of correct/proper govern/control/harness country, by-means-of strange/rare employ weapons
Govern the country through propriety, use weapons through strangeness.

以無事取天下

By-means-of no/lack matters/business/to-serve take/seize/capture under-heaven
Take the world through a lack of affairs.

吾何以知其然{也}哉³³⁷, 以此

I/my [how/why by-means-of]/how know its/it be-like-this/be-so? [Emphasis] By-means-of this/these:
How do I know it is like this? By means of this:

天³³⁸下多忌諱

Under-heaven many/exceeds/multiply antipathy/aversion/taboo/hostile/hateful avoid/taboo/avoid-word
The world has many aversions and taboos,

而民彌貧

And/yet/but common-people permeate/complete/spread-out/even-more poor/impooverished/scarce
And the common people are even more poor.³³⁹

³³⁴ Alternatively 我(谷/欲)不(谷/欲) can translate to “Do I want? Yet the people are unadulterated.” Or “I want not to want [...]” I don’t believe the meaning changes drastically with these, though the last one is harsh on desires.

³³⁵ Mawangdui A has 邦, state.

³³⁶ Both Mawangdui have 畸

³³⁷ Mawangdui A has the current character without 口, Mawangdui B has 才

³³⁸ Both Mawangdui have 夫 in front of this line.

³³⁹ Most translations translate this as “The more [avoidances/taboo/etc.] in the world there are, the poorer the people will become” or some form of this (Waley, Lin, Cleary, Feng & English, Wu, Lau, Chan, Henricks). Only Linnell and I, to my knowledge, translate this as parallel statements rather than causative or correlative. This pattern persists throughout so that by most translations, the increased skill and crafts of the people lead to the rise of strange/rare things, the sharp/beneficial tools cause the dimness of the government, rules and orders cause crime.

民多利³⁴⁰器

Common-people many/much/exceed sharp/smooth/beneficial instruments

The common people have many beneficial tools,

{而} 國家滋³⁴¹昏

[And/yet/but] country (and) family (or state-people) / increase/moist confused-and-dim

And the governing people become increasingly dim and confused.

人多伎³⁴²巧

Common-people much/many/exceed skill/craft/geisha/perform skill/craftsmanship

The common people have many crafts and skills,

{而} 奇物滋起

[And/yet/but] strange/rare/heterodox things increase/moist rise/get-up/helped

And strange things increasingly rise up.

法令³⁴³滋彰

Law/standard/rule command/respected/enable/order increase/moist evident/decorated/signal/display

Rules and orders are increasingly signaled,

盜賊多有

Thievishness/stealing outlaw/villainy/murder many/more/exceed have/exist

Thievery and villainy increasingly exist.

故聖人云

Therefore sage says

Therefore the sage says

我無為而民自化

I lack/without/no act/do/use/manipulate and/yet common-people self transform/change/convert

“I lack manipulation, and the people convert themselves

我好³⁴⁴靜而民自正

I excellent/pleasant/to-like still/motionless and/yet/but common-people self correct/rectify

I am excellently still, and the people correct themselves.

我無事而民自富

I lack/without business/to-serve/matters yet/but common-people self abundant/wealthy/rich

I have no matters, and the people are rich by themselves.

我無欲而民自樸

I lack/without desire yet/but common-people self unworked-wood/simple/plain/honest

I lack desires, and the people are genuine by themselves.”

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The first major difference between the Guodian and Chapter 57 of the received is perhaps a result of my own translational decisions. In the Guodian, I elected for 使 to mean 使, following the Shuowen Jiezi, and noting the difference in the right component from the

³⁴⁰ Only Cleary, to my knowledge, translates this as “crafts”, I put “beneficial tools”. Lau and Linnell have “sharpened tools”. Nearly all others put “sharp weapons” (Wu, Chan, Henricks, Waley, Lin, Feng & English)

³⁴¹ Mawangdui A has 茲 everywhere this occurs.

³⁴² Mawangdui A has 知 and lacks 巧

³⁴³ Mawangdui B has 物, and 章 in place of 彰

³⁴⁴ Most translators (Linnell, Henricks, Wu, Lau, Chan, Waley, Lin, Cleary, and Feng & English) all translated this as “to like, to prefer, fond of”. I translate it as excellent, pleasant, agreeable, consistent with my translation in Chapter 30 “excellent at” or “does [verb] well.”

hand alone (手/又) to hand holding something (手/又/支). The received seems to have gone with the reading of only the hand, resulting in 取 (whose etymology, according to *zi.tools*, may be a hand and an ear, symbolizing taking the ears of the enemy, presumably after vanquishing them). The result is that “to dispatch, to send on an errand, send as messenger, to allow unrestricted action” becomes the much more possessive and dominating “take, seize, capture.” In this way, the lack of matters becomes a way of seizing the world, rather than allowing it to move freely in its assigned purpose.

Some substitutions occur in the next section, which are interesting. Rather than the many disobediences (or enclosures) of Heaven being paired with the rebellious (or limited?) nature of the common people, the section opens with a world full of aversions and taboos, things to be avoided and not to say, and this is paired with the people becoming poorer. The contrastive reading (like “heaven has many places, yet the people are limited/hemmed in) for the received does not work, as these social restrictions and prohibitions would not be expected to lead to abundance. The causative reading (like “heaven has many places, so the people are rebellious/limited”) may make more sense, that making so many things forbidden drives the people into poverty. Most mainstream translations treat these pairs as causative (see footnote in Chapter 57). It could also be read as parallel: there are more and more prohibitions, and as this is happening, the people are becoming poorer – maybe a comment on the lack of awareness of those who decide and enforce these taboos. The beneficial tools (or sharp tools/weapons, as this is often translated, but I retain “beneficial tools” for consistency in translation despite this being a minority position; see footnote in Chapter 57) and dim and confused government remains the same between the Guodian and received. However, instead of knowledge being paired with the rise of strange/rare things, the received points to the skill and crafts of the people, not their knowledge. If these are indeed causative/blame statements, which is how most translations seem to treat these pairs, even the efficient and productive conduct is being blamed for strangeness, or even heterodoxy. Instead of things of the law being linked to further misery linked to the gazing afar of the Guodian, the received describes more laws and orders being signaled out as linked to increasing lawlessness, using the same characters that appear in A:1/Chapter 19. Perhaps the more things one makes against the rules, the more people break them or are considered to be breaking them, or despite the efforts of the government to control the people through laws, it is ineffective in reducing their violent and greedy behavior.

The words of the sage occur in different orders between the Guodian and received versions, and have key differences. The sage’s lack of affairs in the Guodian and in the received is paired with the wealth or abundance enjoyed by the people. The sage’s lack of manipulation (WuWei) is paired with the people winding up as they should be on their own in the Guodian, but leads to transformation or conversion in the received. The difference between these two things may not be very great, but there is a difference: the Guodian uses a movement word, 𠂔, action (doing, using, etc.) over two crawling creatures, meaning winding or curving. The people are taking not a straight path there, but still getting there. The received seems to focus not on the way the people move, but changing them. The people are corrected or rectified by the sage’s being “green” (perhaps flexible like a new shoot of a plant before it becomes woody) in the Guodian, but by the sage’s stillness in the received, another place where the received gives power to motionlessness where the Guodian does not (A:5, A:7, A:13). The people being simple, plain, honest, or like unprocessed wood is paired with the sage wanting the unwanted (or wanting not to want) in the Guodian, but by the total lack of desires in the received, another example of the received being harsher on desires than the Guodian (A:7).

Guodian (A:17)

(𩚑/含³⁴⁵)(𩚑/惠³⁴⁶/德)之(𩚑/厚)³⁴⁷(𩚑/者)³⁴⁸,

Bitter/drinking virtue/power [‘s]/this thick/deep/sincere [person/phrase-end],

Someone who drinks the thickness of virtue³⁴⁹

(𩚑/比)(𩚑/於)³⁵⁰(𩚑/赤)³⁵¹子,

Compare/parallel/duplicate/alike/align/close-to at/in/than [blood-red/exposed child]/newborn³⁵²

Is alike to a newborn baby.

𩚑³⁵³(𩚑/萬蟲)³⁵⁴(𩚑³⁵⁵/它)(𩚑/弗)(𩚑/螫³⁵⁶/蠚),

Venomous(snake?) ten-thousand swarming other/another/snake not sting/venom/pain

Venomous, myriad, swarming bugs and snakes do not sting or bite,

(𩚑³⁵⁷/攫)(𩚑/鳥)(𩚑/獸)³⁵⁸(𩚑/獸/守)弗(𩚑/扣³⁵⁹),

Seize/catch//fearfully-vigilant bird satisfied/sated beast/wild-animal/hunt//defend(ers) not strike

Birds of prey and well-fed guardians do not strike,

³⁴⁵ 𩚑 Zi.tools has “bitter alcohol” or “bitter”. I’m not convinced that 含 is meant, as this shows up in the Guodian in a much different form 𩚑. Through Cook, LRH explains that 含 can be read as “strong” or “full” of alcohol, and suggests that this character, as well as 含, and 飲, may mean “full” or “deep”. 今, according to Wiktionary, means “something in mouth” or “not to speak”, and zi.tools has it as the initial form of chanting (bitterly?), or a bowed head with the tongue sticking out. This could be is an early form of 飲 (drink), evidence is convincing.

³⁴⁶ 𩚑. 惠 according to Henricks, see B:8

³⁴⁷ 𩚑, in zi.tools as 石 over 臺 for 厚, just as in A:2 (𩚑). Compare to A:3 (𩚑→heavy), and the mystery character pair in A:18 (𩚑/𩚑). Originally 石 over 毛 by Cook (and I agree) (zi.tools redirects this to 石 over 臺 for 厚—Henricks has 厚. 石 (stone) over 臺 (fortified wall, city wall, outline), or 石 over 毛 (fur). Meaning thick, deep, richly, etc.

³⁴⁸ There is a lot of variation in this 者 character. Perhaps the shape indicates something specific? (𩚑, 𩚑)

³⁴⁹ More gracefully, perhaps “One who drinks of virtue deeply.” Virtue is drunk, absorbed, taken in, rather than simply owned or stored. One drinks (water or alcohol), and either made hydrated or intoxicated.

³⁵⁰ 𩚑→𩚑→烏 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) 𩚑→於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

³⁵¹ Extra line (𩚑 vs 𩚑), probably nothing

³⁵² 赤子 together means “newborn child”, according to Kroll and Wiktionary.

³⁵³ 𩚑. 由 over 虫 according to Cook and Henricks. Bizarrely, zi.tools has this under 胃 over 虫 (I think it should be 鬼 or 禺 over 虫.) Cook says could be 蠅 (pupa, chrysalis), 蠍 (→𩚑, venomous snake) 蜃 (hedgehog), 蜂 (bee/wasp, hive/swarm). Given the union of ghost and creature, I lean toward “crawling thing that makes ghosts.”

³⁵⁴ 𩚑. This character has a = character combination mark, or some think it is a duplication mark. Some read this as 蠚蟲 (scorpion (and) insects/snakes/creeping animals) or 毒蟲 (poisonous creeping animals). 蠚 itself is “scorpion.” 𩚑 in Chu script is 萬 (scorpion → thousand), 𩚑 in Chu script is 蟲 (insects/mass, together → swarm)

³⁵⁵ The ancient meaning of 它 is “snake”: not hard to see the cobra resemblance: 𩚑

³⁵⁶ 𩚑 Rendered this way because of 若 over 虫, see the 𩚑→若 in A:20—this is a unique variant.

³⁵⁷ Zi.tools has this as 攫 (seize, catch), as Cook and Henricks, with this image only: 𩚑. In truth, the hand component is on the bottom, like 攫 itself, but also on the side. In either case, the resemblance is weak. There appear to eye structures stacked in the middle, a hand on the bottom. Hand catching a bird could be depicted this way, but I’m not entirely convinced—then it would be 攫, to look back and forth in fear or alarm. I default to 攫, but I urge more experienced eyes to reconsider, though the longer I stare at it, the more I think I see 攫.

³⁵⁸ 𩚑 Henricks and zi.tools put 丙 over 口 left of 犬; I agree. Cook has 心 for 口. Maybe 𩚑→獸 (satisfied)? 内?

³⁵⁹ 𩚑 (zi.tools has 扣). CRY, through Cook has 哺 (feed). I think 𩚑+口→𩚑→𩚑 (unable to speak) Or 𩚑→𩚑 (birdsong/cry). The original transcription had 扣 (strike, restrain) for 敏 (attack). Right consistent with 𩚑, see 捉.

(參/骨)(參/溺)³⁶⁰ 董³⁶¹ (參/柔)³⁶²而(參/捉)固。

Bone sinking/flooding/drowning medicinal-flower pliant, yet grasp/catch firmly/steadfast/solid

Bones sinking, a pliant violet, yet the grasp is firm.

(未/智)(參/牝)³⁶³戊³⁶⁴之(參/會/合)³⁶⁵(參³⁶⁶/脛)(參³⁶⁷/芡),

Not-yet/still-not know female/valley/yin halberd/5th [‘s] combine/fit/meet penis/male(?) blossom

Not yet knowing the combination of the valley and the halberd, the young penis blossoms;

(精/精)之(參/至)也。

Essence/purest [[‘s] arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost.

This is ultimate purity.

(弁/終)日(參/虐/乎)而不(參/慰/憂)³⁶⁸,

Finished/finally/end day/daily in/at/perhaps yet not sorrow/worry/troubled

The whole day perhaps yet without sorrow or worry,

和之至也,

Harmony/peace/balancing [[‘s] arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost

This is ultimate harmony.

和曰(參/常)³⁶⁹,

Harmony/balance says/called commonplace/ordinary/normal

Harmony is called commonplace,

³⁶⁰ Actually 弱 over 水 (in zi.tools: 𠂔𠂔弓勿水). Maybe 弱 (weak)? Maybe bones drown in all the infant flesh?

³⁶¹ 董, in zi.tools 董, a violet, buttercup, or as a lime-rich soil, Or aconite, a violet-blue plant that is toxic but can be used in medicine, or another violet used medicinally. Possibly 僅 (only, merely)??? see zi.tools 董/董 (soil, clay), and B:5 and A:13 here these appear.

³⁶² 矛 over 求 in zi.tools and by Henricks; possibly a three-pronged spear according to MPS through Cook. This may be a phonetic loan for 柔(pliant, bending, soft, placate, etc), but why change the radical? Handwriting? See C:1.

³⁶³ Zi.tools and Henricks has 牝. The left part could be 牛 (𠂔). Cook has 牝 but it tends to look like 𠂔 in zi.tools.

牝 means “female animal”, usually the antonym of 牡; used to describe “femaleness” in general, the yin qualities of receptivity and fertility, and yet also means “ravine, valley”, which I think is euphemistic given female connotation.

³⁶⁴ This is the 5th Heavenly stem of 10, called (and looks like) halberd or axe. It has connotations of being in the center. Mawangdui and WangBi have replaced this with 牡, maleness. While “axe” wouldn’t be my choice of euphemistic reference to male genitalia (and why be euphemistic?) context clues seem to point this way. Even if we do read 戊 as center, I would expect 中 (core, middle) to refer to the innermost depths of the female “valley”.

³⁶⁵ Missing the top line under the roof, compared to A:10. Might be 會 (combine, gather, meet), or 答 (respond)

³⁶⁶ 參. Henricks has the original as 勿 under 亠, as does Cook. I cannot find this in zi.tools anywhere. Henricks mentions this could be penis, as 脛 occurs in Mawangdui. There’s an erect, upward line over 勿 (thing) or 夕 (flesh). Wiktionary lists 脛 found in Mawangdui as “penis of a young boy”, so this may be specifically the penis of an infant, which can get engorged even in the absence of arousal or sexual function.

³⁶⁷ Zi.tools accurately has this as 忝 over 忝 (forgive (恕) or anger (怒), variant for both by Wiktionary). In chũ Nôm Vietnamese, 芡 has meanings of “blossom, willing to”, zdic.net lists it here: <https://zdic.net/hans/%F0%A6%AC%91/chuwenzi>.

Adding the heart radical at the bottom may indicate psychological state but I doubt it in this case; this may just be how this kind of “blossoming” is expressed. An erection is not so different from a blossoming flower: petals or flesh that was closed open, fluid pressure causes rigidity and expansion, and color changes (in this case reddening).

³⁶⁸ Originally 頁+心 (listed as 愼 in zi.tools but similar characters are found under 愼, both listed under 愼). 愼→憂 (anxious, burdened with care, constantly worried, grief, afflicted; 愼→愼→憂.) 愼→順 (compliance, agreeable, to follow/go along with, conforming, accommodating). See B:3’s notes, 𠂔.

³⁶⁹ 同 over 示, in Cook and Zi.tools. Originally this meant lower garment. While it can mean constant, persistent, usually this is 亼→亼→恆 in the Guodian. Another meaning is ordinary, normal, conventional, so I adopt this.

智和曰明。

Knowing harmony called brightness/luminosity/insight(ful),

Knowing harmony is called insightful.

(𧰨/益)³⁷⁰生曰(𧰨/兼)³⁷¹,

Increase(value-of?) live/born/living/create called long-term/long-river

Increasing the value of life is called long-term,

心(𧰨/史)³⁷²(𧰨/氣)³⁷³曰(𧰨/𧰨)³⁷⁴,

Heart/mind records/decrees/historians vital-energy/qi/fumes/air/breath called powerful/forced/vigorous

The heart and mind recording vital energy is called forced.³⁷⁵

(勿/物)(𧰨/壺)³⁷⁶(𧰨/鼎)³⁷⁷(𧰨/老),

Things prized/stored(?), royal-cauldrons elder/waning/obsolete

The things that are prized are obsolete cauldrons³⁷⁸ –

是(胃/謂)不道。

This stomach//speak-of/talk-about/called not Dao/way.

This is spoken of as not with the Dao.³⁷⁹

A:17 Commentary:

Before jumping in, it's worth noting the rambling nature of this chapter. We start with newborns and end with over-valued power symbols, with only definitions of purity and harmony connecting them.

³⁷⁰ 𧰨 by Cook and zi.tools (zi.tools technically has 𧰨 over 貝). Henricks has 貝 below 益. Zi.tools has 𧰨 as a variant of 鎰, a measurement of weight. The top part of this character resembles 𧰨 (𧰨) more, listed as a variant of 𧰨 (throat/choke/passing-through → increase) under zi.tools. (See B:2). This would be increase over cowry shell (貝), essentially money. Perhaps “increase the value of”?

³⁷¹ Apparently meant a long deep river, or the appearance of one, or a long period of time.

³⁷² Originally 𧰨, which is technically 卜 over 日 over 又, how it is rendered in zi.tools, where it is listed under 史 (policy (especially written), scribe, decrees, employment). However, zi.tools also lists this character as meaning 事, which I find less convincing, as this character appears elsewhere in another form. (See also A:1).

³⁷³ In zi.tools, Cook, and Henricks as 𧰨. Evidently this refers to qi(氣)

³⁷⁴ Expressed in zi.tools as 𧰨 over 力, under 𧰨. This is a Warring States form of 𧰨. The two lines may be an abbreviation. Consider, though, 𧰨 (𧰨), a variant of 𧰨 in zi.tools but attached to 剛 (hard interruption, rigid, unyielding, firm, strong). This visual resemblance is stronger to me. A:11 and A:17 would be “rigid” over “power” (力), to mean forceful, “brute forcing”.

³⁷⁵ This could also be translated as “The heart and mind ordering by written decree vital energy is called forced.”

³⁷⁶ In zi.tools as 𧰨 over 土, which evidently is just a variant of 𧰨 itself. Shuowen Jiezi calls this “good”, like 善. Kroll calls this 𧰨 “prized, favorable”, and also “slave”. 藏 means to store, or storehouse. Perhaps this could refer to land that is favored, rather than favor that is hidden under grass?

³⁷⁷ 𧰨 --so reduced! The top part of this character resembles the Chu version of 貝 (𧰨) as much as 鼎 (𧰨), but this is not for sure 則 as Cook, Henricks, and Zi.tools label it. For one thing, all but two other instances of the character on zi.tools, the closest thing is this 𧰨 (from the Guodian!), with the knife clearly visible. I must default to 鼎. There are other instances under 則 with the 火 (fire) under it 𧰨 -- I think these also may be 鼎, especially as this variant also shows up in the Guodian with a knife (or maybe 勿) next to it (𧰨)! See also B:1.

This is not cooking pots referred to here. The Ding cauldrons were a symbol of legitimate power, royalty, and rule. The Zhou bronze cauldrons were actively fought and died over during the Warring States period because of their being tokens of political legitimacy—these were not used as cauldrons anymore.

³⁷⁸ Alternatively “Things are stored/prized, cauldrons are obsolete.”

³⁷⁹ Or, back to my stomach mischief, “Stomaching this is not with the Dao.”

Perhaps a chapter was supposed to end with 明, where the slip ended, and start anew after that— to me, that would have seemed a normal break. Yet, I see no mark there.

It's well known by anyone who is out in nature enough that venomous and otherwise dangerous creatures do not seek you out to bite you unless actively hunting you; generally, they freak out and use these things to protect themselves. These aggressive behaviors are truly defensive, triggered by perceived threat, and rarely in response to an appetite for human prey. Indeed, venomous snakes and bugs are not eager to waste venom on threats and will often deliver warning “dry bites”, birds of prey do not normally attack people, especially not unprovoked (and even vigilant birds that spooky easily fly away), and well-fed guard-dogs (protectors), and even animals that hunt in general, are not likely to attack if their belly is full. This may not describe the protective power of virtue, but rather illustrate the non-aggression more widely. This can be interpreted in two ways. The first, the virtuous person has real weapons, venom, stingers, talons, fangs, but will not use them, as nonviolent as a defenseless newborn. The second, the newborn is vulnerable, certainly, but does not provoke the violence that one who would attempt to manipulate or capture nature would. The newborn is safe because it does not startle or threaten anything, so nothing makes it their enemy. In this way, the newborn personifies one who drinks the thickness of virtue.

Even the movements of the newborn do not stem from trying to conquer or subdue. The body of the newborn is categorized by sinking (or weak) bones; I read this as sinking into the plenty of flesh of newborns. The bones of a newborn are deep and insulated by their baby fat, and soft and pliable as their bones have yet to fuse and fully ossify. The grasping hands of the newborn, and erections in newborn boy penises, are involuntary responses. The body does them, but the infant does not think of it, much less command it of his own body. Place a finger in the palm of a baby's hand and without fail they will grab – it is a reflex. The soft, flexible body of the newborn has this strong grip, and the instinct and reflex to hold on, for survival, to stay attached to the mother, the source of protection and food. As for the newborn penis, this is even less than instinct but mere biological reflex. Even adult males are sometimes powerless to control their own “blossoming” genitalia, too. It is not indicative of consent or even consideration or awareness; it is an autonomic physiological process not inherently tied to intention. This is especially the case for a newborn, whose genitalia, though capable of “blossoming”, are not functional. These movements without intention is ultimate purity in the Guodian. There is no motive, no intention, probably no thought or emotion attached to these reflexes – they are pure nature.

A newborn's memory is also very short. A newborn or baby, and most children, can finish each day without worrying about what it means for the future, going to sleep and waking up to a brand new day, finishing that day without dwelling on it much. Perhaps this is what we would today call “living in the moment.” While it is hard to know if a newborn or baby is capable of sorrow or worry, from outside, it sure seems as though they are still beyond it so long as they have their survival needs met. The infant cries, and when the food or conditions for sleep or cleanliness are met, they dwell not in their past woes and discontinue their crying. This freedom of these more complex negative feelings like worry or sorrow, is called ultimate harmony in the Guodian. This harmony is ordinary, commonplace, normal. No magical conditions are met, no great favor or power or wealth or recognition is required; business as usual, ordinary, with needs met, is this ultimate harmony. The absence of disaster, and the presence of sufficiency is all that is required to obtain this ultimate harmony. Recognizing this is called insightful. This ties nicely into the next line, where increasing life (or by my translation, minding the cowry shell addition, “increasing the value” of life), is called “long-term”. High value lives, full of ordinary days and contentment with these, are long lives, or perhaps a life like a long, deep river (𣎵) – long-lasting, ever flowing, rich, full, and nourishing.

The next phrase is a little harder to make sense of. The heart and mind recording vital energy is called forced: this may fit in with the themes of names being forced and separated from the reality of things, but it may be something else. The self (heart and mind) trying to distill itself into writing, trying to capture, record, and institutionalize itself is a forced process, one doomed to never be perfect. It is important to note that the early Chinese did not distinguish heart from mind as those in the West; the organ of feeling, emotions, and pain was the same organ that thought, worried, analyzed, and made decisions. There is no conflict between heart and mind – only conflict within it. Alternatively, if this line is translated as “The heart and mind ordering vital energy by written decree is called forced”, this captures something similar. The vital energy, what powers life, is not a subject that will easily follow what is written, even if these are orders. This situation of trying to control life through written categories or laws is a forced one, not a natural one, and not likely a successful one. Similarly, when the things that are most prized are obsolete cauldrons, power symbols, tools that do not even cook food anymore, this is not the Dao. This great value placed on something that is practically useless is greatly unnatural. So, the progression is this: highly valuing life leads to longevity, trying to force life into writing (or into compliance with writing) is forced (and so less ideal), and this value (that should be placed on life) instead falling on an obsolete cauldron that happens to symbolize dynastic power is against the way of things. These statements depict an increasing corruption of nature.

Received 55 (A:17)

含德之厚 {者}

Hold-in-mouth/hold-in/enclose/withhold/full-of/embody virtue/power [‘s] thick/deep/authentic/richly
Embodying virtue’s thickness³⁸⁰

比於赤子

Compare/parallel/duplicate/alike/align/close-to at/in/than [blood-red/exposed child]/newborn³⁸¹
Is alike to newborn baby.

蜂蠆虺蛇不螫

Wasp/hive/bees scorpions venomous-snakes snake not sting/bite
Wasps, scorpions, and venomous snakes do not bite or sting,

猛獸不據

Brute/fierce/savage/severe/staunch beast/wild-animal not rely-on/evidence/seize/grasp/take-over
Savage beasts do not snatch,

攫鳥不搏

Seize/catch bird not knead/bundle/round/circle/rely-on
Birds of prey do not circle.³⁸²

骨弱筋柔而握固

Bone tender/weak/frail/inexperienced tendon/sinew/muscle pliant/soft/bending but/yet grasp firm/solid
Bones tender, muscles soft, yet the grip is firm,

³⁸⁰ Other translations vary widely for this line: Linnel has “he who embodies the substance of De (virtue)”, Wu has “One who is steeped in virtue” (maybe closer to the Guodian strangely enough), Lau and Chan have “One who possesses virtue in abundance”, Lin has “He who is rich in virtue,” and Feng & English has “he who is filled with virtue.” Henricks (from the Mawangdui, presumably) has “One who embraces the fullness of virtue.” Waley has “the impunity of things fraught with the ‘power’,” and Cleary has “The richness of subliminal virtue.”

³⁸¹ 赤子 together means “newborn child”, according to Kroll and Wiktionary.

³⁸² I cannot find a definition of this character that means claw or grab, and yet Wu, Chan, Waley, Lin, Cleary, Feng & English, and Linnel ALL translate this as some form of “birds of prey do not maul/attack/claw/grab him.” For all of these lines, all of these other translations assume a direct object, which would be the one embodying virtue richly.

未知牝牡之合而全作³⁸³

Not-yet know female-male [‘s] combine/meet/fit and/yet/but complete/be-whole/perfect create/arise
Not yet knowing the meeting of female and male, yet completely arises.

精之至也

Essence/purest [‘s arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost.
This is ultimate purity.

終日號而不嗄

End/finish/finally/whole day announce/command/call-out/shout/cry/keen and/yet/but not hoarse/raspy
The whole day crying, yet never getting hoarse,

和之至也

Harmony/peace/balancing [‘s arrival/arriving]/ultimate/utmost
This is ultimate harmony.

知和曰常

Know harmony/peace/balancing called persistent/constant/enduring
Knowing harmony is called enduring,

知常曰明

Know enduring/constant/persistent called bright/perceptive/luminosity
Knowing endurance is called perceptive.

益生曰祥

Increasing/advance/accumulate/benefit life/born/create called favorable-omen
Benefitting one’s life is called a good omen,

心使氣曰強

Heart/mind cause/allow/dispatch/employ qi/vital-energy/breath called dominate/strong/forced
The mind and heart authorizing the vital energy is called forced³⁸⁴,

物壯則老

Things robust/in-their-prime/mighty/healthy when-then age/old/decay/wane
When things are robust and at their prime, then they age and wane.

是謂不道

This called not Dao
This is called not with the Dao.

不道早已

Not Dao early/ahead-of-time/morning already/stop/finish
What is not with the Dao has an early end.

³⁸³ Mawangdui has 媿怒, the penis of a young boy becoming “angry” (aroused). Despite this, many translations of the received also mention the sexual organ becoming aroused or working. Heshang Gong’s version of the Laozi has 媿作 (young boy’s penis arising), so many modern translations preserve this meaning.

³⁸⁴ This line can be translated in a number of ways. I opted to translate 使 as “authorize” to preserve the allowing, sending one forth aspect while not removing the commanded, dispatching element of the word. Linell translates this as “Heart/mind making Qi speaks of strength,” and Cleary has “The mind mastering energy is called strong.” However Wu translates “To control the breath by will is to overstrain it” (Feng & English have similar) and Lau has “For the mind to egg on the breath is called violent.” Chan has “for the mind to employ the force without restraint means violence.” Henricks has “For the mind to control the breath—that’s called ‘forcing things’.” Waley has “If the heart makes calls upon the life-breath, rigidity follows.”

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The received version's Chapter 55 differs in important and confusing ways from the Guodian. The first portion is largely the same with a few differences: Guodian refers to the one who drinks the thickness of virtue, whereas the received discusses the one who embodies (or holds in) the thickness of virtue. Ultimately I do not think these two are very different. The received separates the birds of prey out from the beasts (who are now savage rather than well-fed, if I translate "well-fed" correctly), and has them circle as hawks and vultures do trying to locate food (or in the case of vultures at times waiting for their prey to die). In most translations of the received, it is assumed that the myriad wildlife do not attack the virtuous person (personified as an infant, or the infant itself depending on how one reads it), and indeed the Guodian may be read this way as well, though, again, birds of prey do not often attack people, and much less to hunt them. The description of the infant's body is largely the same, save for the introduction of muscle being pliant in the received, whereas it appears that the Guodian only refers to bones and features 董 (a flower) instead; this could potentially be in the sense of "only, merely" as in 僅 but I found no evidence that this form of the character is used for that meaning. The erection portion is largely the same, with "blossoming" replaced with "arising", and specifically the Wang Bi using 全 (though other received versions keep the penis/脰 of Mawangdui and Heshang Gong), possibly as a phonetic loan, maybe for censorship? I don't really know why the substitution occurred, but other commentaries rescued the meaning. The two versions, Guodian and the received, agree that this is ultimate purity. However, the idea of ultimate harmony diverges rather dramatically. In the Guodian, some may want to consider this instance of 唐 to be 嘯 (to call, to shout), but there is nothing different about this instance of the character here than anywhere else, and for consistency, I must keep it as 唐. The result is reading the line as "The whole day, perhaps yet without sorrow or worry," which I interpret as the living in the moment and emotional resiliency of the young living simple lives. However, the received seems to think that the capacity for an infant to cry incessantly without its voice becoming hoarse as ultimate harmony or peace, which utterly confuses me. Additionally, babies can suffer from hoarse voices from crying for too long. In the Guodian, harmony is ordinary and knowing this is what is called insight. In the received, however, equates knowing harmony to being enduring/persistent, and knowing endurance/persistence as insight. The received leans into this mystical, distant understanding of harmony, but the Guodian points to something tangible, familiar, probably already known. The last section of the chapter is not quite so different, but still divergent. The Guodian stays very logical and concrete: adding value of one's life prolongs it and this is good, trying to use the mind to record or command vital energy is forced and this is presumably less good, and prizing aging power symbols like the cauldrons is against the Dao, and this is presumably very bad. The received follows a similar pattern, but adding to one's life or benefitting it is rendered more vaguely into a good omen. The meaning with regard to the heart/mind in some way trying to exert control onto the vital energy is likely the same (depending on how one interprets 強). Chapter 30 (paired with A:4) ends with the same three lines, warning that being robust leads to aging and waning, and that this is against the Dao, doomed to an early end. This is not in the Guodian, not here and not in A:4, and is a strange substitution for what was there before. In Chapter 30/A:4, these three lines were just appended to what would have been the end, rather than a substitution.

Guodian (A:18)

名與³⁸⁵ 身管³⁸⁶ 新³⁸⁷

Name give/associate/unite/and/join/share body/self devotion/relentless new

Names grant selves relentless freshness,

身³⁸⁸(𠂔/與)(𠂔/貨)管多

Body/self give/and/unite goods/property/money/resources devotion/relentless many/exceed/multiply

*Selves grant resources relentless multitudes,*³⁸⁹

(𠂔/貢/得)³⁹⁰(𠂔/與)(𠂔/貢/亡) 管(𠂔/病)³⁹¹.

Gaining/seeking(?) give/grant/unite/and losing/gone relentless damage/impede//illness/disease/fault.

Gain of value grants loss of value relentless capacity for damage.

(𠂔/甚)(𠂔/𦣻³⁹²)(𦣻/必)大(𠂔/費)³⁹³,

Excessive fond/love/kind/pity/loathe-to-part-with/begrudge certainly great waste/expend/consume

*Excessive stinginess is certainly a great expense,*³⁹⁴

³⁸⁵ 𠂔 A bit blurry, but this doesn't totally match entries in zi.tools under 與. It certainly has the two hands on the bottom, and it bears decent resemblance to the seal script 𠂔, so I do not challenge it. However, the next two instances of this character in this chapter looks totally normal: 𠂔, 𠂔. In this chapter I translate this as “grant” – what Shuowen Jiezi calls the older form (𠂔) is used in A:2 and A:10 (share), and this form is in A:12 (rhetorical).

³⁸⁶ 𠂔, listed under zi.tools as 管 Early form of 簫. All three are pronounced du3. See A:13 and A:5(𠂔). This character could be a synonym of 𠂔 (which I have been translating as genuine) and so therefore 簫 (thick, relentless, genuine), which I am hesitant about because this character 𠂔 already appears, but the Shuowen Jiezi, by zi.tools, seems to also say this means “thick.” It appears the thick/devoted meaning is more likely. Shuowen Jiezi says “thick and winter-poisonous”, but the poisonous bit may be pronunciation. This may be a Chu version for 孰, meaning “in which cases, which, who, what”, according to zi.tools.

³⁸⁷ Really 𠂔 (technically 木 over 辛 to the left of 斤). C:1 has this neater as 𠂔. This is listed under 新 in both cases.

³⁸⁸ Strange underline on the slips.

³⁸⁹ 多 can also refer to superior-to/more, exceed, highly esteem, and multiply. So this could read “Bodies grant resources relentless high-value/superiority”. But “bodies” transform raw materials into resources.

³⁹⁰ 𠂔 Cook renders as 𠂔 (a form of 之) over 貝, (zi.tools: 𠂔 over 貝) but to me looks like 之 over 貝, (Henricks often expresses 之 component as 止. Cook says could be 得 (zi.tools agrees, but usually rendered as 𠂔 from B:4 or 𠂔 from C:3/4), or 持 (but see A:20 𠂔). Wiktionary claims 貢 is a variant of 𠂔 (like B:4 and C:3/4). I suppose they could be synonyms, but maybe, as a foot or “to go” is involved, it is to seek gain, vs. gain “in the hand”? Conversely, just after is 𠂔→亡 over 貝→貢, to be without or to lose. This echoes the gaining/losing favor in B:4.

Cook mentions that some consider to be a variant of 覓 (to seek). In this case it would be that gaining grants seeking the capacity for harm. This interpretation is not unfeasible, but I clearly see 亡 at the top.

³⁹¹ Cook and Henricks have 𠂔, zi.tools lists under 𠂔 𠂔方, leading to 病 (illness, sickness, disease, defect, troubledness). I think there is a small chance this instance may be 妨 (damaging, impeding, obstruct, cause difficulty). 病 or 妨: the meaning is some kind of “damaging” or harm either way.

³⁹² 𠂔 Looking at the slip photos, looks more like 𠂔 over 心 (which gives the sense of pacing over something in a guarding manner), but is listed as 𦣻 in zi.tools, Henricks, and Cook. In the Warring states period, 𦣻 (𦣻) more so had the sense of “to begrudge”, “to protect greedily from loss or harm” than the modern sense of the word “love”. Its components may mean “saturated/choking heart.” See B:4 (𦣻).

³⁹³ 𠂔, 𠂔 (assist, straighten, technically 𠂔 (𠂔, heavy,) but not listed this way) over 貝 (listed as such in zi.tools), top part as in Shuowen Jiezi. Means to waste, squander, but also expend, consume, sometimes until nothing left.

³⁹⁴ Alternatively, “excessive fondness is certainly a big expense.”

(唇/唇)³⁹⁵(𡗗/贊/贓)³⁹⁶必³⁹⁷多(貢/亡)。

Terrified/tremble/shake plunder/spoils/embezzle/stolen-goods certainly many/exceed lose-value
Terrifying plunder is certainly much loss of value.

(古/故)(智/知)足不(𡗗/辱)³⁹⁸;

Old/ancient//thus knowledge/wisdom foot/sufficiency/adequacy not dishonor/disgrace/humiliate/insult
Thus, knowing sufficiency is not humiliating.

智(𡗗³⁹⁹ 止⁴⁰⁰)/止) 不怠⁴⁰¹:

Knowledge limit/halt not idle/negligent/indifferent/disrespectful/fatigued
Knowing to stop is not idleness,

可⁴⁰²以長(𡗗/舊)。

Possible/can by-means-of long/mature old/familiar/dear-old-friend/long-existing/former.
By means of this one can endure for a long time and become familiar.

A:18 Commentary:

The Guodian continues, in this chapter, with the theme of sufficiency being superior to unmitigated gain.

This continues the discussion in A:17 of harmony being the ordinary, and recognizing this being insight, as well as its handling of recognizing what kind of value is real value.

Names granting relentless freshness: perhaps this “naming” gives selves a perpetual need to keep generating and changing themselves. A person’s name is not their soul – it is a representation of who that person is to other people, and while the true nature of a person remains relatively constant, the names subject to society are victims of this burdensome updating. Indeed, particularly elites could have many names, such as clan names, personal names, courtesy/adult names, and even names for artists and writers, to say nothing of the self-referential language such as “this unworthy person”, or

³⁹⁵ Originally 厂 (cliff, but there are at least two lines in the character) + 句 (phrase, hook, ensnared, linger) in Cook and Henricks (𡗗), treated as 厚 (But see 𡗗 in A:17 and A:2). Zi.tools has 𡗗石句 (I would agree with this if there were a third box, but there’s not). The truth may be somewhere in the middle. Wiktionary describes the etymology of 厚 as a cliff 厂 over an upside down 高 (as 𡗗, jug). Alternatively the top part could be the same top part as in 辰 (hoe, shake, time, celestial body) (see 唇, 𡗗), see below. I initially speculated that 厂/石 (cliff/stone) + 句 (hook/curved/ensnaring) depicts something like a curved/hooked grip clinging onto a cliff face, and may mean something like “clinging, holding on for dear life;” as it turns out this is the etymology for this character if taken as the original form of 振 (Shang/ (商承祚) (1983): 說文中之古文考, through Wiktionary). I default to 唇, which, according to Wiktionary, means “terrified” or “trembling, sound of fear.”

³⁹⁶ Listed in zi.tools under 贊 ← 𡗗 Shares the same components as 贓, so I’ll go ahead and say it is most likely this.

³⁹⁷ Slightly faded but still clearly 必

³⁹⁸ 𡗗: literally 唇 (from the line before) over 又. Z.tools lists this as 辱 and Henricks and Cook both agree – this is also in the received. This does not match how 辱 occurs in B:4 (𡗗, 𡗗, 𡗗) or B:5 (𡗗), which removes the bottom mouth component of 唇/唇. This may reflect different ages/scribes between Guodian A and B, or reflect meaning. I settle on “humiliating/humiliation.”

³⁹⁹ 𡗗 Unable to find on zi.tools. To my eye looks like 𡗗 or 𡗗, or 𡗗. 𡗗 is from Cook; Henricks has this as 走 (止 over 𡗗). 止 can be run, or go, or limit (the end of, stop, halt). Conversely, 之 can mean “to go.” To reach limit?

⁴⁰⁰ 智𡗗 may be “the edge of knowledge”, but also “knowing when to stop/halt.”

⁴⁰¹ 怠 partially faded. Probably partially cut off 𡗗 → 𡗗. To me this looks like 𡗗 over 𡗗 on the slips, very unlikely.

⁴⁰² Significantly faded, but still clearly 可

titles that can be attached to a name. External labels and artificial classifications require update as the circumstances change, but one's true self changes by nature through time and experience, effortlessly, while remaining itself, retaining its true identity.

Selves, or bodies, need resources to live, such as food, money, shelter, medicine, tools, etc., and so these selves grant relentless accumulation (making many) to resources. Every organism needs to continue to secure resources, and most store only when they can afford to set some aside after ensuring immediate survival needs. However, when this relentless making of many becomes *too* efficient, one ends up with this hoard of resources that one comes to store and defend from those who would steal or destroy it. Indeed, the more one gains, the more one has to lose.

Gaining grants loss: This is not as simple as “losing is bad” but “gaining itself generates the capacity for damaging loss.” You can't lose what you haven't gained. The damage-potential is created by the gaining, not just by the losing.

These large stores of resources require much investment and energy to protect and defend, especially if one is still trying to accumulate yet more. Maintaining without tolerating loss, miserly behavior, is expensive – guards, energy, figuring out who to trust and who is trying to make off with one's resources as spoils. Following this, the loss of these resources (even if they were much more than required to comfortably survive), can be devastating. The prospect of being plundered or stolen from (especially if one has excessive fondness for one's hoard) is terrifying and very real, and becomes more of both the more one has. The escape from this world of anxiety is not to renounce all that one has, but rather to recognize what is enough.

Knowing what is enough, sufficiency, is not disgraceful. There should be no shame in not having opulence or such great accumulations of resources. There is no reason for worry if one has enough, and one should not be humiliated by recognizing the practical benefits of this path. Similarly, knowing when to stop accumulating, when one has enough and can rest and enjoy life, is not laziness or idleness or a lack of responsibility. While a lack of ambition to constantly try to gain more status, gain more wealth, gain more power, gain more achievements, is painted as a failing by society, is one really failing if they are content?

This chapter deals with the dangers of chasing constant gain, trying to obtain and retain too much. This echoes in A:20, that halls of gold and jade cannot be defended long. By having too much, or becoming consumed by trying to gain, nothing held in that condition can be truly enjoyed or even be yours in a real way. One becomes attached to the amount of things, but not the real things anymore. By knowing the limit, one can have and keep safe possessions (or oneself) and become familiar (and perhaps by extension dear and sentimental), to have and stay and keep what one has without constantly hungering for more.

Received 44 (A:18)

名與身孰親

Name/reputation/label and/give/grant/join/share self/body who/which parents/kin/intimate

Name and self, which is close?

身與貨孰多

Self/body and/give/join resources/goods/property/money who/which many/much/exceed/multiply

Self and resources, which is many?

得與亡孰病

Gain/obtain and/give/join loss/disappearance/lack who/which illness/disease/fault

Gaining and losing, which is the disease?

甚愛必大費

Excessive/too-much fond/love/kind/begrudge/stingy certainly big/great expense/waste/consume

Excessive stinginess is certainly a great expense,

多藏必厚亡

Many/much/multiply/exceed store/storehouse/hide-away/cover-up thick/deep/authentic/richly loss/lack

*Much storage certainly makes for deep loss*⁴⁰³

知足不辱

Know sufficiency/enough/leg not humiliating/disgrace/unworthy/insult

Knowing sufficiency is not humiliating,

知止不殆

Know stop/limit/halt not danger/peril

Knowing when to stop is having no danger.

可以長久

Possible/can/permissible by-means-of long/enduring/mature long/long-standing/enduring/old

One can endure for a long time.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Chapter 44 of the received opens with a series of questions, asking which of two options is an adjective. Instead of the Guodian's statements that one thing (A) grants another thing (B) relentless something else (C), the received asks "A or B, which is C?" Rather than names granting selves relentless renewal/freshness, we are asked whether names or selves are more intimate/dear/close. Rather than selves granting resources relentless multiplication, we are asked whether selves or resources are more numerous. Rather than gaining granting losing relentless damage/illness, we are asked whether gain or loss is more of a disease. Rather than illustrating causative relationships between these things, the received makes this section a series of potentially rhetorical questions asking the reader to make a value judgement.

While the Guodian and the received agrees that excessive stinginess (or fondness) certainly leads to great expense/consumption, the next line presents a divergence. Where the Guodian illustrates terrifying plunder as certainly a great loss (made possible by the great accumulation before), the received seems to skip a step and directly states that much storage is (or leads to) great loss. This difference probably does not amount to much in terms of differing the meanings between the two versions.

The last part of the chapter is essentially the same except for the final word. Whereas Guodian uses 舊, a word meaning old but also with connotations of familiarity (see Kroll), the received uses 久, which lacks this connotation of familiarity. This also likely does not change the meaning in a significant way between the two versions.

⁴⁰³ Often translated as "leads to deep loss" Additionally 愛 is translated as "desires" by some translators (Wu, Chan, Henricks, Lin, Cleary, maybe Feng & English), but the old sense of this word does not necessarily support that.

Guodian (A:19)

(返)⁴⁰⁴也者, 道(孺/僮)也。

Return/revert/turn-back/repeat as-for/[phrase/person], Dao/way boy/youth.

As for returning, the Dao is a youth.

溺⁴⁰⁵也者, 道之(甬/用)也。

Sinking/flooding/drowning as-for/[phrase/person], Dao/way ['s]/this Bell//use/employ

As for sinking, it is the Dao's mode of operation.

天下之(勿/物)生於⁴⁰⁶ (又/有),

Under heaven ['s]/this things born/live/produce in/at/regarding/than have/exist

Under heaven things are born from existing,

生於亡。

Born/live/produce in/at/regard/than not/lacking/lost.

Born from not existing.⁴⁰⁷

A:19 Commentary:

A:1 mentions becoming young again, and A:17 of course describes the state of drinking the thickness of virtue as being like a newborn, and indeed here the Dao is described as a youth. A:6 describes the sage's return to the passage of conversion of the multitudes, A:11 mentions the Dao as turning back, in the motions like crashing waves, A:13 highlights the need to dwell in needing to return, and the return back to soil of everything, and here, again, the Dao's movement is characterized by returning.

The Dao, like water, will rest at the lowest point, sinking down. This lowering motion has been discussed before, especially in A:2, but also in A:5 (ducking, leaning, and the failure of nobles to sink into mysterious insight), a A:10 (although lowly, not ruled), and B:7 later on (bending, curling, shortening down to accomplish great actions).

This is also not the first time we have encountered existence being born from non-existence: A:9 states that presence and absence create each other, but also indirectly in A:12 and A:13 where the emptiness of the core produces things that exist, and perhaps relevantly, A:10 explains how names come into existence (from not existing), and A:14 describes how things transform into each other and how great things come into existence by little things. Perhaps WuWei as a principle is derived from this concept.

Received 40 (A:19)

反 {也} 者 道 之 動 {也}

Return/go-back/oppose [phrase/person], Dao ['s]/this movement

Returning is the Dao's movement.

弱 {也} 者 道 之 用 {也}

Weak/frail [phrase/person], Dao ['s]/this employ/use

Weakness is the Dao's mode of operation.

⁴⁰⁴ A synonym with 返? 返 is used much more often in the Guodian. An abbreviation? Worth noting.

⁴⁰⁵ Technically 弱 over 水 (in zi.tools: 𠂔𠂔弓勿水). Could be 弱 (weak and frail)? See also A:5 and A:17

⁴⁰⁶ Originally 𠂔 → 𠂔 → 烏 (crow i.e. "the filial bird", to cry out) ↔ 於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

⁴⁰⁷ To explain a bit, "under heaven" everything comes into being through what already exists, but the state of existing comes from absence. Things that are now were not always. So things are born from existence, and that existence is born from non-existence. 亡 → 有 → 物 Put another way "Under heaven things are born from existing, which in turn is born from not existing."

天下萬物生於有

Under heaven ten-thousand things born/create/live at/from/regarding has/exist.

Under heaven ten thousand things are born from existence,

有生於無

Has/exist born/create/live at/from/regarding not/lack.

Existence is born from not existing.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The only differences between the Guodian and the received are that youth is not mentioned in describing the returning movement of the Dao (instead the word movement is used, although this is clear just from “returning”), and “sinking” is replaced with “weakness” in the received. Although weakness is a theme and even favorable trait in the received, this concept is very rare in the Guodian, even if softer, less aggressive approaches are praised. These non-invasive, non-coercive, non-manipulative actions do not come from being weak or acting weak; these seem to just be choices on how to apply one’s power, hard or gentle, pierce or withdraw, sink or surge.

Guodian (A:20)

(𣎵/柴/困)⁴⁰⁸ 而 (湴/盈)⁴⁰⁹ 之,

Bound/constricted/arduous/exhausting and/yet filling/overflow/fullness,

Constraining it and filling it up,

不⁴¹⁰若⁴¹¹(𠄎/已)⁴¹²。

Not(x2) like/if finishing/completing/stopping/already

Not better than being finished.

湍⁴¹³ 而(𣎵/羣)之,

Rapid-waters/torrent/wave/collide/smash-into and group/crowd/gather/teeming this/[‘s]

Smashing into it and crowding it⁴¹⁴

不可⁴¹⁵長保也。

Can not long protect/guard/persist/conserve/sustain

It cannot be sustained for long⁴¹⁶.

金玉(湴/盈)室,

Gold jade fill/overflowed inner-chambers/room/house

Chambers overflowing with gold and jade,

(𣎵/莫)能(獸⁴¹⁷/守)也。

In-no-case/no-one can beast/wild animal/hunt//keep-safe/to-ward/maintain/protect/defend/hold-to

No one is able to defend them.⁴¹⁸

⁴⁰⁸ Cook and Henricks has 柴; Zi.tools renders this 𣎵(之) over 木, (for zi.tools, also 持 (By the Shuowen Jiezi: 槌 (strike, hammer), as mallet or horizontal beam). Received has 持 (hold in hand, support, bear up, maintain, restrain), perhaps itself in place of 序(store up, stock, reserve), but this could also be 殖 (generate, breed, cultivate, implant, trade), or 植 (plant in the ground, growth of plants, implant), and Mawangdui has 植(throw, pitch, send). Cook suggests 柴 could be an ancient form of 困. The wood component of this character is very prominent. 𣎵 being a form of 之 (to go) (and very visually similar to 止), over wood, maybe this means to support, like a wooden bridge, or restrain, like a wooden pen for livestock. This ends up looping back to 柴 being an ancient form of 困, which the Shuowen Jiezi through Zi.tools agrees with. Visual similarity supports 柴→困. (See A:14.)

⁴⁰⁹ 湴 Literally means mud under water. In other Chu writings, 湴 has meant “expanding, filling, fill-out a space (Elsewhere in Laozi A, Hengxian, Guanzi in Zhouhe), as a stand-in for 盈.

⁴¹⁰ This is how it appears on the Guodian bamboo strips themselves. Scott Cook seems to believe the duplication is superfluous and without meaning, maybe a scribe’s mistake. The structure of the fourth line would support this, and the characters are written out—there is no duplication mark like =. If we read this with the double-negative, this could be “It’s not the case that this is better than being finished.” I guess it is a mistake, based on the above logic.

⁴¹¹ This one looks a bit different: 𣎵, most look like 𣎵, but there are many variants of 若 so this isn’t suspicious.

⁴¹² Listed as 巳 (6th earthly branch, snake) in zi.tools, which lists 巳 as equivalent. Some variation, but all forms look like 𣎵 or 𣎵 or the present 𣎵.

⁴¹³ 𣎵→湍 is in the original, but 湍 or 溲(heavy dew, soaked) are both possible transformations, among yet others.

See Scott Cook’s “Bamboo Texts of Guodian” page 283. Warring States Chu were familiar with dams and hydraulic constructions. The imagery of holding back rushing, churning waters would be familiar to a Chu scribe. Kroll has 湍 as rapids, swift water current, torrent/torrential, billow, also smash into, collide, clash, dash against.

⁴¹⁴ In case it is of any value, my initial translation was “Like flood waters smashing into and gathering against it,”

⁴¹⁵ The character in here has an extra dash over it.

⁴¹⁶ Or, “Rushing them wildly and forcing them into a tight crowd, they cannot hold their defensive line for long.”

⁴¹⁷ 𣎵 Originally 單 to the left of 犬, almost certainly meaning 獸.

⁴¹⁸ Technically this could also be “no one is able to hunt them (the halls of gold and jade).” Or it could be no ruler can leave their house to hunt and expect not to be plundered?

more immediately tear it asunder and flood through. What the analogy is actually meant to communicate is less clear to me, and so the rest of this paragraph is speculation. This could refer to the striving and competing of ambitious people against each other, the scheming and announcing involved, taking their toll even on something that looks solid and sturdy, perhaps like finding oneself changed, especially for the worse, by this process of moving up in the world (see also A:5's speculation about the struggling and unworked-wood and other struggles, and the dazzling confusion (or being bound) in B:4). The chase for more takes a route with high tolls; maybe there is less pain in letting the rapids flow by and making use of that than trying to dam a rough river.

Chambers overflowing with riches being impossible to defend indefinitely, this links back again to the sufficiency arguments that are widespread in the Guodian, and over-all I take this to mean something similar as the constraining and overfilling.

Valuing complete loftiness, or valuing the procurement of loftiness, following the logic that links lines one and three, may spell out more clearly what the torrents and crowding of line two refers to. Valuing loftiness is probably a prerequisite to valuing the procurement thereof, so I will treat these together. The Guodian has repeatedly emphasized the power of lower positions (see A:2, A:5, A:10, and A:19) and the dangers and costs of trying to climb higher or the benefits of not doing so (A:1, A:4, A:5, A:9, A:15, and maybe A:16). Indeed, this couple of lines ends with that this approach itself (or loftiness itself) leaves disaster behind, either as something just left behind as it moves, or bequeathed as though inheritance.

Echoing both the piercing of A:5 and A:7, as well as the withdrawing⁴²⁷, similar movement to returning, going back, as discussed in A:19 and featured in A:6, A:11, and A:13), the Guodian shows Heaven, and perhaps by extension the Dao, as both striking to the outside and yielding to the inside. The way of Heaven is both yin and yang, gentle and rough, light and dark, and this balance leads to an easier life for people, too. Striking out against what would control one, destroy one, and recede back into what is real, what one is; do this, and the enduring power of Heaven can perhaps be emulated.

In this commentary for A:20, I have only failed to cite A:8, A:12, A:14, and A:17. A:8 primarily discusses preparation and planning as well as non-manipulative action (WuWei), A:12 describes the emptiness of the core of the bamboo shuttle allowing for movement which allows for production (a movement, that, on a shuttle of a loom, is back and forth, going and returning, and I perhaps could have cited it among the chapters containing returning, though the chapter does not explicitly state back-and-forth movement). A:14, like A:8, discusses the changes of things and the merits of preparation. Finally, A:17 discusses sufficiency in its own way, even if not with money, the source of harmony being ordinary things, and the harms of misplacing value or trying to make the world adhere to artificial categories. It also features those who drink the thickness of virtue as newborns without ambition (or intention) in their action, a state of purity and perhaps returning. I did not fail to cite these because of contradiction, only because of limited relevance to the contents of A:20 specifically. All in all, the Guodian Laozi A is remarkably internally consistent, featuring very few if any contradictions within itself.

⁴²⁷ See also B:5

Received 9 (A:20)

持而盈之

Hold/maintain/restrain and abundant/overfull/plentiful it/['s]

To restrain and overfill something,

不如其已

Not like/(not)-better-than it/maybe complete/stopping/being-finished/already.

Is not better than stopping when completed.⁴²⁸

揣而銳⁴²⁹之

Sharpen/hammer/measure and sharpen[ed]/acute/hone[d]/highly-precise it

Hammer and acutely sharpen it,

不可長保⁴³⁰

Cannot long persist/protect/sustain

It cannot persist for long.

金玉滿⁴³¹堂⁴³²

Gold jade full/brimming/permeate/fulfill/complete halls/dais/plateau

Halls brimming with gold and jade

莫之能守

None/in-no-case this/['s] able/capable/can guarding/maintaining/defending/abiding-by

No one can protect these.

富貴而驕

Opulent/rich/wealth/abundant value/costly/expensive/precious and/yet/but arrogance/haughtiness/pride

Wealthy, valued, and yet being lofty and proud,⁴³³

自遺其咎

Itself/Naturally neglect/reject/bestow/leaves-behind their fault/calamity/blame

Itself bestows calamity.

功遂身退

Work/accomplishment/excellence progress/further/succeed/comply-with oneself/body withdraw

Upon success in one's work, one withdraws,

天之道

Heaven/sky ['s]/this way

It is the way of heaven.

⁴²⁸ This couplet has been translated a number of ways: “To overfill a vessel is not better than having it unfilled” (Legge), “Rather than fill to the brim by keeping it upright, better to stop in time” (Lau), “Stretch a bow to the full and you will wish that you had stopped in time” (Waley), “Holding and filling it is not as good as stopping short” (Linnell). 已 means “already”, “stop”, “finish”, “complete”. The connotation of enough (rather than excess) as being better is lost in some translations. “Stopping early” implies abortion before completion, but 已 does not.

⁴²⁹ Cook points out this character was replaced in some Wang Bi versions (梲, wooden cane, club; or 銳 meaning acute) In the Mawangdui B has “搯而允之”. See Scott Cook’s “Bamboo Texts of Guodian” page 283, and the Guodian translation below

⁴³⁰ 葆 in Mawangdui- lush, thickly growing, conceal

⁴³¹ 盈 in Mawangdui- abundant, overfull, overflowing

⁴³² 室 in Mawangdui—inner chamber, room, see Guodian below

⁴³³ This line has a lot of variation in translations. Wu has “Set s tore by your riches and honor, and you will reap a crop of calamities.” Lau has “To be overbearing when one has wealth and position is to bring calamity upon oneself.” Chan has similar, “to be proud with honor and wealth is to cause one’s downfall”

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: There are some differences between the Guodian and the received, but overall they are quite similar. The first couplet about restraining and filling being inferior to finishing (presumably stopping at capacity) is basically the same (though this may be due to how I understand what I believe is 柴, see that footnote). We trade the smashing and crowding it that I associate with torrents and rushing water for striking and sharpening it, an image I associate with forging and sharpening metal into swords. Linnell makes the same connection, with the comment “you can only re-shape and resharpen [a sword or knife] so many times.” Interpretations of what cannot last differ; Wu, Waley, Feng & English, and Lau translate as though it is the sharpness that cannot last, that the blade will dull. Chan, and Lin translate that the edge itself may not last long, which may be the same as the sharpness, or may imply the blade is so thin that it can break. Henricks is less committed to an image, with “When you pound it out and give it a point, it won’t be preserved very long.” All of these readings have a different feeling than the borrowed time of a battered dam I thought of when translating the corresponding lines of the Guodian, but the meaning – something constantly taking hits is living on borrowed time – may not really differ that much either.

Halls full of riches are equally indefensible in the Guodian and the received, but the next line gives us yet another divergence: the Guodian finds that valuing complete (or the careful obtaining) of loftiness leaves calamity behind; but the received places the cause of calamity as the loftiness and pride, arrogance, that itself may stem from or exist despite wealth and value. In both, the arrogance and loftiness is a problem, but there are nuances regarding where this from that differ: the Guodian cautions the valuing of this pride, whereas the received seems to be describing where the pride comes from.

Regarding the way of Heaven, the point where the Guodian and received agree is about withdrawing, but the first part of the second to last line is not in agreement. The received encourages withdrawing after one’s work is done (not dwelling in it, which is something the Guodian also advocates, see A:9). However, the Guodian instead uses this part of the line to instruct a strike, an attack of some kind, on “following”, repeating the expected actions and having the expected ambitions that lead to misery. The received does not go as far as to order an attack on tradition, and has a more confusing relationship with ambition (see A:9 and possibly A:2, and their commentaries, for areas where the received is softer on ambition than corresponding chapters in the Guodian) than the Guodian as I have translated it.

Guodian (B:1)

(𦉑/緇)⁴³⁴ 人事天，莫若(𦉑/齋)。

Overseeing(?) people matters/serve heaven, in-no-case like frugal/sparing/economical/harvest/save-up
In overseeing the people and serving Heaven, nothing is like saving.

夫(𦉑/唯)⁴³⁵ 齋，是以早⁴³⁶

For-anyone/in-any-case only frugal/sparing/save, this by-means-of morning/early
Only whoever saves up is, by means of this, ready ahead of time.

是以早(𦉑/備)⁴³⁷，是(胃/謂)⁴³⁸□□(重⁴³⁹積⁴⁴⁰德)⁴⁴¹

This by-means-of early/ahead-of-time preparation, this stomach/is-called (heavy accumulation power)
Through this being early prepared, this is called {the virtue of heavy storage}

□□□□不⁴⁴²(𦉑⁴⁴³/克)(重積德(鼎?/則)無)

□not overcome/subordinate/agree-on (heavy storage power; royal-cauldron//rule/regulations lack)
{The virtue of heavy storage, royal-cauldrons} have nothing they cannot overcome.

(鼎/鼎)⁴⁴⁴莫⁴⁴⁵智其(𦉑/互)⁴⁴⁶。

Royal-cauldron in-no-case know its eternal/persistence
No one knows the persistence of a royal cauldron.⁴⁴⁷

⁴³⁴ 𦉑 Cook says this could be 給 or 緇. Zi.tools has this under 緇, which honestly while a little funny is understandable. In my opinion this is 緇 (which zi.tools defines as “repair”, but may be from the Song period.) Zi.tools suggests 治 (govern, control, harness), 始 (start, beginning), or 怡 (joyful, happy, convenient) for 緇.

Given 司 itself means “oversee, supervise, inspect, examine” I opt for something like that. See also A:14 (𦉑)

⁴³⁵ 𦉑 in zi.tools found under 隹. 隹 literally means short-tailed bird. The mouth part on the bottom would lead me to support 唯. 唯/惟, both have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though, even if). 售, to sell, is unlikely.

⁴³⁶ 早 in both cases. 曁 in zi.tools, under 早.

⁴³⁷ This character is faded. 𦉑 (under zi.tools with 備) Henricks writes this with 𠂇, which the slips support, but variants in zi.tools would cover this (𠂇 + 菑). See 𦉑 in A:20, translated as 備 (prepared, complete, maybe procure).

⁴³⁸ Bottom part of this character totally cut off, but maybe consistent if it were 胃—it could be fading, but there are usually two lines in the top circle, not just one. (𦉑 vs 𦉑 or 𦉑 or 𦉑, but see 𦉑, 𦉑)

⁴³⁹ 重: In addition to heavy, weighty, grave, significant, this can also mean double(d), add(ed), repeat(ed).

⁴⁴⁰ 積: Also pile-up grain, heap, store-up, accumulate, collect, gather, entrenched, frequent, obstruct, block

⁴⁴¹ From Cook, suggesting duplication marks on all three (like =). Next line is also Cook, with duplication applied.

⁴⁴² May be repeated? =? After 莫 there is a heavy black mark probably meant to be another duplication mark

⁴⁴³ In zi.tools under 克. To me this looks like 𦉑/貞 over 𦉑/支. Strong resemblance to 事’s bottom two thirds.

⁴⁴⁴ 𦉑 --” so reduced! The top part of this character resembles the Chu version of 貝 (𦉑) as much as 鼎 (𦉑), but this is not for sure 則 as Cook, Henricks, and Zi.tools label it. For one thing, all but two other instances of the character on zi.tools, the closest thing is this 𦉑 (from the Guodian!), with the knife clearly visible. I must default to 鼎. There are other instances under 則 with the 火 (fire) under it 𦉑 -- I think these also may be 鼎, especially as this variant also shows up in the Guodian with a knife (or maybe 勿) next to it (𦉑)! See also A:17

⁴⁴⁵ Duplication mark = here, and for 智其𦉑, all have a singular – mark under each.

⁴⁴⁶ Technically 𦉑, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𦉑 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆

⁴⁴⁷ Or, less literally, “no one knows how long a ruling power will last.”

莫智其(死/互), 可以(又/有)(𠂔/郛)⁴⁴⁸。

In-no-case know its/their/maybe persistence/eternal, possible by-means-of have territory/capital-city

If no one knows its persistence, then it is possible through this to have a territory.

(又/有)郛之(𡗗/母)⁴⁴⁹, 可以長⁴⁵⁰□□ (生(舊/久))⁴⁵¹

Having territory ['s] mother possible by-means-of long/mature/long-lasting (life/birth old/familiar)

Having the territory's mother⁴⁵², one may, by long {life, be familiar}

(是(胃/謂)深根固柢)

“This is called deep roots and firm base.”

長生(𡗗/舊⁴⁵³)(𠂔/視)之道也。

Long/mature/long-lasting life/birth/create long/familiar/long-lasting look/stare ['s]/this Dao/way.

This is the Dao of long life and enduring sight.

B:1 Commentary:

Guodian B opens with a chapter on preparation and being ready, themes repeated from A:8 and A:14. The preparation in question is *saving*, though, storing up and being frugal and loathe to part with things, which on first glance may seem like a departure from other chapters in the Guodian A (A:20 and A:18, dangers of having a lot to lose; A:3, excessive desires; A:15, the costs of “gain”, for some examples), but if this is understood as being frugal, careful about how one spends, the themes of sufficiency and storing up do not necessarily have to conflict. Having a store of one's own makes one self-reliant, and so the whipsaw nature of gaining and losing favor (or natural disaster, or other troubles) is not a threat to survival if one has no need to depend on anyone else's cooperation or alliance. Indeed, A:4 still advocates one to reap the fruits of their labor, and A:1 advises to limit one's desires to what is needed (not eliminate them). If we consider Guodian B to be continuous with Guodian A, the kind of storing that is discussed is likely necessities: food and other material needed for survival, and liquid money not tied up in assets. We are considering the opportunistic nut-storing of some woodpeckers and corvid birds, not the decadent hoard of treasures, jade, and gold alluded to in A:20; the jewels and precious items may be rare, but can you eat them? So, what one gains, one does not immediately use all of, keeping as much as possible left over for potential later use. If one is prepared for disaster, then misfortune has no easy task in bringing one down.

The next portion of the chapter is less straightforward in my opinion, and the scope widens from the individual to the country or ruled-over state, and, indeed, the conservation and disaster-readiness logic is just as advantageous to the survival of a state as a person or family. Moving forward, my translation may be an odd-one-out, as I take 𠂔 to be a ding-cauldron and not 則 (when-then, rule, standard; see the footnote) on account of its being so reduced and missing the knife component. I take this ding-cauldron to be a symbol of dynastic power, royalty, their right to rule. So, that no one knows how long

⁴⁴⁸ 又 郛 (in zi.tools as 郛) both have those single – lines that may indicate duplication, and I treat it this way.

⁴⁴⁹ 𡗗 Cook and Henricks read this as 母 (zi.tools has), which normally looks like 𡗗, whereas 女 looks like 𡗗

⁴⁵⁰ Cut off, but still consistent with 長

⁴⁵¹ This line filled in through Cook. He also adds 是(胃/謂)深根固柢: **“This is called deep roots and firm base.”**

⁴⁵² One can understand this to be the nurturing, generative force of the territory, not literally a mother.

⁴⁵³ 𡗗 Zi.tools lists this under 舊 (owl, borrowed as “old, long-standing, dear friend, familiar”), but it's an odd-one-out. truly this is 隹 over 臼 (Cook and Henricks agree). Compare with A:18 (𡗗). Zi.tools holds that they still both refer to “owl/old”. See also A:12's 𡗗 → 𡗗? → 舊?

a person (or dynasty) will have the right to rule means that there is no pre-known destined end, no foretold disaster that will for certain bring down the operation.

The chapter shifts to having the territory's "mother", presumably its source, its generative power. I'll hazard going out on a limb and guess this is referring to the Dao. The Dao, throughout the Guodian and even the received, is known for its enduring nature, for its being unfathomably old. Thus, by "having the Dao" of the territory, one can enjoy enduring through time, living long enough to watch over the area over a long life. However, there are actually two ways one could read this. The first would be "the mother of having a territory" being familiar by being long-lived. However, one could also read this as being in having the mother of the territory, and, going by the guess that the mother is the Dao, the Dao of the territory. Why are we specifically talking about the Dao of the territory? Perhaps one must understand and experience the way of that territory – what are its resources, what are its dangers, what customs and culture do the people who live there have? Maybe understanding these, and working along these, reduces friction and allows one to establish deep and firm, like the roots that could support an ancient tree.

Received 59 (B:1)

治人事天，莫若嗇

Govern people matters/to-serve heaven, In-no-case like/as/better-than frugal/sparing/harvest/save-up
In governing people and serving Heaven, nothing is better than saving up.

夫唯嗇

In-any-case only/accept/assent thrifty/frugal/sparing/economical/miserly/harvest/save-up
Anyone only saving up,

是謂早服

This called early undertake/accept-responsibility/submit-to/harness/garment/ingest/take-medicine
This is called early undertaking of responsibility⁴⁵⁴

早服謂之重積德

Early accept-responsibility/submit-to/harness called [‘s]/this heavy/significant accumulation virtue
Early undertaking of responsibility is called “heavy” accumulation virtue⁴⁵⁵.

重積德則無不克

Heavy accumulation virtue when-then/rule no/lack/without not overcome/subordinate/agree-on
When there is heavy accumulation virtue, then there is nothing that cannot be overcome.

無不克則莫知其極

Without/lack not overcome/subordinate when-then in-no-case know their zenith/supreme/utmost
When there is nothing that cannot be overcome, then no one knows their peak.

⁴⁵⁴ This line has a lot of variation in how it is translated. Wu has “to be frugal is to return before straying” (???). Lau has “It is because he is sparing that he may be said to follow the way from the start.” (唯, according to Wiktionary, has the meaning of “because” dating from the 4th century, but Kroll does not reflect this and this may be a borrowing from 惟). Chan has “Only by being frugal can one recover quickly,” and Cleary has similar. Henricks has “For only if you are sparing can you, therefore, early submit to the Way.” Waley has “This laying up a store means quickly absorbing” (???). Lin has “To be sparing is to forestall.” Feng & Englis has “Restraint begins with giving up one’s own ideas.” Linnell has “This is called early acceptance.”

⁴⁵⁵ Most translate 重 in the sense of double, repeat – I keep it heavy for consistency within my translation. The meaning does not change much in my opinion.

莫知其極可以有國

In-no-case know their zenith/supreme/utmost can/possible/permissible by-means-of have/exist state
When no one knows their peak, then one can have a state.

有國之母可以長久

Have/exist state/country ['s]/this mother/source can/permissible/possible by-means-of long-lasting(x2)
Having a state's mother, one can last a long time.

是謂深根固柢

This called deep root/base solid/firm base root/base/foundation
This is called "deep roots and solid foundation."

長生久視之道

Long-lasting/long life/born/create long-lasting/enduring/old look/see ['s]/this Dao
This is the Dao of long life and enduring vision.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The differences between the received and Guodian versions of this chapter are very subtle, perhaps in part due to the degradation of the Guodian's slips in this portion and the filling-in coming from the received.

Rather than the Guodian's early preparation as a result of frugality/saving up, the received inserts early undertaking or accepting responsibility, or in some translations, an early acceptance of the Dao. Maybe these two are not so different: disciplined preparation often involves some degree of accepted responsibility and understanding.

My translation to cauldron rather than 則 shifts things considerably. The Guodian, if my translation is correct, explains that one does not know how long a ding-cauldron (symbol of ruling power) will last, and that this not knowing allows one to have a territory. The received changes "persistence/constantly" to 極 (zenith, utmost, supreme), a different kind of limitation to be sure. There is a shift from longevity to quality, probably power and capability. However, these are the only major differences, and even these are minor, again owing at least partially to how much of the Guodian is missing in this chapter.

Guodian (B:2)

(𠂔/學)者日(𦣻/𦣻/益)⁴⁵⁶,

Learn/mimic people day throat/communicate//increasing/advancing/accumulating(?)

Scholars increase what they have daily,

為⁴⁵⁷道者日(員/圓)⁴⁵⁸。

Do/use/manipulate Dao/way people day circular/round

Those who operate with the Dao circle⁴⁵⁹ daily.

(員/圓)之(𦣻/或)(員/圓),

Round/circular this[‘s] some/sometimes/perhaps/someone personnel/member//round/circular

Someone of circling does circles

以(𦣻/至)亡為也,

By-means-of arriving/utmost not/lose/gone to-do/use,

By arriving at not actively doing.

亡為而亡不為。

Not/without/gone Dao/way and/yet/but not/without not doing/using.

Not actively doing, but not leaving anything undone.

B:2 Commentary:

Scholars in the Warring States period were competitive people, with their work tied to political support and personal advancement. They traveled often, vying for political appointments, influence, and funding. The Jixia Academy in Qi is an institutional example of this dynamic; rulers actively hosting

⁴⁵⁶ 𦣻 (according to zi.tools/ Shuowen Jiezi: depicting the mouth above the veins of the throat/neck.) Very clearly 𦣻, where it is listed in zi.tools under 益. Zi.tools itself considers 𦣻 to be a form of 𦣻, based on apparently the Shuowen Jiezi. Wiktionary considers 𦣻 a variant of both 𦣻 (throat, choke, gasp out (Kroll), vital communication line, flattery (Wiktionary) by the Jiyun (集韻) dictionary) and 益 (abundant, increase, by the ShiGu (師古) Dictionary). Cook has 益 (Henricks has 益) and neither makes mention of the form being different. There is a Chu form of 益 (𦣻) but it does not occur in the Guodian, so this character could still plausibly mean 益.

⁴⁵⁷ 𦣻, another weird variant, with two lines above. The next 為 is also like this, but the two following are more like 𦣻, as seen in Laozi A. This switch happens between slips (not within), suggesting a potential scramble that would put the last line in this chapter, somehow, somewhere else. As of right now, I’m not confident to even hazard a guess as to the intended order of the slips based on just this

⁴⁵⁸ 員 Henricks has this as 員 over 大, maybe like 𦣻. This is for every instance in this chapter. Cook mentions could be 異 (differ, dissimilar, differentiate, unusual, erratic, bizarre; 𦣻, but the top circle is not empty as in B:2’s 𦣻) Zi.tools lists it as 員(𦣻, though more usually it looks like 𦣻; perhaps the former is a form like 𦣻. Both instances from this chapter are in zi.tools as odd-ones-out). As it is, we adopt the meaning circular (圓), round: As it is, Wiktionary considers 員 to be the original form of 圓 (circular, round). The received having 損, conserving the 員 element, is reassuring.

⁴⁵⁹ One could read this like “completing a circuit”, “revolving”, or, perhaps, like a bird of prey, “circling”, “going in circles”. A bird of prey circling, sustained, staying over the same territory, moving yet staying in one place, unhurried and floating, watching intently below without affecting it (or at least not yet). Those who are learning are constantly on to the next thing, advancing, accumulating, but those who are “doing Dao” are circling, maintaining, sustaining, repeating, and through that, knowing full well what is below. However, birds circling is expressed in classical Chinese usually with 翔 (soar/circle) or 旋 (revolve/circle back), so this may be an interpretive stretch.

and investing in rival schools of thought simultaneously, fueling debates. Scholars debated not for the sake of it; royal favor, students, and reputation were on the line. 裨, despite being an old form of 益 (increase), is also an old form of 噎 (throat, choke, gasp out). Because this character was actually 裨, the image of a throat, this really could be “pass through [things]”, or “communicate/transmit”, giving the sense of moving ever forward, not staying with anything, but always on to the next thing. The throat is always making words, taking in and transmitting out, communicating. Perhaps, similar to the increasing, or trying day in and day out to augment and add to a store, constant talking and transmitting is throughput, always onto the next one, but instead of just accumulating, they are taking in and shouting out what new thing they try to contribute—perhaps chasing that fame and favor (寵) mentioned in B:4. The reading of just “increase”, in the same vein, works just as well in my opinion, the talking is for gain, the gain is from talking. Either way, they’re not circling like the Dao. There is also the element of choking and gasping out: the scholars may be straining, coughing, trying so hard to broadcast their ideas and their accomplishments that they are strangled by them. Those who follow the Dao are certainly not choking; they circle, circulate: nothing is blocked.

One who is with the Dao circles, going back and forth over the same area (maybe like a old loom’s bamboo shuttle? A:12), so on the outside, it looks like nothing new is getting accomplished, like this person is not doing anything. However, this person is doing everything they need to be doing: they are maintaining what is already there, keeping what they have. They are moving without going anywhere; they do not need to go anywhere.

Circling: Taijiquan’s movements are circular, Heaven’s way is circular, the Dao and those who act in its way are returning, going back, withdrawing, becoming youthful again (A:1, A:19, among other examples). This circling and returning is a maintaining, a keeping, a defending of sorts. Although the received version of the Dao De Jing substitutes the 𠂔 with 損 (decreasing), and that is what the tradition has run with, Taijiquan, a tradition based on motion, on doing, seems to have preserved the roundness, the circling, of understanding the Dao. Unlike 損’s implied destination (decrease until you reach not-doing), 𠂔’s circling has no endpoint; not-doing is not arrived at but inhabited through the continuous circling motion itself, which is precisely how Taijiquan understands practice (not only are the movements circular, but the accomplishment is doing it, over and over again, maintaining it).

Received 48 (B:2)

為 學 [者] 日 益

Do/use/manipulate/act-as learn/mimic [[person/phrase]] day increase/advance/accumulate

Use learning to increase daily,

為 道 [者] 日 損

Do/use/manipulate Dao [[person/phrase]] day decrease/reduce

Use the Dao to decrease daily.

損 之 又 損

Decrease/reduce [‘s]/this also/still/again/simultaneously decrease/reduce

Decreasing this, still decreasing

以 至 於 無 為

By-means-of arriving/utmost in/at/from/regarding/than lack/without do/act-as/use/manipulate

By arriving at not doing.⁴⁶⁰

⁴⁶⁰ I’m the odd one out again. Most translate this as “until one reaches no-action”. It could be my translation of 以 is too strict. I translate it as “by means of” and “by means of this”, if after something that can be referred to.

無為而無不為

Without/lack act-as/do/use/manipulate and/yet/but without/lack not do/use/manipulate/act-as

Not doing, yet nothing is not done.

取天下常以無事

Capture/take/seize heaven under constantly/persistently by-means-of lack/without matters/to-serve

Capture the world constantly through a lack of business,

及其有事不足以取天下

When/reach/arrive/attain their has/exist affairs/to-serve, not sufficient by-means-of capture world

When one's matters exist, they are insufficient to capture the world this way.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: As mentioned above, the change from circling (if I'm right) to decreasing is certainly a shift in how one achieves WuWei (not doing). The other major difference is the addition of the final two lines about taking the world, that one who is without matters can take the world, but if one has matters, this makes them insufficient to do so – the Guodian does not discuss this whatsoever.

Guodian (B:3)

(幽⁴⁶¹/繼)學亡(𢇛/𢇛/憂)⁴⁶²,

Continue learning/mimicry without/no/lose anxiety/worrying

Continue learning without worrying.

唯⁴⁶³(𢇛/與)⁴⁶⁴可,

Only/agree/assent/accept give/grant/associate/unite/and/join able/can/permissible/possible/how

Agreement grants permission,

相去幾 可?

Each-other go/leave latent/invisible/faint/omen/stirring/almost/how-much able/possible/can?

How much can these leave each other?

美⁴⁶⁵(𠂔/与)⁴⁶⁶(𡗗/亞⁴⁶⁷),

Beauty/finest bestows/gives/grants inferiority.

The finest bestows inferiority,

相去可?

Each other go/leave possible/able/permissible?

How can these go from each other?

若⁴⁶⁸人之所⁴⁶⁹(𦘒/𦘒/畏),

If/like/as-for people that-which/place ghost/demon/secret/spirit/fear

As for that which haunts people,

亦不可以不(𦘒/畏)人⁴⁷⁰。

In-that-case not permissible/can by-means-of not fear people.

They too cannot, by means of this, not be haunted by people.

⁴⁶¹ 𢇛→繼, where it is listed in zi.tools. (Compare with 𢇛 from A:1). Both are considered to be old forms of 繼, to continue/inherit. These are both with the vertical line on the left, so clearly “continue” and not “sever”.

⁴⁶² 𢇛, Originally 頁+心 (listed as 愼 in zi.tools but similar characters are found under 𢇛, both listed under 𢇛). 𢇛→憂 (anxious, burdened with care, constantly worried, grief, afflicted; 𢇛→𢇛→憂.) 愼→順 (compliance, agreeable, to follow/go along with, conforming, accommodating). See A:17 𢇛

⁴⁶³ 𢇛; in zi.tools found under 隹. 隹 literally means short-tailed bird. The mouth part on the bottom would lead me to support 唯. 唯/惟, both have meanings of “only”, or 雖 (although, even though, even if). 售, to sell, is unlikely.

⁴⁶⁴ Can also mean to give to/grant to, to be associated with, and, also a blend of 乎 and 也 when ending sentences.

⁴⁶⁵ Originally a person in a fancy feathered hat, 𠂔, 美 is the front profile used today. 𠂔 is a typing placeholder. yet zi.tools lists this character here, but maintaining that it is still 羽 (feather) over 亻 (a person).

⁴⁶⁶ 𠂔 This is not 與 (𠂔)— it is not shaped the way 與 is in any other part of the text (but see A:2 and A:10 𠂔).

Henricks has 与 over 𠂔, zi.tools has this just under 与. This difference is not arbitrary: The Shuowen Jiezi has 与 to mean unidirectional giving (one person giving/bestowing a scoop to another), and 與 is communal or mutual giving with multiple parties working to lift and carry together. In the Han, these collapsed into the 與.

⁴⁶⁷ Here, technically 亞 around 十 according to zi.tools. Kroll’s dictionary defines it as “secondary, junior; inferior”.

⁴⁶⁸ 𦘒 Looks closer to 部/都 (which it can’t be), or 那 (How) or even 諾 (to assent, agree), or 𦘒, or 耶 (interrogative particle that may work), or something else with 乃 or 又 on the right? (若+乃)??? I cannot find this character at all on zi.tools. It does almost look like 若 (𦘒 or 𦘒) but with 乃 or 𦘒 next to it. I must default to 若.

⁴⁶⁹ 之所 is represented by one, fused character on the actual Guodian slips(𦘒), but this visually checks out and is confirmed by a = mark below it (also repetition of a character but used a different way for contractions).

⁴⁷⁰ May actually not be here, but part of B:4 of Guodian

B:3 Commentary:

The first line “Continue learning without worrying” is more puzzling than its alternative “Continue learning without conforming/compliance (see footnote),” which would fit the rejection of artificial classification and tradition. However, 學 looks sufficiently like the other instance in A:17 that I am forced to favor “worry/anxiety.” Perhaps this links back to B:2’s description of the constant increasing (or emitting) of the scholars, and to continue to seek information without worrying about outcomes is a way to remain inquisitive and aware but unchained to the world of constant gain. However, perhaps 學, a word with links to imitation and mimicry, is hard-wired to follow the established conventions. A lot of this feels like a reach to me, so I’m afraid I am forced to admit confusion about this initial line.

Similarly, “Agreement grants permission” is intuitive: one does not give permission without approval.

However, this character 允 is also associated with joining, uniting, and working together, as I have used it elsewhere in this project. I can’t imagine the meaning changes much with this adjustment: agreement and permission need to be together – 允 could even mean “and”; the point still comes through, as reinforced by the next line – how far can these really part from each other? The next line is familiar: the finest bestowing inferiority has been mentioned in some form elsewhere in the Guodian, in A:9, so the inability to separate the best from less is consistent and familiar.

The distance between agreement and authorization, and between superior and inferior, weighs heavily on the minds of people. Perhaps this is “that which haunts people”. Henricks translates this portion as “Those who are feared by the people, must also, because of this, fear others.” I read this as more reflexive, that the fear between what people fear and people themselves tends to be mutual. People do have a tendency to set out and attack or eliminate what they fear, and at least from a wildlife standpoint there is truth in the bidirectional flow of fear: wolves were driven to extirpation in much of the US due to hatred and fear, for example. However, this could also be a comment about people fearing each other – the same idea probably still stands. Those with power fear the revolt of those without, and those without power fear the tyranny of those with. Those competing with one another fear each other in ways they wouldn’t if they weren’t in competition. The snake in the garden must hide in fear of getting its head chopped off primarily for the reason that it is scary to humans. Fear begets fear. If one lets go of fear, and worry, and just takes in the world around them, perhaps they’ll find they get much farther.

Received 20 (B:3)

絕學無憂

Sever/leave-behind learn/mimic without/lack worry/anxiety/grief

Leave behind learning without worry.

唯之與阿

Only/accept/agree [‘s]/this join/unite/grant/give slope/brace/strut/support/biased-to/pander/flatter⁴⁷¹

Agreement is together with pandering,

相去幾何

Each-other go/leave latent/invisible/faint/omen/stirring/almost/how-much how/why?

How much can these leave each other?

⁴⁷¹ Mawangdui has 訶 (A) and 呵 (B). Legge has the translation I understand the most, with “The (ready) ‘yes’ and (flattering) ‘yea’,” but this line has a lot of variation.

善⁴⁷² 之 與 惡

Good/skilled/excellence ['s]/this and/join/unite/grant/give ugly/hateful

Excellence is together with hatefulness,

相 去 若 何⁴⁷³

Each-other leave like/as-for how/why

How can these depart from being like each other?

人 之 所 畏 不 可 不 畏

People ['s] that-which/place fear not able/possible not fear

What people fear, one cannot avoid fear of it.

荒 兮 其 未 央 哉

Weed-choked/neglected/barren/self-indulgent [!] Their not-yet center/to-end/inside exclamation!

Neglected! They are not yet finished!⁴⁷⁴

眾 人 熙 熙,

Multitude/crowd people shine/glitter/radiant/serene x2

The crowds of people are radiant and shining,

如 享⁴⁷⁵ 太 牢⁴⁷⁶

Like/if offer-sacrifice/sacrificial-feast/relish/enjoy-gift great/grand/extreme pen/sacrificial-animal

Like enjoying a grand sacrificial feast,

如 春 登 臺,

Like springtime/vigor/vitality climb/ascend/advance tower/terrace

Like in springtime ascending terraces;

我 獨 泊 兮

I/me solitary/alone/unique moor-boat/pause/rest/sedate/tranquil/ripple [!]

I, alone, pause!

其 未 兆

Their/perhaps not-yet omen/sign/origin/begin

Perhaps not yet divining an omen,⁴⁷⁷

如 嬰 兒⁴⁷⁸ 之 未 孩

Like/if baby/child ['s]/this not-yet infant-smile

Like an infant's not yet smiling.

⁴⁷² Mawangdui has 美, see Guodian

⁴⁷³ Mawangdui has the last two characters in the opposite order.

⁴⁷⁴ Mawangdui has 壘 for 荒 and 才 for 哉. There's a lot of variation in how this line is translated. Linnell has "How ridiculous! They are not yet centered," but Kroll does not mention an exclamatory or scolding flavor to 荒. Wu has "what abysmal nonsense this is!" Lau has "And wax without having reached the limit," which I also struggle to understand. Chan has "But, alas, how confused, and the end is not yet." Henricks has "Wild, unrestrained! It will never come to an end." Waley has "How false and superficial it is!", Lin has "Ah, distant yet is the dawn (of awakening)!" Cleary has "Wild indeed the uncentered!" Feng & English have "What nonsense!" Honestly I find the range of this variation kind of bizarre, and unsure how some got to "nonsense" – I must be missing something.

⁴⁷⁵ Mawangdui has 鄉 instead.

⁴⁷⁶ 太牢, Lau considers this to refer to the Tai Lao sacrifice/festival

⁴⁷⁷ 其 is not a first-person possessive. Linnell has "Like one who has not given any sign," but there is no 如 in this line. Wu has "I alone am placid and give no sign," and Lau and has essentially the same, and so does Chan, though adds the sign is of desires. Henricks has very similar to Wu, only with "not yet having given any sign". 兆 as sign refers to a prophetic sign, as one in divination, not a signal in the human communicative sense.

⁴⁷⁸ 嬰 means "encircle, sustain, enwrap;" and 兒 means "youth, child"

僂僂⁴⁷⁹ 兮若無所歸

Tired-&-overtaxed/fatigued/worn-out [!] like without/lack that-which/place go-home/restore/refuge
Fatigued and exhausted, like one without a place to go home or take refuge.

眾人皆有餘

Multitude/crowd people all have/exist surplus/remainder
The crowds of people all have surplus,

而我獨若遺

And/but/yet I alone/unique/solitary like neglect/ignore/reject/lose/bestow/leaves-behind
Yet I alone am as if I left everything behind.

我愚人之心也哉, 沌沌兮

I ignorant/untaught people ['s]/this heart/mind [!] Uneducated/unaware/ignorant/benighted x2 [!]
Mine are the heart and mind of an ignorant person, indeed! So unaware and uneducated!

俗⁴⁸⁰ 人昭昭, 我獨昏昏⁴⁸¹

Popular/simple/vulgar/usual-actions people radiant/display/perceptive/astute, I alone dusk/incompetent
Normal people are bright and perceptive, I alone am dim and confused.

俗人察察, 我獨悶悶

Popular/simple/vulgar people scrutinize/pristine-purity, I alone gloomy/despondent/stupid-seeming
Normal people are pristinely white, I alone am gloomily dull.

澹兮其若海

Placid/tranquil/mild [!] Their/perhaps like sea
Placid, perhaps like the sea!⁴⁸²

漂⁴⁸³ 兮若無止

Gust/blow/drift-on-wind/glide [!] like without/lack limit/end/stop/halt
Drifting in the wind! As though without stopping.

眾人皆有以

Crowd/multitude people all have/exist by-means-of/use
The crowds of people all have a use,

而我獨頑似鄙

And/yet/but I alone coarse/unpolished/crude/stupid/stubborn, seems-like low/mean/vulgar/vilipend
And yet I, alone, am coarse, seeming as though vulgar.

我獨異於人, 而貴食母

I alone different at/in/from/than/regarding people, and/yet value/precious food/eat/nourish mother
I, alone, am different from people, and value being nourished of the mother.

⁴⁷⁹ In place of both of these characters, Mawangdui has 累

⁴⁸⁰ Everywhere this occurs, Mawangdui has 鬻, “peddle, hawk, vend, or sell.”

⁴⁸¹ Mawangdui has 我獨若悶呵, “I alone am as though troubled/gloomy/despondent/stupid-seeming/stuffy.”

⁴⁸² Perhaps I am biased by a life of familiarity with swimming and observing the Atlantic Ocean, but “tranquil” and “placid” would only describe it on some days, probably not even most. The South China Sea may be different, but given that it births monsoons and typhoons, I still can’t help but be skeptical about this.

⁴⁸³ Mawangdui has 壘, HeShangGong has 漂. Wang Bi has 颶 (when reduplicated, rush and gust, rush and roar, like high wind, or blank and empty, according to Kroll; Wiktionary has “to drift”. In this case, I use the character from HeShangGong (漂, which by Kroll and Wiktionary is an alternate form of 飄: to gust, blow, float or toss on the wind, flutter, glide.)

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Chapter 20 of the received is one of the longer chapters in the Dao De Jing, and what is covered in the Guodian is only a portion of it. Within the portion, there are a few shifts. The big obvious one is the difference between “continue” and “sever” again, with respect to learning and knowledge (see A:1). Rather than agreement and permission being linked as in the Guodian, agreement and pandering are linked in the received; rather than the causal dimensions of agreement and authorization (internal state to external action), the received offers a corruption; agreement that is not really genuine, or exists only to influence and manipulate. The joining of the finest and the inferior, in my mind, are alike enough to the favorable and the hateful that I will not discuss it. The final line of the Guodian ends with the word people (人), dropped in the received. The Guodian’s bidirectional fear becomes the force of the masses, forcing one to fear what everyone else fears.

The rest of the received Chapter 20 that extends beyond the Guodian’s limit reminds me somewhat of A:5, in its description of someone who is presumably with the Dao or profound in some way as being in absolutely miserable situations, and yet this state is glorified as being “nourished from the mother” (the mother being presumably the Dao). The narrator wanders, alone, exhausted, maybe even without enough to call sufficient, without a home, professing to gloominess and confusion. This isn’t exactly a ringing endorsement for being close to the “mother”, as even the freedom of “drifting on the wind” or the respite afforded from “pausing” does not seem to bring contentment, peace, or even comfort. The Guodian has urged the “closing of one’s gates” and the withdrawal from at least the ambitious currents of society, but the positive effects of making such a decision are laid out as such – becoming youthful again, making it to old age, avoiding danger, having enough. Chapter 15 praises the one crossing the river in the winter at night, jumpy and alert, where A:5 of the Guodian, rather than praising and idolizing this, mocks it for its distance from the murky and mysterious and the misery the constant striving and competition results in. While other received chapters also advertise the advantages and benefits of following the Dao, this chapter is self-defeating in a way that makes me suspect that perhaps a distantly old version of this, perhaps preserved or perhaps not, reads more like my translation of A:5.

The only other possibility I can think of is that this is an illustration of how one who is with the Dao may appear to others who are not, who cannot appreciate the advantage of this way. Indeed, this is how I recall understanding this chapter about nine or ten years ago as an undergraduate. One who is with the Dao, who adheres to true nature, looks stupid and uneducated because of what they have managed to unlearn, and they look like they are paused and not advancing because they are on a different track. They drift on the wind, fluttering like a leaf, free to follow the Dao wherever it takes them, not harnessed to ambition and driven to march obediently down roads of expectation. Yet, revisiting it now, I would expect such a person, so attuned to nature and the way of things, to be sharply observant, awake, even if they see things differently than others. I would expect such a person, so free from the confines of artificial frameworks and tangled political relationships, to be energetic and happy. Perhaps, when I was younger, I understood what I wanted to, this image of the weird, nonconforming person as free, calm, resting, centered. I did not imagine such a person to be exhausted and thoroughly worn out, without a place to call home or feel safe, having no resources other than the “mother” (who by this description does not seem to be sufficient), dim, depressed, and confused. Surely, I am missing something, but after translating this myself, I cannot help but admit confusion myself.

Guodian (B:4)

[人?] ⁴⁸⁴ (𪛗/惠/寵) ⁴⁸⁵ (𪛗/辱) 若 (𪛗/營) ⁴⁸⁶,

[People?] Feel-powerful/favored (feel-)shame/disgrace like confused/deluded;

Favor and shame are like binds of dazzling confusion;

貴 ⁴⁸⁷ 大患若身。

Value/costly/treat-as-expensive big troubles/worries like self/body.

Value big worries as you value your self. ⁴⁸⁸

可 (胃 ⁴⁸⁹ /謂) 惠辱? 惠為下也。

How stomach//called power/favor shame? Power/favor use/do/act-as lower.

What can we call favor and shame? To have favor is to be subservient to those who bestow it.

(𪛗/得)之若 (𪛗/營), (𪛗 ⁴⁹⁰ /失/逸)之若 (𪛗/營)

Obtaining ['s]/this like dazzling-confusion, Escaping/losing ['s]/this like dazzling-confusion.

Obtaining this is like binds of dazzling confusion, this escaping is like binds of dazzling confusion.

是(胃/謂) 惠辱 (𪛗/營)。

This called favor shame dazzling-confusion/delusion. ⁴⁹¹

This is what is meant by favor and shame being dazzling confusion.

⁴⁸⁴ Part of Guodian B:3, but may belong here instead according to some. I personally do not think it does.

⁴⁸⁵ Could not find in dictionary but zi.tools has this as equivalent to 寵 (favor, honor, indulged). This character as written is a dragon (𪛗/龍) over a heart (signifying emotional/psychological state rather than something literal), so this could be read as a “dragon” state of mind—elevated, powerful, intense, likely untamed. This could also have the sense of favored, “loved by dragon” or “made into a dragon through love (of a ruler or the like)”. Later in this chapter, it is noted that this “is to be lower”—this suggests that this quality is not inherent—it is bestowed by a ruler or yet greater power who can on a whim give it or take it away.

⁴⁸⁶ For whole chapter, could also be 纓 (strings, ribbons, encircle; listed under zi.tools as 𪛗 over 系), 繫 (tie up, constrain, coil around, entwine). This could be related to 瞿 (alarm) as BYL suggests, as an alternate of 營 (deceive, confuse). See Cook’s “Bamboo Texts of Guodian” page 291. I think this is 𪛗 (𪛗 over 炊 over 系 visually); zi.tools considers this to be 榮 (honor, full-flowering, florescence, glory, but also 營), but Schuessler (2007, through Wiktionary) states that 榮 is the same as 榮: glimmer, sparkle, dazzle, bewilder. “Bondage” also works if taken as 繫 or 纓. But 繫 and 𪛗, maybe “to bind the eyes” could combine bondage and dazzling. Perhaps favor and shame bind the eyes in dazzling confusion.

⁴⁸⁷ Could potentially be 遺 – bequeath, bestow, but see Guodian A:20). I don’t think so, the slips look like 貴

⁴⁸⁸ If 若 is “if” this could be “Value great troubles if (they concern the) body/self.” Henricks has “Be wary with matters that cause great distress – treat them as if they could mean your life.” I agree with this translation.

⁴⁸⁹ It is not very controversial that this means 謂. For mischief’s sake, if we leave this character as “stomach”, this sentence becomes “How can one stomach power/favor and shame?” (in the sense of “can the gut process/digest this”) or even “Can power/favor and shame be eaten?” (in the sense of “what good are these things”). The point, if we keep the stomach in the reading, is consistent, “Do power and shame nourish, or are they empty or even toxic to one’s being?” This messaging has the wit and sarcastic dismissal of the ego consistent through Daoism, while keeping the primal, animalistic, natural, visceral tone of early, pre-Qin Daoist thought. Feeding the stomach is necessary for survival, feeding the eyes with dazzling delusion is a deleterious distraction.

⁴⁹⁰ This resembles the second “失” in A:6 (𪛗). Zi.tools has this as 𪛗 (walk) around 止 (foot/stop) over 𪛗 (handcuffs/fetters), giving a sense of breaking out of jail, escaping and running away (Zi.tools is very particular about this: 𪛗 𪛗 止 𪛗). This can relate to 失 (lose) in the sense that the guards lost their charge, but also relate this to escaping, or 逸 (a rabbit running, the way this was expressed west of Chu). Could be 迭, or 達/達.

⁴⁹¹ Or, in my stomach mischief, “Thus, stomaching favor and shame is confusion/delusion.” They cannot be digested, they cannot be used, they are not needed for survival. It is just a drain on vital energy.

□□□□⁴⁹²若⁴⁹³身? (可(胃/謂)貴⁴⁹⁴大患)

_____ like body/self? (How called//stomach valuing great troubles/cares)

{What does it mean to value big worries as} oneself?

(~~吾~~/虐/吾)所以⁴⁹⁵(又/有)大患者, 為⁴⁹⁶(虐/吾)(又/有)身。

My/I mechanism-by-which having big worries/troubles [phrase-end] do/act-as/use I have body/self

The source of my worries is because I have a self⁴⁹⁷

(~~逸~~⁴⁹⁸/返/及)(虐/吾)亡身, 或可 □(患?)

When/reach/arrive/attain I lose-body/die⁴⁹⁹, some/perhaps/someone can (worries/troubles?)

When I lose myself and so die, can someone have {worries}?

□□□□為天下, (故貴以身⁵⁰⁰)

_____ do/use/act-as the world; (Thus, value by-means-of self/body)

{Thus, value the self as you} would the world;⁵⁰¹

若可以, (~~氏~~/厓/宅)⁵⁰²天下矣。

Like/as/if, permissible by-means-of reside/be-comfortable/home with under-heaven/world

If one can, one resides comfortably in the world!

(~~愛~~/惡⁵⁰³)以身為天下,

Greedily-protect/fond/love/kind/pity/loathe-to-part-with/begrudge by-means-of body use/do world;

Loathe to part with the self as you would the world;

若可以, (~~逸~~/迭/去⁵⁰⁴)天下矣。

If/like/as permissible/can by-means-of leave/depart/distance/store world.

If one can, one stores the world! / If one can, one leaves the world!

⁴⁹² From Cook

⁴⁹³ May behave more like 而 here, see Cook's "Bamboo Texts of Guodian" page 291

⁴⁹⁴ Could potentially be 遺 – bequeath, bestow, but see Guodian A:20; I don't think so, this should be 貴.

⁴⁹⁵ Everywhere, 也→目→以. In Warring States grammar, 所以 is "the means by which" or "what accounts for".

⁴⁹⁶ Written like 𠂔, which is unusual: 為 is nearly always like 𠂔, 𠂔 or similar in the Guodian, with two thick horizontal lines BELOW, not above, if any. Signifying "because" to contrast it to the "doing"/"manipulating"? Only here I have translated 為 as "because". Kroll does list "because of, on account of" as definitions for 為.

⁴⁹⁷ More grammatically: "As for what accounts for my having great troubles — it is because I have a body/self."

⁴⁹⁸ This is listed as 返 in zi.tools (through the 及 page) but bears resemblance to the character we've been using as 失/逸, to lose/to escape. It probably isn't and is almost certainly 返, but I wanted to note this in case I'm wrong.

⁴⁹⁹ 亡身 is a well known Warring States way of saying "to die" in a more literary way, from the Zuo Zhuan, Xunzi, and Lvshi Chunqiu. I keep the biting, sarcastic bluntness of tone rather than suggest that losing one's body is some favorable outcome. Put more modernly, "You can't be worried if you're dead; You want to be free of worries? Die."

⁵⁰⁰ Cook: may end with 於. Zhuangzi has 於 here and "愛以身於為天下". Also, 以 X 為 Y means "take X as Y"

⁵⁰¹ Also, 以 X 為 Y means "take X as Y", so "Value self as the world."

⁵⁰² 厓 in zi.tools, listed under 宅. Usually translated as "entrust" by 託, but the resemblance is stronger with 宅.

⁵⁰³ 𠂔In the Warring states period, 惡 (愛) more so had the sense of "to begrudge", "to protect greedily from loss or harm", or "to hoard" than the modern sense of the word "love". Its components mean "saturated heart". I initially saw it as 又 over 心, which has the sense of pacing over something in a guarding manner. See A:18 (𠂔). This form specifically looks a bit like 𠂔 (𠂔女心)→ 恕 (compassion, forgive, excuse, show mercy). This could also be read as "be kind to the self/body as though it is the world," but this is less consistent.

⁵⁰⁴ Original is rendered as 迭 in zi.tools and elsewhere, as a variant of 去, to go, or even a loan for 弄, to store. 弄 honestly makes more sense in context in my opinion, and "store up" is listed under 去 in Kroll. The structure of the character itself, though the structure itself, including 辵(walk), suggests "depart." I present both options.

B:4 Commentary:

The first part of this chapter hinges on this character 繫, or in a modern font, 繫 (目 over 炊 over 系).

Henricks translates this as bondage, and there are transcriptions and translations that link this to 繫 (tie up, coil around), but this combination of components is also linked to shining, florescence, and bewilderment, (see 榮, 熒 and 營), perhaps attention-grabbing. Refer to the footnote regarding this above, but I compromise in my translation between tied up, constrained, coiled around and dazzling, bewildering, misleading using the words “binds of dazzling confusion,” leaving its victims transfixed and disoriented, eyes and minds bound by the glittery, bright nonsense. Let me be clear: I believe that both the bondage and the dazzling confusion readings work, even separately, but I cannot help but suspect that perhaps these aspects should be understood together: eyes, by glistening light, tied.

Henricks translates this section differently, as “Favor is really disgrace –it is like being in bondage”.

Honestly, this could work too, and the meaning is not that different. If favor is already being in a subordinate position (and it is; one cannot earn it oneself as it must be granted by someone more powerful), then certainly disgrace is even lower. The dependence of favor is bondage (and thus perhaps disgraceful), and the psychological damage of shame or disgrace is bondage, too.

Escaping favor being like dazzling confusion/bondage, this may yet be confusing. The reason escaping is also like a delusion is because favor and shame are not real: they are social constructs. You cannot obtain or escape from them in any real way as you can't catch or outrun a shadow. It's futile to obsess over seizing it or liberating yourself from it; just ignore it, it's not a natural reality. At the end of this part, 若 is dropped: these things ARE being bound by dazzling confusion. The reason favor and shame are disorienting is because one “misprices” them, values them wrong. One's self (including one's health, one's life, maybe even one's happiness) should be the cost standard.

Valuing large troubles like oneself: the Guodian seems to be advocating for the protection of oneself, minding one's worries/cares/afflictions and protect oneself accordingly, rather than chasing matters of the ego. Early Daoism, I suspect, is NOT calling for a disregard for your physical body and safety. It is indeed suggesting deep, organic attachment to one's body and self-preservation above societal expectations of success (see also A:1, A:5, A:13, A:17, and A:20) . Instead of focusing outward to climbing in social rank and (political) power, focus inward on your own natural processes, the Guodian is cautioning NOT to ignore illness or disaster in a lofty detachment, but rather focus: react as a wild animal would to protect itself. Henricks translates 身 as “body” or “as if they could mean your life”, and I do not disagree with this. Certainly, the self is linked to one's needs and being, and while we're alive, that is highly dependent on the body.

The source of the troubles being the body/self: This is not in the Buddhist sense of renouncing the body and transcending it. This is very literal: bodies get hungry, cold, tired, sick, requiring protection and care all the time. Our worries stem from biological vulnerability. Of course one worries about having enough food, having shelter from weather, and having basic necessities. To illustrate this point, there is the perhaps sarcastic remark: if one loses one's body or self (in other words, die), could someone even have worries? Is there anything left to worry about? One can't be worried if they are dead (presumably, though the beliefs and culture of keeping the dead appeased to prevent vengeful ghosts or other calamities in general has a very long history in China).

By valuing one's body (or oneself), keeping one away from unnecessary danger and unneeded stress by valuing these over fame, fortune, or favor, one can make a comfortable home in the world and live long within it. If one is stingy with oneself, being loathe to take risks or go in harm's way for much of anything, having a fondness and kindness enough for oneself not to be so quick to risk parting with this, then one can “store up” the world; one can keep the world for a long time and have more of it, by

living longer and accumulating what one needs. If one chases the dazzling confusion instead of these necessities, one loses the world when one loses oneself.

However, looking at the structure of the character 遁/迭, “one leaves the world” is a viable translation. I do not think this “leave the world” means to die. I think this means to leave the political, power-struggle world, leave it to manage itself. I imagine this somewhat in the sense of leaving a responsible teenager to occupy the house. This is a departure from engagement, not necessarily life. In this sense, the “world” is governmental. By extension, it is interesting that by valuing the body, one can dwell comfortably in the world, but by protecting it, one may leave. Perhaps these two lines are talking about two different “worlds”; the first is the physical world of being alive, the second is the political, societal, governmental world. Value your body to live long, protect your body to remove yourself from the dangerous, artificial world. This feels like a stretch, and treating 迭 as “to store” is a much more comfortable reading. Alternatively, though this is also a stretch, 惡 may be referring to *excessive* stinginess or fondness for oneself, and by clinging too hard, one loses it. I find this less convincing because it runs contrary enough to the point of the entire chapter behind it, encouraging valuing and protecting oneself, and thus one’s place in the world.

Received 13 (B:4)

寵⁵⁰⁵辱若驚

Feel-powerful/favored (feel-)shame/disgrace like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy/startled/alarm/frighten

Favor and shame are as if skittish⁵⁰⁶

貴大患若身

Value/costly/treat-as-expensive big troubles/worries like self/body.

Value big worries as you value your self.⁵⁰⁷

何⁵⁰⁸謂⁵⁰⁹寵辱若驚? 寵為下⁵¹⁰

How/why called favor shame like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy/alarm Favor do/use/act-as below/low/down

Why do we say that favor and shame are as if skittish? Favor is acting as lower, subservient.

得之若驚,失之若驚

Obtain/gain this/['s] like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy/startled, Lose/loss ['s]/this like/as-if/if skittish/jumpy

Obtaining this is like it is skittish, losing this is like it is skittish.

⁵⁰⁵ Mawangdui A has 龍 (dragon), B has 弄 (to be manipulated, toyed with), for this whole chapter

⁵⁰⁶ My translation may be unique. Linnell and Cleary have this as “Favor and disgrace seem alarming”, which has merit. Lau has “Favor and disgrace are things that startle.” Henricks has “Regard favor and disgrace with alarm.” Wu has “Welcome disgrace as a pleasant surprise.” Chan has “Be apprehensive when receiving favor or grace.” Throughout these translations, favor and shame are treated as though they make someone startled or alarmed. My issue is that 若 is not generally causative; it generally compares something to something else. So, favor being flighty and unstable seems to me a more grammatically grounded translation.

⁵⁰⁷ If 若 is “if” this could be “Value great troubles if (they concern the) body/self.” Comparing to the main translation, though, Chan similarly has “Regard trouble as seriously as you regard your body,” which is an elegant way to put it. Henricks has “Respect great distress as you do your own person.” Wu has the vaguer “Prize calamities as your own body.” However, Linnell treats 貴大 as “high rank” and translates “High rank brings suffering if you have a self.” Lau similarly has “High rank is, like one’s body, a source of great trouble.” Waley has “High rank hurts keenly as our bodies hurt.” Cleary has “High rank greatly afflicts your person.” Feng & English have “Accept misfortune as the human condition.”

⁵⁰⁸ Mawangdui A has 苛

⁵⁰⁹ Mawangdui have 胃 and so does Guodian -- stomach

⁵¹⁰ HeShangGong has 上 here (or in some versions 辱為下), but Mawangdui does not.

是謂寵辱若驚

This/indeed call favor shame like skittish/jumpy/alarm

This is called favor and shame being as if skittish.

何謂貴大患若身

How/why called value/precious/costly big/great worries/trouble like/as-if/if self/body

Why do we say to value great worries as if they are oneself?

吾所以有大患者為⁵¹¹ 吾有身

I that-which by-means-of have/exist big/great worries/troubles [person/phrase] act-as/do/use have self

The mechanism by which I have great worries,

及吾無身吾有何患⁵¹²

When/reach/arrive/catch-up-to/succeed/attain I without body I have how/why worries/troubles

When I am without a self, why would I have worries?

故貴以身為天下

Thus/therefore value/precious/costly by-means-of body/self do/use/act-as heaven under

Thus, value the self as you would the world,

若可{以}寄⁵¹³天下{矣}

Like/as-if/if can {by-means-of} lodge/take-refuge/impart/entrust heaven under {[!]}

If one can, one is entrusted with the world!

愛以身為天下

Greedily-protect/fond/love/kind/pity/loathe-to-part-with/begrudge by-means-of body use/do world;

Loathe to part with the self as you would the world;

若可{以}託⁵¹⁴天下{矣}

Like/if can {by-means-of} entrust/confide/rely-on/borrow/take-responsibility-for heaven under {[!]}

If one can, one takes responsibility for the world!⁵¹⁵

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing:

Chapter 13 of the received is actually quite similar to the Guodian, depending on how one translates it.

Rather than 繫 (bondage, dazzling confusion, or both), the received has 驚 (alarm(ed), skittish, jumpy).

Most translations treat this word as describing the receiver of favor and shame, not the things themselves. Because of the use of 若 in these lines, I take a different approach (see my footnote there), and treat favor and shame as skittish and flighty, just as the Guodian treated these as bondage or dazzling confusion (or both). The danger of these in the eyes of the Guodian is that these are a trap, something to get stuck in, but the danger of these in the received text is that these are fleeting, jumpy, always ready to fly away.

⁵¹¹ While I rarely translate 為 as “because” in texts this old, very little else makes sense. This is translated often as “is that” (Lau, Chan, Henricks, Waley, Cleary, and Linnell). Lin has “because”. Feng & English and Wu have “comes from” and “is the very source” respectively.

⁵¹² Mawangdui A has 梲 for most instances of this character

⁵¹³ In Mawangdui B, this is 橐, in A it's 託 or 迺

⁵¹⁴ Mawangdui has 寄: lodge, take refuge in, attach to, stop over, entrust to, confide to, send, transfer to, impart.

⁵¹⁵ Translations vary widely for these last four lines. Wu has “Hence, only he who is willing to give his body for the sake of the world is fit to be entrusted with the world; Only he who can do it with love is worthy of being steward of the world.” Lau has the opposite: “Hence he who values his body more than the dominion over the empire can be entrusted with the empire; he who loves his body more than the dominion over the empire can be given custody of the empire.” Henricks, Lin and Chan have somewhat similar to Lau's and mine.

The other major difference is the result of valuing and being stingy with/loving oneself. In the Guodian, one can live comfortably, take refuge in the world by valuing oneself like the world; and by being loathe to part with oneself (or loving oneself), one can either store up the world or leave it (see the discussion above). In the received, however, this valuing and being stingy with/loving oneself leads one to be entrusted with the world and to have responsibility for it. These are very different: the Guodian talks of personal results (living comfortably, storing up/departing), but the received focuses on suddenly gaining duties and perhaps power as a result, a political outcome rather than a strictly personal one. While one that takes good care of oneself and does not seek power is probably one with the traits of a good caretaker and leader for the world or the empire or the government, this does feel slightly counterintuitive as a result of being this way. One that values themselves, is careful with themselves, is the kind of person that perhaps the people would most need in government but also the least likely person to seek that power. One who most values and is careful with themselves is someone who withdraws, who does not sacrifice oneself. However, someone who values themselves as much as they value the world, so in equal measure, perhaps this is the recipe for a careful and possible leader. If one cares for the world as much as oneself, then care is split equally between self and world, making for a responsible, empathetic, but also enduring, careful ruler.

Guodian (B:5)

上士(昏)⁵¹⁶道,

Above/high nobles sunset/dusk/incompetent Dao/way,

The high nobles are dim and confused about the Dao,

(堇⁵¹⁷/堇/僅)能行於⁵¹⁸其(中)⁵¹⁹。

Scarcely?/clay/soil//hardly/barely able enact/transmit/engage in their core/center/middle

Barely able to engage at their core.

中士昏道,

Middle/center nobles sunset/dusk/incompetent Dao/way

The middle nobles are dim and confused about the Dao,

若昏若亡。

If/like/thus twilight/dusk/incompetent/blurry/dimmed if/like/thus gone/not/lost.

Like it is blurry, like it is gone.

下士昏道,

Below/low twilight/dusk/incompetent Dao/way

The low nobles are dim and confused about the Dao,

大(笑⁵²⁰/笑)之。

Big/great smile/laugh this/[‘s].

They laugh greatly at it.

(弗/弗)大(笑/笑), 不足以為道矣。

Not big/great smile/laugh, Not-work [by-means-of do/manipulating]/taken-as/used-as) Dao/way [!]

If there wasn’t great laughter at it, it would be insufficient to be taken as the Dao!

是以(建)⁵²¹言(又/有)之:

This by-means-of establish/found/propose/build/enact/determine words have/exist this

By means of this, established words exist for this:

(明/明)道(女/如)亨,

Luminous/light/evident/illuminate/perceptive Dao/way woman//like/as burst-out/explode/puff/comet

The brightness of the Dao is like an explosion;

⁵¹⁶ In C:1, 昏 was used to mean 昏 in the sense of “incompetent”. See also A:16 (昏)

⁵¹⁷ Cook, Henricks, + Zi.tools list as 堇 but it’s clearly 黄 over 土, so 堇. See A:13 (堇). In this case it is impossible to get soil/clay to work. Kroll holds that this character also is borrowed for 僅 (hardly, barely, only just manage), though usually as reduplicated. Lau and Cook both prefer using this character instead.

⁵¹⁸ Originally 烏 → 烏 → 烏 (crow i.e. “the filial bird”, to cry out) ↔ 於 (in/at/to/than/with regard to)

⁵¹⁹ Duplication mark here

⁵²⁰ In zi.tools, Henricks and Cook, 笑. It is this character in every instance in this chapter.

⁵²¹ Listed in zi.tools as 建. To me, looks like 聿 over 木 over 止. Cook and Henricks just have 建. 建言, which also occurs in the received, may refer to a specific work, or just established sayings in general (Linnell, Cook)

(悠⁵²²/遲)道□□⁵²³ ((女/如)(績/繪))

Slowly/tedious/procrastinate/wait/tardy/backward Dao (woman/like fabric-fringe//paint/embroider)
The tediousness of the Dao {is like color-coordinated embroidery;}

□⁵²⁴(悠/道)⁵²⁵ 若⁵²⁶(修/退)⁵²⁷。(進)

□ Dao, like withdrawing/receding/go-back (go-forward/advance)

The {advancement of the} Dao is like withdrawal.

上(惠/德)⁵²⁸ (女/如)(浴)⁵²⁹,

Above/top/high/foremost upright-heart/virtue/power woman/like a bath/wash/purify/swoop/stream
High virtue is like a stream.

大(白/白) (女/如)(辱/辱),

Great white/plain/clear/blank woman/like shame/dishonor/humiliation
Great whiteness is like humiliation.⁵³⁰

(生/往)⁵³¹ (惠/德) (女/如)不足,

Mound/bestow/sealed-up/border//turn-toward virtue/power woman/like not-foot/insufficient,
Moving⁵³² virtue is like being insufficient,

(建/建)(惠/德) (女/如)⁵³³ □ (愉/愉/愉/輸)⁵³⁴

Establish/found virtue/power woman/like (negligent//enjoy//pulling-out//transfer)
Establishing virtue is like {negligence}.

⁵²² Cook and Henricks has 遲, zi.tools has this listed under 遲. In zi.tools, these are treated as equivalent.

⁵²³ On the slips, long large gap after 道, but no one says the strip is broken, the Jingmen photos in the section lack it. Cook and Henricks have (女/如)績 next, apparently based on fragment 20 – consistent with 女 績.

⁵²⁴ There is room for about three characters in that gap, Cook supplies 進 here.

⁵²⁵ From what I can tell, Cook, Henricks, and zi.tools treats this like 道. The previous instance appears as 悠, and the one before that as 修 (both of which are listed in zi.tools), so it's likely this was just a strangely faded version.

⁵²⁶ Unlike other instances, this is indeed 若 and not 女/如 like in the rest of the chapter apart from the fourth line.

⁵²⁷ Also listed under 復 on zi.tools: 修 See also A:20 (修)

⁵²⁸ Or 惠. 惠 on the slips everywhere it occurs in this chapter.

⁵²⁹ In A:10, this character was treated as “stream(s)” 流, and in A:2 (流, the only time this form occurs). I originally had “The greatest virtue is like bathing, greatly blank, like societal shame”, as the cleansing process would make one clean, or “blank”, unadorned. However, consistency favors the translation of “stream”, and so “clear” for 白, even if this is really more like white.

⁵³⁰ I read this initially as referring to the stream above, “Greatly clear, like societal shame.” This may also be an independent line, “Great whiteness is like humiliation.”

⁵³¹ Can also probably be expressed as 生. Cook asserts that this is the ancient form of 往, but that seems to be 往, and this is already in C:2 as 生. Top more like 之 on the slips, but the mountain shape is sometimes a form of it. By zi.tools, 生 is like 封 (border, mound, boundary, entomb/seal off) but Wiktionary has “to grow wildly” or as the original form of 往. Zi.tools, citing the 漢多, 生 originally means to go or arrive, like 往. If we think of this as 往 without the step 辵, it is foot over earth (or king). If 往 is move toward/directionally, perhaps turn/orient? Stand?

⁵³² Because of uncertainty of 生, this may be: arriving moving, turning, sealed, entombed, going, bestowed, standing.

⁵³³ Partially cut off, but remainder is consistent with the character.

⁵³⁴ Supplied by Cook, as well as 質 on the next line. Cook gives options: 愉 (negligent, undignified, nonchalant, dis-esteem), 愉 (happiness, enjoy; possibly stealthy/cunning), 愉 (pull out, draw out) or 輸 (transport, deliver, destroy).

口貞⁵³⁵ (女/如) 愈⁵³⁶。(質)

□ steadfast/chaste/divination woman/like increasingly/heal. (substance/genuine/ground/aiming)
{Aiming for} respectable firmness is like surpassing.

大(方/方)亡(禺/禺⁵³⁷/隅),

Great/big only-then/means/direction/proper/square/earth no/gone/lost land-plot/simian//niches/corners
The great square of earth lacks corners,

大(器/器⁵³⁸) (曼/曼) (成/成⁵³⁹),

Great/big instruments/capacity extend/stretch/slender/diffuse/graceful complete/enclosed
Big instruments are completely stretched to the thinnest.⁵⁴⁰

大音(祗/祗⁵⁴¹) 聖⁵⁴²,

Big sound respect/honor/only/barely/still/as-before sound/noise//listen-clearly/sagely/virtue
Great sounds are barely heard clearly,⁵⁴³

天(象/象⁵⁴⁴)亡(堊/堊⁵⁴⁵/垠),

Heaven image/replica/imagination lack/no/gone boundaries/territories/limits
The image of Heaven lacks boundaries.

⁵³⁵ Originally was 直 without the 亠, written a bit strange: 𠄎→𠄎

⁵³⁶ Photo is blurry but consistent with 愈, listed under 愉 in zi.tools. The heart radical is undoubtedly on the bottom. A little troubling, as the 愈 character itself is, by Wiktionary and zi.tools, an alternative form of 瘡 meaning “cured (of an illness).” I take surpassing here, as correction making it better than the original. See also A:12 (愈)

⁵³⁷ This character alone means plot of land, tract, or simian, monkey-like, or macaque-like monster. Mawangdui B has 愚 (ignorant, untaught), Cook suggests 隅 (niche, corners, thorough) as in the other received versions, or 隅 (human-figurine/statuette, pair/counterpart/mate/partner, jibe with, or accidentally/perchance.)

⁵³⁸ Not the clearest in the photos, nor is the next few characters. Zi.tools equivalent pasted next to these. For 器 compared with C:3/4's 喪 (喪), which also has a dog and mouths/boxes.

⁵³⁹ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 堊. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it's a phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁵⁴⁰ Like an atmosphere, becoming so big it becomes invisible, or “Great capacity is completely stretched.”

⁵⁴¹ 祗 on the slips, listed as 肅 on zi.tools on the 祗 page but it is the only instance. To me looks like the top part of 事 (事) over 而. I'm having trouble understanding the derivation and structure of this character, but 肅 from the Late Warring States period is described like 肅 meaning 祗 as well, and they are reasonably similar.

⁵⁴² 聖 = 聖 This character, later “noise”, means peerless, paragon, possessing wisdom/judgment/moral excellence, profoundly wise and virtuous, master. It is meant as sage, the same character, later in this very chapter. I read it as “Hear correctly” or “hearing clarity”; and so the sage (聖人) is “person who hears clearly.”

⁵⁴³ Originally, I had here “Great sounds honor careful listening.” This may also be paradoxical like the other lines.

⁵⁴⁴ 象 on the slips, Zi.tools has 𠄎 over 胃. 象 originally means “elephant” (which was mostly imagined based on bones by the time of the Warring states – elephants had shifted their range due to habitat loss and climate change; refer to Han Fei's description of them) or “ivory”, and by extension “image, representation, icon, effigy, replica, apparition, figure”. It is indeed an image, but how realistic it is, how faithful to the truth it is, is such an open question that this word has also come to refer to illusion. The character itself could by my eye be 冒 over 肉 but that may be redundant. Compare with 𠄎, which is 為: 𠄎 has an open bottom.

⁵⁴⁵ 堊 By Wiktionary and zi.tools, this character leads to 阱 (pitfall, trap), or 型 (mold, but see A:9: 𠄎). It could be A:9's instance has the knife radical, conveying an active shaping/molding, whereas this may just be shape? Or, this could be a form of 垠→境 (end-point, limit, boundary, territory).

道⁵⁴⁶□□□ (隱亡名)

The Dao (cover/hidden/obscure lack name)

The Dao, {obscure, lacks a name.}

B:5 Commentary:

Like A:5, the Guodian is again referring to the shi (士) in less than flattering terms. All of the shi are confused and dim about the Dao. The high shi can maybe just barely make use of it (maybe by defending the core, see A:12 and A:13). The middle shi seem to have inconsistent awareness of the Dao, sometimes barely seeing it, and sometimes it is out of reach again. The low shi simply laugh at it. In the later versions of the Dao De Jing, this laughter is often taken as knowing laughter, an understanding that words cannot capture, an intimate connection too lofty to convey otherwise. Here, though, this has more of a feeling of laughing with mockery, as atheists would mock the concept of a god, a laughter that holds incomprehension and rejection. This laughter, this lack of understanding, actually fits the latent, subtle, authentic nature of the Dao. While “knowing” laughter is certainly documented in Chinese (and Japanese) religious and spiritual thought, this is much more strongly attached to the substantially later Chan/Zen Buddhism, their “koan” riddles, and their use in breaking through the conventional thinking into enlightenment, a tradition that is documented only long after the Han as far as I know.

Cook maintains that the low shi who laughs at the Dao may be the more enlightened one, though this is customary to the usual reading. The way I see it, Cook is actually quite a bit more right or quite a bit more wrong. If the low shi is low because they are not considered to be the high-achieving shi (not drowning in mysterious insight), they may laugh because they better understand the Dao, a laugh of friendly familiarity, even if they are still mystified by it. On the other hand, these low shi may be completely unable to access it in any meaningful way, laughing at it derisively, as it means nothing to them, a waste of time, a distraction in their mission to strive and gain. Cook phrases this as the low shi being “truly enlightened”, but if that were so, why would they still be confused and dim about the Dao? Why, then, would the high shi be able to even a little bit engage (with the Dao) at their core, and the middle shi not even be able to perceive it and be sure of its existence, if the low shi have it figured out? Regardless, the shi all do not have mastery of understanding or harnessing the Dao; they are all still dim and confused.

The brightness of the Dao is like an explosion, the tediousness of the Dao like embroidering with many colors. Explosions tend to be very bright, but not sustained in their brightness. As for embroidery, it is slow work. These descriptions contrast with the next. The Dao’s advancement is like withdrawing, a concept we have seen before (A:19 especially). However, this line is a subversion of assumptions, not a statement of the obvious like the other two.

The topic shifts to virtue; the highest virtue like a stream,⁵⁴⁷ the high virtue found in the lowest place, where streams run. The streams gain their power from being in low places (see A:10, also A:2), so that high virtue comes from low places should be somewhat familiar to us. Great whiteness is like disgrace or shame (the same character used in B:4). This great blankness refers, perhaps, to the lack of perceptible or recordable accomplishments or accolades. This lack of achievements, fame, favor, status, or wealth can be seen as a cause for or source of shame.

⁵⁴⁶ Bottom of the character got cut off, but still consistent with 道. Suggested fill-in from Cook.

⁵⁴⁷ The way I translated this initially, the stream was greatly clear, and yet this clarity (blankness) is like disgrace or shame (the same character used in B:4). A cold clear stream does not have much suspended in its water, and around the ripples one can see to the bottom.

The comparisons continue. What I translate to “moving” virtue is insufficient, but exactly what is meant by “moving” (toward or away? Turning or straight? Is this moving at all or just standing?) is ambiguous. As a result of this ambiguity, I am really not able to say much. Establishing (or established) virtue is like negligence, at least if we assume the Guodian and the received are the same here. Yet, simply aiming to be respectably firm (or genuinely being so) is like doing even more than that. Perhaps this is trying to communicate that if one focuses on applying virtue to themselves (moving or establishing it), it is always less than ideal, whereas simply focusing on one’s behavior and conduct (being steadfast and “chaste”), one may be “clear” of accomplishments, but they have attained the high virtue. I will admit that this interpretation is quite speculative, though.

More contradictory images end the chapter: the great square lacking what are presumably corners (plots of land or monkeys do not really make sense in context), huge instruments so huge that they are diffuse and invisible (like a planet’s atmosphere), great sounds that require much focus to even make out to hear, and an image lacking boundaries or margins. An image lacking boundaries, instruments so big that they are stretched impossibly thin, and a square so vast its corners are gone, all of these descriptions point to something limitless and ever expanding to the point where their edges are imperceptible. Perhaps this applies to the “great sound” as well; the endless drone of something, even if relatively loud, can be tuned out in the brain, such that someone actually has to actively focus to regain awareness of it. Apparently like these, the obscure Dao, of course, lacks a name, lacks a limiting definition, lacks an easy classification and explanation.

Received 41 (B:5)

上士聞道勤而行之

High/above nobles hear/inform Dao struggling/toiling/laboring and/yet/but engage/enact/move this/['s]
The high nobles, hearing of the Dao, struggle yet enact it.

中士聞道若存若亡

Middle/center/core nobles hear/inform Dao like/if exist/preserved/survive like/if gone/not
The middle nobles, hearing of the Dao, are as if preserving it and as if losing it.

下士聞道大笑之

Low/down/below noble hear/inform Dao, big/great laugh/smile ['s]/this
The low nobles, hearing of the Dao, laugh greatly at it.

不笑不足以為道

Not laugh/smile not sufficient/leg [by-means-of do/act-as/use]/taken-as/made-into Dao
If there was no laughter from him, it would be insufficient to take as the Dao.

故建言有之 [曰]

Therefore/thus/as-a-result establish/found/propose/build/enact/determine words have/exist this/['s] say
Thus, established sayings have this said:

明道若昧

Bright/perceptive/light/evident/insight Dao like/if dim/indistinct/obscure
The bright Dao is like dimness,

進道若退

Go-forward/advance Dao, like/if withdrawing/receding/go-back
The advancing Dao is like withdrawing,

夷道若類

Barbarian/crude/level/flatland/even/faint Dao like/if knotty/kink/rough/defect/deform/perverse
The level Dao is like unevenness.

上德若谷

High/above virtue/power like/if valley/cave/chasm

High virtue is like a valley.

大白若辱

Great/big white/plain/clear/blank like shame/dishonor/humiliation

Great whiteness is like humiliation.

廣德若不足

Broad/wide/spacious/accepting/widespread virtue like not sufficient/leg

Broad virtue is like insufficiency.

建德若偷⁵⁴⁸

Establish/found virtue/power like undignified/nonchalant/dis-esteem

Establishing virtue is like negligence.

質真若渝

Substance/genuine/aiming real/true/authentic/pure like/if change/alter/abandon/renounce/overflow

Genuine authenticity is like alteration.

大方無隅

Great/big only-then/means/direction/proper/square/earth lack/without niches/corners

The great square of earth lacks corners,

大器晚⁵⁴⁹成

Great/big instrument/tool/capacity evening/late/night/belated/tardy complete/accomplished

Great instruments are late to completion.⁵⁵⁰

大音希聲

Great/big sound/tone rare/sparse/dilute/look-up-to sound/tone

Great tones are sparse sounds.

大象無形⁵⁵¹

Great/big image/replica/imitate without/lack mold/shape/outline/contrast/form

Great images are without form,

道隱無名

The Dao cover/hidden/obscure lack name.

The Dao, obscure, lacks a name.

夫唯道善貸⁵⁵²且成

In-any-case only Dao skilled/excellent lend/provide/borrow/absolve even/and/or/shall complete

In any case, only the Dao is skilled at providing and completing.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing : The first major difference we see between Guodian B:5 and the received Chapter 41 is the change from dim and confused to “hear/inform”. Instead of the shi being dim and confused about the Dao, now they are hearing of it (or hearing it). Still, the high shi must struggle and toil to engage it (most translations have “practice [the Dao] diligently/assiduously”), and the middle shi only have half a grasp on it, preserving it and losing it. The low shi, just as in the

⁵⁴⁸ HeShangGong has 掄 (pull out, draw out). This character is missing in *both* Mawangdui.

⁵⁴⁹ Mawangdui B has 免 – avoid, escape, remove

⁵⁵⁰ Linnell says this is a euphemism for “Great talents mature slowly.”

⁵⁵¹ Mawangdui B has 刑 – model, form, correct, torture, disfigure.

⁵⁵² Mawangdui B has 始, and inserts 善 after 且, good at starting and finishing.

Guodian, laugh greatly at it. The shift between being “dim and confused” about the Dao, a state of perception and understanding, to hearing and reacting to the Dao, tracks the more favorable treatment of the shi in the received (see A:5). The high shi in the Guodian can barely tap into the Dao within themselves, whereas those in the received, while still having to work hard, are able to enact it.

To discuss the Dao itself, the “explosion” in the Guodian becomes “dimness” in the received, for the bright Dao. The slow Dao is not mentioned, replaced with a level or even Dao that is as though “knotted” or bumpy in some way – I translate this as uneven. The advancing Dao, in both, is like withdrawing.

High virtue, for its part, was a stream (or bath?) in the Guodian, and now is a valley or cave. Streams travel in low areas, grooves in the ground, so valley and stream are not hugely thematically different.

This connection with streams in the Guodian is found elsewhere, linked to a low position (A:2 and A:10).

Additionally, the Guodian’s “stretched out” instruments are now simply “late to complete” in the received. The Guodian’s instruments are imperceptible, whereas those of the received require patience to obtain, not a perceptual shift.

The rest of the chapter is very similar, perhaps in part due to the use of the received to fill in damaged parts of the Guodian.

Guodian (B:6)

闕⁵⁵³(元⁵⁵⁴/其) 門,

Close-gate/shut-in/conclude/private/closed/still its/it gate/key/access/orifice/sect/section

Close one's gates,

(賽⁵⁵⁵/塞) 其 (逸⁵⁵⁶/兑)

Compete/rival//supply/fill/obstruct its/it cave/mouth//progress/channel

Block one's open passages

(夊⁵⁵⁷/宀/終) 身不(叕/岑)⁵⁵⁸。

Finish/end/finally body/self not sharp-peak/high/at-the-pinnacle.

In the end oneself is not somewhere sharp and steep.

(啓/啟) 其(兑/兌),

Open/start/announce its cave/mouth/

Announce one's open passages,

(賽/塞) 其事,

Compete/rival//supply/fill/obstruct its affairs/matters/business/to-serve

Obstruct one's affairs⁵⁵⁹,

(宀/終) 身不(來⁵⁶⁰/來)。

Finish/end/finally body/self not come/approach/arrive

In the end oneself does not arrive.⁵⁶¹

⁵⁵³ Both Cook and Henricks has this. Slips have this 闕, which is consistent.

⁵⁵⁴ In truth, every instance of 其 is 元 or 丌 in the Guodian

⁵⁵⁵ 賽 To me looks like 宀 over 工 over 貝, zi.tools has this listed as 賽 (as do Cook and Henricks), though most examples have two 工. (i.e. 賽) Originally referred to a ritual/offering of thanks to the spirits or tutelary deity for prosperity, but could also mean compete, rival. 塞, the precursor to 塞, means to obstruct, stop-up, restrain, fill, supply, compensate, or fortress. I default to the meanings of 塞, but perhaps someone more knowledgeable than I should revisit this.

⁵⁵⁶ Happy (夊)(man with a smiling mouth) within 辵 (walking/moving). According to Chinese Text Project, has a connotation of moving swiftly, at least with a horse example. Zi.tools is under the impression this means 稅 (taxes) Has been read as 穴 (cave, hollow) and 遂 (progress, channels, administrative processes, institutional conduits, responses). I wonder if it could be 逸 (to flee). 兑/兌 means joy, delight, open a passage, hole/cave. I struggle to understand why the walking radical would be here if cave were meant. I speculate that maybe on its own, this running happy talker is enthusiasm, outward-seeking adventure? “Open passages”, through which one could walk, be it a hole or some sort of entrance/exit, resonates most convincingly with the 辵 radical. See also A:15.

⁵⁵⁷ This is not 冬. In Chu, 冬 ← 各 ← 豕.

⁵⁵⁸ 岑, listed under 叕 in zi.tools. Old form of 岑, which is the name of a mountain. Could be 瞢 (bewildered), 瘡, 侮 (disgrace, but see C:1, 侮), 務 (strive, focus on, apply oneself to, requisite, pursuit), 瘳 (sick from worry), 矜 (peril/brag), 教. See Cook pg 300. Inspired by the suggestion of BYL through Cook, 岑 in neighboring Qin looked like 岑, which is similar to what we see here, meaning peak, sharp and steep, pinnacle, lofty/high. Sharp, steep peaks are precarious, dangerous, harsh places: this doesn't have a connotation of victory, as far as I can see. The suggested characters mostly have connotations of hardship and toil, so I decide to take a literal approach here.

⁵⁵⁹ Or, “Obstruct oneself with affairs”, though the grammar may not support this.

⁵⁶⁰ 來 → 來 according to zi.tools. The foot (止) was added to 來 (later 麥, to mean wheat), to mean “come”.

⁵⁶¹ Or, put more plainly, “The self/body does not come to (reach, arrive at) the end.” You don't make it there.

B:6 Commentary:

Closing one's gates keeps trouble from coming in, prevents getting dragged into things that don't absolutely have to concern them. Blocking passages for coming in or going out does something similar to protect the home and keep danger out. Close one's gates to the drama and power-struggles happening outside, take care of oneself, and one won't find their self in a precarious, dangerous situation where a fall is certain doom, or at the very least extremely painful. This interpretation, of a precarious, high place with a disastrous fall is from a perhaps unique treatment of the character on the slips 𡵚. See the footnote for more details, but this character may be the Chu equivalent of 岑, meaning peak, sharp and steep, and high up. While climbing mountains may be in a figurative sense an image of victory, actually being on steep and sharp mountains is a precarious, stressful place to be, where mistakes are punished harshly. Perhaps this imagery is creative on my part, but the themes of striving and "climbing" leading to more danger and troubles resonates with this image convincingly enough for me to settle upon it for this project.

Announce your openness, get involved in many issues and matters, and one won't make it to the end to see them all through. Recall also the imagery of the throat from B:2 (𤢔), the possible meaning of the throughput or choking on what the scholars want to announce and transmit, and what they lose as a result. Being too open risks being obstructed. Letting too much through may lead to the passage lacking a meaningful filter or becoming impossible to clear. Entanglements may increase, one may get drawn further into competitions and rivalries, or ambitions and pursuits of glory and grandeur. As a result, one may not only fail to arrive at the victory or accomplishment they are aiming for; they may not even make it home, let alone to old age.

The stakes here are considerable. The target audience for this advice about involvement are likely heads of households. The heads of households that would be part of the Warring States (or even before) rat-races for power would have been husbands, fathers, first-born sons. By getting involved in power struggle nonsense, they were putting their wives, children, and elderly parents at risk, too. The defense is not just for oneself, but one's family. When the head of the household is in danger or gets into a rivalry he does not win, the entire family can be endangered, or lose the one they depend on for living well (or living at all). Perhaps this is the importance of the "dependents" mentioned in A:1. Perhaps the withdrawal is not just into oneself, but also to one's household, to their families, to the people they should love and care about the most.

Received 52 (B:6)

天下有始以為天下母

Heaven under has/exists start/begin by-means-of do/act-as/use Heaven under mother/source

The world has a beginning, considered as the mother of the world.

既得其母以知其子

Wholly/totally/completely/just-after obtain/gain their mother/source by-means-of knowing their child

Just after gaining the mother, one by means of this know her children.

既知其子復守其母

Completely/just-after knowing their children, return/go-back/revert guard/maintain/defend mother

Just after knowing her children, go back to guarding their mother,

沒⁵⁶² 身不殆⁵⁶³

Sink/dissolve/disappear/submerge/overcome body/self not/no danger/peril

So that dissolving oneself is not dangerous.

塞其兌⁵⁶⁴, 閉其門

Block it/its open-passages/joy/delight, close/obstruct it/its gates

Block one's open passages, close one's gates,

終身不勤⁵⁶⁵

Finish/end/finally body/self not struggle/toil/labor

In the end one does not struggle and labor.

開其兌, 濟其事

Open/expose their open-passages/joy/delight, cross-over-river/cross/arrive/succeed/help their affairs

Expose one's open passages, arriving to success in one's affairs,

終身不救⁵⁶⁶

Finish/end/finally body/self not relieved/rescue/save/cure/prevent

In the end one does not find relief.

見小曰明

See small/little say/called insight/perceptive/light/evident

Seeing the small is called perceptive,

守柔曰強

Guard/protect/maintain pliant/bending/soft called dominate/strong/firm/powerful/forced

Protecting the soft is called strong

用其光復歸其明

Employ their light/glow/illuminate return go-home/restore/refuge-with their perceptive/bright

Employ their light, return to restore their brightness

無遺身殃, 是謂習常

Without neglect/bestow/reject/lose self/body die-early/tragedy, this called practice/train/repeat constant

Without bestowing oneself tragedy; this is called practicing the constant.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The received chapter adds sections that are absent in the Guodian. The received starts with discussing the beginning of the world, its mother. Having the mother leads to knowing her children, so that going back to guarding the mother, there is no harm in dissolving oneself. We see this in Chapter 16. “Dissolving one’s self/body is not dangerous/makes it such that there is no danger”, which has a decidedly Buddhist flavor to it, and runs contrary to all of the protection of the self the Guodian instructs elsewhere. Linnell translates this line in this way, writing “When the self disappears, there can be no danger.” The more common translation is that someone who is one with the Dao will be some kind of safe either until the end of their lives (Lau, Chan, Henricks, and Lin) or even after the loss of their body (Wu and also Waley). The former is perhaps an extension of the self-protective logic of the Guodian. The latter wanders into the mystical pursuit of immortality, or even the merging oneself with the Hindu concept of the Brahman, the universal consciousness, total freedom and invincibility at the cost of the individual identity, the self.

⁵⁶² 沒 later meant “not have”, “to be not so...” (Wiktionary), but Kroll doesn’t list these for Classical Chinese

⁵⁶³ See also Chapter 16. Linnell translates this as “When the self disappears, there can be no danger.”

⁵⁶⁴ Mawangdui A has 悶 with 二 over the heart, B has 堦.

⁵⁶⁵ Mawangdui has 董

⁵⁶⁶ Mawangdui B has 棘

The Guodian would have no issue with the prolonging of life, , but eternal life and destruction of the self, or even the body, would run contrary to the circular nature of nature itself, the circular nature of the Dao.

The Guodian unites with the received here: Close the gates, block the open passages, and one is spared in some way from unpleasantness. The Guodian (if we go by my interpretation) holds that one does not find themselves somewhere dangerous; the received instead offers being spared toil and labor. The Guodian's reward is safety, the received version's is ease. Announcing or exposing one's open passages, and either successfully striving in affairs (received) or obstructing (or being obstructed by) affairs (Guodian), there is no reward. The received warns there will be no relief from these successes, and the Guodian warns that one may not "arrive" at all, another higher-stakes outcome more oriented on survival than feelings.

The Guodian stops here, but the received continues: seeing the small is insight or perception, protecting the soft is strength or dominance; use their light but return to restore their brightness, and (presumably) by doing so, one does not bestow an early death or disaster to oneself, and thus one practices constancy. It is interesting that by not bringing disasters upon the self, this is constancy, yet earlier in the received, there are interpretations that would almost call for the removal of the self. Protect it? Discard it? What does the received Dao De Jing really want us to do with our shen (身)? The Guodian leaves nearly no doubt on this: even if the self/body is the source of all worries (B:4), this is because everything relies upon it, and nothing is more precious and necessary.

Guodian (B:7)

大(𡗗/盛/成⁵⁶⁷)若(夬⁵⁶⁸/決),

Big/great completion/containment like/similar to dividing/breaking-through/resoluteness

Great completion is like breaching through⁵⁶⁹

其(甬⁵⁷⁰/用)不(𦐇⁵⁷¹/敝)。

Its/it employ/use not deteriorated/badly-used/worn-out/destroy/discard

Its use does not deteriorate it.

大(𡗗/盈)若(𡗗/中),

Great/big filling/overflow/fill-to-brim like middle/core/center

Great filling is like the middle,⁵⁷²

其(甬/用)不(𦐇⁵⁷³)。

Its/it employ/use not spent/depleted/reach-an-end/cease/failure

Its use does not deplete it.

大(攷⁵⁷⁴/攷)若(𡗗⁵⁷⁵/𡗗),

Great/big strike/examine/research like short

Great examining is like being short,⁵⁷⁶

⁵⁶⁷ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 盛. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it's a phonetic for 成 though it's strange that it's more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城.

⁵⁶⁸ This character is cut off a bit but still definitely 若 (𡗗 vs 𡗗). The character after is blurry, but still probably 夬 (夬 vs 夬). 夬 in Kroll means to divide/break-through, and resoluteness. These are like those of 決 (as mentioned in Shuowen Jiezi, “分決也”), which means break through, flow out, break off, and decidedly/decisive, determined.

⁵⁶⁹ There are some contradictions “X like Y” in the Guodian, but this may be one, given 盛's feeling of “contain”.

⁵⁷⁰ In this chapter, first the left line is cut off, then the right, but they are all consistent with the shape of 甬 → 甬

⁵⁷¹ 𦐇 Zi.tools lists this under 𦐇 (𦐇)(and 采 over 市 → 𦐇), but the entries in each page look essentially identical). Zi.tools holds that 𦐇 represents a tattered towel or worn-out clothes, and was the old form of 敝.

⁵⁷² Filling to somewhere in the middle, not to the edge – if you fill past the edge it is overflowed and wasted. A vessel is full before it overflows, when the meniscus is between the bottom and the top—the middle. This could also be “empty vessel” (盂), but “to the middle” should at least be considered.

⁵⁷³ Originally 身 under 𠂔 according to Henricks, Cook, zi.tools and the slips. Zi.tools lists this under 窮 → 窮 (go to the end of, spent, thoroughly studied, depleted, last resort, to be trapped/cornered, failure, cease), other Chu characters agree better with these, though it could be an abbreviation. There is also 穿 (穿) → 穿 (cave (穴) + tooth (牙); to penetrate, pass through; later to put on clothes (cover the body)). A roof (宀) over a body (身) lends itself to the idea of clothing oneself, and I wonder if the similarity visually between a character meaning to make a cave/hole with teeth (bite through, penetrate) and a character meaning to cover put a “roof” over one's body (wear clothes) would result in our modern understanding of 穿. Zi.tools has 躬 and 躬 as meaning 身, so I favor 窮 → 窮

⁵⁷⁴ 攷 Right side is definitely 攷. The left is probably 𠂔. Zi.tools has this as 攷 (knock, strike, examine, analyze, research). 𠂔 means the experiential skill of an artisan, craftsmanship. This *could* be 攷 (with 攷 = 攷 as usual), meaning wash, cleanse, sometimes in Chu for 修 (to cultivate, cleanse (esp. internally), or let flow). See A:1 (攷)

⁵⁷⁵ I would have said 𠂔 left of 止 (止) or 之 (之) but 出 (出) works better. Zi.tools and Wiktionary both mention that this character is a variant of the Wu (吳, kingdom east of Chu) dialectal character 𠂔 (short in length or height), (<https://dict.variants.moe.edu.tw/dictView.jsp?ID=80344>). But maybe 𠂔 → 𠂔 → ancient form of 拙 (clumsy).

⁵⁷⁶ Not in the sense of brevity or time, but in terms of height or length. Perhaps seeing things from a different point of view, like a short child? Or bending over to get a better look at something, to really examine it in detail? If this is great striking, perhaps this advocates for striking in a low stance?

大(茲/盛/成)若(𣎵/𣎵)⁵⁷⁷,

Great completion/containment like obtuse/dull-witted/rude/bent/bend/subdue/humiliate/diminish
Great completion is like being bent,

大(𣎵/植)若⁵⁷⁸(𣎵/屈)。⁵⁷⁹

Great/big plant-in-ground/embed/implant/organize/growth(plants) like bend/curl/do-wrong/humiliate
Great planting is like curling over.

梟(𣎵⁵⁸⁰/勝)(𣎵/蒼⁵⁸¹/滄),

Birds-chirping/cicadas-buzzing/clamor/din overcomes/excels green-gray/grizzled/shadowy-and-distant
Birdsong and buzzes overcomes the shadowy and distant.

(𣎵/青)(𣎵/勝)(𣎵⁵⁸²/燃),

Green(Of plants?) overcomes burning,
Living green overcomes the burn.⁵⁸³

清清⁵⁸⁴(𣎵⁵⁸⁵/為)天下(𣎵/定)。

Clear/pure/evident/honest(x2; the highest clarity?) do/use world settle-down/decide/secure/stabilize.
Highest clarity enforces stability under heaven.

B:7 Commentary:

Great completion being like breaching through (or resolute, or breaking away, or dividing; 夬), and its use does not result in deterioration or becoming worn out. This word with the connotations of breaking through something recalls the “piercing” from A:5 and A:7. However, I am honestly not sure how this breaking away or breaching through relates to the never-deteriorating usage/“doing” of the great completion. Perhaps this is the breaking away from the completed achievements, not dwelling in them, so that they remain evermore (A:9). If one understands great completion to be resolute, the undamaged state of the great completion is from its determination and unwavering nature, which makes some sense but may fly contrary to the ideas of WuWei. For that reason I favored the reading of “breaching through”, but both are possible.

⁵⁷⁷ May be 紕 in meaning, but slips, Henricks, and Cook agree.

⁵⁷⁸ Blurry, but consistent with 若

⁵⁷⁹ According to Cook, B:7 ends here, and so my count and Cook’s get thrown off here.

⁵⁸⁰ Technically, zi.tools has 𣎵 over 力, Cook has 𣎵, which probably should be 乘 over 力. Most accurate would probably have been 𣎵 over 力. 𣎵 and 𣎵 seem to be an ancient form of 乘 (ascend, go up, according to Wiktionary.) It seems that regardless, this character combination was a Chu way to express 勝 (excel, overcome, prevail, superlative, totally). This fits with rise and power (力) components well enough that I don’t challenge it.

⁵⁸¹ Clearly has the grass component on top, and not the water component. This 蒼 refers to green-gray, the color of far off mountain forests and undergrowth, but also gray-black in the sense of “grizzled” like farmers, and also silver, shadowy and faint, like the pale moon. 滄 has a sense of iron-gray-blue, like the cold or deep water.

⁵⁸² 𣎵 Cook has this as 然, as does zi.tools, but consistently, this character is expressed as (𣎵/𣎵) in the Guodian. It could be as in Korean 𣎵 (to burn), or the sense of 然 in the Shuowen Jiezi, which is also to burn.

⁵⁸³ In the WuXing, Wood generates fire (not really overcoming it), so this is a bit interesting. According to the Shuowen, 青 is associated with wood (“東方色也。木生火”).

⁵⁸⁴ 𣎵 Appears to have a duplication mark, but Cook treats this as 清清 or the reverse, to be read as 清靜

⁵⁸⁵ The form of 為 in Laozi B looks more similar to 象 with two lines above it, and a boxed-off bottom. (𣎵 vs 𣎵), Laozi A tends to express 為 like 𣎵, more horizontal, sometimes underlined.

Middle being sufficient, unceasing or without depletion: The middle has been mentioned as valuable, and even the source of efficacy in the Guodian (A:12-A:13, alluded to in B:5). Indeed, as the center of the shuttle of the loom, the emptiness in the center enables the tireless work of the loom. However, this refers to great filling. Therefore, this could refer to filling something half-way or at least not at the very top or bottom (see A:20), or this could be an allusion to achieving emptiness (lack of accumulation, the source of the loom shuttle's efficiency) by defending the core. As for the use not ceasing: a vessel filled only part-way still will always have room for more (so long as that "middle-ness" is maintained); and of course the empty center will never exhaust its usage for the loom shuttle of A:12-A:13.

Great examining (or research, or striking) is like being short, great completion is like being bent, great planting is like curling over. Great analyzing or examination being short makes sense: people often bend over or crouch to get closer and better examine something, or even just squat/sit down and think for a while, or even just to get a look at something from a different angle. Naturalists do this all the time, examining something on the ground or ducking low to watch something from a hidden vantage point. Children are sometimes not fooled by the illusions of magicians, because from their short stature and upward gaze, they see the trick when adults would not. A straight, dignified posture is not how one gets the best look at something⁵⁸⁶. Great planting being like curling over makes sense – saplings and sprouts often bend back toward the ground when they are young, and even tree branches droop. But the act of someone planting seeds is bending the back, squatting down, digging in the soil. As for great completion being bent, one rarely finishes a great undertaking without bending over with exertion, wiping the sweat from their face, catching their breath. Again, grand things are not done with a straight back: if the work is worthy and complete, the worker is often hunched over, working on it or resting to preserve oneself.

Birdsong and/or the buzzing of insects overcoming the shadowy and distant (or the green-gray). In dense forests or misty mountains, one hears the birds and insects clearly without seeing them. Even though one cannot see them, their noise overcomes this hiddenness so that one can still appreciate them, or at least become aware of them. Alternatively, in the case that it is the state of being grizzled being overcome (as 蒼 can also have this sense), perhaps even in the weathered, tough, experienced veterans of the world can have their nature softened and rejuvenated by these sounds, but I think that is a much farther interpretive stretch.

Living green overcoming the burn: One, especially an American, may be tempted to point to the pine barrens that actually require fire and burning for regeneration, but these ecosystems do not exist in China as far as I know (at least not anymore). Regardless, even after devastating fires, the plants and trees do grow back and retake the damaged area. From a WuXing perspective, it is interesting that there is something of a reference to wood overcoming fire, when the relationship is usually considered to be fire being generated from wood, wood conquering earth, and water conquering fire. Of course not everything has to relate to WuXing, but I thought it was worth pointing out anyways. This could be evidence that the ideas of WuXing were not so cemented in the consciousness of scribes or their masters, or that the WuXing understanding is being deliberately being deviated from, or these may not be related to the WuXing at all.

Highest clarity enforcing stability in the world; perhaps having a clear view of the world as it really is, seeing it from that low vantage point, up close in the details, allows one to know how to manage the world or oneself in it. One perceives the great even in these lower forms – short, bent, curled through this clarity. Rather than expansive knowledge on artificial ideas and arguments, adhering to the

⁵⁸⁶ Alternatively, if 攷 refers to strike, a straight upright posture is often not the best way to deliver a blow. In Chen Style Taijiquan, the knees do not lock straight, and many of the stances are lower than the Wuji neutral stance. In other martial arts, old and modern, there is a degree of lowering one does to widen the stance or increase the power of the strike.

expectations of how the world should be, this clarity enables one to look at what nature actually brings about, how the world actually is (A:1). Alternatively, this clarity brings one to understand where to find stability and safety in the world. Clarity allows one to lower oneself, and lowering oneself, perhaps, is the source of this stability. Water is most stable collecting at the bottom of the basin, making a lake or sea; water seeks this, flowing downward (see A:2). Low stances in martial arts often prevent one's opponent from knocking them down, by sinking one's weight. Stability is found on the ground, not climbing high on precarious mountains.

Received 45 (B:7)

大成若缺

Great accomplishment/completion like smashed/in-pieces/defective/splintered/in-shreds/incomplete

Great completion is like being in shreds,

其用不弊

Their/its employ/use not destroyed/ruin/wasted/detriment/fall-down/abused

Its use does not ruin it.

大盈若冲

Big/great filling is like an empty/sublime

Great filling is like emptiness,

其用不窮

Their use/employ not spent/depleted/reach-an-end/cease/failure

Its use does not deplete it.

大直若屈⁵⁸⁷

Great straight/upright/confront/on-duty similar-to/like curl/bend/do-wrong/humiliate

Great straightness is like being bent.

大巧若拙

Big/great craftsmanship/skill like unskilled/awkward/clumsy/inept

Great craftsmanship is like being inept.

大辯若訥

Big/great argue/debate/quarrel/eloquence like stutter/stammer

Great debating is like stammering.

躁勝寒

Restless/agitated/impulsive/impetuous/rash/disturb overcomes cold/frigid/lacking/alooof/ignoble

Agitation overcomes freezing

靜勝熱

Stillness/motionless overcomes hot/heated/fever/excited/aroused/inflamed/vehement/ardent

Stillness overcomes heatedness

清靜為天下正

Clear/pure/evident/honest/lucent/clarity stillness do/use/act-as heaven under proper/correct/rectify

Clear stillness acts as the world's correction.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing:

Where the Guodian says that great completion is like breaching through, the received holds that it is like being in shreds, in pieces, smashed, incomplete. Though less overtly, the received advocates for weakness rather than an assertive, piercing action (see also A:5; A:19). Rather than breaking through to

⁵⁸⁷ Mawangdui B has 掘, apparently, Mawangdui A has 誦

clarity or wisdom by piercing and breaking through (A:5, A:7) as the Guodian suggests, the received does not take this position. What the received may mean here could be that the great completion, or seeking it, results in the smashing or shredding of someone in the process; or that great completion appears like being destroyed or broken. Both agree that the use of the great completion does not result in its deterioration or ruin.

Where the Guodian says great filling is like the middle, the received takes the more extreme position of saying this is emptiness (see A:3 for a similar treatment of desire). Middle or empty, both agree that great filling cannot be depleted.

In the received, great straightness is like being bent, great craftsmanship is like being inept, and great debating is like stammering; the received leans more into the opposites theme than the Guodian, in which all three lines of great something involve bending, curling, or becoming short, essentially going down in some way. To be fair, the received also speaks to a lowering in a sense: bending is the same, stammering is lowering the quality of speech, and ineptitude is lowering the quality of skill, but this is much more abstract.

Where birdsong or buzzing of insects overcomes the shadowy and distant (or see above for other options) and green overcomes the burn in the Guodian, the received has agitation overcoming freezing, and stillness overcoming heat, or impetuousness, or impulsivity. This may be more of the trope of the lesser overcoming the greater, or the more subtle overcoming the more obvious, the soft overcoming the forceful, but again, this is a bit abstract.

In the Guodian, true clarity brings stability, but in the received, the clarity of stillness corrects the world, representing another example of the received using stillness to exact some kind of control over the world, correcting it to some model. The Guodian instead uses a word to secure or stabilize, to set in place, not so much control. See also A:5, A:7, and A:13 for similar treatments of stillness in the received as contrasted to the Guodian.

Guodian (B:8)

(𠄎/善)⁵⁸⁸(𠄎/建)⁵⁸⁹者不(𠄎/拔)⁵⁹⁰,

Skilled/favorable establish/found/propose/enact {person/phrase} not uprooted/drawn-out/capture/molt

Those skilled at establishing are not uprooted,

善(𠄎/休)⁵⁹¹者不兌⁵⁹²,

Skilled/favorable resting/take-break/blessing/fortunate {person} do not delight/opening/mouth/cave

Those skilled at resting do not open passages,

子孫⁵⁹³以其(𠄎/祭)⁵⁹⁴(𠄎/祀)⁵⁹⁵不(𠄎/乇)⁵⁹⁶。

Children grandchildren by-means-of their sacrifice sacrifice/year not leaf/branch/cut(?)/divide(?)

Children and grandchildren, by means of their sacrifices and ceremonies, do not branch away.

𠄎/攸⁵⁹⁷之身, 其(惠/德)⁵⁹⁸乃貞⁵⁹⁹。

That-which/swift this/[‘s]/to-go body/self, their virtue/power indeed/then steadfast/chaste/correct

That which goes to the self, its virtue will then be steadfast.

攸之(爰⁶⁰⁰/家), 其(惠/德)(又/有)(𠄎⁶⁰¹/舍)。

That-which/swift this/[‘s]/to-go home/family/household, their virtue/power has/exists dwell/save

That which goes to the home, its virtue will have a dwelling.

⁵⁸⁸ 8 characters from the bottom of strip 15 of Laozi B, according to the Jingmen Museum photos. I don't know what the DaoisOpen facsimile is doing. This character is faded but still consistent with 善.

⁵⁸⁹ In zi.tools and in reality, technically 𠄎, listed under 建

⁵⁹⁰ 𠄎 over 木 in both Cook and Henricks, zi.tools lists this as 𠄎申天, under 拔, Liushutong script agrees.

⁵⁹¹ 𠄎 This is not 保. Cook has 𠄎 + 𠄎, and I agree. Zi.tools has this as 𠄎. This does not match the 保 in A:1 𠄎 A:5 𠄎 A:20 𠄎. Zi.tools describes both as hands protecting a baby. Maybe this is a variation between Laozi A and Laozi C in selected character variants, maybe an abbreviation. This also resembles the Chu entry in zi.tools of 休(𠄎), though somewhat less well. Zi.tools and CRY (through Cook) has 休 as equivalent to 休, so I accept 休.

⁵⁹² 兌: weird line, but consistent with 兌. Because this lacks 𠄎, this “open passages” I’m treating as a verb, not a noun (See B:6 and A:15). While this could be “delight”, it would be strange for resting would deprive joy. Even if 𠄎 is 保, protecting/guarding should also result in happiness, though it would prevent open passages.

⁵⁹³ 𠄎 The = here likely represents a combined character. 𠄎 = 孫 according to zi.tools, 𠄎 is 子. Neither Cook nor Henricks mention this is a split character. I guess this works, I don't know enough to be suspicious of it.

⁵⁹⁴ Zi.tools lists this under zi/𠄎夕父示 and this is more accurate, but it is still listed under 祭.

⁵⁹⁵ 祭祀 is a paired phrase according to Wiktionary, meaning “to offer sacrifices to gods/spirits/ancestors” or honor or worship by rite. 祭 has a connotation of sacrifices with meat (and possibly wine)

⁵⁹⁶ 𠄎=乇, meaning growing leaf or blade of grass according to Wiktionary and Shuowen through Zi.tools. Wiktionary also considers this a variant of 託, entrust. See Cook pg 305; this could be read as to “cease” or “sever”.

⁵⁹⁷ Listed under zi.tools as 攸, what I see is closer to 攸 to the left of 攸. Made of similar components there is 攸, which zi.tools calls a variant form of 赴 (to go to, proceed to, throw oneself into (a task), carry out and follow through on). The crossroad/step radical (攸) next to the hand-holding-something meaning hit or tap radical (攸/攸) lends itself more readily to mean moving to do something. 攸, for its part, means “move swiftly, smoothly slipping by, rushing, place, place where, or “that which”/ “they who”. I favor 攸 based on the other examples in zi.tools.

⁵⁹⁸ Or 惠. 𠄎 on the slips everywhere it occurs in this chapter.

⁵⁹⁹ Originally was 貞 without 𠄎, written a bit strange: 𠄎→𠄎. Zi.tools has this as 貞, but it is an odd one out, most look like 貞, but I have not found anything that resembles 貞 over 田 more. 貞 in Chu is often expressed as 貞.

⁶⁰⁰ There's a fair amount of variation in this character as listed by zi.tools, this one happens to be 爰, the next is 爰

⁶⁰¹ Technically listed under 舍 in zi.tools.

攸之(𠂇⁶⁰²/背), 其(惠/德)乃(𠂇/長)。

That-which/swift this/['s]/to-go back/north/departed/earlier, their virtue/power then mature/long
That which goes to the departed, its virtue will then mature and last long.

攸之邦, 其(惠/德)乃(𠂇/奉)。

That-which this/['s]/to-go state, their virtue/power then received-with-respect/offered/respected
That which goes to the state, its virtue will then be offered up.

攸之天下⁶⁰³□□□□ (其德乃溥)

That-which this/['s]/to-go under-heaven/world □□□□ (one's virtue will then large/vast)
That which goes to the world, its virtue will then be vast.

□□□□ (以身觀身)

By-means-of self observe/display/behold/watch-intently self
{Intently observe the self through the self,}

□□□(家/家), (以家觀)

□□□ family/household, (by-means of family/household observe/display/behold/watch-intently)
***{Intently observe} the home {through the home,}*⁶⁰⁴**

以背(𠂇/觀)⁶⁰⁵背,

By-means of back/north/departed/earlier observe/display/behold/watch-intently back/departed/earlier.
***Intently observe the departed through the departed,*⁶⁰⁶**

以邦觀邦,

By-means-of state observe/display/behold/watch-intently state
Intently observe the state through the state,

⁶⁰² Zi.tools and Cook have this under 向, Henricks has 背, possibly with 日 on the bottom: the closest I could find sort of like this was 皆, which in the Guodian according to zi.tools presents as 𠂇. The etymology of 向 depicts a mouth (口) under a roof at home (宀), meaning an echo in place, but the Chu form has a top that looks almost like that of 𠂇/善, really suggesting that this is indeed really 背 (by zi.tools a variant of 背 or 皆 (all, every), by 北 (北) over 日/甘 (甘). 北 originally had a meaning of depart or separate, from two people facing opposite directions; it later came to mean “north”, the direction one faces away from. In the Songs of Chu, it is mentioned in 招魂, “Summoning the Soul” and 大招 “great Summons” that north is a dark, dangerous place from which death emerges and toward which dead souls depart. 𠂇 could represent 北 over 日, speech toward the departed: prayers for them or memories of their words. If it is the sun on the bottom (日), it could be literally “put your back to the sun → north itself”. If the bottom is 甘, it could also be “turning away from sweetness” or “sweetness for the departed”, but this is even more of a reach. 𠂇 also resembles 背, meaning “the back of a vertebrate, back of an object, north side, behind, secret” or to turn one’s back on someone or something, reject and disobey. 向 can have a meaning of direction, “Toward, inline toward,” but also “earlier, formerly, recently, just-now.” This character is unsure and much of this footnote is speculation, but given the mention of sacrifices for the ancestors earlier in the chapter, I am comfortable translating this in some way “toward the departed”, especially in some honoring, memorial, or thanksgiving way (but also tutelary or as prayer).

⁶⁰³ Honestly this character doesn’t survive and very little of it is seen, not enough for me to confirm it is even 下.

Missing characters in Italics from Cook.

⁶⁰⁴ Perhaps “home” in this sense carries a connotation of family and kin – those you live with. Observe your kin through no outside lens, just from one’s experience and theirs.

⁶⁰⁵ By zi.tools, and actually on the slips, 見 to the left of 𠂇. This 𠂇 literally means stork or heron, a bird that stands very still in shallow waters, watching intently, striking when a fish comes into view. This is a very intent watching. In the images from the Jingmen Museum that I have, these are mostly hard to make out, but the shapes are consistent from what I do see.

⁶⁰⁶ Perhaps “observe the departed” refers to one’s memories and honoring them, rather than societal constructions.

以天下觀天下。

By-means-of under-heaven/world observe/display/ behold/watch-intently under-heaven/world

Intently observe the world through the world.

(虛/吾) 可以智天□□□□ (下然? 以此。)

I/me possible by-means-of know heaven (*under thus/this-way/to-be-so/burn? By-means-of this.*)

How is it possible that I know {the world is like this? Through this.}

B:8 Commentary:

Those skilled at establishing are not uprooted, those skilled at resting (or guarding) do not open passages:

Large trees with deep roots and heavy wood are not so easily torn from the ground even in the worst of storms. One who is good at finding one's place and locking it in is not so easily dislodged from it. This is common sense. Those skilled at resting or guarding not opening passages is also intuitive. If one is resting, one does not want whoever entering into their lives and making it complicated or busy, and for guarding, of course one is wary about who is allowed to pass into their lives similarly. Keeping passages closed limits the chaos that can drift into one's life and disturb one's rest or safety.

Children and grandchildren, through rituals like ceremonial sacrifices during the year, do not branch off from each other (or otherwise become divided). It's worth mentioning that this certainly isn't the "laugh at rituals" breed of Daoism we're talking about. For all of the distrust in the state (that line could even be "that which goes to the state, its virtue will then be offered up" – perhaps not exactly a glowing encouragement), not a bad word is being said about the dead, the family, or the ancestors – just against factions and the "tribal" thinking of political intrigue of clans. This, in combination with the mourning rituals mentioned in C:3, is worth mentioning. The Guodian does not seem to be anti-ritual or anti-tradition in its entirety, but is choosy about which traditions should survive. Honoring one's ancestors, defending one's households, minding one's dependents, and mourning the dead are not criticized. The worship of kings and lords, the admiration of the scholars and nobles; these are more the traditions that draw criticism from the Guodian; rituals that broadcast and announce virtue and power, communicate loyalty to a political or societal power.

To mention the dead for a bit: in ancient Chinese culture, much ink has been printed about how ancestor veneration was a ritual system for managing potentially dangerous spirits and maintaining good luck and safety for the living. However, the ancient Chinese were also human, and love, grief, and missing people is not an ignorable dimension in a document that *does* deal with self-preservation and mourning. Rituals of mourning and of memorial, at least as far as I can empathize from rituals of my own culture, are not just cosmic maintenance – how can they be, when familial love and familiarity and grief and memory are such natural processes? Such emotions, psychological states, actions, and rituals are also how humans deal with having a relationship with someone who is gone. Parents, grandparents, partners, close friends, siblings, in the worst case, children – those closest to a person help shape who they are, their self, and when they leave their body behind and die, of course their self responds. The loss and remembering does something, the actions and rituals done to express these also do something to the self, perhaps to keep it grounded. In addition, it may do something to keep the communities left behind bonded to each other.

There is a story in the Zhuangzi (Chapter 18), dating at latest to sometime in the Han Dynasty, that recalls the death of Zhuangzi's wife. His fellow finds him banging on a basin or pot like a drum and loudly singing. When his fellow (Huizi) asks why, Zhuangzi explains that of course he is sad that she is gone, but she exists in a different way now, and that this is just the way of nature and life, like the seasons changing. Initially I perceived this reaction by Zhuangzi as callous and detached, but after reading more of the Guodian, and having my own lived experience, I see this much differently. His drumming and singing may not be a desperate attempt to escape his overwhelming grief, but rather a very

authentic expression of that grief that is true to both his and her nature. It may not be burning incense at an altar, but perhaps this musical performance would be something she recognized to honor her; his genuine self remembers and honors her genuine self. In the same chapter of the Zhuangzi, the titular master converses with a skull in his dream about the bliss of the dead, an interesting passage to include after mentioning the death of his wife and his reaction. Many mourners, for sure now and perhaps back then, wonder if their departed are happier and more comfortable in this new state of existence, even if it is death; this is a natural thing many mourners consider after the death of a loved one, especially if they died of painful illness. Death is confusing. Cultures create fixed rituals and timelines that give a sense of what this part of life should look like, but for every individual, for every *self*, the reality is not so cookie-cutter. I now close this aside, and we return back to B:8 of the Guodian

That which goes to the body has steadfast virtue; the importance of the self emerges elsewhere in the Guodian, especially B:4. What one applies to the body should be steadfast and reliable as its virtue, as perhaps this pertains to survival.

That which goes to the home/family has virtue that will have a dwelling/home; perhaps this pertains to the responsibility, protection, cooperation, and mutuality of being in a family. This family is not necessarily a clan; but rather the inherently human relationships of one with their parents, grandparents, siblings, spouse, children, and grandchildren. What one invests into their family, or even into their home, the place they belong and should find stability, will bring one to dwell somewhere rather than drift from place to place. Perhaps this relates to the “dependents” mentioned in A:1. Confucianism does not have a monopoly on the mutual relationship of responsibility and depending between family members, and certainly in most healthy families there is an assumption of some level of love or at least care.

That which goes to the departed (possibly – see that footnote) will have a long-lasting, maturing virtue; ancestor veneration has been part of Chinese culture since the Shang dynasty at least. Remembering and honoring the departed allows their presence in the family to last far longer than their lives. One does not need to go out and accomplish great feats that bring fame and recognition in order to remain important to people. By venerating one’s ancestors, one encourages the later generations to venerate oneself one day.

That which goes to the state offers up its virtue; perhaps this frames working for the state as altruistic (which may not actually be a positive trait in the Guodian, which seems to greatly value protecting and withdrawing the self). Alternatively, this is very literal; that which goes to the state is offered to the state. Talent and labor are (or should be) received by the state with respect.

That which goes to the world will have vast virtue. The world is vast, and so things of the world should also be vast. I will not comment too much on this, as this is reconstructed from the received.

It is worth noting that the Guodian tracks virtue from the small to the largest, the self within the home/family, within the genetic line (family living and dead), within the state, within the world.

Then, the Guodian instructs one to view things through themselves; the self through the self, the home through the home, the departed through the departed, etc. The narrator knows what they know through this. Observing things as they are, not through a filter or a lens, gives true understanding.

Received 54 (B:8)

善建者不拔

Skilled/favorable establish/found/propose/enact {person/phrase} not uprooted/drawn-out/capture/molt
Those skilled at establishing are not uprooted,

善抱者不脱

Skilled/favorable embrace/hug/enwrap {person} not strip-off/shed/peel-away/fall-off/extricate/remove
Those skilled at enwrapping are not shed away,

子孫以祭祀不輟

Children grandchildren by-means-of their sacrifice sacrifice/year not stop/suspend/interrupt

Children and grandchildren, by means of their sacrifices and ceremonies, go on uninterrupted.⁶⁰⁷

修之於身其德乃真⁶⁰⁸

Refine/cultivate/prepare/tapering this in/at body/self, their virtue/power then true/authentic/pure

Cultivating this in the self, its virtue is then authentic.

修之於家其德乃餘

Refine/cultivate/prepare this in/at family/home/household, their virtue/power then surplus/remainder

Cultivating this in the home, its virtue is then more than sufficient.

修之於鄉其德乃長

Refine/cultivate/prepare this in/at countryside/hometown, their virtue/power then long-lasting/mature

Cultivating it in the hometown, its virtue is then long enduring.

修之於國其德乃豐

Refine/cultivate this in/at country/state, their virtue/power then abundant/luxuriant/rich/serving-tray

Cultivating it in the state, its virtue is then luxuriant.

修之於天下其德乃普

Refine/cultivate this in/at heaven under, their virtue/power then pervasive/universal/impartial

Cultivating it in the world, its virtue is then pervasive.

故以身觀身

Thus/therefore by-means-of body observe/display/behold/watch-intently body

Thus, observe the self through the self,

以家觀家

By-means-of home/family/household observe/display/behold/watch-intently home/family/household

Observe the home through the home,

以鄉觀鄉

By-means-of countryside/hometown observe/display/behold/watch-intently countryside/hometown

Observe the hometown through the hometown,

以國觀國

By means of state/country observe/display/behold/watch-intently state/country

Observe the state through the state,

以天下觀天下

By means of heaven under observe/display/behold/watch-intently heaven under

Observe the world through the world.

吾何以知天下然哉,以此

I how/why by-means-of know heaven under thus/this-way/to-be-so/burn indeed/[!] By-means-of this

How do I know the world is this way? Through this.

⁶⁰⁷ Linnell is close to my translation, with “Thus children and grandchildren offer sacrifices, and so sacrifices do not stop.” However, both of us are kind of odd one’s out. Wu has “your descendants will carry on the ancestral sacrifice for generations without end.” Lau has “Through this the offering of sacrifice by descendants will never come to an end.” Chan has similar: “Thus from generation to generation his ancestral sacrifice will never be suspended.” Henricks has “And your sons and grandsons, as a result, will sacrifice without end.” My hesitation to treat 以 as “thus/as a result” is because it is not 故 and more often is translated as “through/by means of”, so I’d try harder to make it translate as the latter.

⁶⁰⁸ Variant of 真

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The divergence between the Guodian and received are slight but perhaps significant. The received and the Guodian agree that those who are skilled at establishing are not uprooted. However, where the Guodian follows with those skilled at resting (or guarding) not opening passages, instead the received has that those skilled at enwrapping are not shed away. I honestly struggle to see this as anything much more than a tautology, whereas the same line in the Guodian supports the advice to close ‘open passages’ mentioned elsewhere for protection or peace (B:6, A:15). Perhaps this enwrapping not being shed away is just a restatement of establishing not being uprooted, making oneself permanent and lasting.

The line with regard to children, grandchildren, rituals and either not branching off or going on uninterrupted, I treat as roughly the same between the versions.

Cultivating (presumably the Dao) or “that which goes to” in the self in the Guodian leads to steadfastness in virtue (at least according to my translation), and the received is perhaps not so different, leading to authentic/true virtue. I suspect the connotations of these two words (if they are even different) are quite similar.

Cultivating it or “that which goes to” in the home (family, household) results in virtue having a dwelling in the Guodian, but having a surplus in the received. The Guodian I follow – one’s home is the place someone always can go back to (at least usually or ideally), and so cultivating toward one’s family and home ensures that this stable “dwelling”, the shelter of one’s place of belonging, remains “inhabitable”. The received, however, uses the word surplus, sometimes in association with wealth (Chapters 20, 24, 53, 77, 79). This would be a rare occasion the word is used with an apparent positive valence, as far as I understand. What kind of surplus this is meant to convey (a surplus of the virtue itself?) is not totally clear to me.

I will not hazard to compare the third “cultivating”/ or “that which goes to” line as my translation rests on perhaps shaky ground, but whatever is in this slot, both the Guodian and the received agree that it is indeed long-enduring. Hometown or countryside also provides another expansion outward from the self and family, so the pattern of expansion is followed regardless.

Cultivating it or “that which goes to” in the state is characterized perhaps quite differently in the received than the Guodian. The Guodian maintains that going to the state, virtue is offered up, respectfully, but still given or received. The received simply describes this virtue as “luxuriant”, though the same word can be used to mean a high-end serving tray, so perhaps this offering-up connotation is preserved, even if faintly.

Cultivating it or “that which goes to” in the world: while both of my translations have “vast” or “pervasive”, I do not think it is fair to compare these given the damage erasing the original characters in the Guodian and my reliance on Cook to fill in the blanks.

The rest of the chapter is essentially the same in both versions.

Guodian (C:1)

大上下⁶⁰⁹智(又/有)之。

Great/big top/above/higher/supreme below/lowly know exist/have this[‘s]

Those below the greatest superiors know they exist.

其⁶¹⁰即, (𠄎/新)⁶¹¹(𠄎/譽)之。

Its/their exactly/if/instantly/take-over new/fresh/recently acclaim/commend/reputation/applause this.

Their taking over is met with fresh praise of them,

其既⁶¹², (𠄎/畏)⁶¹³之;

Its/their wholly/totally/completely/just-after dreadful/frighten/shrink-from/awe-inducing/exorcise this

Their completion is met with haunting them with fear,

其即, (𠄎/侮)⁶¹⁴之。

Its/they exactly/if/instantly/take-over offend/humiliate/disrespect them.

Their taking over is met with humiliation for them.

(𠄎/信)⁶¹⁵不足⁶¹⁶

Trust/faith/reliable/pledge not sufficient/enough.

Trust is not enough;

(𠄎/安/焉)⁶¹⁷ (有/又)不信。

Peace/quiet/how/where/than/[interrogative-pronoun] exist/have no trust/faith/reliable

From this, distrust exists,

(𠄎/猷/猶) (虐/乎), 其貴言也。

Design/similar to perhaps/at/in/“!” their cost/value words/speech

Yet still⁶¹⁸ it seems that their value is words.

⁶⁰⁹ Both of these in Guodian have an extra line below and above them, respectively, but this does not change their meaning. See zi.tools for 上 and 下.

⁶¹⁰ In the Guodian, this is always 𠄎 but the meaning is the same.

⁶¹¹ 𠄎 Technically 木 over 辛 to the left of 斤 under zi.tools, listed under 新 with many similar examples in zi.tools

⁶¹² 𠄎 If this is 即, this character is abnormal (usually expressed as 𠄎). This particular character is listed under 巳 to the left of 丶 inside of 次, listed itself under 既. 既 can mean completely, wholly, but also "just after" or "upon completion" or "as soon as". See also A:10

⁶¹³ 𠄎, 心 under 鬼 to mean 畏 (but listed under zi.tools as to mean 媿→悞), but could be read 畏 over 心 (→悞; ashamed, embarrassed). Cook has this as supposed to mean 畏. In A:5, I have this as “haunted”.

⁶¹⁴ 𠄎 Originally 𠄎 (矛 over 人). Zi.tools lists it under 侮 (offend, insult). Other entries under 柔(𠄎) are consistent with 𠄎(𠄎). 柔 means pliant, bendable, springy, or gentle, soften, tender, or placate, pacify, mollify, soften. It could be 侮, maybe a phonetic loan. Holding a spear to someone is a good way to insult or disgrace them, maybe.

⁶¹⁵ 𠄎 Technically 言 to the left of 人, listed as 信 in zi.tools under (𠄎言千, which is kind of wrong).

⁶¹⁶ Literally, this means “not feet”, but it really means it’s not enough. 足, in oracle bone, was a marching human leg, toward a destination. That your feet marched all the way to the destination, it became in the Zhou an abstract measurement meaning “full, complete, satisfied, sufficient”. Perhaps more viscerally this can be translated as “do not make it there”, or, more literally “has no legs (and thus cannot go)”.

⁶¹⁷ Originally like 𠄎 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安 and 𠄎. This one instance on the strips are faded.

⁶¹⁸ Elsewhere in my translation of the Guodian, I have taken 猷 as 猶, meaning similar to/like, or “designed/plan”. Here, I actually think that the original character’s definition of still/yet works best here. Shuowen Jiezi also lists “hesitant, timid, doubtful and cautious” as meanings of 猶, even relating the “like/similar to” to the act of planning and designing. I do not love the inconsistency in my own translation, so I note it here.

(盛/成)⁶¹⁹事(述/述)(社⁶²⁰/功),

Complete business/serve recount/rehearse/describe/follow merit/labor/work/achievement/excellence

Complete affairs, follow excellence, ⁶²¹

而百眚⁶²²曰

Yet/but/and hundred eye-cataract/shroud/aberration/ flaw/imperfection say/says:

Yet a hundred cloudy-eyed will say:

我自然⁶²³也。

“I/we natural/self-nature/self-determined/spontaneously/so-because-so.”⁶²⁴

“We are this way on our own.”

(古/故)大道(彖/發⁶²⁵),

Ancient/old//thus Great/big Dao stomps-down//shoots//abandons

Therefore, the great Dao is stomped down,

(安/焉)(有/又)(息/仁)義。

Peace/quiet//how/where/than/[interrogative-pronoun] has benevolence/empathy proper/dutiful⁶²⁶

From this, compassion and dutifulness exists.

(六/六)⁶²⁷(新/新)親不和,

Six/houses(?) new/fresh//parents/kin/intimate/close-to not harmonious

Houses that are new are not harmonious, ⁶²⁸

⁶¹⁹ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 盛. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Almost certainly, it’s a phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城.

⁶²⁰ 元工 originally, where zi.tools lists it. Zi.tools says this is the Chu form of 攻, a sacrificial name, but this character occurs next to 述 in A:20 – why use a totally different character. What we have, it is probably 攻 or 功 based on later versions, which is a deduction I’m hesitant to use. I have done this transcription and translation trying to stay as blind to WangBi, Mawangdui, and anything later as possible, but here I think I’ve hit a dead end. Visually it looks similar to 社 (god of the soil, sacrifices to this god, and sacred), but the element to the right on the slips is pretty unambiguously 工. Shuowen Jiezi is clear about 攻 having a strike/attacking meaning. Probably 功.

⁶²¹ Alternatively, “Complete business, record excellence”

⁶²² As 眚, and there are a few in zi.tools under 眚 that look like this too (and others that look normal).

⁶²³ Actually 然, being 然 without the fire radical on bottom. As natural as a dog eating meat. Later Han dynasty scribes added fire because dog-meat didn’t feel great for an abstract philosophical concept.

⁶²⁴ Cook has this as “We did it ourselves.”

⁶²⁵ See A:4. 變 according to Henricks, and I agree this is four feet over a hand. 彖, zi.tools agrees (𠄎 | 𠄎 | 𠄎 | 𠄎), under 發 as “tread on grass, stomp down or cut grass”, used in place for 發 (shoot (like an arrow), go out, set forth, emit, effuse, express, breach) 廢 (discard, abandon, abolish, remove, neglect, disabled) or 伐 (Hack, lop, strike, attack, denounce, condemn, boast; not likely this as this occurs in the Guodian in a much simpler form 𠄎)

⁶²⁶ 義: right-mindedness, proper, appropriate, dutiful and responsible, but all of these with special attention to one’s own clan or social group. Social consciousness.

⁶²⁷ Shuowen Jiezi discusses this in terms of the Zhouyi/Yijing, where six is the most yin that is turning into yang. Wiktionary and zi.tools say 六 may have originally meant house or shed, though Kroll only lists “six” and greatest yin. Cook thinks its “六新(親): referring to father and mother, elder and younger brothers, and wife and son(s).”

⁶²⁸ This is literally “Six new not harmonious”. The received has “六親不和”; the six relationships are not harmonious (see two footnotes above). The characters for occurs several times in the Laozi Guodian in the form right here, including in this very chapter. 親 does not occur in the Laozi Guodian, but still occurs in the Guodian (𠄎). I negotiate by translating this as “houses that are new”, but it very well could match that of the received: “The six relationships are not harmonious.”

(安/焉)(有/又)孝(孳⁶²⁹/孳)。

Peace/quiet//how/where/than/from-this have/exist filial-devotion multiply/breeding

From this, filial piety and produce children exists.

邦家⁶³⁰(緡⁶³¹/昏)(𠂔/亂⁶³²)

State family fishing-line/coin-string/deploy//twilight/incompetent be-confused/troubled/disordered.

The state's officials are incompetent and disordered,

(安/焉)(有/又)正⁶³³臣。

[Interrogative-pronoun] have/exist proper/correct/rectify subject/servant/anger/submission

From this, correct conduct and submission exists.

C:1 Commentary:

Those in superior positions, high rank, make themselves well known to all of those below, earning their praise, scrutiny, and resentment. They heap with new praise those who assume new power, but haunt those with power as well, and those with power, upon their failures, find humiliation under the collective gaze of the people.

“Taking over” is stated twice. This could be one ruler’s assumption of power, and then an attempt to assume yet more (and meeting humiliation in the attempt), or it could be that another new “superior” entity takes over the existing one, and the original meets humiliation this way. I am tempted to favor the second one, but for reasons external to the Guodian and the Dao De Jing. In the yarrow stalk method of consulting the Yijing (Zhouyi), “old yin”, the most yin you can get, changes into “new yang”, and “old yang”, the most yang you can get, changes into “new yin”. Once things reach their peak, they work to fall back down, and once things hit their lowest, they work to rise back up.

Trust (or faith, in pledges) is not enough, from this there is distrust, yet still their value is in their words: Elsewhere in the Guodian, words are repeatedly characterized as insufficient, superfluous, or less valuable in some way. This remark about the value placed on words regardless is a criticism consistent with elsewhere in the Guodian (A:1, A:15).

Complete affairs, follow excellence, and yet a hundred cloudy-eyed will say “we are like this ourselves.”

I struggle with this line as well. Perhaps this refers to the unobservant people not realizing their success is the result of the work of those with the Dao (or the Dao itself). Just as the overvaluing of words is not registered by the people, the completion of matters and emulation of excellence is rendered invisible, and thus not valued at all. However, elsewhere in the Guodian, “following” is not necessarily a positive thing (A:20), and striving to complete grand things in general is not always encouraged, especially considering WuWei, where things are done by not manipulating or interfering. Probably, those that accomplish much through WuWei are not necessarily those who become highly decorated and recognized for their accomplishments, and so their accomplishments are assumed by the oblivious as just the way things are.

⁶²⁹ 孳 Zi.tools has this as 孳 (propagate, multiply, breed)

⁶³⁰ Originally 𠂔 over 家 (as listed in zi.tools), sometimes written as 𠂔: 𠂔

⁶³¹ 緡, listed under zi.tools as 緡 → 緡, meaning fishing line, cord for stringing coins, and potentially “to cover”. It is unusual to add a radical to a character for decorative reasons, and 昏 on its own is used in B:5. By context, defaulting to meanings under 昏.

⁶³² Partially missing, Henricks reports 𠂔 Maybe originally 𠂔 → 𠂔 (in zi.tools, listed under 𠂔 to the left of 𠂔 to the left of 𠂔). 亂 means disordered or rebellious

⁶³³ 𠂔, technically 𠂔

Therefore, the great Dao is stomped down, and from this exists compassion and dutifulness. Clearly the great Dao being trampled is not an ideal situation, yet compassion and dutifulness emerges from this. Perhaps that compassion and dutifulness arise anyways even when the way of things is quashed is in itself latent workings of the Dao bringing things to stability (A:7). Alternatively, this could also mean that compassion and dutifulness are the artificial constructs used to bring order and peace in the absence of the primal, natural order doing so itself.

Reading literally as “six new not harmonious” presents some problems. If we read this line as “Houses that are new are not harmonious, and from this filial piety and producing children exist”: This line was initially quite confusing to me. The six here may refer to the six core family relationships (parents, elder/younger siblings, spouse, and children) (though this may only apply to the phrase 六親, which appears in the received, 六 alone may have been the initial form of “house”: see zi.tools and Wiktionary); when these are new, not rooted yet in time or familiarity, these relationships have not hit their stride, and so people rely on expectations of filial piety and the process of rearing their young to stabilize those relationships. This could be saying that old relationships that endure and last long are superior and more natural, but this could also, more latently, be the workings of the Dao, using the tendencies of familial cooperation and reproduction to help these relationships survive their early life before becoming naturally robust as they age. It’s worth noting that filial piety and reciprocal responsibility are indeed Confucian ideals, but, as I’ve written elsewhere, Confucianism does not have a monopoly on respect of the elders and mutual reliance. However, it’s probably more likely that this pair of lines offers what is left when the relationships of a household are not harmonious, keeping with the patterns found in the other pairs of lines in this part of the chapter.

Similarly, it is of course not ideal for the state’s officials (or clans) being incompetent and dysfunctional, and from this, things still are at least somewhat functional with correct conduct and respect to authority of the people. This propriety and agreeableness arises to counteract the chaos of suboptimal leadership, possibly a manifestation of the latent work of the Dao.

Received 17 +18 (C:1)

太⁶³⁴ 上 下 知 有 之⁶³⁵

Great/grand top/above/higher/supreme below/lowly know exist/have this[‘s]

Those below the greatest superiors know they exist.

其 次 親 而 譽 之

Their next-in-sequence parents/kin/intimate and/yet/but acclaim/commend/reputation/applaud this/[‘s]

Their next⁶³⁶ below are cherished like kin and praised.

其 次 畏 之

Their next-in-sequence dreadful/frighten/shrink-from/awe-inducing/exorcise this/[‘s]

Their next below are feared and dreaded.

其 次 侮⁶³⁷ 之

Their next-in-sequence offend/humiliate/disrespect this/[‘s]

Their next below are humiliated and disrespected.

⁶³⁴ 大 in both Mawangdui and Guodian, but this is normally interchangeable

⁶³⁵ Linnell has this as “The existence of the best ruler is barely known to the people”. Chinese often uses 下 to be an indicator of “those below X”. Even 天下 (world) is literally a noun “under heaven”, so I don’t think that 下 can be used to mean “barely” directly. It could be implied that this knowing is the only way people are affected, though

⁶³⁶ Most translations have “the next one down [below the greatest superiors]”, but MAYBE it’s a time sequence?

⁶³⁷ Both Mawangdui have 毋

信不足焉有不信焉

Trust/faith/reliable/pledge not sufficient/leg how/than/from-this exist/have no trust/pledge from-this
Trust is not enough, and from this there is distrust.⁶³⁸

悠⁶³⁹兮其貴言

Pensive/thoughtful/drawn-out/relaxed/wistful/uncertain [!] their value/prized/expensive words/speech
Wistful! Their value is words.⁶⁴⁰

功成事遂

Work/accomplishment/excellence complete/achieve/accomplish matters progress/succeed/respond
When work is completed, and matters are successful,

百姓皆謂我自然⁶⁴¹

Hundred surnames all called/say I/we self nature/so
The people all say “we are this way on our own.”⁶⁴²

大道廢有仁義

Big Dao discard/abandon/abolish/neglect/disabled have/exist humane/kind/benevolent proper/dutiful
When the Great Dao was abandoned, there existed benevolence and dutifulness.

慧智出,有大偽

Intelligence/discerning wisdom go/emerge/produce/send/exceed have big fabricate/artificial/deception
When intelligence and wisdom emerge, there is great fabrication.

六親⁶⁴³不和,有孝慈

Six/house parents/kin/intimate not harmonious have filial-piety tenderness/merciful-care/benevolence
When the six relationships are not harmonious, there is filial piety and merciful care.

國家昏亂,有忠臣

State family incompetent confused/disordered have wholehearted/dedicated/loyal servant/submission
When the state’s officials are incompetent and disordered, there is loyalty and submission.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: Rather than the Guodian’s “taking over” or “completion”, the received has “next (in a sequence)”, and most translate this as those below the greatest superior ones,

⁶³⁸ Lau has “When there is not enough faith, there is a lack of good faith”, and Wu and Chan has similar. Henricks has “When trust is insufficient, there will be no trust in return.” Waley has “Truly, it is by not believing people that you turn them into liars,” Lin has “When they do not command the people’s faith, some will lose faith in them.”

⁶³⁹ Mawangdui has 猷

⁶⁴⁰ Linnell has “Thoughtful! He values his words.” Lau has “Hesitant, he does not utter words lightly.” Chan has “[The great rules] value their words highly.” Henricks has “Hesitant! Undecided! Like this is his respect for speaking.” Waley has “But from the Sage it is so hard at any price to get a single word.” Lin has “And then they resort to oaths!” Wu has “The sage is self-effacing and scanty of words,” which I don’t follow. Cleary is somewhat similar to mine with this line and the one before” Therefore when faith is insufficient and there is disbelief, it is from the high value placed on words.”

⁶⁴¹ In the received, Chapter 17 ends here.

⁶⁴² Linnell words this slightly differently but with essentially the same meaning: “We are naturally so”. Wu has “We ourselves have achieved it!” Lau has “It happened to us naturally.” Chan has “[we] just follow Nature.” Henricks has “These things all happened by nature.” Honestly, these are essentially saying the same thing, that the result of the work is that people think it is just naturally so, whether that be how they are or what their circumstance is.

⁶⁴³ According to Cook (from notes in the Guodian), “六親: refers to father and mother, elder and younger brothers, and wife and son(s).”

arranging different rules by rank and the response of the people rather than describing a sequence of events. Rather than the Guodian's angle of "of course the people know about the great superior ones, they praise them, fear them, and disrespect them," the received frames this as though the greatest superior is someone the people are aware exists and that's about it, and the next best are those they love, next after that those they fear, and next after that those they humiliate.

Trust is not enough, and distrust exists, and their values put on words is consistent between versions, and roughly the same outside of some flavor text. The response when work is completed and matters successful is the same, though the kind of people are different: in the Guodian they are cloudy-eyed, in the received they are just the 100 families, the common people.

Benevolence and responsibility (or righteousness) in both versions is a product of some denigration off the Dao, either abandonment in the received or being trampled over in the Guodian. Filial piety and rearing children in both is a product of families lacking harmony in both versions. The governing people's incompetence and confusion results in similar results in both versions, in the Guodian correct conduct and submission, and in the received loyalty and submission. The received has an extra member of this section, again accusing increased knowledge and intelligence for deception and artificiality – this is not in the Guodian, or at least not what has survived.

Guodian (C:2)

(𠂔/𡗗/執)⁶⁴⁴大象⁶⁴⁵,

Arrive/devoting-oneself/gift-to-elder//uphold/set-forth great replica/imitation/image

What aligns oneself with the Great Image

天下(往/往)⁶⁴⁶。

Under heaven go/move/gone/go-towards/takes-refuge-with.

The world goes toward;

往而不(𠂔⁶⁴⁷/害),

Go/move/gone but not harm/abuse/destroy/misuse

They go toward it but there is no harm.

(𡗗/焉)⁶⁴⁸(𡗗⁶⁴⁹/坪)大。

How/where/from-this/[interrogative-pronoun] flat-land/level/flatten//tranquil/flat big/great.

Thereupon, the flatland great

樂(𡗗/與)⁶⁵⁰餌⁶⁵¹, (𡗗/恠)⁶⁵²(客/客)(𡗗/止⁶⁵³/止)。

Music/glee, mutual-sharing/unite/giving/joining/and cake/bait change-(minds?) guests/strangers limit

Gleefully grants cake – these influence the guests to halt⁶⁵⁴.

⁶⁴⁴ 𠂔 on the slips, zi.tools has under 𠂔, listed under 執, which Cook has. Henricks has 𡗗 (arrive/devotion), which is more supported by the slip images. I see 𡗗 to the left of maybe 用 over surely 女. Cook says maybe 執 or 設.

⁶⁴⁵ 𡗗 on the slips, Zi.tools has 𡗗 over 胃. 象 originally means “elephant” (which was mostly imagined based on bones by the time of the Warring states – elephants had shifted their range due to habitat loss and climate change; refer to Han Fei’s description of them) or “ivory”, and by extension “image, representation, icon, effigy, replica, apparition, figure”. It is indeed an image, but how realistic it is, how faithful to the truth it is, is such an open question that this word also refers to illusion. The character itself may be 胃 over 肉 but that may be redundant.

⁶⁴⁶ Duplication mark here. 往 also can mean both going and move toward. I choose move toward for ease of reading, and that it seems to be most supported by other more experienced translators, but it could be “leaving” too.

⁶⁴⁷ In zi.tools, listed as 𠂔害又, which I honestly don’t see. (Hand on top, or 夕?) It also does not resemble the other examples on the page or on the 害 page. Cook makes no mention of this abnormality, Henricks does not either. I am deeply uncomfortable assuming this character is just 害. 宜 by zi.tools looks closer but isn’t it (𡗗). See also A:2. Maybe contains 肉(𡗗)? Maybe also related to 蓋→盍(𡗗) but this is a stretch. I put 宜 or 害, uneasily. I default to 害, but I cannot help but wonder if this is something else.

⁶⁴⁸ Originally 𡗗 → 焉, though in zi.tools shows up under 安 and 𡗗.

⁶⁴⁹ Itself meaning flat land, from 《漢語變調構詞考辨》 through zi.tools under 平.

⁶⁵⁰ This may just be “and” rather than mutual giving, granting, rhetorical functions, etc.

⁶⁵¹ 𡗗 in the slips. Henricks has this as 餌, preserved in Korean and Kanji fonts. Means cake, eat with pleasure, bait

⁶⁵² 𡗗 in the slips, maybe 𡗗 but the Chu put extra strokes sometimes. (Normal form is like 𡗗) According to zi.tools, could be 過 (pass by, go beyond, excessive, trespass), 禍 (unblessed, divine misfortune), 化 (change, transform), 訛 (misspeak, blackmail). Maybe to change minds or hearts, given the heart radical, or change of heart, influence or convince?

⁶⁵³ 𡗗 Unable to find on zi.tools. To my eye looks like 𡗗 or 𡗗, or 𡗗. 𡗗 is from Cook; Henricks has this as 走 (止 over 𡗗). 止 can be run, or go, or limit (the end of, stop, halt). Conversely, 之 can mean “to go.” To reach limit?

⁶⁵⁴ I normally translate 𡗗 as “edge of” or “to the limit”, where one must stop. Here, guests stop as they are drawn in. This line could alternatively be “Music and cake – these influence the guests to halt.”

(古/故)道⁶⁵⁵□□ (𠄎/談)⁶⁵⁶可其(𠄎/無)(𠄎/味)也。(之/出)

Old//thus Dao/way talk/converse can/possible/able their lack/without taste/significance (['s] emerge)

Thus the Dao{'s emerging'} talk can be its flavorlessness.

(𠄎/視)之不足(𠄎/見)⁶⁵⁷,

Look ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough look.

Look at it but seeing it does not work.

聖⁶⁵⁸之不足(𠄎/聞/聞),

Noise//Sage/virtue/hear-correctly ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough hear/inform/reputation

Listen closely for it but hearing it does not work.

而不可(𠄎/既/既)⁶⁵⁹也。

But cannot upon-completion/wholly/just-now.

But it cannot be spent completely.

C:2 Commentary:

The “Great Image” is the result of what one can perceive, a world made of changing, temporary things, powered by the latent but inexhaustible Dao, that process that shapes all of it. This great image is the perhaps outline, the Dao is the subtle details that make it live, breathe, function, and change. The Great Image is the tangible matrix, easily observed, readily understood, stable, relatively obvious. Yet it is powered by the elusive, hard to perceive, everywhere-and-nowhere Dao. Aligning oneself with the observable nature of life, the “Great Image”, is to align oneself closer to the Dao in its own way, and because of this, all under heaven is drawn toward it, but not through duress or force, but rather by their own inclination.

The flatland giving cake influence the guests to halt: I think this may be an image explaining the above lines, referring to the joys of life, what is pleasant to the senses. The flatland means there needs to be no climbing or scaling down to reach it, just a gentle walk will do, and the bait is sufficient to stop everything in its motion to stay. The Dao is responsible for these, even if through the veil of the Great Image. Life and existence are not just some horrible, dangerous thing to eventually escape: it offers the joy of existing. The Dao, though itself quiet, tasteless, invisible, generates these wonders and pleasing sounds, flavors, and sights. Although this is an image, there does not seem to me an implication that it is fake; if it were, why would aligning oneself with it bring in everything in the world?

However, because of the latent nature of the Dao, talk of it can be rather unexciting, unstimulating, subtle, as it cannot be seen despite looking or heard despite listening, and yet, it is inexhaustible, supporting everything else.

⁶⁵⁵ Partly cut off but what is visible is consistent – missing characters from Cook, though see my note below. It could be 言 is not actually there, although Cook places it there, thinking there are three missing characters. I’m operating as though there are only two – the spacing on the slips I feel could go either way.

⁶⁵⁶ Partially obscured but it’s not water to the left, though Henricks and Cook say it is. Could be 赤 or 光 or 炎 on the right? 吓 (frighten)? 沾 (flash)? 談 (talk, chat, converse?) 啖 (to eat with pleasure, taste, feed)? 燻? Not finding this in zi.tools. It looks most like 談, and it might be Cook was wrong about how many characters were missing? As it happens, Mawangdui A also has 談.

⁶⁵⁷ These characters look slightly different on the slip: 𠄎 under 視 and 𠄎 for 見

⁶⁵⁸ 聖 = 聖 This character means possessing wisdom/judgment/moral excellence, profoundly wise and virtuous, master. I read it as “Hear correctly” or “hearing clearly”; so sage (聖人) is “person who hears clearly.”

⁶⁵⁹ See A:10 and C:1. This particular character is listed under 巳 to the left of 丶 inside of 次, listed itself under 既. 既 can mean completely, wholly, but also “just after” or “upon completion” or “as soon as”.

Received 35 (C:2)

執大象，天下往

Grasp/seize/capture big/great replica/imitation/image, world go/move/go-towards/takes-refuge-with
What grasps the Great Image, the world will move toward.

往而不害

Go/move/gone/go-towards/takes-refuge-with and/yet/but not harm/abuse/destroy/misuse
Go toward, yet there is no harm;

安平太

Peace/quiet/stable/install flatten//tranquil/flat great/grand
Peace, tranquility, and grandness.

樂與餌過客⁶⁶⁰止

Music/glee and/join/grant/give cake/bait, pass-through/trespass strangers/guests stop/cease/halt
For music and cake, passing guests halt.

道之出口⁶⁶¹淡乎⁶⁶²

Dao ['s]/this produce/put-out/arise/emerge mouth/taste/opening mild/bland/tasteless/insipid/mild [?!]
The Dao's emergent taste is tasteless!

其無味

Their lack/without flavor/taste/significance
Its lack of flavor:

視之不足見

Look ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough look.
Look at it but seeing it does not work.

聽之不足聞

Noise//Sage/virtue/hear-correctly ['s]/this not legs/sufficient/enough hear/inform/reputation
Listen closely for it but hearing it does not work.

用之不足既

But cannot upon-completion/wholly/just-now.
But it cannot be spent completely.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: There are not many differences between the Guodian and the received. Instead of aligning in the Guodian, there is grasping or seizing, a more perhaps aggressive word. Aligning is harmonizing, but grasping is like trying to control it and use it (for a similar tension, see A:11). Rather than the flat-land in the Guodian, there is peace, but both are great, and offering music/glee (I translate for glee in the Guodian for consistency elsewhere in the Guodian, but it could go either way without changing the meaning too much) and cake, causing the traveling guests or strangers to halt. Where the received has taste, the Guodian seems to have talk (as does Mawangdui A), but both are flavorless and not stimulating. Overall, the essence of the two versions appear to me the same.

⁶⁶⁰ Mawangdui has 格

⁶⁶¹ Mawangdui has 言也曰

⁶⁶² Mawangdui has 呵

Guodian (C:3)

君⁶⁶³子居則⁶⁶⁴貴左⁶⁶⁵,

Noble/gentlemen dwell/rest/reside norm/standard/rule/when-then expensive/costly/value-highly left

When the nobleman are at rest, then values highly the left,

(甬/用)(𠄎/兵)則貴右。

Bell/use/employ weapons norm/standard/when-them expensive/costly/value right

When using weapons, then values highly the right.

(古/故)曰：兵者，□□□□(不祥之器也。⁶⁶⁶)

Ancient/old//thus says, “Weapons □□□□ ([phrase] not favorable-omen [’s] instrument/capacity)

Therefore it is said, “As for weapons, they are {inauspicious instruments.}

□(得/得)已⁶⁶⁷而(甬/用)之[。](不)

Obtaining finishing/already/stop and/but employing it. (Not)

When one {cannot} find another way to end things, only then they are used.”

(鐏/鈛)⁶⁶⁸(𠄎/𠄎/襲)⁶⁶⁹為上，(弗/弗)(𠄎/𠄎/美)⁶⁷⁰也。

Sharp-tool/sharp/keen respect//cover/dress/attack do/use/act-as above/top, not beautiful/praise.

Covering weapons is superior action, not regarding them as beautiful.

(𠄎/美)⁶⁷¹之，是樂⁶⁷²(𠄎/殺/殺)人。

Beauty(?) [’s]/this, this music/glee kill/cut-down people

To regard them as beautiful is to find glee in killing people.

⁶⁶³ In the photographs I have, this character is obscured and darkened, but I can make out 𠄎 or something very similar, so I am fairly confident in 君.

⁶⁶⁴ 𠄎, so more accurately, 鼎 to the left of 刀, as it is listed on zi.tools, under 則. Can mean norm, standard, law, what is carved into the bronze ding cauldron, but also can mean if...then, and when...then, and also but/whereas

⁶⁶⁵ Left and right could be read literally, or left has associations with heterodoxy, deviance, sinisterness, but also auspiciousness, as the sun rises in the east and the king often faces south. Right has connotations of honor, but also war, as the warrior sits on the right side of the chariot, and is associated with the west, the setting sun.

⁶⁶⁶ From Cook, same with 不 on the next line.

⁶⁶⁷ 不得已 is a fixed phrase meaning “not obtaining (a way to) stop.” → cannot avoid.

⁶⁶⁸ 鐏 on the slips. 鐏 or 鐏. Under 鈛, zi.tools lists 金 to the left of 千 over 𠄎, which I cannot find fault in, but wonder about the stray vertical line between the two sides. Zi.tools has this defined as “ancient weapon” and “sharp tool.” More often, it is translated as simply “sharp”, or to sharpen.

⁶⁶⁹ 𠄎 Originally 𠄎+𠄎, supported by zi.tools. 𠄎 means “equal, fair, neat” as 𠄎 by zi.tools but it is not clear to me why. 𠄎 is respect, reverence, supply, by 襲, in turn by 恭. Mawangdui A has 襲 (raid, attack, invade, but also overcoat, to dress, to put a second layer of clothing, repeat, double, inherit, perpetuate, conform-to accept, follow along), Mawangdui B has 𠄎. I adopt 襲, as it contains 衣 (kind of similar to 𠄎), and makes sense in context.

⁶⁷⁰ 𠄎 → 𠄎 + 女 → 𠄎 → 美. See A:9 (𠄎). Originally I had “Sharpening and raiding acts as superior, not beautiful.”

⁶⁷¹ 𠄎 Under 𠄎 to the left of 女 in zi.tools, but written as 𠄎 over 𠄎, all next to probably 女. I am uncomfortable calling this 美: This does not look like the other instances of this character (though it could be a moment of bad handwriting). In the most technical sense, this is 羽 (as 习) over 𠄎, next to maybe 女. Cook mentions GR suggests this variant may convey a causative version, but Cook thinks this is already accomplished through the 弗 in the line above. The bottom box is like a mouth (𠄎), so perhaps this is to call something beautiful? But this is only for the second instance. Cook and Henricks also treat these two differently but translates both “modern equivalents” as 美.

⁶⁷² For both instances of this character, the left side appears to be faded, so that only one string is visible on the right. However, zi.tools gives enough examples that I’m fairly confident both characters in question are indeed 樂.

夫樂□□□□以(導/得)志(怡/於)天下。(殺者不可)⁶⁷³

Adult/in-any-case/husband glee □□□□ by-means-of obtain aspiration/intention in/at under heaven
Whoever is gleeful {in killing cannot} obtain their aspirations of the world.

(古/故)吉事上左,

Old/ancient//thus/so auspicious/benign/favorable matters/serve above/foremost/high left

So, benign matters are high priority on the left,

喪⁶⁷⁴事上右。

Grief/crying matters/serve above/foremost/high right

And matters causing grief are high priority on the right.

是以(變⁶⁷⁵/辨)(旉/將)(軍/軍)居左,

This by-means-of artificial-differentiation, brings/will/lead armies dwell left

By means of this, artificial differentiation brings the armies to dwell on the left,⁶⁷⁶

上(旉/將)軍居右,

Foremost/High bring/leader armies dwell right,

Primarily, one brings the armies to dwell on the right.

言以喪(豐⁶⁷⁷/禮)居之也。

Words by-means-of grief rich/abundance/fullness/pleasing//rites/rituals/formality dwells [‘s]/this

Words dwell in this warfare through grieving rituals.

(古/故)殺⁶⁷⁸□□則以(參/恣/哀)(參/悲)⁶⁷⁹位之; (人眾)⁶⁸⁰

Old//thus killing □□ when-then by-means-of mourn/grieve sadness/yearning/pity seat/position this

So, when killing {multitudes of people}, then one should sit with mourning and sadness.

(戰/戰)(參/勝)⁶⁸¹, 則以喪(豐/禮)居之。

Combat/struggle/tremble competence/overcome/conquer when-then by-means-of grief rites dwell this.

When one conquers and overcomes through combat, then one should dwell in mourning rituals.

⁶⁷³ From Cook again.

⁶⁷⁴ 𣦵, then 𣦵, then 𣦵 in this chapter, getting simpler each time but still having at least one of all of the components, seeming to differ mostly in the number of mouths. Zi.tools has all of these under 喪 (as 𣦵 𣦵 𣦵 𣦵 死) In Henricks, 𣦵, same thing three lines below and the two lines below that. Photos of the slips support this, looking at the Chu slip version of 死 under 哭 (which apparently can look like 九, with more mouths sometimes between. Cry and death seems to signify grief at least, and the Shuowen through zi.tools describes this as a “mournful sound”

⁶⁷⁵ 𣦵 Originally 𣦵, approximately. (𣦵 over 又). Could be 辨 (discrimination, differentiation, (ultimately artificial classifications), could be 𣦵→鞭 (whip) read (because of shared phonetics and a cut/boundary/dispute connotation) as 辯 (Confucian debate tactics, argumentation, (institutional) disputes) or 辨. By Cook, also could be 二 over 𣦵, could be 便. In zi.tools, 鞭 contains 𣦵, but its page leads to 辨. This is usually treated like 偏 in this chapter. See Cook “Bamboo Texts of Guodian”,

⁶⁷⁶ As 將軍 together can mean “leader of the army, general”, this could also be: “By means of this, artificial (???) generals dwell on the left, and high generals dwell on the right”.

⁶⁷⁷ According to zi.tools and Wiktionary 豐 is the original form of 禮, though it may be a variant of 豐 (luxuriant)

⁶⁷⁸ The bottom two thirds of this character are lost, but the top that remains is consistent with 殺.

⁶⁷⁹ Cook and Henricks swapped these, but looking at the photos of the slips, it should be 恣悲, not 悲恣.

⁶⁸⁰ Again from Cook.

⁶⁸¹ By zi.tools, technically 𣦵 over 力

C:3 Commentary:

The opening of the chapter helpfully defines the cultural meaning of left and right. Left is associated with nobles at rest, right is associated with the use of weapons.

What is said is that weapons are tools of last resort, one uses them when all other options have failed, when there's no other choice left. Combat is never really favorable – even many animals evolved communication and threat displays all to avoid the costs and catastrophes of really coming to blows. Weapons are not instruments of favorable outcomes or fortunate times, but rather an emergency tool one uses to survive and protect their families.

By this logic, covering up sharp weapons is a superior, higher kind of action than finding beauty in them, or adorning them to make them beautiful. To celebrate these weapons is to celebrate what they are capable of, what they are used to do – to injure and kill. It is not adaptive to take such pleasure and pride in warfare, and often it is not productive. The resources it drains, the people it consumes, the incalculable toll on the countless lives it demands – one truly cannot expect one to have success in the world if one enjoys war and violence to such a degree.

As a result, benign matters have priority on the left, the restful side, and matters of grieving have priority on the right. Mundane ordinary tasks, beautiful in their own right, enjoy their value on the left, and the deafening sorrowful cries and wails of widows, orphans, and parents belong on the right.

Artificial differentiation brings armies to dwell on the left: the intellectualization of war as a way to achieve peace, as a noble thing and an opportunity for glory, to make all of the weapons and bloodshed a collection of concepts and thoughts, can bring war to look like it belongs on the left. Propaganda praising and justifying war, when one is just thinking about it, can make warfare seem like it is a favorable, acceptable thing. However, the highest view of war, the primary, true placement of war, is solidly on the suffering-soaked, tear-stained, blood-drowned right. This could also refer to differently ranked generals (see the brief discussion below), though.

The Guodian suggests, presumably to combat this intellectualization and glorification of war, that words should adhere to grieving rituals when discussing war, that killing should be executed and reacted to with sadness and mourning, and that even military triumph should be met with funerary rites and grief rituals.

Received 31 (C:3)

夫佳兵者

In-any-case/man seemly/pleasing/attractive/gratifying weapons/warfare {person/phrase}

In any case, attractive weapons –

不祥之器

Not favorable-omen/auspicious/lucky ['s]/this instrument/tools/vessel

These are inauspicious instruments;

物或惡之

Thing/creature some/perhaps/sometimes/someone ugly/hateful/abhorrent ['s]/this

*Some things hate these.*⁶⁸²

⁶⁸² Linnell translates this as “Creatures detest them, no matter what”, but this reading is not supported by the definitions found in Kroll for 或 (or anywhere else I could find). Wu has “Even things seem to hate them.” Lau has “It is because arms are instruments of ill omen and there are things that detest them that one who has the way does not abide by their use.” Chan has “They are hated by men” (Lin has similar), and Cleary has “People may despise them.” Henricks has “And among things there are those that hate them.” Only Feng & English have “all creatures hate them”, similar to Linnell.

故有道者不處

Therefore/as-a-result exist/have Dao/way {person/phrase} not stay/occupy/reside

Therefore, one who has the Dao does not dwell with these.

君子居則貴左

Noble/gentlemen dwell/rest/reside norm/standard/rule/when-then expensive/costly/value-highly left

When the nobleman are at rest, then values highly the left,

用兵則貴右

Bell/use/employ weapons norm/standard/when-them expensive/costly/value right

When using weapons, then values highly the right.

兵者不祥之器

Weapons/warfare {person/phrase} not favorable-omen/auspicious ['s] tools/capacity/instruments

As for weapons, they are inauspicious instruments.

非君子之器

Not gentleman/noble ['s]/this instruments

Not a gentleman's instruments.

不得已而用之

Not-obtaining-way-to-stop/cannot-avoid and/yet/but employ/use this/['s]

When one cannot find another way to end things, only then they are used.

恬淡⁶⁸³為上

Tranquil/quiet/carefree/content/unambitious/alooof/negligent bland/mild/insipid/pale/faded do/use up

Carefree and mild is superior action;

勝而不⁶⁸⁴美{也}

Competence/overcome/conquer and/yet/but not beautiful/attractive/finest

Conquer and not regard it as beautiful.

而美之者是樂殺人

And/yet/but beauty ['s]/this, this music/glee kill/cut-down people

And to regard them as beautiful is to find glee in killing people.

夫樂殺人者

In-any-case/man music/glee kill/cut-down people {people/phrase},

In any case those that find glee in killing people,

則不可以得志於天下矣

When-then not possible/can by-means-of obtain/gain aspiration/intention in/at/regarding world[!]

Then cannot obtain their aspirations of the world.

吉⁶⁸⁵事尚左

Auspicious/benign/favorable matters/serve exalt/surpass/even/venerable/manage left

Benign matters are venerated on the left,

凶事尚右

Ill-omen/deadly/lethal matters/serve exalt/surpass/even/venerable/manage right

Lethal matters are venerated on the right.

⁶⁸³ Mawangdui has 鈇襲 (A) or 鈇戇 (with heart radical to the left on the latter, B).

⁶⁸⁴ Mawangdui has 勿, and not 勝而 before this, meaning “Do not regard as beautiful”, in my opinion.

⁶⁸⁵ Mawangdui has 是以 before this word.

偏⁶⁸⁶ 將軍⁶⁸⁷ 居左

Slanted/off-center/eccentric/sideways/sweep-aside/division will/bring-about/leader army dwell left
Division generals dwell on the left,

上將軍居右

High/above/up bring-about/will/leader army dwell right
High generals dwell on the right.

言以喪禮處之

Words by-means-of grief rich/abundance/fullness/pleasing//rites/rituals/formality dwells [‘s]/this
Words dwell in this warfare through grieving rituals.

殺人之眾

Kill/cut-down people [‘s]/this multitude/crowd
The crowds of people killed,

以哀悲泣之

By-means-of mourn/grieve sadness/yearning/pity weep/shed-tears this/[‘s]
Through mourning pity and weep for them.

戰勝以喪禮處之

Combat/struggle/tremble competence/overcome/conquer by-means-of grief rites dwell this.
Conquering and overcoming through combat, one dwells through mourning rituals.

Comparison to the received Dao De Jing: The difference between the Guodian and the received chapter in this case are not large. The received adds a few lines, that things hate weapons, that those who have the Dao do not dwell with them, and that they are not gentlemen’s instruments. Outside of that, the chapters are essentially the same.

I won’t comment on the difference between “artificial differentiation bringing to the left and high bringing to the right” vs “division generals dwelling on the left and high generals dwelling on the right” because I am not actually confident this difference is real in my translation, or I’m missing something. Maybe both discuss generals (see footnote in Guodian). I will note that perhaps lower generals are on the left because they have less power, they don’t decide wars, they only manage soldiers, whereas high generals are those who play war like games, MAYBE. This is all speculative.

⁶⁸⁶ Mawangdui has 是以 before this word.

⁶⁸⁷ 將軍 together means leader of an army, general.

Guodian (C:4)

為之者(𠄎/敗)⁶⁸⁸之,

Manipulate [‘s] person corrupts/defeats/spoils/destroys/ruins it

Those who manipulate it, corrupt and destroy it.

(𠄎⁶⁸⁹/執)之者(𠄎⁶⁹⁰/失/逸)之。

Grasp/seize/clutch/take-control [‘s] person break-free/escape

Those who seize it have it break free from them and escape.

聖人無為,

Sage no/without act/do/use/manipulate

The sage, without manipulation,

(古/故)無敗也;

Old/ancient//therefore no/without corrupt/defeat/spoil/destroys

As a result, does not corrupt,

無執, (古/故)□□□ (無(𠄎/失/逸)也)⁶⁹¹

Without/no grasp/seize/clutch, old/ancient//therefore □

Without grasping, therefore, {it does not break free and escape}.

(𠄎⁶⁹²/慎) (𠄎⁶⁹³/終)若(𠄎⁶⁹⁴/詞),

Cautious end/finish/finally like words/expression/lyrics

Stay cautious to the end, like explaining something;

(𠄎⁶⁹⁵/則)無敗事(𠄎⁶⁹⁶/壹/喜)。

Norm/standard/rule/when-then not/without corrupt/destroy/ruin matters/affairs/serve drum//happiness

Then there will be no corrupting or destruction of matters or happiness.

⁶⁸⁸ In Henricks, left part is 𠄎, but Cook doesn't address this. Expressed both as 敗 or 𠄎 in zi.tools, under 敗.

⁶⁸⁹ In zi.tools as (𠄎幸𠄎𠄎女), under 執, so the components are consistent. Contrast with C:2 (𠄎 for 𠄎)

⁶⁹⁰ 𠄎 This resembles the second “失” in A:6 (𠄎). Zi.tools has this as 𠄎 (walk) around 止 (foot) over 𠄎 (handcuffs/fetters), giving a sense of breaking out of jail, escaping and running away. This can relate to 失 (lose) in the sense that the guards lost their charge, but also you can relate this to escaping, or even 逸 (a rabbit running, the way this concept was expressed in kingdoms west of Chu. Could also be 迭, or 達/達).

⁶⁹¹ Missing characters from A:6, switching 亡 for 無.

⁶⁹² 𠄎, not listed in zi.tools but greatly resembling 𠄎 under the 𠄎 listing. Compare with A:6 (𠄎) and A:15 (𠄎). However, 𠄎 → 𠄎 is attested in the Shuowen to be equivalent to 慎. The only evidence I've seen so far that these characters are 慎 comes from the Mawangdui and WangBi. Henricks has 誓 (to swear; but see 𠄎 from Wiktionary, zi.tools has this as 𠄎斤言𠄎); Cook has this as what zi.tools does, and discusses theories. 𠄎 itself means “happiness”. Following A:15, I take this in the sense of 慎, but the etymology is not the most convincing to me.

⁶⁹³ No sun below this one in the actual slips

⁶⁹⁴ Listed in zi.tools as 言 left of 𠄎 under the 詞 page. The page itself suggests several meanings, like 治, 始, 殆, and 辭 (explain in A:10, 𠄎): only the last one is convincing to me, given the prominence of 言. Not like A:6 (𠄎)

⁶⁹⁵ Compare to C:3. 𠄎. The rightmost line making the knife was likely faded out and lost, probably meant to look like this 𠄎. Notice also the abbreviated form of 鼎 as 𠄎 from A:17.

⁶⁹⁶ As reluctant as I am to just default to the received text here, I'm totally stuck: 𠄎 means drum and I cannot find a way to make that make sense in this sentence. Cook reports that this is sometimes rendered 喜 (happiness, 𠄎), but grammatically, that's hard to swing as well. I guess you could add “and happiness” to the translation...

人之敗也，

People [’s/this] ruin/corruption/destroying

People’s ruin,

(𣦵/互)⁶⁹⁷(𠂇/於)其(𢦏/攄)⁶⁹⁸(埜/成)⁶⁹⁹也，敗之。

Constantly/persistently in/at/than it/its grasp/take completion/achievement, corrupt/ruin.

Persistently in their grasping at completion, they ruin themselves.

是以(口/聖)⁷⁰⁰人

This by-means-of sage

By means of this, the sage,

欲⁷⁰¹不欲，不貴(𢦏/懣)⁷⁰²(𢦏/得)之(𢦏/貨)；

Desire/craves/urge-to-obtain not desire/crave, not/no value/costly/precious fear/terror obtain/get goods

Desires the undesired, not valuing goods terrifying to obtain as precious.

學不學，(𢦏/復)⁷⁰³(𢦏/眾)(之所)⁷⁰⁴(𢦏/過)。

Mimic/learn/emulate/study not mimic/learn/study, return multitude/crowd/numerous [’s] place change

Learns the unlearned, returning to the multitude’s place of conversion.

是以能(𢦏/補)(𢦏/壘/萬)(勿/物)之自然，

This by-means-of can dense-growth ten-thousand(?)⁷⁰⁵ things [’s] self-nature/self-so

And by means of this, enable the dense growth of ten-thousand things’ self-nature

而(𢦏/弗)敢⁷⁰⁶為。

And/yet/but not dare act/do/use/manipulate.

Yet does not dare to manipulate them.

C:4 Commentary: (Including Received 64 Part 2: [SEE A:6])

Concerning C:4, I suspect this was written quite a deal later than A:6, given the use of 𢦏 for 亡.

In C:4, grasping it leads to losing it, rather than it becoming more distant as in A:6 but more similar to what is written in the received, sticking closer with the opposites phrasing.

⁶⁹⁷ Technically 𣦵, confirmed by zi tools but this says it means 恆 and the Shuowen Jiezi supports this. This means constancy/eternal/persistence (and also ordinary), and has connotations of the moon (Henghe), and the right part of 恆 has been described as a boat. However, 𣦵 over 心 exists and zi.tools reports both mean 恆, though without support from Shuowen Jiezi for this latter form with 心. This cluster is also related to 恒, which Cook seems convinced this means 極 in B:1 and here, but 恆 in strips 6, 13, and 18.

⁶⁹⁸ Henricks and zi.tools have 慶, Cook has 戲 (zi.tools also, the only difference between them being a repositioned hand). Maybe 攄 for 取 (take, retrieve, grasp with fingers).

⁶⁹⁹ In zi.tools under 城—everywhere this occurs in the Guodian, it is technically 埜. This literally means city wall, walled in, etc. Probably phonetic for 成 though it’s strange that it’s more complex. There is a connotation of containment, enclosing. See the notes in zi.tools under 城, regarding ABC Etymology and the dictionary of cognates (漢語同源詞大典).

⁷⁰⁰ Missing in the slips, filled in by A:6 and Cook.

⁷⁰¹ Unlike in A:6, this is actually 𢦏, not 谷.

⁷⁰² Unlike in A:6, has a heart radical below. Now this means terrified, scared.

⁷⁰³ Henricks and Zi.tools accurately has this as 復, probably emphasizing the walk/going aspect.

⁷⁰⁴ Fused character, not the clearest: 𢦏. 所 can also mean “that-which”

⁷⁰⁵ Almost normal 萬 (𢦏) but earth under it, zi.tools considers this extra component to have no effect on meaning

⁷⁰⁶ 𢦏 Zi.tools has this under 敢, this is a variant of 敢

C:4 encourages caution to the end, as though explaining, whereas the received has be cautious in the end as though starting. As mentioned before, A:6 associates caution with winter and danger. This caution in explaining may relate to the insufficiency of words, or the need to know when to stop (see A:10). In any event, caution leads to preventing destruction (and possibly conserving happiness).

C:4 adds the section about people's ruin being grasping for completion constantly, which appears in the received, but not in A:6. I think this is mostly a statement about WuWei; the harder the people try to push for something, the more they sabotage their own efforts because they're forcing it, trying to grab it and use it.

C:4 mentions the sage does not value terrifying-to-obtain items as precious, whereas A:6 mentions the sage does not value difficult-to-obtain items as precious (through the absence of the heart radical). In the received, it is rare items that the sage does not consider precious. In all three, something evidently non-essential is not considered to be precious, and ordinary things are, for the sage, sufficient.

Rather than teaching the untaught in A:6, C:4 has the sage learning the unlearned, as the received does.

This could refer to learning the subtle mysteries of the Dao, possible by escaping artificial classifications and striving ambitions. In both A:6 and C:4, the sage returns to where the multitudes are converted, as opposed to the received having the sage return to where the people have passed over. The Guodian, in my opinion, seems to be suggesting a reversal of a transformation back to an original state, whereas the received in this case is emphasizing learning the unknown as a result of not following the societal path, but this is speculation on my part.

As I have translated it, C:4 has the enabling of dense growth of the self-nature of ten thousand (earthly?) things. A:6 has spreading the self-nature of ten-thousand things. The received has the stabilization of the self-nature of ten thousand things. The spreading and enabling dense growth to me resonate as nurturing and facilitative, not seeking to control but rather let things be as they are; the received has more of a controlling tone, perhaps, with "stabilizing."